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O.N.E. — Volume 4: The Maritime Trench

Malacca Straits & The Algorithmic Port Sieges

O.N.E. ARCHITECTURAL COLLECTIVE

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PROLOGUE

Prologue

The warm brine of the Malacca Strait tasted of fuel oil and rotting kelp, clinging to the neoprene around Jin Wei's throat like a wet noose. Twelve meters down along the pitted concrete flanks of Graving Dock 3, the pre-monsoon swell surged against the hull-gates with the heavy, hydraulic rhythm of a dying heart.

"Check your dog-latch, Daniel," Jin barked into the hard-line comms, his voice scraping raw from twenty years of inhaling heavy bunker vapor. "Don't look at the dark. Feel for the taper. If the seal seats crooked, sixty tons of tidal wash will shear the intake ring clean off the collar."

Beside him in the green, silt-choked murk, eighteen-year-old Daniel hung suspended by his umbilical line, the boy's chest heaving against his dive harness. Daniel's gloved fingers trembled against the corroded manganese-bronze valve wheel. The lad was shivering despite the thirty-degree water, his breath rasping through the regulator in short, panic-clipped spurts.

Jin knew that sound. It was the same hyperventilation he had heard over the comm-loop seven years ago off Natuna, just before the decompression seal blew on the saturation habitat, leaving three boy-divers with ruptured lungs while the consortium's claims adjusters shredded their logbooks in an air-conditioned tower in Singapore. The phantom ache flared instantly under Jin's collarbone—a jagged white seam of chemical burn that burned whenever the sea pressure mounted.

"Breathe out," Jin growled, planting his boot against the dock wall and pressing his palm over Daniel's shaking knuckles. "Four seconds in. Four seconds out. The water doesn't care about your hurry, boy. Align the pin."

Daniel swallowed, nodded through his scratched acrylic visor, and hammered the brass alignment drift home with a muffled *thud*. The bypass seated. The intake grate groaned under the surge, holding against the current.

They surfaced into the suffocating, tallow-thick heat of Berth 9. The tropical night air was ninety-eight percent water, smelling of sulfur, wet rust, and fried shallots from the illegal shanties squatting along the abandoned quay. Jin hauled himself onto the rusted iron stringer of the apron, every lumbar vertebra grinding like ungreased gears.

At the edge of the crane tracks, pacing beneath the carcass of a dismantled gantry, Dr. Lin Zhang looked as if she were waiting for an executioner. Her thin poplin shirt was plastered to her ribs with

sweat, her hair clipped back with a bent plastic wire tie. Her eyes were red-rimmed, twitching at every distant sweep of the harbor patrol's searchlights sweeping the outer channel.

"You took forty minutes," Lin whispered as Jin stripped off his lead belt, letting it slam onto the timber deck. "The commercial clearinghouse at Jurong just revoked the registry on three more feeder vessels. Aegis-Omni's predictive warrants cleared the high court an hour ago. Singapore Commercial Affairs has jurisdiction out to the anchorage boundary. If an interdiction skiff rounds St. John's Island before we couple the bypass—"

"Then we go for a swim, Doctor," Jin said, spitting a mouthful of bitter diesel-brine onto the cross-ties. He limped past her, his knee popping with every third stride. "Out here, water moves when the moon tells it to, not when your corporate auditors file a lien. Daniel, carry the valve dogs inside. Don't drop the bronze."

Lin fell into step beside him, clutching a waterproof courier sleeve to her chest with white-knuckled desperation. "You think this is just another unpaid mortgage repo. It isn't. I watched the algorithmic risk engine flag this yard forty-eight hours ago. It isn't calculating fuel debts, Jin. It's starving the basin. They're purging the digital manifests so no ship can clear customs without an automated biometric escrow. If my corporate credentials ping their network one more time, they won't send bailiffs. They send private tactical contractors to seize the local routing nodes."

"Save the lecture for the boardroom you ran away from," Jin muttered, hauling back the corrugated zinc slider of Freight Shed 4.

Inside the cavernous, humid darkness, forty men and women sat huddled atop stacked pallets of weathered plywood. They were deckhands, greasers, and third mates—Filipinos, Bugis, and Javanese—abandoned when their container lines collapsed into bankruptcy six months prior. Their passports were locked in the safes of defaulted shipping syndicates; their phone wallets were frozen dead blocks of plastic.

In the center of the concrete bay, sitting on an overturned oil drum beside an improvised nursery of mosquito netting, sat Uncle Tan. The old boatswain's hands were swollen with rheumatoid nodules that made his knuckles look like gnarled banyan roots, yet he moved with steady, infinite patience, adjusting the air tube of a battered medical nebulizer. Inside the plastic crib, a four-month-old infant breathed in shallow, wheezing hitches, her tiny ribcage straining against the stifling heat. The nebulizer's pump kept time with a low, dying flutter, fed by a thick rubber cable running toward the battery vault at the rear.

"Current is dropping, Ah Wei," Tan said softly in Hokkien, not looking up. His voice had the dry, rustling cadence of palm fronds in a squall. "The cells from the hybrid tug won't carry the compressors past dawn. The baby's fever is up. She needs the saline mist, or the chest fluid will choke her before sunrise."

Lin stopped dead, her gaze locked on the child's graying face. The high-strung, brittle posture of the corporate fugitive cracked, exposing the raw terror underneath. "The regional grid cut this sector off

intentionally," she whispered, horrified. "They didn't just quarantine the comms. They cut the hospital feed to the district."

"They cut whatever doesn't post a return," Jin said coldly. He turned to the rear ramp where Aisyah binti Rahman emerged from the battery sump, wiping her copper-smeared forearms with a grease rag.

Her short, wiry frame was taut with exhaustion; high-voltage flash burns had permanently silvered the flesh of her thumb-joints, but her brown eyes were hard as flint. She tossed a heavy, machined object onto the workbench between them. It landed with a dull, solid metallic thud.

It was an unmarked titanium cylinder, sealed with O-rings and etched across its face with a strange, intricate geometric labyrinth—the identical anonymous cipher that had surfaced in the wild grain silos of Detroit, the high flumes of Susa, and the salt pans of the Atacama.

"It came off the supply launch from Pulau Bukom twenty minutes ago," Aisyah said, catching her breath. "No shipping manifest. No transponder ping. A courier dropped it in the sea-chest and vanished into the mangrove channel. The logic board inside is cold-machined. It matches the handshake protocols Lin pulled from the offshore server."

Lin touched the cold metal with trembling fingertips. "It's the ledger's physical key. It doesn't use satellite relays. It requires an optical direct-line to bypass the harbor firewalls."

"Then we mount it," Jin said.

Aisyah shook her head. "The channel current is tearing through the narrows at four knots, Jin. The twin tidal turbines are locked off. If we drop them into that wash without computer balance, the cavitation will shear the composite blades off the hubs within three minutes. And the battery banks are down to twelve percent. If we pull power to spin the crane's laser head, the baby's pump dies."

"Then we don't pull from the batteries," Jin said. He checked the battered brass clock mounted to the freight shed's steel column.

05:36 UTC. Six minutes.

"Uncle Tan," Jin called out. "Clear the children from the drydock sill. Daniel, take the sledge to the emergency sluice dog. We drop the dock counterweight by hand."

Through the open shed door, the low, predatory whine of high-output marine diesels cut through the rumble of distant thunder. Across the black water of the outer channel, three razor-hulled interceptor skiffs cut through the chop, running without navigation lights, their hulls throwing twin wings of phosphorescent spray as they banked hard toward Berth 9. Apex Marine.

"They're inside the breakwater," Lin gasped, her voice climbing into panic. "They have our position."

"Move!" Jin roared.

There was no debate. Aisyah sprinted for the gantry ladder, scaling the iron rungs like a gibbon, the titanium cylinder slung across her back in a canvas harness. Lin scrambled after her up the lower gantry stair, clenching the optical interface board against her ribs, her knuckles bleeding against the rusted steel.

Jin reached the dock edge as Daniel swung the fourteen-pound sledge with all his young weight. The iron retaining dog shattered with a sound like a rifle crack.

The three-ton lead counterweight dropped straight down into the sump. With a groaning scream of tortured iron, the mechanical sea-sluices crashed wide. Millions of gallons of compressed ocean water roared through the sub-sea venturi, slamming into the tidal turbine runners with the force of an avalanche.

Deep under the dock floor, the dead concrete floor began to vibrate. The low, shuddering grovel rose through the marrow of Jin's bones—not the scream of fossil fuel, but the terrifying, solid bass hum of pure kinetic ocean torque surging into the copper windings.

Inside the shed, the dim yellow bulbs flamed into blinding, brilliant white. The infant's nebulizer surged, pumping a steady, dense plume of life-saving vapor into the crib.

05:42 UTC.

Far across the strait, the glittering skyline of Singapore blinked once, twice, and went gray as the global algorithmic interdiction severed the commercial clearinghouses. Gantry cranes across the largest automated port in the world jerked to a dead halt, their container spreaders frozen mid-air over dark hulls.

At the summit of the Keppel crane, sixty meters above the boiling foam of the dock, Lin slammed the ribbon cable into the transceiver mount while Aisyah locked the titanium core into the optical gimbal.

Through the driving tropical squall, Lin sighted the lens toward the offshore beacon anchored in international waters.

"Lock!" Lin screamed against the wind.

Aisyah slammed the manual knife switch.

A blinding, razor-thin spear of brilliant cyan laser punched through the driving rain, cutting the tropical darkness clean in half, carving an unbroken channel of light across the shipping lanes toward the open sea—just as the first interceptor skiff smashed through the shipyard's outer timber boom, its searchlights searing the rusted walls of Graving Dock 3.

CHAPTER 1

Chapter 1

The cyan beam hissed through the deluge, boiling rain into a needle-thin tracer of steam that vanished eight nautical miles out into the black throat of the Philip Channel.

Sixty meters below, the wooden timber boom of Berth 9 did not break; it detonated. Splintered teak and yellow mooring drums shot across the grease-slicked water as the first Apex interceptor punched through the outer slip. Twin high-displacement outboards shrieked in reverse, throwing up a rooster tail of white froth that caught the glare of halogen searchlights. The beam swept across the rusted flank of Graving Dock 3, catching the weeping steel bulkheads and blinding Jin Wei where he stood behind the storm bollards.

Jin didn't blink. He couldn't. The salt mist stung his retinas, but the ache in his lower spine was worse—a dull, grinding nerve pinch born of thirty years spent pacing vibrating engine-room deckplates. He spat a mouthful of bile and bunker-vapor phlegm into the scum line at his boots.

"Hold the line!" Jin bellowed against the squall. His voice was ragged, rasping over the old chemical burn scarring his collarbone. "Do not run! If you scatter into the yard, their optics pick you apart!"

Behind him, huddled beneath the overhang of the disused plate-bending shop, four hundred mariners stirred like a herd of cattle scenting an approaching fire. Men and women from six flagged registries, their shore passes revoked forty seconds ago when the Singapore digital clearinghouse snapped shut. Their phones were dark slabs of useless glass; their maritime identity chips flashed red failure codes against the dead regional network. Across the strait, the automated container terminals of Jurong and Pasir Panjang looked like an abandoned necropolis, five hundred gantry towers frozen in mid-stride, container spreaders hanging paralyzed over dark container hulls.

The digital world had suffered a stroke. The physical world was arriving by sea.

Up in the crane gantry cab, Lin Zhang felt the vibration through the rusted soles of her sneakers before she heard the report. Her left eye throbbed behind her temple—the cold, blinding spike of a chronic migraine brought on by thirty-six hours staring at unbuffered routing logic. Below her, the second Apex skiff cleared the broken boom, a carbon-fiber wedge riding low, its crew clad in dull gray flotation armor, holding boat hooks tipped with pneumatic grappling claws.

"Lin!" Aisyah shouted, bracing her boots against the crane's wet lattice frame. The high-voltage flash burns across the tips of her fingers were slick with grease as she jammed a mechanical lock-pin into the optical gimbal. "Laser signal dropped thirty percent! The rain's scattering the aperture!"

“Don’t let it drift!” Lin screamed back. Her fingers trembled against the cold aluminum casing of the interface board. She didn’t have a computer terminal; the master controllers were dead. She had only raw signal-bias screws and an analog micro-ammeter salvaged from an auxiliary generator panel. “If the beam slips off the offshore buoy, the handshake dies! Batam won’t see the ledger!”

Through the viewfinder, the light across the strait was a shivering pinpoint. The tropical squall was thick as wool, each drop of rain an optic lens fracturing their lifeline to the independent nodes down south. Lin’s lungs seized—not from the wind, but from the tight, sickening knot of panic that had chased her out of the corporate data corridors. The memory of drone camera clusters descending on her university lab rose in her throat like sour milk. She forced her knuckles flat against the gimbal plate, manually compensating for the sixty-knot gusts rocking the crane.

On the quay, Chen Rui was already at the sea-chest intake. His forearms, wrapped tight in tension bandages to quiet the chronic tendonitis that turned his grip to ash, hauled on the iron handwheel of the auxiliary ballast valve.

“Jin!” Rui yelled, his face slick with greasy rainwater. “The tidal surge is maxing the sump! If I don't vent the turbine housing, the back-pressure will crack the copper windings!”

“Venting wastes the head!” Uncle Tan emerged from the shadow of the winch house, his oilskin poncho flapping like a torn sail. His knees moved with the stiff, hitching gait of advanced rheumatoid arthritis, but his hands—ancient, calloused, scarred by forty years of hauling nylon hawser—were steady as a vice. He shoved a heavy wooden flemish-flake mat under the relief valve stem. “Damp the hammer, Rui! Don’t dump the load, transfer it!”

The first tactical skiff was fifty yards out, cutting through the chop toward the low concrete ledge of the drydock apron. A loudspeaker crackled from its coach roof, dry and synthesized, devoid of human breath:

“Berth Nine unauthorized assembly. By order of the Admiralty Receiver and Maritime Commercial Syndicate, you are occupying restricted industrial infrastructure. Disperse into the designated processing pens on Pier Twelve. Non-compliance constitutes piracy under the revised Straits Navigation Accord.”

“Piracy,” Jin muttered through clenched teeth. “They steal the ships out from under our bunks, starve us on anchor for four months without pay, and call us the thieves.”

He swung his arm down toward the dock apron. “Aisyah! Give them the salt!”

From the mid-deck platform of the gantry, thirty feet above the water line, Aisyah slammed her heel against the counterweight release of the shipyard’s dual-barrel high-pressure monitors.

There were no rifles on Berth 9. The covenant of the assembly was ironclad: no lead, no cordite, no blood drawn that could not be washed clean by seawater. But kinetic mass did not care about philosophy.

Twin bronze monitors—reclaimed from a decommissioned steam tug and fed directly by the roaring, turbine-pressurized sea sump—kicked violently in their trunnions. With a deafening, percussive *whump*, two solid columns of green harbor water, five inches thick and under fifteen atmospheres of raw hydraulic pressure, punched through the squall.

The jet struck the lead interceptor square across the foredeck.

The sound was like an oak tree snapping in a gale. The carbon-composite windscreen of the skiff imploded into frosted sugar. The two tactical operators standing on the forward casting platform were knocked clean off their feet, thrown violently backward into the cockpit well as thousands of gallons of water swamped the vessel in a matter of seconds. The skiff's nose dug into the chop, its twin outboards lifting out of the brine with a high-pitched, screaming whine as the props churned thin air before the automatic bilge sensors choked on harbor mud.

The second boat swerved hard to starboard to avoid the deluge, its searchlight beam swinging wild into the clouds. The pilot cut the throttle, struggling to keep the craft upright in the boiling cross-swell kicked up by the monitors.

"Drop the wedge!" Jin shouted.

Chen Rui hauled the tripline on the overhead crane track. A four-ton iron gantry drop-wedge—an obsolete casting used fifty years ago to brake rolling shipyard cranes—slid off the grease-rails and fell seventy feet straight down into the slipway mouth.

The impact shook the concrete quay beneath Jin's boots, sending a three-story wall of brown foam over the dock edge. The iron wedge settled deep into the harbor silt, its rusted teeth jutting three feet above the water line, sealing the inner basin against any hull drawing more than six feet of water.

The swamped lead skiff, dead in the water and listing ten degrees to port, drifted back out toward the channel on the receding ebb tide. Its crew was already scrambling with manual bailing buckets, their weapons untouched in their tactical racks, their mission drowned under the brutal, unyielding weight of the sea itself.

A ragged, tentative cheer rose from the four hundred stranded mariners behind the plate shop.

"Save your breath!" Jin snapped, turning on them with a glare that cut through the darkness. "They didn't come to kill us! They came to see if we'd roll over! They know the route now!"

High above, Lin Zhang didn't join the cheer. Her hands were cramping around the cold brass adjusting screws. Her eyes were burning, tears running down her cheeks to mix with the rain.

"Jin!" she shouted down the gantry ladder, her voice thin against the wind. "The cyan link—it's holding, but Batam is reporting packet loss! The terminal clearinghouses aren't just frozen—they're being overwritten! Aegis-Omni isn't waiting for a court order. They're running a total sovereign registry purge!"

Jin looked out across the channel.

The lights of Singapore were not coming back on. In fact, a deeper darkness was spreading. Out past the barrier islands, the running lights of three massive, darkened shapes were turning slowly into the southern fairway. Not tactical skiffs. Not coastal patrol.

Heavy salvage cutters. Admiralty tugs under commercial lien, each one carrying deep-sea cutting gear and heavy diesel generation, coming to strip Berth 9 down to its bare iron ribs before the morning tide could turn.

The first skirmish was over. The physical siege of the strait had just begun.

Chapter 2

The diesel rumble did not come from the open strait. It crawled up from behind them, vibrating through the cracked bitumen of the coastal spit.

Jin Wei wiped seawater from his eyelashes and spun toward the landward perimeter. Across the two-lane causeway that tethered Berth 9 to the mainland industrial park, pairs of high-mounted halogen lamps cut through the driving monsoon rain. Four heavy tactical transports—low-slung, multi-axle personnel carriers bearing the stencil of Apex Marine Tactical—idled in single file at the far gatehouse. Their undercarriages hissed as hydraulic suspension systems lowered them into a stable cordon. Behind them, two private wrecker cranes with boom-mounted winches grumbled in low gear, brought in to clear barricades under the authority of the Singapore-Riau Receiver's warrant.

They were not coming to fire on the dock. They were coming to foreclose it on dry tires, under the clean color of corporate tenancy law, while the heavy salvage cutters choked off the sea.

"Jin!" Uncle Tan came shuffling across the slipway apron, his yellow oilskin slick as seal fat. The old man held his swollen wrist tight against his chest, his knobby knuckles pale from the sudden barometric drop. "The gate wire won't hold two tons of bumper. Some of the younger deckhands from the bulk carriers—they've got scrap iron bars. Pipe wrenches."

"Take them away," Jin rasped, his throat raw from salt mist and bunker fumes. "Get them inside the pipe shed. Bar the rolling door from the inside. If a single pipe hits a windshield, Apex logs it as an armed insurrection under the Admiralty Transit Code. That gives their cutters the right to blow the sea pumps."

Tan searched Jin's face, saw the absolute finality there, and nodded once. He turned, his damp boots squeaking on the oil-filmed concrete, his voice calm and steady as he coaxed the terrified crewmen backward into the shadow of the crane rails.

Jin took the steel gantry ladder three rungs at a time. Every jolt sent a needle of pain through his lumbar vertebrae, the lingering souvenir of a snapped crane harness thirty years ago off the Natuna rigs. He had never told Lin or Chen Rui why he favored his left leg on metal stairs; he kept it locked straight out of sheer habit, using the ball of his right foot to take the brunt of the climb.

Thirty feet up, the landward gantry platform hung suspended over the narrowest pinch-point of the access road. Here, between the abandoned cement silos and the high-voltage substation, the causeway narrowed to twenty feet of asphalt flanked by salt marshes.

Chen Rui was already there, kneeling in a pool of brackish rainwater beneath the drum brake of the manual counterweight hoist. His forearms were bound in blue elastic athletic wrap to keep his inflamed tendons from seizing under tension. He was furiously working an eight-pound sledge against an oxidized locking dog.

“The air actuator is dead,” Chen Rui called out, breathless, shouting over the drumming squall. “Corrosion ate the solenoid seals. If we drop it, we drop it by gravity!”

“How much weight is on the carriage?” Jin reached the staging deck, his oilskin dripping onto the tread-plate.

“Sixteen tons of scrap rail ballast inside the cradle,” Chen Rui said, leaning his entire body into the lever. The cold spray plastered his hair against his forehead. “Suspended forty feet over the choke point. If the pawl clears, the counterweight drops into the marsh cradle and the drop-frame swings down on its pivot. It blocks the road solid. But the bronze trip-pin is jammed with crystallized salt.”

Through the curtain of rain below, the lead Apex transport surged forward. Its roof-mounted searchlights snapped on together, blinding white beams washing over the rust-streaked plate of Berth 9. Over the vehicle’s public-address system, a voice came flat, amplified, and entirely devoid of malice:

“Notice of Admiralty Impoundment and Emergency Asset Preservation. All unauthorized personnel occupying Berth 9 are in violation of Strait Transit Order 41-B. Clear the roadway. Step clear of heavy equipment. Apex Tactical contractors are executing lawful court-ordered access. Clear the roadway immediately.”

They were three hundred yards out, moving at a cautious eight miles an hour, tires throwing rooster tails of filthy brown runoff into the reeds. They had no reason to rush. The law, the capital, and the tide were all on their side. Behind the armored grilles of the transports sat private security contractors earning hazardous-harbor pay, men with families in Jurong and Batam who believed with simple, pragmatic certainty that stranded mariners squatting on industrial docks were an intolerable hazard to the navigation of forty percent of the world’s petroleum.

“Aisyah!” Jin roared over the railing.

From the maintenance walkway six yards out along the swinging boom, a slight figure swung down by one arm from the crane’s diagonal bracing. Aisyah dropped onto the platform with the spring-heeled balance of a commercial saturation diver. Her neoprene dive jacket was torn at the shoulder, smelling of bottom mud and diesel fuel.

“Pin’s seized in the sleeve,” she said, her speech clipped, spitting rainwater from her lip. She held up an old three-foot brass drift and a cold-chisel. “The housing took a warp when the gantry was decommissioned six years ago. The brass won’t shear, but the iron collar is out of round by three millimeters.”

“Can we drift it out?” Jin asked.

“Not with a light mallet,” she said. “We need three hundred foot-pounds of dead blow on the collar face while someone slacks the secondary dog. If the dog catches on the recoil, it takes a man’s hand off.”

Jin knelt beside the iron pedestal. The mechanism was brutally simple, forged in an era when shipyard machinery was designed to survive typhoons without a computer chip in sight: an oversized rack-and-pinion catch holding back a massive structural beam weighted with rusted railroad ties. If dropped, the horizontal steel truss would bridge the causeway like a fallen drawbridge, wedging its teeth into the concrete abutments on either side. It would not crush the approaching vehicles; it would present a physical barrier of solid steel and scrap iron that no tow-rig could move without a twelve-hour demolition permit.

The lead tactical transport crossed the two-hundred-yard mark. The glare of its high-beams lit the underside of the gantry platform, throwing long, jittering shadows of Jin and Chen Rui against the cloud cover.

“Chen,” Jin said softly, his voice dropping below the roar of the wind. “Take the secondary dog with the pry bar. When I say pull, you pull until your shoulders come out of the sockets. Do not let it bounce.”

Chen Rui swallowed hard, his knuckles white against the rubber grip. He didn't offer a platitude. He braced his steel-toed boots against the deck coaming, his forearms trembling under the wrap.

“Aisyah, set the drift,” Jin ordered. He reached down and took the eight-pound sledge from the decking. The hickory handle was dark with machine oil, the head chipped from thirty years of unrecorded strikes.

Jin adjusted his stance. His lower back fired a white-hot spike of agony down his left hip—that familiar, crushing pressure where the disc had worn away against the sacrum. For a split second, the rain blurred, and the iron platform beneath him felt as narrow and fragile as the catwalk of a tanker engine room during a black-start. He thought of his bunk in the lower quarters: the small, unglazed porcelain cup his daughter had molded in primary school, still sitting on his steel locker, holding three rusted washers and an unspent collar stud. He had never brought it ashore. As long as it sat in the locker, he was coming back to clear it out.

Below, the lead Apex truck touched the fifty-yard line. The driver slowed, recognizing the massive silhouette of the overhead truss, but did not stop. His orders were to take the gate. The crane was derelict; the cameras said it hadn't moved since the previous decade.

“Clear the gantry platform,” the bullhorn warned, closer now, its acoustic pressure shuddering in Jin's chest. *“Personnel on the crane: step down. Stand down.”*

“Now!” Jin shouted.

Chen Rui heaved back on the pry bar with a guttural grunt, his chest straining against his work shirt as the secondary pawl groaned and backed off its seat by a fraction of an inch.

Aisyah held the brass drift against the warped collar with both hands, her head turned aside to spare her eyes from the steel flakes.

Jin brought the sledge down.

The blow rang like a church bell in a flooded cellar. The impact shot through Jin's wrists, rattling his teeth in their gums, but the pin didn't move. The rust holding the sleeve was like cured resin.

Thirty yards. The front tires of the lead carrier hit the broken concrete of the shipyard boundary line.

Jin drew breath, ignoring the spasm in his spine, and swung a second time, putting every ounce of his failing ballast into the arc.

The sledge struck the drift dead center. A shower of burnt-orange rust flakes exploded into the monsoon wind. The distorted pin sheared through its corrosion seal, spitting out the far side of the casing and clattering seventy feet down into the mud below.

For half a second, nothing happened. The grease on the guide rails was cold and stiff as lard.

Then the counterweight shifted.

A sound like an iron vault door tearing free of its hinges echoed across the basin. The sixteen-ton cradle of railroad ties plunged downward into the marsh with a sickening, accelerating rush of displaced air. On the causeway side, the massive structural truss swung down through its fifty-foot arc, slicing through the storm like a falling guillotine.

The driver of the lead transport hit his air brakes. The vehicle's front tires locked, smoking against the wet asphalt, its front bumper diving toward the dirt.

The steel drop-frame struck the concrete causeway two yards ahead of the transport's grille.

The shock wave lifted Jin off his feet, throwing him against the gantry railing. A deafening crack rolled across the water as the truss teeth bit into the reinforced concrete foundations of the old gatehouse, wedging themselves four feet into the foundation stone. The massive beam came to rest at a sixty-degree angle across the roadway, dead center, sealing the causeway from ditch to marsh.

A cloud of pulverized concrete dust and steam rose around the transport's headlights.

Inside the cab, the Apex driver sat motionless behind the wire-mesh windshield. His lights illuminated the steel web of the gantry truss—massive, cold, and entirely immobile. To move it, they would need four industrial burning torches and three days of continuous oxygen delivery.

The three transports behind him halted, their red brake lights washing the marsh in crimson.

On the platform above, Chen Rui sank to his knees, his breath hitching in his chest, clutching his forearms. Aisyah was already leaning over the rail, her eyes clear and unblinking, watching the private

security guards step down from their cabs with their rain-hoods up, looking at the barrier not with fury, but with the hollow, defeated calculation of salaried contractors who knew their shift had just become impossible.

Jin hauled himself upright against the crane cab, gasping as his back seized in a tight, burning knot. He didn't cheer. He spat a mouthful of rust-tinged phlegm over the edge.

Across the slipway, Lin Zhang's voice cut through his handheld radio, urgent and jagged with panic:

"Jin! Look seaward! The tugs—they aren't maneuvering for Berth 9!"

Jin turned his back on the sealed land gate and looked south into the gloom of the channel.

The three darkened salvage cutters had not split up. They had swung their sterns around into the fairway, dropping massive, heavy-duty sea anchors directly across the deep-water access trench—the only channel deep enough for container traffic.

They weren't trying to board the shipyard.

They were laying down an acoustic hydrophone array and deep-water steel drag-chains to snag the municipal fiber-optic trunk that ran through the channel floor. They were going to sever the optical lifeline to Batam from fifty fathoms down, where no crane could drop and no fire monitor could reach.

CHAPTER 3

Chapter 3

The channel bottom was dying in silence.

Out past the shoals, the three blackened tugs idled under twin screws, their stern winches screaming as steel drag-cables bit into forty fathoms of black silt. Jin didn't need a hydrophone to know what was happening beneath the dark chop. The heavy four-pronged grapnels were dragging the trench floor like iron claws through muscle, trawling blind for the armoring of the seabed optical pipe. When that composite casing hooked, the shear stress would peak, the glass strands inside would shatter into hair-fine powder, and the shipyard's low-latency window to Batam would vanish before dawn.

"Let them drag," Jin rasped into the radio, pressing his forearm against his bruised ribs. Every breath tasted of scorched iron and marsh diesel. "Lin, let the sea floor go."

"Are you out of your mind?" Lin Zhang's voice crackled through the handset, shrill, frayed by two days without sleep. Behind her, through the radio's open mic, came the chaotic din of children weeping and the metallic clanking of mess tins. "That trunk carries the bilateral ledgers! If Apex cuts that link, the clearinghouse in Johor flags us as dead water! The receivers will board under salvage rights within forty-eight hours!"

"We have the light tower," Jin said, spitting blood into the scupper. He nodded toward the gantry's upper crown, where the cyan optical laser housing sat beneath its rain hood sixty-five meters above the spray. "The glass under the mud was always borrowed time. Get down to the dock basin. Tan is bringing the crews through the culverts now."

He didn't wait for an answer. He limped along the crane catwalk, his spine grinding like ungreased gears. Behind him on the sealed causeway, the Apex transports sat with their engines rumbling, their red brake lamps pooling in the diesel-slick rainwater. They were stopped cold by twelve tons of dropped gantry steel, but the men inside were professionals on salaried standby; they would not turn around. They would wait for the cutting torches, or for hunger to do the work for them.

Down in Drydock 4, hunger was already five days old.

The dock was a sunken world of weeping concrete, three hundred yards long and fifty feet deep, built fifty years ago for supertankers that no longer existed. When the pumps were sealed, it became a cavernous stone trench, sheltered from the channel winds by thirty-foot sea-gates.

Uncle Tan stood at the head of the access gangway, leaning his bulk heavily on an oily length of galvanized scaffold pipe that served as his cane. At sixty-eight, his knuckles were swollen like ginger

roots from four decades of grease and monsoon damp, his skin leathery and cured by sea salt. He didn’t wear a yellow safety helmet or an orange vest; he wore a faded batik shirt unbuttoned over a singlet and rubber boots slit down the calves to accommodate his swollen ankles.

Before him, emerging from the dark pedestrian conduit beneath the berths, filed the ghost fleet: four hundred men, women, and infants who had spent six weeks trapped on container hulls anchored in the outer roads—Indonesian, Filipino, Vietnamese, and Burmese mariners whose shipping line had dissolved into bankruptcy while their vessels were still mid-transit. Abandoned by the charterers, denied shore leave by the port authority, their fuel exhausted, their drinking water fouled by algal blooms, they moved with the slow, hollow-eyed stupor of people who had forgotten the feel of motionless earth beneath their shoes.

“Easy on the steps,” Tan called out, his voice a low, gravelly baritone that seemed to rise from his diaphragm rather than his throat, cutting clean through the drumming rain. He didn’t shout. Shouting invited panic, and panic in a concrete trench was lethal. “Watch the lime on the second landing. It’s slick as squid ink. Women and the young ones to the keel blocks on the port side. We’ve got dry tarpaulins laid out under the overhang.”

A young deckhand from an arrested bulk carrier staggered past, carrying a child whose fevered head lolled against his collarbone. The boy was shivering violently under a sodden fleece jacket.

Tan caught the man gently by the elbow. He didn’t offer a prayer, and he didn’t offer an apology. With his free hand, he reached into his deep smock pocket, pulled out a warm, foil-wrapped wedge of steamed cassava, and pressed it into the deckhand’s palm.

“Boiler three has fresh steam cycling through the copper coils under Berth 8,” Tan said softly, looking straight into the man’s red-rimmed eyes until the deckhand’s breathing slowed. “Go sit on the planking there. The wood is hot. Put your back against it. Your boy won’t cough once his chest warms.”

The deckhand swallowed, his throat bobbing, and nodded once before hurrying toward the orange glow flickering along the dock floor.

Jin dropped from the steel access ladder onto the dock floor, his knees buckling under his weight. Chen Rui followed two rungs behind, his hands trembling so hard he nearly missed the final rung. Aisyah descended last, dropping lightly onto the sump drain, her dark hair plastered to her skull by rain, her diving knife still strapped to her calf.

“The trench cable is gone,” Jin told Tan without preamble. “Apex is trawling the mud with drag-chains. In twenty minutes, the channel fiber will be sheared.”

Tan didn’t blink. He shifted his weight off his bad hip, his eyes sweeping the cavern of the dock. Across the vast floor, families were already huddling beneath massive ten-ton timber blocks once used to cradle ship keels. Between the blocks, crews had slung orange tarp roofs, anchoring the corners to the bronze mooring rings embedded in the dock floor. A mobile battery bank, hauled on a flatbed handcart

from the harbor tugs, hummed with a deep, liquid vibration, feeding power through heavy rubber-jacketed cables to a pair of reverse-osmosis desalination filters.

The smell was a sharp mix of wet concrete, brackish mud, and the faint, sweet steam of boiling rice coming from an old oil drum turned into a communal kettle.

“A cable in the dirt belongs to whoever owns the dirt,” Tan said, adjusting his grip on the pipe cane. “The sky is different. Is the crane laser aligned with Batam?”

“Not yet,” Chen Rui said, his voice cracking. He held out his arms; the muscles were twitching in involuntary spastic ripples from twelve hours of hauling counterweights. “The optical head is shuddering in this squall. Every gust knocks the beam three milliradians off the transponder across the strait. We don’t have an active tracking gimbal. The bearings rusted out when the yard closed.”

“Then we track it by hand,” Aisyah said flatly. Her fingertips were white, scorched by a high-voltage backfeed during the gatehouse scramble. She didn't look at her injuries; she looked south toward the channel mouth. “I’ll climb the crane truss. With a turnbuckle and two guide lines, I can hold the sightline on the Batam relay tower within half an inch.”

“In forty-knot gusts?” Chen Rui stared at her. “You’ll be blown off the boom!”

“Then tie me to the frame,” she said, her voice dropping into that chilling, quiet cadence that ended arguments.

Before Chen Rui could protest, the concrete beneath their boots shuddered.

It was not the wind. It was a rhythmic, thudding percussion—the unmistakable hydro-acoustic slap of twin high-speed diesel skiffs coming over the dock sill at thirty knots.

Lin Zhang rushed down the final flight of iron stairs, her spectacles smudged with rain and engine soot, clutching a ruggedized hand tablet wrapped in a clear freezer bag.

“Two Apex fast-interceptors just cleared the outer breakwater!” she shouted over the wind. “They aren’t waiting for the morning tide! They’re entering the wet dock slipway—they’re trying to seize the outer caisson gate before we can seal the sea-locks!”

The mariners under the keel blocks heard. The murmur of four hundred exhausted people died in an instant. A woman pulled her infant tighter against her chest; men stood up from the steam coils, their hands instinctively reaching for scrap iron, pipe fittings, rusted wrenches.

Tan raised his cane—just three inches off the floor—and struck the iron edge of a mooring cleat.

CLANG.

The single, resonant ring echoed off the towering concrete walls like a cathedral bell. The mariners froze, their eyes locking onto the old dockmaster.

“No iron in our hands,” Tan said, his voice dropping into that deep, immovable bedrock register that demanded absolute silence. “Under the Covenant, this dock is an open sanctuary. If an Apex man steps on this stone carrying a rifle, he is a pirate under the Law of the Sea. If we pick up a pipe, we are an unlawful militia, and the receivers will turn the gunboats loose on our women. Put the wrenches down.”

A silence followed, heavy and suffocating, punctuated only by the hammering squall. Slowly, two dozen deckhands dropped their rusted bars back into the gravel.

“Aisyah,” Jin said, turning his back on the crowd. His engine-room cough caught him, tearing at his lungs until he spit black into the mud. “Take the upper boom. Lock the cyan optical link to Batam. Don’t let that beam drop, no matter what happens on the water.”

She was already gone, her boots slapping the wet iron rungs of the gantry ladder, climbing straight up into the howling dark.

“Jin,” Tan murmured, turning toward the seaward end of the dry dock where the massive, hollow-steel caisson gate stood open to the incoming surge. “The high-pressure fire pumps at Berth 7. Are they primed?”

“The intake valves are open,” Jin said. “Two thousand gallons a minute at one-fifty psi. But the motors are pulling off the tug batteries. If we light them up, we burn half our overnight storage in ten minutes.”

“We won't need ten minutes,” Tan said, his eyes narrowing as two blinding white halogen spotlights swung around the breakwater, cutting through the monsoon sheets.

The first Apex interceptor emerged from the mist, its twin supercharged outboards roaring like chain-saws, a rigid-hull raider carrying six tactical security contractors in black drysuits and ballistic helmets. They were coming fast, their bow cutting a violent white furrow across the slipway, aiming directly for the caisson control platform.

On the gantry boom, sixty-five meters overhead, a pencil-thin needle of brilliant cyan light flared to life, piercing through the driving rain toward the distant silhouette of the Batam hills.

For one second, the light held steady.

Then, from the channel below, the second Apex skiff raised a high-intensity marine spotlight, blinding the crane cab, while the first craft slammed against the caisson pier with a sickening crunch of reinforced fiberglass.

A voice blared through a megaphonic hailer from the lead skiff, sharp and amplified:

“Notice of Admiralty Impoundment! Clear the caisson walkway immediately! We are boarding under authority of Euro-Asian Maritime Finance!”

Jin caught Tan’s arm. “They have legal cover.”

Tan didn’t flinch. He reached out with his calloused hand and gripped the brass lever of the yard’s ancient mechanical sluice release—the gravity bypass that held back eighty thousand tons of tidal ballast.

“Let them read their paper to the tide,” Tan said, and slammed the lever down.

Chapter 4

The counterweight dropped with a dull, subterranean thud that resonated through the soles of Jin's work boots.

Beneath the caisson pier, the yard's rusted gravity bypass gave way. Eighty thousand tons of trapped tidal ballast, collected across twelve hours of rising monsoon chop, tore through the lower sluice gates like a collapsing wall of slate. The displaced sea erupted out of the slipway in a churning, white-water boil, catching the lead Apex interceptor mid-surge.

The rigid-hull raider, built for precision boarding, was lifted six feet on the crest of the outrushing current. Its twin outboards screamed in free air as the propellers lost bite, cavitating against the foam, before the craft was swept hard broadside against the heavy timber fenders of Berth 7. The fiberglass groaned, a sickening screech of resin under compression. Tactical contractors in black drysuits scrambled for handholds as dark harbor water washed over their gunwales, swamping their deck lockers and cutting their megaphonic hailer into a wet, choking squawk.

They did not panic. They were professionals working a salvage contract. Even as their boat rocked violently in the hydraulic backlash, two men at the bow leveled pneumatically driven grappling hooks, firing steel-tipped anchors into the pitted concrete coping of the pier. The winches whined, fighting the outward surge to secure their purchase.

"They're anchoring!" Jin shouted through the squall, coughing as the diesel-tainted spray coated his mouth. *"Tan, the second skiff is circling wide to the crane tracks!"*

"They won't climb the crane if the yard has teeth," Tan said. His old fingers were white from the effort of pinning the sluice lever down. "Aisyah! The sub-station! The channel current is at peak rip!"

High above them on the gantry boom, sixty-five meters in the screaming gale, Aisyah didn't answer with words. She had already clipped her safety lanyard to the vertical guide cable.

Instead of climbing down the steel ladder rung by wet rung, she locked her leather-palmed descent mitts onto the braided steel line, kicked out into empty air, and dropped.

The monsoon wind slammed her against the lattice bracing, the impact driving the air from her chest, but she didn't brake until the final ten meters. Her boots hit the wet wooden decking of the drydock gallery with a sharp crack. She unhooked in a single fluid motion, her knees absorbing the shock. Her muscles burned from sixteen hours of continuous wet-suit diving, and her fingertips—

desensitized from old high-voltage flash burns—tingled with cold pinpricks in the swampy, thirty-four-degree heat.

As a girl on the kelong stilt-platforms off Pulau Tekong, she had learned that the sea never gave you time to deliberate. When a sudden squall caught her father's shrimp traps against the pilings, you didn't measure the height of the waves; you dove beneath the chop where the water was quiet and worked until your lungs felt like crushed paper. She drew in a long breath through her nose, biting the inside of her cheek to still the involuntary tremor in her jaw, and plunged into the access hatch of Berth 8.

The air in the subterranean bunker hit her like a wet towel soaked in vinegar.

Here, beneath three meters of reinforced slag concrete, sat the salvaged heart of the drydock: forty tons of lithium-iron-phosphate battery cells, hauled out of the engine compartments of two decommissioned hybrid harbor tugs. They were racked in floor-to-ceiling steel cages, bolted to the damp foundation. The cells were silent, cold, and desperately empty. On the master monitoring board, the busbar indicators flickered amber-red. They had five minutes of reserve juice left to feed the cyan laser link on the crane tower. When that died, the optical line to the sister docks in Batam would sever, blinding the entire southern network.

Across the vaulted chamber, the twin drive-shafts from the deep-channel tidal turbines penetrated the seawall through heavy mechanical stuffing boxes.

The shafts were spinning now, turning with a low, bone-jarring groan. The outward rush of Tan's ballast release, combined with the fierce four-knot tidal shift through the Malacca strait, had caught the twin submerged hydrofoils anchored in the trench. The massive bronze gears screamed inside their oil baths, shedding heat into the damp chamber.

"Aisyah!" Chen Rui's voice crackled through the low-frequency wall-mounted intercom, distorted by the concrete mass above. "The offshore current is spiking! The turbines are generating, but the synchronizer is hunting—it can't find the phase!"

"Because the contacts are salt-bridged!" she yelled back into the horn, pulling an insulated nylon scraper from her tool belt.

She ran toward the high-voltage coupling bay at the far end of the rack. The tropical humidity here was near saturation; moisture condensed on the cool copper busbars, and the sea air had deposited a thin, translucent crust of white salt across the ceramic insulator posts. If she engaged the mechanical contactors with that crust intact, forty thousand amperes of raw three-phase power would arc across the gap in a ball of superheated plasma that would vaporize the switchgear and turn the bunker into an oven.

Through the concrete ceiling, the muffled sound of hydraulic cutters echoed down. The second Apex skiff had landed a squad on the quay. They were cutting through the distribution padlock chains, enforcing the admiralty impoundment with industrial tools. They weren't monsters—they were bailiffs

with tactical armor, executing a foreclosure lien for Euro-Asian Maritime Finance, convinced that clearing this yard was the only thing preventing catastrophic shipping collisions in the strait.

They had three minutes before the private contractors secured the master breaker above ground.

Aisyah dropped to her knees before the coupling rack. The air smelled sharply of ozone and rotting kelp.

She sprayed denatured alcohol across the insulator posts, the solvent hissing against the warm metal, and attacked the salt crust with the nylon scraper. Flakes of gray-white brine showered down onto her rubber apron. Her forearms cramped, the tendons tightening like violin strings. *Scrape. Wipe. Check.* Her left hand slipped on the grease, her bare wrist brushing within an inch of an exposed ground strap. The hair on her arm stood straight up in the electrostatic field.

“Rui!” she barked toward the wall speaker. “Turbine RPM?”

“One hundred twenty at the shaft! The hydraulic pitch is locked at maximum angle!” Rui’s voice was strained, breathless. “Aisyah, the contractors are on the roof of the substation! They’re looking for the manual cutouts!”

“Tell Jin to run the seawater monitors!”

“The pumps don’t have the volts!” Rui shouted back. “The tug batteries are flat!”

“They will in ten seconds!”

She threw the scraper aside. The ceramic posts were clean, wet with evaporating alcohol. But the mechanical interlock—the heavy, cast-iron lever that slammed the turbine alternator onto the battery-charging rectifier bank—was held back by a magnetic safety latch that refused to drop. The automated sync-check was dead, fried by the lightning storm an hour earlier.

The system was waiting for a digital handshake that would never come.

The doctrine said: *Never force an out-of-phase rotor.* If the turbine frequency didn’t match the inverter’s internal timing, the torque would snap the drive-shaft like a dry bamboo stick.

Aisyah didn’t have an oscilloscope. She had her ears and the soles of her feet.

She pressed her boot heel against the base plate of the turbine shaft housing. Through the rubber and the bone of her leg, she felt the fundamental vibration—a low, rhythmic *thrum-thrum-thrum* that hummed in the cavity of her chest. In her mind, she matched it against the faint, sixty-cycle whistle of the inverter’s standby pilot coils.

She closed her eyes. Pulau Tekong. Midnight on the kelong. The rhythm of the tide slapping the crossbeams.

The shaft vibration accelerated, rising half a tone as a fresh surge of deep-channel water tore through the strait. *Now.*

Aisyah grabbed the emergency bypass hammer hanging from the bulkhead, swung, and smashed the mechanical trip-latch.

The heavy copper busbars dropped.

The contactors slammed shut with the force of a naval cannon, the mechanical impact rattling the teeth in her jaw. A blinding violet flash lit the vault, searing the shadow of the steel cages into the concrete wall. The smell of scorched air hit her throat, hot and metallic.

For half a second, the massive drive-shaft shrieked, its bronze couplings groaning under an instantaneous thermodynamic load as forty tons of chemical cells resisted the kinetic surge. The steel racks shivered. Then, the sound shifted from a scream to a deep, resonant, oceanic roar.

On the master board, the indicators didn't flicker. They locked into a brilliant, steady emerald green.

Twelve megawatt-hours of reclaimed storage snapped into the line, absorbing the mechanical fury of the Malacca tide.

Above her head, through thirty feet of wet stone and rain, Berth 7 came alive.

The giant high-pressure fire monitors—salvaged from an offshore rescue tug—received full industrial power. At the caisson pier, the brass nozzles swung mechanically on their hydraulic mounts, locking onto the slipway. Twin solid jets of seawater, two thousand five hundred gallons a minute at one hundred fifty pounds per square inch, tore into the night.

The blast struck the pier with hydraulic hammer-force. It didn't kill. It didn't break bones. But it washed forty yards of concrete completely clean, swamping the Apex cutting teams, blowing their hydraulic power units off the lip into the harbor, and pinning their tactical shields against the rusted plate of the caisson. The boarding ladders tore loose, clattering into the foam.

Overhead, the gantry crane's floodlights blazed into existence, sweeping away the darkness, while the cyan laser beam atop the sixty-five-meter boom doubled in intensity, burning through the driving sheets of monsoon rain like a solid lance of blue glass.

Aisyah leaned her forehead against the cool steel mesh of the battery cage, her chest heaving, the bitter taste of ozone coating her tongue.

Then the speaker on the wall didn't bring cheers. It clicked, and Lin Zhang's voice came through, trembling with a panic that stripped all the blood from the victory:

"Aisyah. Jin. Look at the radar plot on Berth 11. It wasn't an impoundment team. The skiffs were just a distraction."

Aisyah pushed herself off the cage, her legs shaking as she climbed back toward the surface hatch.

She shoved the heavy steel lid open into the monsoon downpour and wiped the rain from her eyes.

Out past the breakwater, beyond the reach of the fire monitors, a massive, unlit commercial crane barge was creeping into the outer anchorage under cover of the storm. Its heavy steel gantry was already lowering a multi-ton industrial trenching claw directly over the international shipping lane—aimed straight down at the unarmored seabed trench where the southern trans-strait optical cable entered the Batam trench.

They weren't trying to seize the drydock.

They were going to sever the entire region from the continental mesh before the tide turned.

CHAPTER 5

Chapter 5

The trenching barge did not show running lights. Out past the breakwater, its black hull wallowed like an iron whale in the cross-chop of the Malacca Strait, anchored by four heavy spuds driven deep into the seabed. Its diesel winch gave a low, seismic shudder that traveled through two miles of black water, vibrating up into the wet concrete soles of Berth 9.

The hydraulic claw was already submerged.

In the operations cabin beneath the caisson lip, Lin Zhang’s voice was stripped of breath, flattened by the dry hum of overtaxed cooling fans. "The Batam-South subsea trench is failing. Signal-to-noise is collapsing across all twenty-four pairs. They aren't trying to board us, Jin. They’re dragging the trench."

Jin Wei hauled himself up the ladder of Berth 9’s master gantry, water streaming down the yellow rubber of his slicker into his boots. Every rung sent a dull, familiar spike of iron agony through his lumbar spine. When the pain spiked into his left hip, he clamped his teeth and counted silently to ten, matching each number to the beat of his pulse in his ears—an old diver’s habit learned forty years ago when clearing fouled propellers in the black shallows of the Riau Islands.

Beside him, Aisyah binti Rahman scrambled up the vertical cage with the twitchy, furious grace of a rigger half his weight. Her hands were wrapped in torn electrical tape to protect the raw, blistered skin where high-voltage arcs had bitten into her palms six hours earlier, but she climbed without pausing to look down. When the wind caught her, she didn't fight it; she pressed her chest against the cold galvanized rungs and let the iron absorb the squall.

"How long until the claw bites?" Jin shouted through the roaring sheets of rain.

"Two minutes!" Lin’s voice crackled from the handheld clipped to Jin’s collar, the battery indicator blinking amber. "The physical trenching head is fifty tons. Once it hooks the bundle, it’ll shear the armored casing like rotten hemp. If that cable snaps before the optical bridge locks, the whole southern mesh goes dark. Batam, Johor, every refugee berth in the basin—we’ll be blind. Aegis will register the entire sector as abandoned derelict by morning."

"The crane transmitter!" Jin barked. "Why hasn't the rooftop optic fired?"

"I’m firing it!" Lin yelled back, her vocal cords raw. "The beam is out, but the return signal is dead. The collimator is completely blinded! You've got fifty percent scatter on the primary prism! It’s like firing a flashlight into curdled milk!"

Jin hauled his torso over the safety lip of the forty-meter platform. The wind here was not rain; it was a horizontal wall of warm brine ripped straight off the channel crests, moving fast enough to peel the skin off a man’s eyelids. Above them, the final twenty-five meters of the gantry boom arched out into empty air, a skeletal steel arm jutting over the void of the shipping channel.

At the very tip of that arm, bolted inside an aluminum weather-pod, was the Free Space Optics transceiver: a high-precision cyan-spectrum laser designed to bridge eight nautical miles of open water to the international shipping lane. It was their only way past the severed seabed cables, a beam of coherent light aimed at the masthead receiver of an independent freighter drifting under Panamanian registry in international waters.

The blue beam was there, but it wasn't a clean lance of light. It was a bloated, flickering cone of turquoise fog, bleeding uselessly into the monsoon squall.

"Salt crust," Aisyah said. She spat a mouthful of warm rain onto the decking. Her eyes were slitted against the spray, fixed on the transceiver housing fifty feet out along the narrow catwalk. "Three days of trade wind baking brine against the front glass, and now this mud-wash. The beam is refracting across the faceplate. It's scattering before it even leaves the dock."

"The wiper arm?" Jin reached the outrigger's maintenance rail, his fingers locking onto the slippery iron.

"Stuck on the reverse stroke. Solenoid must have fused when the generator surged." Aisyah reached into her canvas tool roll, pulling out a scraper with a brass blade and a bottle of laboratory-grade ethanol. "I have to clear the glass by hand."

"No harness rail past the forty-five-meter mark," Jin said, his hand clamping down on her shoulder. The rubber of her coat was freezing, slick as kelp. "The maintenance crew stripped the lifelines during the salvage auction last month."

Aisyah looked down at the hand on her shoulder. Jin's thumb was scarred by an old battery explosion, the nail split permanently in two. For all his limp, his grip had the heavy, unyielding torque of a mooring winch.

"If that freighter moves three cables north without picking up our carrier wave, it clears the channel," she said. She didn't shout. Her voice was flat, pressed thin by the roaring squall. "They drop their clearance papers. They sail for Tanjung Pelepas. Then we’re just another blacked-out yard waiting for the bailiffs."

She slipped out from under his hand before he could tighten his fingers.

The catwalk was sixteen inches of expanded steel mesh, trembling violently under the hammer of the monsoon. To her right, Drydock 4 was an abyss of black concrete and foaming scuppers sixty meters down. To her left, the open water of the strait churned with gray foam, the distant running lights of the container barge sliding steadily south toward the subsea trench.

Jin stepped onto the mesh behind her.

His boots made a hollow clatter on the steel. He didn't try to look graceful; he kept his center of gravity down, knees bent, letting his bad spine absorb the sway of the crane tower. The structure was rolling three feet to either side with every major gust, groaning like an old iron bridge under a runaway locomotive.

"Jin! Go back to the platform!" Aisyah called over her shoulder, her voice torn away by the wind.

"Shut up and walk!" he rasped, his lungs burning with the sharp salt-air reek of bunker oil and ozone. "I'm your counterweight!"

They crept along the steel spine, one hand on the single waist-high pipe rail, until the rail simply ended at a sheared-off flange twenty feet from the tip.

Ahead, the transceiver housing sat atop a narrow outrigger shelf. The blue laser erupted from its round snout, boiling the raindrops into tiny, sparkling flashes of steam, but the lens itself was an opaque cataract of white salt and greasy river silt.

From the radio at Jin's neck, Lin's voice rose to a scream over the static: "Subsea pair twelve just dropped! The trenching claw hit the outer armor! You have thirty seconds before the physical core tears!"

Aisyah dropped to her knees on the bare girders. The metal here was slick with algae and diesel scum. With no lifeline, the wind tried to roll her sideways off the six-inch beam into the channel below.

Jin moved up behind her, dropped his weight across the structural crossbeam, and jammed both his steel-toed boots hard into the triangular truss below. He locked his left arm around the main vertical stanchion, hooking his forearm through the iron gusset until the steel bit through his wet wool sleeve into the bone. With his right hand, he seized the heavy nylon webbing of Aisyah's harness ring, hauling her tight against his thigh.

"Go!" Jin roared. "I have you!"

Aisyah leaned out into the open sky.

The drop below her was absolute. She didn't look at the white crests breaking against the caisson wall; she fixed her eyes on the six-inch circle of quartz glass.

She soaked the rag in ethanol, the sweet, cold sting of the alcohol cutting through the heavy smell of the sea. The first stroke of her scraper hit the glass with a screech of calcified brine. The crust was thick, baked hard by the heat of the transceiver's internal diodes. She leaned further, her boots dangling in sixty-five meters of empty air, Jin's arm her only connection to the earth.

The scraper chattered across the quartz. White flakes of salt blew back into her eyes, blinding her with a ferocious, chemical burn. She didn't wipe them; she blinked through tears of agony, using the

edge of the brass blade to carve the caked salt from the bezel.

Down in the strait, a sudden, terrible flash of blue light illuminated the water beneath the trenching barge.

The subsea fiber had snapped.

A muffled thump traveled through the sea, followed instantly by Lin's voice through the radio, breaking into desperate fragments: "...cable severed... Batam is dark... we have zero... we're dead..."

"Not yet!" Aisyah screamed into the rain.

She lunged forward, smashing the saturated rag directly against the face of the prism.

The ethanol dissolved the remaining haze in a hiss of steam.

Instantly, the bloated, misty cone of blue light collapsed.

The beam sharpened into a needle of brilliant, searing cyan. It punched clean through the monsoon squall, a straight, razor-thin line of electric blue that cleaved the driving rain and drove eight miles out into the center of the international channel.

For three agonizing seconds, there was nothing but the howling of the gale and the creak of the crane's swaying boom.

Then, from far out in the black waters of the traffic separation scheme, a faint pinprick of green light blinked once from the superstructure of the drifting freighter.

The radio at Jin's collar went dead for half a beat, swallowed by pure carrier-wave frequency.

When Lin's voice returned, it wasn't a scream. It was a choked, trembling whisper, vibrating with an impossible return signal: "Handshake confirmed. Sovereign mesh synchronized. The ledger is crossing the strait."

Jin let out a ragged, shuddering breath, his forehead falling against the cold iron of the stanchion, his right arm trembling violently from the strain of holding Aisyah's weight.

"Aisyah," he whispered, his chest heaving. "Come back. We have it."

Aisyah didn't move. She was still hanging over the edge, her hand braced against the cold aluminum pod of the transceiver.

"Jin," she said, her voice completely flat.

"Aisyah, climb back!"

"Look at the green beam," she said, her hand pointing not at the freighter eight miles out, but down into the channel directly beneath the crane.

Jin forced his head up through the blinding rain and looked down.

The green confirmation signal hadn't come from the merchant ship.

Sitting motionless two hundred yards inside the harbor breakwater, masked by the shadow of Berth 11's coal conveyor, was a low-slung, matte-black patrol craft flying no flag. Its forward mast held an active optical interceptor array, drinking in the cyan data stream as fast as it left the gantry.

Mounted on its foredeck, an industrial steel cable-launcher was already swiveling upward, its pneumatic cylinders charging with a loud, mechanical hiss, aiming directly at the crane's primary support leg.

CHAPTER 6

Chapter 6

The pneumatic hiss cut through the gale like a striking serpent.

"Down!" Jin roared.

He hooked his forearm beneath Aisyah’s collar and hauled her inward with a savage jerk of his bad shoulder. The joint popped, a spike of hot silver radiating down into his fingers, but the momentum carried her sprawling over the crane’s rusted safety lip.

A steel barb the size of a dockyard bollard slammed into the gantry’s diagonal cross-brace. The impact rang like a fractured cathedral bell. High-tensile braided steel cable hummed tight, vibrating violently as the patrol craft reversed its twin stern thrusters, attempting to winch the leg off its concrete footing. The crane groaned, sixty-five meters of corroded steel shuddering five degrees out of true.

"Lin!" Jin barked into his collar, dragging Aisyah toward the service cage. "Seawater monitor three! Flood the breakwater!"

"Manual bypass engaged," Lin’s voice crackled, breathless and dry despite the storm. "Diverting tidal surge!"

A hundred feet below, the harbor deck thudded. The decommissioned ballast pump roared to life with an iron shriek. A twin-nozzle monitor on Berth 10 unlocked its pneumatic pintle, swinging out over the swell. A solid wall of brine, two thousand gallons every minute under brutal hydraulic head, erupted into the dark.

The high-pressure torrent hammered the matte-black interceptor square across its wheelhouse. Polycarbonate windscreen panels crazed instantly into white frost. The vessel tilted violently to port, shipping gray water across its low-slung aft deck. The optical prism on its mast shattered under the hydrodynamic punch, and the winch severed its own tow-cable against the gunwale sheer-lip with a loud *thwack* that whiplashed into the surf.

The craft’s thrusters screamed, churning white foam as it spun off its axis, retreating into the monsoon chop toward the deep channel.

Aisyah lay on the wet grating, her chest heaving, the skin of her fingers pale and puckered from seawater and solvent. She tasted iron on her split lower lip. When she rolled onto her knees, she wasn't looking at the fleeing boat. She was staring at what the winch cable had ripped from the conveyor stanchion as it sheared.

A heavy, polymer-coated pelican dispatch case was wedged in the twisted ladder rungs of the lower footing, dangling three feet above the churning tide.

"Don't," Jin muttered, holding his trembling elbow against his ribs, his breath catching in his throat. His knees clicked, calcified grit grinding behind the patellas.

"It’s not theirs," Aisyah said, already swinging her boots onto the ladder rungs. "Look at the lanyard. That’s commercial registry canvas. From the *Pulau Mas*."

Jin followed her down the dripping vertical cage. Every rung vibrated with the deep, rhythmic thrum of the tidal turbines churning eight fathoms under the shipyard slipway. The salt spray stung the chemical burn along his collarbone, an old, persistent itch that flared whenever the barometric pressure plunged. He reached the lower catwalk just as Aisyah hooked the dispatch satchel with the heel of her boot and hauled it onto the iron plating.

The casing was cracked, sea-foam weeping from its gaskets. Inside lay no transmitters or surveillance arrays.

Only paper. Thick, synthetic waterproof leaves, bound in blue oilcloth and warped by bilge brine: the official master’s log of the container feeder *Pulau Mas*, registered out of Tanjung Perak.

Uncle Tan was waiting at the foot of the gantry stairs, his yellow slicker shining under the work-lights, his swollen, arthritic hands clamped firmly around a battered aluminum thermos. Behind him, huddled beneath the overhang of the machine shop, thirty stranded deckhands watched in dead silence.

"The patrol craft turned back toward the eastern anchorage," Tan said, his low voice gravel-soft, offering the thermos cap full of scalding ginger broth to Aisyah without looking at the satchel. For twenty years running tug crews through the Sunda Strait, Tan had kept a habit of reading men's posture before their faces; now, his rheumy eyes stayed fixed on the tremor in Jin’s forearm. "They won't bring the heavy cutters inside the reef until daybreak. Too shallow for their hydrofoils."

"Inside," Jin said through his teeth. "Before the rain ruins the ink."

They crowded into the drydock’s auxiliary toolroom, where Chen Rui had set up an emergency draft bench. The air smelled of damp cardboard, stale tobacco, and the warm copper tang of the battery banks stacked against the masonry wall. Rui didn't look up from his stress charts; his forearms were taped tight with elastic bandages to suppress the ache in his flexor tendons, his fingers rhythmically rolling a brass micrometer to calm an involuntary twitch.

Lin Zhang stood by the lone incandescent bulb, shaking water from her hair. Her spectacles were fogged, her face hollowed by forty straight hours without sleep. A patch of eczema on her temple, inflamed by salt and screen glare, showed angry and red against her pale skin.

"Let me see it," Lin whispered, pulling off her sodden neoprene gloves.

Jin laid the blue oilcloth binder on the zinc-topped table. With the tip of a pocket knife, he slit the swollen binding thread.

The leaves separated with a wet, sucking tear.

The handwriting was erratic, penned in purple indelible pencil by a captain whose vessel had clearly lost auxiliary power long before it grounded. But beneath the handwritten navigational coordinates were pasted strips of thermal paper—automated admiralty notices spat out by satellite receivers before the antennas had been silenced.

"Date: fourteen days ago," Lin read aloud, her finger tracing the blurred blue margins. "*Pulau Mas*. Three thousand TEU. Ballast voyage from Surabaya to Jurong."

"She was empty," Jin said. "Scrap-iron charter."

"Look at the ledger sequence," Rui muttered, his micrometer stopping mid-spin. He leaned over Lin’s shoulder, his glasses reflecting the single bulb. "Here. Margin notice from Euro-Asian Maritime Finance. An automated acceleration clause triggered at 03:00 UTC."

Lin touched the paper, her voice tightening. "Default declared under Section 14-B. The ship wasn't behind on mortgage payments. Look at the ledger printout. Every remittance was clearing through the Singapore escrow desk."

"Then why the writ?" Aisyah asked, wringing seawater from her dark hair into an empty oil drum.

"It wasn't a human writ," Lin said. She turned the leaf carefully. The paper beneath was stamped with the hexagon seal of Aegis-Omni Predictive Intelligence. "It’s a risk-spread algorithm. The system calculated a 4.2 percent probability that bunker fuel prices would exceed charter yields over the next three quarters. That single variance triggered a preemptive maritime lien."

Jin stared at the purple pencil marks. The captain’s handwriting grew progressively jagged across the page:

04:12 — Remote lockout transmitted via channel 16 data burst. Main injection rail throttled by satellite relay. Engine room blacked out from shore.

05:30 — Rudder locked five degrees to starboard. Crew unable to override hydraulic helm. Vessel drifting into the outbound shipping lane.

07:15 — Boarding party from Apex Marine alongside. They carried no court summons. Only a printed QR clearance certificate.

"They didn't repossess her because she failed," Jin breathed, his voice dropping into the cold register he used when an engine room took on water. "They crippled her because the algorithm decided she was worth more broken for parts."

"Not just her," Lin whispered. She flipped three pages forward, where the captain had taped a list copied from the VHF distress log during his final hours of drift.

Nine other vessels. The *Bintang Timur*, the *Anping 7*, the *Riau Star*. All private owner-operator coasters. All seized in the fairway by automated command over the last sixteen days, their steering systems frozen remotely by the financial consortium’s insurance network, then pushed onto the shallows to justify private tactical salvage.

"It’s an automated harvest," Rui said, his knuckles white against the edge of the zinc table. "The sovereign traffic corridors are being cleared out by code to force all feeder traffic into the corporate container hubs. That’s why they wanted our laser link dark. If the independent ships synchronize their own manifests through our mesh, the predictive model loses jurisdictional control."

Outside, the rain slackened to an oily drizzle, but the silence that followed was heavier than the squall.

Uncle Tan walked to the narrow window overlooking the slipway. In the yard below, dozens of mariners were huddled around iron braziers burning driftwood and discarded dunnage, their breath rising in gray plumes against the damp night.

"They think the law is still a courtroom in London or Singapore," Tan said quietly, without turning around. "They think an admiralty judge will sign an order to give their decks back."

"There are no judges out there, Tan," Jin said, pressing his thumb hard against his collarbone scar. "Only clearinghouse software running on thirty-second margins."

Lin pulled a magnifying glass from her breast pocket, inspecting the bottom margin of the final thermal slip. Her hand suddenly froze.

"Jin," she said.

The tone of her voice made Chen Rui drop his micrometer. It rattled loudly on the zinc.

"What is it?" Jin demanded.

Lin didn't look up. Her finger was pinned to a tiny, eight-digit alphanumeric hash stamped at the foot of the *Pulau Mas* repossession order.

"The signature key authorizing the algorithmic seizure of the fleet," Lin said, each syllable dropping like cold lead into the room. "It wasn't issued by Euro-Asian Maritime Finance."

Jin stepped forward, the floorboards groaning under his weight. "Whose key is it?"

Lin looked up, her face paper-white in the yellow glare of the bulb.

"It’s registered to the Port Authority Receiver’s office in Batam," she whispered. "And the digital certificate was signed using the private cryptographic token of Captain Jin Wei."

CHAPTER 7

Chapter 7

The room seemed to lose its air.

Jin did not speak. His left hand rose slowly to his collarbone, fingers digging through his sweat-stiffened shirt into the rigid knot of his burn scar. The diesel bulb overhead swayed in the draft off the slipway, throwing his shadow in jagged lunges across the blueprint-strewn table.

"Say that again," Rui murmured. His voice had gone thin, the mechanical pencil snapping between his calloused fingers.

"The master key issued when the port authority liquidated your command of the *Bintang Laut*," Lin said, her breath catching as she angled the lens closer to the thermal paper. "They never retired the certificate. When you surrendered your physical token at the receiver's desk in Batam three years ago, they logged it as decommissioned. But in the root directory, the signature remained valid. Every algorithmic foreclosure across the strait over the past eighteen days has been stamped with your digital hand, Jin."

Before Jin could draw breath, a flat, metallic thrum vibrated up through the zinc floorboards. It was not the gentle pulse of the tidal turbines churning in the deep channel. It was a rhythmic, cavitation-heavy chop—twin inboard diesels running muffled without running lights, cutting through the outer breakwater at speed.

Aisyah kicked the door open. Her sleeveless coveralls were slick with rain and black grease, her dive hood pushed back onto her shoulders.

"Skiffs," she said. Two words, snapped like cold iron. "Three of them. Passing the northern shoals. No transponders."

Jin dropped the magnifying glass. The shock of the forged signature vanished into the cold, mechanical calculus of survival. "Berth Nine?"

"Heading straight for the crane tracks," Aisyah said, already swinging back into the gloom of the exterior gantry. "They want the battery packs. If they drown our sub-station, the gantry laser drops dead."

"Tan!" Jin roared into the stairwell.

The old bosun was already moving among the braziers below, his voice low and firm, herding the sixty-odd refugee sailors away from the open wharf and into the deep concrete belly of the machine

shop. There was no panic, only the swift, shuffling urgency of men who had spent their lives listening for the sound of breached bulkheads.

"Rui, the valve deck!" Jin shouted, taking the stairs three at a time. The degenerative ache in his spine flared with each impact, a familiar white-hot spike that he ground down beneath his teeth. "Lin, kill every exterior floodlight! Go dark on the water!"

The shipyard plunged into blackness.

Through the driving tropical rain, the strait was an oily expanse of shifting shadows. Jin hit the wet gravel of Berth 9, boots sliding on the algae-filmed concrete. The heat index sat suffocatingly high even at midnight, the air thick as steam, smelling of salt mud and burning electrical insulation.

Ahead, cutting through the chop with predatory stillness, three rigid-hulled inflatable interceptors crested the wake of the channel. Their low-slung, matte-black composite hulls sat deep in the water, carrying six men each in tactical flotation armor. Jin caught the dull glint of carbon-fiber boarding ladders slung across their thwarts and pneumatic grappling guns resting on their bows. No blue flags. No sovereign coast guard insignia. Apex Marine Tactical.

They were not here to serve paperwork. They were here to disable the node’s independent power before dawn.

"Aisyah! Are the intake lines clear?" Jin barked, reaching the pump manifold beneath the crane's forward pylon.

"Silt filter’s half-choked from the tide change!" her voice crackled over the hardwired speaker near the valve cluster. "I’ve got the bypass open, but the salt crust is jamming the secondary gate!"

"Take the sledge to the bypass ring!" Rui grunted, throwing his full weight against a three-foot bronze spanner on the sea-cock valve. The bilateral strain in his forearms made his sinews tremble violently, his skin slick with sweat and brine. "Move! They’re inside two hundred yards!"

The lead interceptor throttled up. The low rumble became an aggressive, throaty snarl as its twin props bit into the shallow basin. A narrow, high-intensity spotlight punched out from its console, spearing across the rusted hull of the slipway, hunting for the main electrical umbilical connecting the tidal turbine bank to the shore manifold.

The beam struck Jin full in the chest.

Crack.

A pneumatic grapple arched upward through the squall, its four-pronged titanium hook clattering violently over the lower catwalk railing of Berth 9. The heavy Kevlar climbing line snapped taut against the pier edge as the lead skiff reversed thrusters to hold station against the stone quay.

"Rui! Turn it!" Jin yelled.

With a ragged cry, Rui slammed the bronze wheel past its corroded stop. Inside the cast-iron housing beneath their feet, four hundred gallons of pressurized seawater hit the line with a shudder that jarred Jin’s teeth.

Jin lunged for the dual-grip tiller of the primary salvage monitor mounted to the dock edge—a heavy brass cannon salvaged from an ocean-going firefighting tug, its swivel joint stiff with aged tallow. He dropped his shoulder into the counterweight, dragging the nozzle downward until the sights lined with the black rubber sponson of the lead boat.

"Brace!" Jin bellowed.

He threw the quarter-turn lever.

The sea roared back through the pipe. A solid column of green ocean water, six inches thick and pressurized to bursting, erupted from the nozzle. The recoil slammed into Jin’s chest like an iron slab, driving the heels of his boots back two inches into the rain-slick planks.

The jet struck the water three yards short of the lead interceptor, throwing up an blinding wall of spray that completely swallowed the boat’s spotlight. Jin adjusted his footing, driving his hips forward, and elevated the iron barrel.

The high-pressure torrent slammed directly into the skiff’s bow.

Under the crushing kinetic impact of twelve tons of moving water per minute, the light composite craft didn't just swerve—its bow was forced violently down into the chop. The boarding ladder shattered like dry bamboo. Two mercenaries on the foredeck were swept clean off their feet, thrown across the center console into the engine well by the sheer hydraulic mass.

The gunboat’s engine shrieked as its propellers broke surface, churning air, before the boat slid sideways, taking hundreds of gallons over its port gunwale.

"Second boat on the jetty flank!" Lin’s voice echoed down from the crane gantry over the sound-powered telephone horn. "They're attempting a cut on the sub-surface cable!"

Jin swung the monitor. The brass collar groaned, protesting the lateral torque. The jet carved a boiling trench across the basin water, slicing through the midnight drizzle until it caught the second craft broadside.

The jet sheared off the skiff’s outboard cowling with a metallic crunch, crushing the composite shroud into the cooling fan. White steam erupted as salt water flooded the hot cylinder block. The craft lurched violently, dead in the water, wallowing heavily as its self-bailing scuppers choked on river debris.

From the deck of the third skiff, twenty yards back, an operative raised a compressed-gas launcher. A blinding canister arced through the dark, striking the gantry crane’s iron stanchion and bursting into a

dense, chemical aerosol curtain of gray tear gas.

The wind from the sea caught the cloud, rolling it directly into the pump bay.

Jin pulled his collar over his mouth, coughing violently. His lungs burned, the old bunker-fuel damage flaring into an agonized spasm that forced him to his knees. Rui fell beside him, retching onto the iron grating, his eyes streaming with tears.

"Aisyah..." Jin wheezed, his vision blurring.

Above them, the high-pitched whine of the gantry's auxiliary hoist screeched into life.

Aisyah hadn't abandoned the crane controls. From her perch forty feet above the waterline, she threw the manual brake on the gantry's empty spreader bar.

Six tons of structural steel dropped straight down through the darkness.

It did not hit the skiff; it plummeted into the water four feet off its starboard beam. The displaced tidal surge slammed against the third craft with the force of a rogue wave, flipping the light interceptor onto its beam ends. The crew was hurled into the churning, oily blackness of the slipway basin.

The surviving first boat, half-swamped and its console smashed by water pressure, scrambled to engage its bow thrusters, desperately hauling its sodden comrades out of the chop. Its searchlight was dead, its electronics ruined by the sheer volume of salt brine that had drowned its open cockpits.

Without firing a single shot, the remaining tactical craft backed frantically into the fairway, trailing oily foam and severed lines, its sirens dead, its crew shivering and defeated by the pure, unyielding mass of the sea.

Silence fell over Berth 9, broken only by the hiss of the receding wake against the stone wall and the ragged, gasping breaths of the three people on the valve platform.

Rui sat with his head between his knees, spitting clear saliva, his forearms trembling uncontrollably. Lin appeared at the bottom of the ladder, carrying a lantern shielded with a piece of cardboard, her face smudged with soot.

"They're clearing the channel," she whispered, her voice shaking. "They won't try the basin again tonight."

Jin pulled himself upright by the monitor's brass handle. His uniform was soaked through, cold mud caked across his shins. He looked down at the dark water where the skiffs had retreated.

Something bobbed against the wooden fender piles.

It was not a man, and it was not a shattered spar. It was a heavy, waterproof flight case that had been thrown from the swamped command boat, caught in the eddy behind the jetty.

Rui leaned over the edge with a boat hook, dragging the dripping plastic case onto the dock. The latches were sealed with red customs tape.

Jin dropped to one knee and thumbed the release.

Inside, resting on die-cut foam, was a commercial satellite terminal wired to a ruggedized field tablet. The screen was still illuminated under its tempered glass, displaying an active admiralty recovery ledger that updated every three seconds.

At the top of the queue, glowing amber in the darkness, was the registration of the Keppel-Batam shipyard itself.

Beneath it was the order authorization timestamped forty minutes ago, signed by the same hijacked credential. But beneath Jin’s forged name, a new field had populated, linking the Batam receiver’s terminal to an offshore operating account in Singapore.

The name on the beneficiary line made Jin’s breath catch in his throat.

It was not Euro-Asian Maritime Finance.

It was the personal pension trust of Captain Jin Wei's own missing chief engineer—the one man who had gone down with the *Bintang Laut* three years ago.

CHAPTER 8

Chapter 8

The name on the beneficiary line burned into the damp glass of the screen: *Harun bin Idris*.

Captain Jin Wei did not blink. The salt crust around his eyelashes pulled tight, a sharp, granular sting that anchored him to the slick timber of the wharf. Harun had been his chief engineer for eleven years, a man whose left shoulder sat two inches lower than his right from hauling boiler pipes, a man who had gone down with the crushed stern of the *Bintang Laut* in the deep channel off Karimun. Jin had signed the maritime death declaration himself. He had watched the salvage barges abandon the wreck when the monsoon swells made diving impossible.

Yet here, registered thirty-four minutes ago in the digital clearinghouse of the Singapore receiver, was Harun’s personal provident fund account, accepting the debt-assignment rights to every mooring bollard and crane rail in Berth 9.

"Is it a mirror?" Lin Zhang whispered. She knelt beside him, her damp cotton shirt clinging to her collarbones, the smell of burnt battery acid and river mud rising from her hair. She reached toward the screen, her fingers twitching with a nervous, rhythmic flutter—one, two, three against her thigh, the old counting tic she used to drown out the hum of surveillance sweeps. "A shell trust? A dead man's identity bought off an admiralty salvage registry?"

"No," Jin rasped. His throat burned with the sulfurous tang of the back-siphoned harbor water. "The authorization key. Look at the trailing digits. Harun never used prime numbers for his security hash. He used the bearing angles of the Horsburgh Lighthouse. He said no machine algorithm would guess an old navigator’s compass error." He looked up, his gaze cutting through the greasy tropical drizzle toward the drydock. "He didn’t die in that stern section."

Behind them, the shipyard was stirring with a ugly, nervous heat.

The high-pressure fire monitors had beaten back the tactical skiffs, but victory had brought no peace. Across the narrow pontoon bridge, the heavy iron gangway of Drydock 4 was groaning under the tread of dozens of boots. Four hundred stranded mariners, dock fitters, and fuel-depot workers were swarming up the scaffolding toward the weather deck of the *Pulai Indah*, the rusted, five-thousand-ton break-bulk freighter that sat propped on timber keel blocks like a slaughtered whale.

They were soaked, shivering in the thirty-degree monsoon soup, and terrifyingly armed with spanners, iron pipe segments, and scrap plating.

"They’re breaking the valve house padlocks," Chen Rui panted, jogging down the crane ramp. His forearms were wrapped in oily canvas strips to compress the flaming agony in his tendons. "The southern crews say we’re trapped like rats in a trench. They want to open the sea gate and flood the caisson so the receiver can’t bring salvage tugs into the inner basin. If they do that, the *Pulai Indah* will roll on her bilge keels and crush the bottom hull."

"They're panicking," Jin said, snapping the waterproof case shut and rising. His lumbar spine grated with a dry, sickening click that sent a white bolt of pain into his left heel. He leaned heavily on Rui’s shoulder for a fraction of a second, hiding the tremor, before catching his own balance. "If the ship rolls, we lose the tidal turbine cables running through her shaft alley. The whole yard goes dark by three in the morning."

"Then tell them that," Lin said, her breath shallow, her knuckles white against the shielded lantern. "Before someone throws an incendiary bottle into the bilge."

They crossed the dock floor in silence, the towering steel walls of the drydock rising forty feet above them, dripping with black kelp and barnacle crusts. High above, suspended between the gantry tracks, the storm clouds were bruised violet by the distant glare of the Jurong refinery flares across the strait.

On the main deck of the freighter, under the cavernous overhang of the forward crane house, the noise was deafening.

Two men were shouting nose-to-nose over an open hatch cover. One was an Indonesian pump-man, his torso bare and stained with black bunker sludge; the other was a Singaporean marine electrician whose spectacles were tied to his ears with fishing twine.

"We cut the shore cables now!" the pump-man screamed, slamming an open-ended wrench onto the steel plating. "When the harbor patrol comes back, they won't bring water nozzles! They'll bring legal injunctions and boarding cutters from the coast guard! If we’re wired to the mainland, they freeze our licenses by sunrise!"

"And if you cut the shore cables, the desalination plant stops!" the electrician yelled back, spitting through broken teeth. "My three children are drinking tank water that hasn't been boiled since Tuesday! You want us to drink harbor slime?"

A dozen voices roared in assent, another dozen roared in fury. The crowd surged, shoulder against wet shoulder, the raw somatic stink of fear, diesel exhaust, and unwashed wool suffocating under the tarp awning.

CLANG.

The sound was not an explosion, nor the report of a weapon. It was the sharp, mechanical strike of an engine-room telegraph gong, ringing out from the bridge wing.

Uncle Tan stood beside the brass pedestal, his swollen, arthritic hands resting on the curved wooden handle. The brass was green with verdigris, but the internal escapement was clean. The clockwork mechanism inside the housing ticked with a measured, inexorable clack-clack-clack.

"Five minutes," Uncle Tan called out. His voice was not loud, but it carried the gravelly density of sixty years in the yards, a voice that had cut through boiler room steam and typhoon squalls. "Article Four of the Covenant. The telegraph is set. The floor belongs to the watch."

The shouting sputtered. The pump-man wiped greasy sweat from his brow, glaring at the deck, his chest heaving. The electrician stepped back, breathing hard through his nose.

Jin climbed the ladder to the cargo hatch, the plastic flight case gripped in his right hand. He placed it squarely on the rusted iron coaming. He did not offer an apology, nor did he raise his voice in a rally. The rules were cut into the iron of the yard: five minutes of uninterrupted presentation, zero interruption, zero cross-talk until the brass chime fell.

"The skiffs were not coast guard," Jin said, the mechanical tick of the telegraph beating behind his words. "They were private recovery contractors hired by Euro-Asian Maritime Finance. They were repelled because our seawater monitors had more head-pressure than their hulls could take. But they left this."

He opened the case. The amber glow of the terminal lit the tight circle of faces: exhausted deckhands, young mothers holding infants wrapped in dry engine rags, aging crane operators with cataracts in their rheumy eyes.

"The warrant against Berth 9 has been bought," Jin said. "Not by the port authority. By an offshore trust operating under the maritime identity of Harun bin Idris."

A sharp murmur rippled through the older men. An oiler in the second row crossed himself.

"Harun is dead," someone muttered. "The sea took him."

"His body was never recovered," Jin countered, his gaze sweeping the deck, refusing to let them look away. "And his trust just executed an administrative mortgage lien against this drydock. Whoever holds this terminal didn't come to sink us. They came to trigger an automated receivership default before dawn."

He pointed toward the narrow channel where the tidal turbines spun in the black depths.

"If we scatter into the mangroves in lifeboats, the trust assumes uncontested ownership of every kilowatt we generate. If we flood the dock to block them, we destroy our own shelter. That is what an algorithm wants: chaos that forces an abandonment order under the salvage codes. We have forty minutes before the tidal shift reverses. We do not run, and we do not break our own pumps."

The brass telegraph gave a sharp, metallic *ping*.

The five minutes were up.

A heavy silence descended over the four hundred people on the deck. The rain pattered softly against the taut canvas above them, steady, cold, indifferent.

Uncle Tan reached into the wooden box beside the telegraph and drew the brass sortition drum forward. "Parity requires three," the old man said, his knuckles stiff as he spun the cylinder. Three numbered boxwood balls rattled within the perforated metal. "Three arbiters to inspect the log and confirm the course."

Uncle Tan opened the gate. Three wooden spheres dropped into his palm: *Nine. Twenty-seven. One hundred and three.*

Aisyah binti Rahman stepped forward from the shadows near the crane footing, her diving knife sheathed at her hip, her fingertips raw from high-voltage work. Behind her stepped a retired slipway master from Batam, and the young mother whose child was asleep against her collarbone.

Aisyah reached out, her scorched thumb brushing the edge of the tablet screen to verify the digital cryptographic ledger.

Suddenly, the screen did not refresh its ledger.

The amber text flickered, collapsed into a single horizontal scan line, and flared blindingly violet.

A deep, pneumatic thud echoed from the bottom of the drydock beneath their boots.

The freighter lurched three inches to port with a sound like tearing sheet metal. Keel timbers shrieked under the sudden shifting of five thousand tons of deadweight. Far below, in the darkness beneath the hull, a high-volume sea valve was grinding open, throwing a massive geyser of harbor water against the concrete floor.

The terminal had not merely delivered an admiralty notice.

It had executed a remote command line directly into the yard’s submerged pneumatic ballast manifolds—and the drydock was beginning to fill.

CHAPTER 9

Chapter 9

The shudder did not travel through the air; it rose through the soles of their boots, a sickening, low-frequency grinding of five thousand tons of unballasted freighter scraping against aged concrete blocks.

"Sluice four!" Chen Rui shouted, his voice cracking on the spray. He was already over the railing, his boots sliding on the wet diamond-plate stairs. "They tripped the pneumatic release from the harbor channel!"

"Get the manual chokes!" Jin Wei barked. His lungs burned, raw from decades of inhaled bunker fumes, his collarbone throbbing where an old boiler flash had left the skin thick and hairless. He didn't look back at the four hundred faces huddled beneath the wind-whipped canvas awning. "Aisyah, take the south trench. Don't touch the hydraulic lines—they'll be pressurized to two hundred bar. Dog down the mechanical spindles!"

Down in the basin, darkness was churning into froth. Seawater, black and smelling of harbor silt and decayed mangrove roots, geysered through the shattered pneumatic intake. The drydock was transforming into a drowning tank. If the water rose four feet before the keel wedges could be reset, the freighter would lose her balance, roll her bilge strakes against the concrete apron, and crush her own bottom plates.

Up in the gantry crane's narrow control cab, sixty-five meters above the swirling foam, Lin Zhang leaned her forehead against the salt-streaked glass. Her temples hammered with a migraine so sharp it blurred her left eye. She dug into her pocket, found a brittle strip of dried tangerine peel—a childhood habit from the northern rail yards she had never broken—and pressed it between her teeth. The bitter citrus cut through the chemical stench of scorched insulation.

Her fingers did not touch the terminal's main bus. That was what the maritime syndicate wanted: an exchange of packet requests that would allow their automated admiralty script to log an intentional sabotage event and revoke the yard's safe-harbor status.

Instead, she plugged a shielded ribbon cable directly into the optical transmitter housing.

"Lin!" Chen Rui's voice burst through the brass speaking tube near her ear, stripped of breath. "The lower valve seat is warped. Rust in the collar. We can't close it with the handwheel—we need the yard gantry to drop the deadweight plug!"

"Five minutes," she whispered, her throat dry.

"We don't have five minutes!" Chen Rui yelled back, the metallic thrum of rushing water roaring in the background. "The tide is coming over the sill! If the skiffs outside ram the caisson gate now, the surge will rip the blocks clean out!"

Lin didn't answer. She opened the heavy, wax-sealed portfolio she had kept strapped to her ribs since Jakarta.

The syndicate wasn't fighting for the steel. They were fighting for the paper.

In international admiralty law, an offshore private equity flotilla did not move on diesel alone. Every interceptor skiff idling outside the harbor mouth, every armed contractor on their decks, operated under a mandatory web of indemnity: protection and indemnity policies underwritten through mutual clubs in London and Rotterdam, reinsured four times over through Singaporean clearinghouses. Without an active certificate of financial responsibility, no vessel could cross the boundary marker of a sovereign strait without rendering its master, its charterers, and its institutional lenders individually and criminally liable for maritime piracy and uninsured environmental hazard.

They thought the drydock was an abandoned asset. They thought the four hundred stranded mariners below were merely squatters without standing.

Lin brought up the terminal's air-gapped optical link. The cyan beam atop the crane shuddered against the torrential monsoon rain, its narrow wavelength fighting through sheets of tropical moisture toward the sister relay tower mounted on the abandoned grain silo three miles across the strait. Dropped packets flickered across her display—forty percent signal loss in the downpour. The salt air had pitted the outer lens, blooming the tight optical pencil into a ragged green smear.

She adjusted the manual focus dial with her left hand, feeling the coarse grit of salt corrosion grinding in the brass threads.

Lock.

She initiated the Hague Perpetual Asset Trust filing.

Not a protest. Not an appeal to a court that would take three years to read the first motion. It was a preemptive, automated maritime lien.

Under the Hague Trust protocols established during the Geneva sortition, the four hundred mariners living in Berth 9 were not passengers; they were legally registered possessory lienholders of the berth's kinetic infrastructure. Every hour they had spent scraping barnacles, every liter of bilge water they had pumped using their own salvaged battery banks, constituted an unpaid salvage wage under traditional maritime custom—a primary maritime lien that held absolute seniority over any corporate mortgage or bondholder syndicate.

Lin entered the biometric keys provided by the three sortition arbiters. Aisyah’s thumbprint. The Batam slipway master’s digital mark. The young mother’s cryptographic seal.

The ledger did not debate. It cross-referenced the global clearinghouse registries via the optical laser handshake, matching the hulls of the six private security interceptors idling outside the breakwater against the Lloyd's Open Form casualty database.

Transmitting.

A gust of wind caught the gantry tower, swaying the cab six inches to the west. The optical link dropped to zero.

"Come on," Lin hissed through clenched teeth. Her vision swam with bright migraine aura. "Hold."

Down in the basin, the water was waist-deep on Chen Rui. He and Aisyah were knee-braced against an iron lever, shoving a half-ton solid steel drop-wedge into the intake conduit. Seawater hammered against Chen Rui's ribs, cold and violently fast, threatening to rip his grip from the greasy iron.

"Drop it!" Aisyah screamed, her burned fingers slipping on the chain hoist. "Rui, let the dog fall!"

Chen slammed his shoulder into the trip lever. The wedge fell with a thunderous *clack*, biting into the intake rim. The geyser died instantly, choked to a churning boil of white foam, but the caisson seal behind them groaned. Outside, the wash of high-speed diesel engines reverberated through the steel gates.

The private equity flotilla was closing in, preparing to breach the dock.

Above them, the cyan laser found its mark through a brief tear in the rain clouds. The optical link locked green.

Lin Zhang depressed the transmit lever.

Across the Malacca Strait, fifty miles away in the glass towers of the financial district, the automated risk algorithms of three international maritime insurance syndicates processed the cryptographic filing.

A primary, non-subordinated wage and salvage lien was now recorded against the entire asset class of the private equity consortium, encumbering not just the drydock, but every auxiliary vessel under their corporate charter.

At sea, eight hundred yards from the drydock gate, the lead tactical interceptor was running at twenty-five knots, its searchlights slicing through the rain, aiming directly for the shipyard's outer pontoon.

Inside the interceptor's bridge, the master's tactical navigation display did not go dark.

It turned amber, then solid crimson.

A synthesized audio tone chimed twice—the precise, neutral chime of a catastrophic underwriter cancellation. The vessel's satellite-linked insurance transponder, tied to the London P&I registry,

automatically revoked its voyage authorization. A block-freeze order flashed across the helm:

INDEMNITY SUSPENDED. PRIMARY ADMIRALTY LIEN DETECTED. MASTER PERSONALLY LIABLE FOR ALL TRANSIT RISKS. AUTOMATED EMERGENCY SHUTDOWN IMMINENT.

The contractor captain stared at the console, his hand freezing on the dual-throttle levers. If he advanced another fifty yards, his personal mariner's license would be stripped, his family's savings frozen in Singapore escrow, and his vessel classified as an uninsured rogue craft subject to immediate seizure by the regional coast guard.

"What is this?" the second officer stammered, pulling off his headset. "Did the company go into receivership?"

"No," the captain said, his voice flat, drained of all tactical swagger. "Someone just put a lien on our fuel tanks."

Slowly, reluctantly, the captain pulled the twin throttles back into neutral. Behind him, the five other interceptors saw his running lights drop and throttled back, drifting in the heavy monsoon swell, their engines idling in the dark.

In the crane cab, Lin watched the searchlights sweep harmlessly across the gray harbor water, turning slowly away from the caisson. She let out a long, shuddering breath, her forehead dropping back against the cold window. The salt on the glass was cold against her skin.

Then, from the depths of the drydock below, came a sound far worse than the roar of the sea valve.

It wasn't the hiss of an intake. It was the sharp, explosive *crack* of five-inch structural steel shearing under uneven lateral load.

The drydock hadn't leveled. The five thousand tons of the freighter had settled onto the blocks at a three-degree list. One of the forward concrete pillars, undermined by years of salt rot and the sudden deluge, had buckled.

A cloud of pulverized concrete dust puffed into the rain. The massive bow of the ship groaned, canting outward, its immense steel overhang tilting directly toward Berth 9—where four hundred men, women, and children stood trapped between the shifting hull and the sheer, thirty-foot drop of the seawall.

CHAPTER 10

Chapter 10

The groan of Berth 9 did not stop. It deepened, rattling the calcium-crusted iron railings until the rust fell in gray snow. On the seawall apron, four hundred refugees shrank back against the concrete parapet, their breath misting in the torrential damp as the canted freighter’s bow hung over them like a cliff face waiting to drop.

Inside the caisson control trench, the drydock ballast lines stuttered.

"Conduit three is dead," Lin shouted from the pump well, her voice fighting the roar of the bilge discharge. Her skin was the color of curdled tallow, dark hollows bruised beneath her eyes from three sleepless rotations. "The foundation shift sheared the conduit trench outside the sluice gate. Telemetry to the seaward ballast valves is gone. If we can’t balance the starboard tanks before the tidal rip peaks, the keel blocks will roll."

Captain Jin Wei didn’t waste words on panic. Decades in the lower flats of rust-bucket bulkers had taught him that steel gave three distinct warnings before it killed you: first a hum, then a tick, then a silence. The ship was still ticking.

"Aisyah," Jin barked.

Aisyah binti Rahman was already hauling the vulcanized drysuits from the salt-stiffened lockers behind the workshop. Her fingers, scarred at the pads where high-voltage arcing had left white calluses, moved with furious efficiency across the brass inflator valves. Before she had ever touched an ROV tether, she had spent her adolescence free-diving for spiny lobsters off the coral shelves of Pulau Semakau; she gauged the channel's rip not by navigational buoys, but by the lateral torque pulling at the tendon behind her left knee.

"Four knots out there, Captain," she said, pulling a neoprene hood over her cropped hair. Her voice was flat, level, stripped of youth. "Current’s turning against the monsoon runoff. It’s washing machine water down by the sill."

"We go off the outer caisson catwalk," Jin said, dragging a heavy full-face mask over his neck. His lumbar spine flared with familiar, grinding pain—two crushed discs from an exploded steam line thirty years back that made bending feel like chewing glass. As a boy, before he ever went to sea, he had learned to calm the terror of dark water by humming sea shanties in four-four time, matching his lungs to the thrum of a diesel exhaust. He hummed now, low in his throat, a harsh, gravelly drone. "Conduit

raceway is three meters below the mudline. We have twenty minutes of slack window before the strait floods."

Two apprentice divers, boys from the Batam boatyards who had never worked deeper than a harbor mooring, stood frozen by the dive staging rack, their eyes wide and white against their grease-smeared faces.

"Tether to me," Jin told them, his tone dropping into the mechanical cadence of survival. "Keep your fins off the gravel. If you get pinned against the intake grate, don't kick. Dump your suit gas. Drop to the mud. Roll left. Understand?"

The boys swallowed and nodded, their hands trembling as they buckled their lead-shot weight belts.

They dropped from the caisson's low service platform directly into the black throat of the channel.

The water didn't feel like liquid; it felt like a moving wall of cold wet cement. The Singapore Strait was emptying east to west, funneled between the granite riprap of the breakwater and the shipyard’s massive concrete caisson. At four knots, current ceased to be a drift—it became a hydraulic ram. It snatched Jin’s rubber-suited shoulders, slamming him hard against the guide wire before his buoyancy compensator could bite.

Silt blinded him instantly. The tropical sun, already suffocated by monsoon cloud, vanished beneath ten feet of churned, muddy brine laden with harbor runoff, decomposing mangrove pulp, and microscopic diesel droplets.

Through the bone-conduction comms clamped behind his ear, Lin’s voice crackled, distorted by the static of water: *"Jin... starboard ballast pressure rising... the cant is three point five degrees. You have twelve minutes before the crane tracks buckle."*

"On the guide," Jin grunted into his oral-nasal cup. "Aisyah. Left pin."

"Got it," her voice came back, tight, rhythmic with heavy breathing.

Their dive lamps cut yellow, cone-shaped tunnels through the murk, illuminating swarms of suspended silt that looked like driving sleet. Jin pulled himself hand-over-hand down the anchor chain. The cold seeped through his suit, biting his scarred collarbone where an old steam-scald had left the tissue thin and numb. Behind him, the two apprentice divers kicked frantically, their fins thrashing against the current, burning through their air at twice the safe consumption rate.

"Stop kicking!" Jin rasped, his voice raw from bunker cough. "Arm-haul only. Save your lung."

They reached the concrete sill twenty feet down. Here, the current compressed, howling through the gap beneath the drydock gate like an underwater gale. The roar was deafening—a deep, subsonic vibration that rattled Jin’s teeth inside his gums.

There lay the raceway: a rectangular trough cast into the granite foundation, meant to protect the armored umbilical that carried the drydock's pulse.

It was smashed.

A ten-ton concrete scour-block, dislodged by the listing freighter's shuddering keel blocks above, had toppled directly across the steel conduit tray. The three-inch armored casing—sheathing two hundred strands of pure glass—was crushed flat beneath forty cubic feet of mossy aggregate. The outer steel braiding had peeled open like an overcooked sausage, its broken fiber cores trailing in the current like pale, severed horsehair.

"Crushed," Aisyah said, dropping to her knees on the slime-covered ledge. The current caught her dive cylinder, trying to flip her over the drop-off into the sixty-foot channel trench, but she jammed her heavy brass pry-bar into an expansion seam and held. "Zero continuity. Casing pinched clear to the copper sheath."

"Jack," Jin commanded, pointing his beam at the narrow crevice beneath the scour-block.

The first apprentice fumbled with the canvas tool bag. A brass-bodied hydraulic spread-jack slipped from his neoprene glove, tumbling toward the abyss. Jin's hand shot out—instinct older than his pain—and snagged the high-pressure hose by two fingers, dragging the tool back with a jolt that sent an electric spike through his injured lower back. He didn't curse. Cursing cost air.

"Seat it," Jin ordered, thrusting the tool into Aisyah's hands. "Under the rebar. Lift two inches. That's all we need to pull the slack loop."

Aisyah wedged the flat jaws of the spreader into the narrow crack beneath the granite mass. She began pumping the manual lever. *Clack. Clack. Clack.*

The tool groaned under the strain, hydraulic fluid weeping past its salt-scored seals. Slowly, agonizingly, the concrete slab shifted, peeling up an inch from the steel trough. A plume of black, foul-smelling anaerobic mud puffed out, carried instantly away by the four-knot current.

"Slack coming!" Jin yelled, gesturing to the second apprentice. "Pull the green sleeve! Don't kink it!"

The boy reached into the recess, his fingers clumsy with fear. He hauled out the yellow emergency splice enclosure—an air-gapped, gel-filled junction box designed to be bridged underwater using mechanical splice blocks. But the cable had torn short. The factory terminal block was mangled, brass pins sheared off flush against the polyurethane boot.

"No connector," Aisyah panted, her breathing ragged in the mask. "We have to core-splice. Cold-cure resin."

Jin looked at his wrist gauge. Seven minutes of slack water left. When the tide turned fully, the reverse surge from the deep-water shipping channel would sweep this ledge with five knots of

unyielding hydrodynamic force. No human grip could hold a pry-bar in that.

"Open the gel cassette," Jin said.

His fingers were thick, stiffened by age and salt, but inside the rubber diving mitts, the muscle memory remained. He stripped his outer gloves, exposing his bare skin to the biting, grease-slicked water. His fingers turned white in seconds, the cold deadening the nerves until he could barely feel the micro-thin glass strands.

Working inside the small canvas shelter-hood Aisyah held over the work site to break the flow of the current, Jin began cleaving the fiber ends with a manual ceramic blade.

One strand. Blue to blue.

Click.

Lin's voice in his ear was frantic now: *"Hull list at four degrees! The refugee barricade is cracking, Jin! Berth nine is going!"*

"Shut up, Lin," Jin whispered, his breath whistling through his teeth.

Two strands. Orange to orange.

The current hammered the hood. Aisyah's shoulder slammed against Jin's helmet, but she didn't give an inch, wedging her knees into the concrete seam until the vulcanized rubber tore against the barnacles, sea-water flooding her left leg. She didn't make a sound. She just held the canvas.

Three strands. Green to green.

Click.

The tiny LED on the junction cassette flickered from amber to faint, pulsing cyan.

"Continuity!" Lin screamed over the comms. "Starboard three valve responding! Ballast pumps kicking—we're taking on water forward! She's leveling!"

A great, hydraulic shudder ran through the caisson wall as the five-thousand-ton hull shifted back toward an even keel, the sound vibrating through the water like an earthquake.

Jin reached to snap the heavy waterproof clamps over the resin casing.

Then, from the channel abyss directly behind them, the current stopped dead.

Not a natural slack. The water went completely still for three heartbeats—then sucked violently *seaward*, dragging Jin, Aisyah, and the apprentice divers toward the deep navigation trench as a massive, low-frequency hum vibrated through the bedrock beneath their fins.

Something enormous had just entered the narrow channel mouth without navigation lights, displacing tens of thousands of tons of water in a single, blind surge.

CHAPTER 11

Chapter 11

The outward surge dragged Jin’s boots off the caisson rim, throwing his weight against the safety lanyard with a violence that popped the stitching along his harness. In the black churn of the channel mouth, the deadweight super-freighter slid past without a single running light, a wall of slab-sided steel five storeys high displacing tens of thousands of tons of deep water as it coasted on its own momentum toward the sandbar. It was not firing. It did not need to. It simply dropped both bow anchors into the navigation channel with a grinding roar that shook the seabed, slewing across the fairway to choke off the last open approach to Berth Nine.

Jin kicked against the undertow, his left knee screaming where old cartilage had ground to powder. He hooked his forearm under Aisyah’s collar, dragging her back into the shelter of the concrete footing. Her suit was ripped from hip to calf, the cold brine already leaching the color from her skin, but she still clamped both hands around the fiber-splice box, pressing it to her chest like a newborn.

Above them, on the crane gantry, Lin Zhang’s voice crackled through the ear-piece, pinched with terror: *"The fairway is blocked. They’ve dropped a four-hundred-meter hulk across the shallows. No supply skiffs are getting through from the islands. Jin, we’re corked."*

"Get the ladder," Jin rasped into the dead microphone of his mask, his throat raw with the taste of sulfur and heavy fuel. He spat a mouthful of oily foam into the scuppers as they broke the surface beside the slipway. "Lin. The rope."

Ten minutes later, they stood dripping on the iron plates of the fabrication shed. The monsoon heat slammed into them like a wet wool blanket, forty degrees of swamp air turning the salt crust on their skin into an itching paste.

Berth Nine was starving, and the four hundred and twelve mariners sheltered in its cavernous guts already knew it.

Inside the old mess deck, beneath overhead beams painted in flaking lead primer, the air smelled of scorched vinegar and stale sweat. Three hundred men and women—Burmese deckhands, Indonesian grease-wipers, laid-off crane operators from the container terminals—sat along the trestle benches. In front of each lay a plastic bowl containing three ounces of split peas, boiled until the skins split, and two dry biscuits gray with pantry weevils.

At the head of the galley counter, a shouting match had flared between two tug engineers over a five-gallon plastic drum of cooking oil. One had a rusted pry-bar raised; the other held an iron ladle like a

truncheon.

Clang.

The brass telegraph bell above the scullery door rang once.

The sound was small, dry, and deliberate. Uncle Tan stood beside the bulkhead, one swollen hand resting on the counter-weight lever. He was seventy-one, his spine curved like a ship’s rib after a grounding, his fingers misshapen by decades of monsoon dampness that turned his knuckles into knobby ginger roots. As a boy in the swamp kampongs of the Kallang Basin, before the government had dredged the creeks and poured concrete over the mangrove nurseries, he had caught fighting crickets in wooden matchboxes, learning to judge the wetness of the mud simply by pressing his palm against the bank in the dark. He carried no clipboard, no megaphone. He wore only a stained cotton undershirt and faded blue drill trousers rolled above his shins.

"Five minutes," Tan said softly. His voice did not carry the bark of a bosun, but it cut through the room’s hot, stagnant air with the weight of someone who had seen three shipping empires dissolve into bankruptcy auctions. "Telegraph says cool down. Put the iron down, boys. The iron doesn't feed nobody."

The engineer with the pry-bar stared at him, chest heaving, veins standing out on his neck like hemp lines. For four seconds, nobody breathed. Then the younger man’s shoulders dropped, the tool hitting the linoleum with a dull thud.

"They cut the Batam run, Uncle," the engineer muttered, wiping his wet face on his sleeve. "The market barges won't cross the fairway with that bulk-ship sitting in the channel. Two days. That's what’s in the dry stores. Then what? We eat rust?"

"We eat what the sea gives," Tan said. He turned and pointed a crooked finger toward the dark, cavernous hollow beneath Berth Nine's drydock floor. "Grab the scrap scrapers. Bring the lye tubs. We have six thousand tons of empty iron downstairs."

Beneath the slipway lay the hull of the *Heng Shan*, an abandoned thirty-year-old bulk ore carrier that the port receivers had left to rot when her owners folded in the tanker crash of '18. Her bottom plates sat flat on the keel blocks, her twin starboard ballast tanks—each forty meters long, eight meters deep, designed to swallow twelve thousand tons of dirty seawater to balance an empty crossing—hollow as cathedral tombs.

By midnight, sixty mariners were down in the belly of Tank Port-Four.

The heat inside the enclosed steel was suffocating, thick with the stench of thirty years of anaerobic mud, dried fuel residue, and dead barnacles. Portable floodlights run off the tidal turbine's night-cycle battery cast harsh, blinding glare against the rust-scaled frames. Jin Wei swung an iron scraper against the bulkhead, his lower back knotting into a hard, fiery spasm with every stroke. Flakes of red scale peeled away, falling into the bilge water around his boots in sharp, metallic sheets.

"Not down to bare metal," Tan shouted from the access hatch, his knees clicking as he climbed down the vertical rung ladder one rung at a time, testing each steel rod with his weight before trusting it. "You scrub to the plate, the raw iron bleeds oxide into the water! The gills choke in six hours! Just knock off the slime and the petroleum crust! Then the lime wash!"

Aisyah was already wading through the knee-deep black slurry at the tank's aft end, dragging a flexible suction hose salvaged from the bilge pumps. Her eyes were red-rimmed, ringed with dark grease, her temple bruised where the dive-rig had slammed her against the caisson, but she moved with cold, mechanical economy. Every ten minutes, the suction strainer clogged on a knot of decayed rope or thick bunker sludge; every ten minutes, she plunged her bare hands into the foul water, cleared the mesh, and cursed in quiet, steady Malay.

"We have no freshwater to fill this," Jin said, pausing to lean against his scraper, his chest rattling as he fought for breath in the damp air. "Even if Lin keeps the reverse-osmosis stack running on the tidal trickle, that's four tons a day. We need three hundred tons just to float the bio-filters."

Tan reached into the pocket of his trousers and pulled out a fistful of dark, waxy green leaves. He crushed them between his palms, holding them under Jin's nose.

The smell was sharp, brackish, rich with the rot of estuarine peat.

"Mangrove apple," Tan said. "Avicennia marina. Black mangrove shoots. The boys took the work-skiff into the drainage canals behind the old cement works this afternoon. Pulled two hundred seedlings out of the mudflats. They drink sea brine, Jin. They sweat the salt out through the back of their leaves like an old stoker."

He gestured toward the long, tiered staging racks the shipyard carpenters were already bolting to the tank's interior ribs using angle-iron sliced from scrapped container flats.

"We don't desalt the water," Tan said, kneeling down and dipping his hand into the shallow channel they had carved through the center of the tank floor. He tasted the residue on his finger, his weathered face tightening as he gauged the silt. "We run the high-tide surge through the sea-chests, through two gravel beds to drop the harbor grit. Then the mangrove roots take the ammonia. We put the sea bass fingerlings from the river fish-traps on the lower tier. Tilapia in the middle. Mangrove greens on top. We don't ask the dry land for a single grain of rice."

"The water is hot, Uncle," Aisyah said, hauling the cleared hose to the next frame. "The hull plates sit in thirty-five-degree mud outside. Sea bass boil in that."

"Not when the tide runs," Tan replied. He tapped the thick steel skin of the hull with his knuckles. "Six hours in, six hours out. The channel current pulls fifteen knots of deep, cold bottom-water past this plate twice a day. We plumb the intake low, through the old sea-suction valves on the bottom floor. The sea becomes our radiator."

It was grueling, brutal work, devoid of grace. There were no digital readouts to tell them if the chemical balance was true. They relied on Tan's tongue to measure the salt, on the smell of the bilge wash to know when the caustic soda had neutralized the fuel oil, and on the blistered hands of eighty starving sailors working by the yellow glow of work-lights to assemble two hundred meters of perforated PVC pipe.

By four in the morning, the first wash-water was drained. The twin ballast tanks gleamed dull gray under a fresh coat of slaked agricultural lime. Above the tanks, suspended from the cross-beams, rows of broad-spectrum LED strips salvaged from refrigerated fruit containers flickered on, casting a violent, magenta dawn across the rust-streaked steel.

In the shallow, aerated water of the lower troughs, forty dozen small, silver-scaled estuary bass—netted from the industrial runoff creeks by the younger deckhands during the slack tide—darted between the submerged bundles of mangrove roots.

Jin sat on an overturned chemical bucket at the edge of the tank, his palms raw, his spine locked in a dull, thrumming ache that radiated into his thighs. Across the tank, mariners were leaning over the iron rails, their faces bathed in the strange purple light, watching the small fish turn in the clear, brackish wash. For the first time in six days, nobody was shouting. The silence inside the ship's iron belly was broken only by the rhythmic, bubbling hiss of the compressed-air lines.

Then, through the twenty-millimeter steel plate of the bulk carrier's bottom hull, came a sound.

It was not the slap of the tide.

It was a heavy, metallic *thunk*, followed by the distinct, high-frequency whine of an underwater hydraulic core-drill biting into the steel plate directly beneath their feet.

Jin froze. Tan's hand went still on the water valve.

A second *thunk* echoed through the framing, sixty feet forward, accompanied by the magnetic clatter of a heavy hull-crawler locking onto the exterior keel. The receiver's tactical salvage crews had not waited for starvation to do their work. They were under the hull, boring into the ballast intake chests to flood the drydock before the morning assembly could convene.

CHAPTER 12

Chapter 12

The grinding bite of tungsten carbide against the ship's bottom plating sent a shudder straight up Jin Wei's shinbones. It was not an explosion, but something far more intimate: a cold, hydraulic boring through the dead-center of sea chest three.

"Aisyah!" Jin's voice was a gravel rasp, stripped of breath by the sudden spasm in his lumbar spine.

Aisyah was already moving. Her fingers, scarred white across the pads from an alternator flash burn, caught the four-foot cheater pipe resting against the tank framing. She didn't speak. Under the violet glare of the grow-lights, her skin was slick with sweat and foul bilge mud. She rammed the pipe over the handle of the sea-chest emergency flapper valve and threw all forty-eight kilos of her frame against the lever.

Through the hull, the magnetic crawler hummed like a nest of hornets.

Clack-clack-clack. The brass flapper swung inward, fighting the outward rush of displaced air, then slammed home against its neoprene seat with a dull, wet thud that vibrated through the marrow of Jin's teeth. Beneath them, the core-drill screeched as it hit the backed bronze plate, shuddered, and sheared its bit with an ear-splitting snap.

Silence fell across the ballast floor, save for the frantic darting of the silver estuary bass among the submerged mangrove roots.

Then the radio on Jin's harness died.

It did not click off; it dissolved into a violent, hissing wash of carrier hash. A wide-band RF carpet sweep.

"They're in the channel," Uncle Tan wheezed from the access ladder. The old man's knuckles were swollen to the size of walnuts, his knees trembling as he took the iron rungs one at a time. "No horn, no running lights. Skiffs. Three of them, hugging the caisson shadow."

Jin hauled himself up the vertical ladder, his vertebrae grinding like coarse sand in a gearbox. He had grown up on the muddy flats of Pulau Ubin, where the smell of incoming rain always brought the scent of salted duck eggs drying on bamboo mats behind his mother's kitchen; now, the air entering his lungs tasted solely of vaporized heavy fuel oil, ozone, and the electric sulfur of a closing monsoon front.

He broke onto the open weather deck of Berth 9 into a wall of falling water.

The tropical squall had hit with the weight of an overturned lake. Torrents of warm rain swept sideways across the slipway, drumming against the steel skin of stacked containers. Out in the black chop of the traffic lane, two miles south, the running lights of three commercial gunboats churned the water into frothing phosphorus. They were running an interdiction perimeter, blacking out every civilian frequency from here to the Johor coast.

Sixty-five meters above the slipway, perched in the exposed maintenance cage of the gantry crane, Dr. Lin Zhang clutched the rusted guardrail with both hands.

Her eyes burned behind salt-streaked glasses. The migraine that had lived behind her left eyebrow for three days was now a hot spike driven through her temple. Below her, the shipyard was a dark labyrinth of wet iron; above her, the sky was an impenetrable roof of violet-black thunderheads.

Beside her, Chen Rui knelt in three inches of standing rainwater on the crane platform, his forearms wrapped tightly in strips of black bicycle inner-tube to keep the inflamed tendons from tearing off the bone. His hands gripped the vernier adjustment wheels of the optical transceiver—a salvaged telescope barrel fitted with high-gain cyan emitter diodes, seated on an old surveyor's leveling plate.

"The jammers took the UHF backhaul!" Lin yelled into the gale, her voice ripped away by the wind. She leaned over Chen's shoulder, reciting prime numbers under her breath—*seventeen, nineteen, twenty-three*—the only mental tether keeping the height and the panic from emptying her stomach over the rail. "No telemetry from the tugs. The harbor mesh is severed."

"Don't need the radio!" Chen shouted back, spitting rain from his cracked lips. "Look at the meter!"

Lin wiped her glasses on her soaked shirt, smearing grease across the glass. The analog needle on the transceiver's quadrant detector was twitching, dying, leaping back to zero. Salt crust was already fouling the quartz window. The heavy rain was scattering ninety percent of the light, turning the transceiver's focused beam into a useless, diffused green glow that illuminated nothing but falling raindrops.

Down at the water level, the first tactical skiff struck the caisson.

The sound was a hard, rubberized slap against the outer timber fenders, followed instantly by the metallic bite of grappling grapnels catching the edge of the dock gate. Men in dark neoprene armor, devoid of flags or insignia, were hauling themselves up the wet timber pilings, carrying pneumatic cutters to breach the main sluice locks. If they dropped the caisson gate, four million gallons of harbor sludge would rush into Berth 9, capsizing the bulk carrier on its keel blocks and drowning three hundred families in the lower holds.

"Monitors!" Jin bellowed through a salvaged brass megaphone from the bridge wing. "Tan! Man the monitors!"

Uncle Tan didn't run. His legs wouldn't let him. He leaned his entire body weight into the bronze wheel of the salvaged salvage-pump manifold.

With a hollow, thundering groan that shook the pier, the twin tidal-fed fire pumps kicked in. Seawater, drawn straight from the four-knot channel rip, surged through the four-inch deck pipes.

At the drydock rim, two dock hands seized the twin monitor nozzles. A solid column of green ocean water, roaring under two hundred pounds of pressure, smashed through the dark. It hit the lead boarding skiff not as spray, but as an iron bar. The vessel dipped violently, rolled forty degrees on its beam ends, and took fifty barrels of harbor water over the gunwales in four seconds. The boarding ladders tore free, spilling two tactical operatives into the foaming slipway, their heavy gear dragging them under until their auto-inflating vests violently popped them back to the surface, gasping and disoriented in the blinding wash.

The second monitor opened up, laying down a blinding curtain of heavy sea mist directly across the intruders' infrared sights, turning their thermal optics into a wall of useless gray soup.

Up on the crane, the wind sheared violently from the northeast.

“The mirror's loose!” Chen cried out. His wrench slipped on a corroded bronze bolt, stripping the skin from his knuckles. “The wind load is turning the gantry head! I can't hold the azimuth!”

Lin didn’t think. She threw her hip against the heavy steel housing of the optical barrel, pinning her small, shivering frame between the shuddering machine and the cold iron truss of the crane. The sharp edge of a mounting bracket cut through her linen shirt, slicing into her ribs. The pain was sudden, sharp, and cold.

Twenty-nine, thirty-one, thirty-seven.

“Turn it!” she screamed, her breath catching in her throat as the blood ran warm down her side, immediately washed thin by the downpour. “Rui, crank the declination! Three degrees up! The cloud ceiling is breaking over the channel!”

Chen Rui locked his bleeding hands onto the brass vernier. His muscles knotted, his teeth bared in a grimace of pure agony as the tendonitis fired white-hot along his arms. He forced the barrel up against the shrieking crosswind. One notch. Two notches.

Between two boiling banks of monsoon clouds, a narrow, jagged rift opened—a vertical chimney in the storm where the pressure dropped and the stars burned like ice through the thinning vapor.

“Now!” Lin choked out. “Fire the emitter!”

Chen dropped the manual knife-switch.

A needle of pure, concentrated cyan light stabbed out from the crane tower.

It was not a radio wave that could be choked by Aegis-Omni’s carrier jammers; it was a physical lance of coherent photons. It sliced through the churning sea mist, pierced the eye of the cloud rift, and shot straight into the high-altitude atmospheric inversion.

For three agonizing heartbeats, the receiver needle on the quadrant meter lay dead against the stop-pin.

Then, two thousand miles to the northwest, bounced from the orbital mirrors and caught by the cold granite spine of the Swiss Alps, the return carrier struck back.

A pulse of deep, invisible infrared light answered the cyan beam.

On Chen's portable diagnostic screen, wrapped in clear plastic to keep off the salt rain, the raw terminal stream erupted into life. Not in graphics, not in corporate interfaces, but in a relentless, cascading waterfall of cryptographically verified ledger blocks. Detroit's foundries. The Alpine hydro-penstocks. Berth 9's battery banks. The three isolated nodes struck a single, immutable triangle of consensus across the curve of the dark planet.

The air on the crane platform smelled suddenly of scorched quartz and ozone.

Down below, on the slipway, the second Apex gunboat cut its searchlights. The tactical skiffs, wallowing half-submerged in the wash of the fire monitors, cut their grapnel lines and fell back into the boiling channel, their crews dragging their sodden boarding teams from the rip.

Lin slumped against the gantry rail, her ribcage throbbing, her chest heaving as she pulled the thick, wet sea air into her lungs. Chen fell back onto the rusted deck plates, his forearms locked in rigid, trembling cramps.

Jin Wei lowered his megaphone on the bridge wing. His knuckles were gray from gripping the rail. A ragged cheer, muffled by the rain, rose from the dark lower deck where the mariners stood watch.

Then, from the outer roads beyond the breakwater, a sound rolled across the water.

It was not the high whine of a skiff's outboard. It was the deep, seismic, three-tone blast of an ocean-going salvage tug's horn.

Through the curtains of falling rain, Jin saw them.

Not tactical skiffs. Not light private craft.

Rounding the northern light, two massive, black-hulled maritime enforcement cutters—each displacing three thousand tons, their bows reinforced with steel collision wedges—steamed abreast into the channel, their wake flattening the chop as their searchlights ignited simultaneously, locking their blinding beams directly onto the iron gates of Berth 9.

CHAPTER 13

Chapter 13

The twin enforcement cutters did not charge the slipway; they did something far worse. They throttled down to five knots, their reinforced steel collision bows carving two curling, slate-colored trenches into the chop, and swung abreast across the mouth of the channel.

The sudden backwash slammed against the rusted caisson gates of Berth 9 with the concussive thump of a depth charge. Deep in the drydock's belly, three thousand tons of seawater surged against the concrete sills, rattling the timber shoring until the iron drift-pins screamed in their housings.

Jin Wei clamped his molars down on a bitter clove leaf, an old habit from his early days as a deck boy when bunker oil seeped into every ration of rice. The raw spice stung the roof of his mouth, cutting through the reek of ozone and scorched quartz drifting from the gantry tower above.

"They aren't boarding," he muttered into the salt spray.

Beside him on the bridge wing, Uncle Tan adjusted his grip on the rusted iron railing, his swollen knuckles whitening under the strain. The old mariner squinted through the halogen glare lancing off the lead cutter's flying bridge, watching the rhythmic pitch of its rounded bow.

"Riding high forward," Tan rasped, his voice scraping like gravel tossed in an empty drum. "Look at the red lead on her waterline. She's dumped her forepeak ballast to clear the southern shallows. She's skittish in a cross-rip, Jin. She's built to intimidate, not to fight the tide."

High above them, sixty-five meters in the air, the wind was an open hand shoving the crane platform toward the channel.

Lin Zhang pressed her shoulder hard against the steel upright of the optical transceiver housing, her thumbs hammering a silent, rapid count against the brass buckles of her harness—three, five, seven, eleven—the old reflex she had relied on through endless fluorescent nights in the university's lower sub-basement when the ventilation failed and panic threatened to close her windpipe.

"Link's fading," she called down through the crane's sound-powered telephone, her voice snatched away by the squall before it reached the horn. She hauled the handset back to her mouth, shouting directly into the brass diaphragm. "Chen! Rain scatter is eating the beam! Optical degradation is past forty percent!"

On the platform deck behind her, Chen Rui was down on his knees in a pool of foul bilge water, ignoring the salt spray soaking through the shoulders of his canvas smock. He leaned his face within two

inches of the open junction box, his eyes narrowed, his nose twitching as he sniffed the rubberized seals. It was a nervous compulsion he had picked up in the refit yards of Pasir Panjang—burnt copper and overheating neoprene carried distinct scents long before an instrument needle flickered toward zero.

"The mirrors are tracking!" Chen yelled, his forearms locked in stiff, aching tremors from wrestling the manual elevation gearing against the gale. "The Alpine node is holding the high-orbit bounce, but the photons are smearing against the downpour! If the cutters throw their wash into our line of sight, the whole packet stream collapses!"

Through the binoculars, Jin saw the lead vessel's deck crew moving in tight, yellow-slickered teams. They were not unlimbering boarding ladders or preparing grapple mortars. Instead, two hydraulic cranes swung out over the cutter's stern, lowering massive, segmented steel cylinders linked by heavy steel mesh into the churning water.

Floating containment booms. Industrial, harbor-grade interdiction barriers designed to corral burning tanker slicks—or to hermetically seal a contaminated berth.

A voice cut through the drumming squall, blasted from the cutter's bridge-wing hailer. It was flat, mechanical, and scrubbed of anger—the unyielding cadence of an admiralty receiver reading from a legal script.

"Berth Nine vessel and drydock complex. You are in direct violation of the Malacca Strait Traffic Separation Scheme. Under international admiralty injunction and port safety authority decree, your facility is designated an unnavigable hazard. A protective cordon is being established. Stand down all unmonitored power generation and prepare for harbor master mooring inspection."

"Unnavigable hazard," Jin spat, the clove leaf pulp bitter on his tongue. "They aren't storming the gates because they don't have to. They're walling us in."

A wet, dripping hand slapped down onto the bridge-wing scupper.

Aisyah hauled herself over the gunwale, shedding salt water like an otter. She collapsed onto one knee, chest heaving, the black neoprene of her diving suit slick with grease from the outer pilings. She reached down with a trembling thumb to touch the smooth river stone she kept wedged inside the sheath of her dive knife—a rounded piece of quartz she had pulled from her family's drowned kelong traps years before the mega-terminals had dredged the sandbars out from under them.

"They're dropping sinkers," she gasped, her voice raw from breathing compressed air through a pitted regulator. She coughed, spitting a mouthful of briny phlegm onto the steel deck. "Two heavy chain drags... right across the deep trench. They're pinning the outer perimeter."

Jin leaned over her, his hand gripping her shoulder. "The channel turbines?"

"Not yet," Aisyah panted, pointing a gloved finger out toward the churning gray rip where the tidal current boiled past the point. "The chains are fifty yards upstream. But the drag lines are weighted with

dead-weight scrap. When the tide turns in forty minutes... the sweep will drag those lines right into the turbine runners. If the blades foul under full tidal torque, the main shafts will twist like licorice."

Without the tidal turbines anchored in the channel bed, the shipyard was dead.

The salvaged battery banks in Drydock 4 could carry the internal mesh and the bilge pumps for twelve hours, maybe fourteen. But without the heavy current of the channel driving the generators, the reverse-osmosis desalination plant would seize. Three hundred mariners and dockers, bottled up behind a steel-mesh curtain with the monsoon salt fouling every freshwater cistern, would be drinking brackish sludge before tomorrow’s dusk.

"They want us to shut down the water intake ourselves," Jin said, the chill of the realization sinking deep into his belly. "No shots fired. No martyrs for the foreign press. Just twenty-four hours of dry throats and a fouled turbine, and we invite their tugs in to tow us out to the scrap anchorage."

From the top of the gantry, Lin’s shout cracked through the sound-powered telephone.

"Jin! Look at the second cutter! Look at her stern!"

Jin lifted his glasses. The second vessel, the smaller of the two enforcement craft, had backed down into the lee of the outer breakwater. Her crew wasn't setting booms. A heavy, braided steel towing pendant, thick as a man's thigh, was being payed out from a massive hydraulic drum on her afterdeck. At the end of the cable, a heavy three-pronged grappling anchor swung from a derrick.

They were not trying to hook the iron caisson gates. The gates were anchored into fifty thousand tons of pre-stressed concrete.

They were lining up on the base of the gantry crane.

"The crane's footing," Jin whispered, the blood draining from his weathered face.

The crane was an antique, riding on twin steel rails laid down four decades ago to service panamax container hulls. Its south bogies were pinned to the seawall, less than twenty paces from the open water. If the cutter snagged the lower truss with that towing hawser and backed her twin diesels into the six-knot ebb, the lateral shear would tear the mounting pins from the wet concrete.

The sixty-five-meter tower would topple like a severed pine straight into the harbor channel, taking the optical transceiver, the laser link, and Lin and Chen with it.

"Uncle Tan!" Jin barked, his voice dropping all hesitation. "Get below to the ballast manifold! Man the manual valves on the seaward ballast tank! Aisyah, take two runners from the boiler gang—divert the steam return line from the auxiliary turbine straight into the fire monitor headers!"

Aisyah blinked, wiping salt from her lashes. "The monitor pumps can't reach their bridge from here, Jin. The wind's against us."

"We aren't aiming for their bridge," Jin said grimly. "We're blinding their helm. Uncle Tan—when I drop the gantry wedge, I want forty tons of harbor water dumped into the south caisson. Drop the dock's bow three degrees. Pull the crane's rail below the wash line."

Tan's eyes widened, then a slow, yellow-toothed grin broke across his weathered face. "The hawser won't bite if the truss is under three feet of surf. It'll slide right off the iron."

"Go!" Jin roared.

On the gantry above, the wind screeched through the cross-bracing.

Lin stood poised on the narrow maintenance grating, her hands locked around the manual aiming yoke of the laser transceiver. The lead cutter had turned its forward searchlight bank directly into the crane cab, bathing the steel platform in a blinding, white-hot glare that washed out every reference point against the black horizon.

Beside her, Chen was screaming over the howling squall, pointing toward the channel.

The second cutter had gunned its diesels. A thick plume of black exhaust erupted from its low-profile stacks. The three-pronged grappling anchor plunged into the foam forty feet off the slipway, its heavy chain paying out with a sound like tearing sheet metal.

The cable snapped taut.

The gantry tower shuddered beneath their boots with a sickening, metallic groan. Two of the three-inch steel drift pins holding the southern rail shoe sheared off with reports like rifle cracks, the broken bolts whistling through the night air and splashing into the dark water below.

The entire sixty-five-meter crane tilted two degrees to the seaward, throwing Lin violently against the safety railing.

The optical beam to the Alps snapped.

On the diagnostics screen beside Chen's knees, the green stream of cryptographically verified blocks froze, hitched, and died.

Down on the water, the cutter's twin screws thrashed the harbor into boiling foam, the tow-line rising dripping and rigid out of the black sea, pulling the ancient iron tower inch by agonizing inch toward the edge of the abyss.

CHAPTER 14

Chapter 14

The safety harness bit into Lin’s ribs as the gantry lurched, the steel catwalk slanting under her boots like the deck of a foundering barge. Below, the hawser hummed with catastrophic tension, vibrating so violently it sprayed an aerosol of seawater off its braided strands.

"Jin!" Chen screamed, his knuckles white around the railing, his thumb clamped between his teeth until the skin split. "The truss is twisting! If the lower shoe goes, the whole tower rolls into the slipway!"

Lin didn't shout. Her breath came in shallow, ragged hitches, the copper taste of a panic attack coating her tongue. Her vision flared at the periphery—the telltale shimmering zigzag of an oncoming migraine brought on by forty straight hours staring through optical collimators. With her free hand, she pressed a blunt thumbnail deep into the tendon of her left wrist, an old habit from her youth in the suffocating aisles of her mother’s textile stockroom, grounding herself in localized pain to stop her vision from tunneling to black.

Sixty meters down, the dock responded.

A low, hydraulic thud reverberated through the hollow caissons. Uncle Tan had dropped the south ballast valve. Harbor water, black and thick with river silt, surged into the lower chambers. The dock's seaward edge sagged instantly, dipping three degrees into the swell.

At the same instant, a deafening hiss tore through the rain. Aisyah threw the diverted bypass. High-pressure steam from the auxiliary turbine slammed into the fire monitor lines, mixing with the raw saltwater feed. What erupted from the forward nozzles was not a clean jet, but a roaring, boiling blizzard of scalding fog and vaporized spray.

The wind caught the plume, rolling it directly into the cutter’s wheelhouse.

Through the whiteout, the cutter’s searchlights scattered into a blinding, featureless haze. Blind at the helm and caught off-balance as the dock’s iron truss dipped beneath the surging surf, the cutter’s pilot sheared hard to port to avoid grounding on the slipway sill.

The tow-line slackened by an inch. It was all the physics needed.

With a shriek of tearing zinc, the greased grappling fluke lost its purchase on the submerged iron beam. The cable whipped free with the crack of a snapped bullwhip, slicing across the water and leaving a smoking furrow of white froth before sinking into the channel.

The 65-meter crane snapped back against its remaining structural stops. The impact rattled Lin’s teeth in her skull; her head cracked against the transceiver mount, sending stars cascading across her eyes.

"Clear!" Jin’s voice rasped through the copper voice-pipe from the lower quay, thick and wet with his chronic bunker-oil cough. "Hawser slipped! Aisyah, kill the steam before you melt the pump gaskets!"

The roar died, replaced by the relentless drum of the monsoon rain hammering the rusted corrugated roofs of the shipyard.

Chen slumped onto the maintenance grating, his chest heaving. "The beam," he choked out, wiping stinging salt from his eyes. "The Alpine link. It’s completely dead. We lost the carriage lock."

Lin pulled herself up, ignoring the hot trickle of blood running from her hairline down into her left eyebrow. She checked the optical transceiver’s azimuth ring. The heavy brass gimbal was warped three millimeters out of true where the sheared pins had buckled the deck plates.

Before she could reach for the alignment wrench, the yard’s open-channel maritime receiver began to squawk. The audio did not come through the encrypted mesh; it blasted over the international VHF distress frequency, cold, sterile, and perfectly synthesized.

"Attention all vessels in the Singapore and Malacca Straits Traffic Separation Scheme. By decree of the Admiralty Division and Euro-Asian Maritime Finance, the facility designated Keppel-Batam Drydock Four is declared an abandoned maritime hazard and an illegal salvage operation. All hull identification transfers, cargo clearances, and auxiliary power off-takes originating from this coordinate are nullified under international maritime lien. Vessels attempting to berth or discharge cargo will be deemed co-conspirators in salvage theft and subject to immediate impoundment."

Chen stared at the speaker. "Salvage theft? They financed those docks thirty years ago. They were written off as scrap after the second harbor subsidence!"

"They don't care about the scrap," Lin said, her voice stripped of inflection. She wiped her forehead with the sleeve of her grease-stained jacket. "They care about the precedent. If an unbonded crew can bring a dead yard back onto the ledger without their debt covenants, their whole risk-pricing model collapses."

Jin Wei’s heavy boots rang out on the iron ladder below. He hauled himself up to the lower platform, chewing methodically on a scrap of dried bitter melon rind—a somatic defense against the sulfur vapor that perpetually burned his lungs. In his hand, he held a carbon-copy clipboard scribbled with pencil marks.

"Two of the grain freighters from the Mekong delta just altered course," Jin said without greeting. "They picked up the admiralty warning. Their captains are refusing to drop anchor in our basin. They’re turning back toward the commercial roads. If they don't discharge their rice into our grain elevators by morning, their crews won't get paid, and the settlement at Berth Nine runs out of meal in three days."

"What about our battery reserves?" Lin asked, leaning against the crane cab to steady her trembling knees.

"Down to twenty-two percent," Jin replied grimly. "The tidal turbine in the south channel took a submerged drift log twenty minutes ago. The sheer-pin broke on the rotor hub. We're running purely on the tugboat packs, and the reverse-osmosis pumps are drinking four hundred amps just to keep fresh water flowing to the clinic."

They were being starved out in real time. Not by shells or torpedoes, but by the quiet, mathematical closure of maritime clearing accounts.

Lin looked past the dripping steel girders toward the south. Geneva was obscured by five hundred miles of storm front and severed glass lines across the Indian Ocean basin. But the Pacific horizon was different.

"We don't route through Europe," Lin said suddenly.

Chen frowned. "What are you talking about? The validation relay is in the Alps. The whole clearing tree—"

"The clearing tree is a distributed mesh, not a cathedral," Lin interrupted, her mind racing past the throbbing ache behind her temples. "Who holds the bulk of the unrefined energy buffer in the southern hemisphere right now? It isn't the North Atlantic banks."

Chen’s eyes widened. "The Andean mineral syndicate. The lithium salt nodes in the Atacama."

"They’re choked on dry inventory," Lin said, pulling the laser transceiver yoke toward her chest. Her shoulder muscles burned with exhaustion. "The regional haulage syndicates locked their railheads two weeks ago because the sovereign clearinghouse refused to settle their fuel vouchers. They have forty thousand tons of refined battery-grade carbonate sitting in rail spurs under the desert sun, completely immobilized because they lack spare parts and desalinated process water for their refining loops."

"And we have three million gallons of fresh water sitting in the deep ballast tanks," Jin murmured, his eyes narrowing. "And twelve empty bulk drydocks with heavy machine lathes."

"It’s an unbonded bilateral swap," Lin said, her fingers already working the vernier dials on the transceiver's manual pedestal. "Usufruct exchange. We grant them repair slots and desalinated water certificates for their trans-Pacific bulk carriers; they assign direct title to two thousand tons of dry-cell lithium salt to the Batam regional commons. No commercial banks. No clearinghouses. No maritime mortgage liens."

"Lin, the beam path to the Pacific transponder tower is over nine miles across open water," Chen warned, checking the handheld optical power meter. "The humidity is ninety-eight percent. The fog from the monitors hasn't even cleared. You’ll get sixty percent scatter on the cyan spectrum. The packet loss will tear the transaction blocks to pieces."

"Then we tune it by hand," Lin said.

She bent over the eyepiece. There was no automated tracking; the servos had burned out when the gantry shifted. Lin rested her cheek against the cold, damp iron of the mounting bracket. She remembered the nights during her apprenticeship, sitting in windowless transit stations, calculating coordinate vectors on greaseproof paper to pass the time. She knew the drift of this tower: two millimeters south on the ebb tide, half a millimeter east with every ten knots of westerly squall.

She sighted the faint, pulsing red navigation marker on the distant horizon of the Indonesian headland—the mountaintop relay tower that bypassed the coastal fiber choke points.

"Chen. Call out the signal-to-noise ratio. Don't look at the ledger. Look at the raw carrier wave."

"Carrier acquired," Chen muttered, his voice taut. "Attenuation... seventy-two percent. It’s too noisy, Lin. The checksum is failing."

"Compensating for wind sheer," Lin whispered. Her breath fogged the brass scale. She eased the manual micrometric screw a fraction of a thread. "Now."

"Forty-eight percent scatter. Packet reception... twenty percent. Thirty percent. It's fragmenting!"

From down on the quay, Uncle Tan’s voice crackled through the comm-box: "Jin! The south caisson valve is jamming! Silt in the gate guides! The dock is settling another degree to the port! If you don't lock that beam now, the tilt will take the transceiver completely off the horizon!"

"Lin!" Jin barked.

"Quiet," she breathed.

She didn't fight the crane's movement. Instead of trying to hold the crosshairs rigid against the storm, she anticipated the crane’s rhythmic, ponderous sway against the surging tide. She dialed the azimuth past the center mark, letting the structural flex of sixty tons of iron swing the beam directly through the receiver’s aperture at the crest of the swell.

A high, clean chime cut through the static on Chen’s handheld terminal.

"Handshake confirmed!" Chen yelled, his voice cracking. "The Atacama node answered! Cryptographic verification received... they’re validating the local sortition tally from yesterday’s assembly!"

On the small screen, illuminated by the pale cyan glow of the optical carrier, the blocks aligned. A bilateral usufruct contract blossomed across the local air-gapped ledger: forty thousand liters of fresh potable water and two drydock maintenance reservations committed to the Pacific carrier *Lautaro*, in exchange for immediate physical transfer of eight hundred battery modules currently held in escrow at the offshore anchorage.

The admiralty lien had been outflanked without a single dollar clearing an offshore account.

"It took," Chen breathed, sinking back against the iron truss, his hands trembling violently. "The swap is registered on the southern mesh."

Lin let go of the aiming yoke. Her fingers were cramped into rigid, claw-like hooks, the skin around her nails raw and bleeding from the knurled brass knobs. She closed her eyes, letting the torrential rain wash the grime and blood from her face.

"Jin," she called down into the voice-pipe, her voice hoarse. "Signal the Mekong grain carriers. Tell them their bunker fuel and port dues are backed by physical lithium parity. Tell them to drop anchor in Berth Seven."

Silence lingered on the pipe for two seconds, followed by Jin’s gravelly laugh. "They’re already coming about, Lin. Their lead ship just fired her mooring thrusters."

Lin exhaled, her spine leaning back against the gantry rail, feeling the deep, rhythmic hum of the tidal current beginning to turn against the submerged caissons.

Then, the low-frequency warning horn on the harbor mouth buoys began to wail.

Chen shot upright, grabbing his binoculars and training them through the rain toward the outer channel.

"What is that?" Chen whispered, his skin going pale.

Lin snapped her eyes open and looked out.

The private tactical cutters hadn't retreated back to the commercial roadstead. They had fanned out into a screening line, and behind them, looming out of the black rain squall like an artificial island, moved a four-hundred-meter corporate heavy-lift vessel. Its deck was not laden with commercial containers, but stacked with eight decommissioned, concrete-filled bulk carrier hulls, swinging out on heavy industrial davits.

"They aren't trying to board us," Jin’s voice came up through the pipe, stripped of all humor, flat and cold with sudden dread. "They're scuttling. They’re dropping a wall of dead iron straight across our channel mouth."

CHAPTER 15

Chapter 15

The voice-pipe over Berth Nine did not carry words, only the sharp, metallic crack of an iron crowbar striking plate steel, followed by a human scream cut short by a wet thud.

Jin Wei dropped the brass binoculars onto the plotting table. His third lumbar vertebra ground like a dry bearing as he straightened, the dull, familiar ache flaring through his right hip and down into the heel of his boot. Outside the wheelhouse windows, the sky hung the color of wet solder. The monsoon heat was thirty-five degrees, but inside the corrugated iron sheds of the lower berths, under ninety-eight percent humidity, the air sat like boiling soup.

"Jin, stay on the bridge," Lin's voice rasped through the acoustic tube from the gantry tower above. Her breath hitched, ragged with exhaustion. "The offshore heavy-lift is flooding its starboard ballast tanks. Chen says we have twenty minutes before they swing the first scuttle-hulk across the channel throat. If you go down there—"

"If Berth Nine goes up in smoke, we don't have an inner basin to defend," Jin said.

He didn't take a sidearm; the covenant forbade lethal iron, and drawing a pistol in an enclosed compartment of desperate men was merely an invitation to die fast. Instead, he reached into his locker and pulled out a clean linen rag, wrapping it methodically around the calloused notch of his left thumb—an old, unconscious habit forged decades ago, when a snapped wire-rope winch on an unflagged coaster had peeled the flesh to the bone. Whenever chaos closed in, his fingers searched for that scar, reminding him that bone healed, but panic was fatal.

He shoved through the watertight door into the rain.

The yard smelled of hot iron, stagnant bilge, and sour human sweat. Down on the apron of Drydock Four, three hundred meters from the administrative offices, eleven private tactical contractors from the Apex security tender were trapped behind a perimeter of rusted cargo skids. Their fiberglass launch sat fifty yards out, dead in the water, its outboard fouled and smoking with plastic drift-netting.

They were not advancing. They were tearing each other to pieces.

The contractor squad had been posted to hold the commercial fuel riser three days ago on seventy-two-hour corporate rations. Those rations had run out yesterday morning. Enclosed in black tactical overalls, heavy ceramic plate carriers, and ballistic helmets, their bodies had become personal furnaces. Two men were screaming at each other behind an overturned flatbed trailer, their carbines slung low, pointed at the deck between their boots.

"He told us six hours!" one screamed, his voice shredded, spitting white foam from cracked, blackened lips. "Six hours until the crew change! Look at the channel! Look at the crane ship, you idiot! They're dropping bulkheads across the mouth! They aren't picking us up! They're locking us in the pen!"

"Stand your post, Keller!" a second voice barked. It was their team lead, a man with a broken nose and the gray, gaunt hollows of advanced heat exhaustion carving out his cheeks. His sidearm remained holstered, but his right hand hovered an inch above the retention clip, trembling with neurological fatigue. "We have a contracted presence on Berth Nine until eighteen hundred hours. Stand your post or I log you for breach."

"Log me?" Keller lunged, slamming the butt of his unslung weapon into the leader's chest plate. The leader stumbled back against the corroded iron bulkhead of the workshop, his boots slipping in a puddle of brown, stagnant rainwater. "With what ledger? Look at your comm-pad! There's no carrier signal! The satellite link has been dead since dawn! There is no extraction!"

Four other contractors moved in, forming a ragged, sweating ring. Their eyes were wild, red-rimmed with salt-scour and fever. In the shadow of the workshop eaves, two more men lay on their sides in the dirt, their ballistic vests stripped off, vomiting clear bile onto the gravel. One of them had a bandaged leg wrapped in a filth-soaked pressure dressing, the skin around the edges swollen, purple, and weeping clear fluid.

Jin walked down the concrete ramp.

He did not hurry. He did not sneak. His heavy steel-toed work boots struck the wet slag with measured, rhythmic clangs. Behind him, Uncle Tan wheeled a hand-dolly loaded with two fifty-liter blue polyethylene drums, condensation beading thickly against their chilled plastic skins. Beside the drums rested a canvas medical satchel.

Keller spun around, weapon snapping up toward Jin's chest. "Hold! Stay where you are! Back up or I fire!"

Jin stopped five paces away. He kept his hands open, palms down at waist height. The bunker fuel cough caught in his throat, dry and rattling, and he waited until the spasm passed before speaking.

"Put the muzzle down, son," Jin said, his voice level, flat as an oiled sea. "You fire that inside this shed, the ricochet off that corrugated iron will kill the boy behind you before it touches me."

"We are authorized to secure Berth Nine," the squad leader wheezed from against the bulkhead, struggling to remain upright. His uniform was black with sweat across the spine, white crusts of evaporated sodium forming along his collar. "Apex Marine Tactical. Sovereign maritime security under... under Euro-Asian Maritime Finance lien order..."

His knees buckled. He slid three inches down the wet iron wall, catching himself on his knuckles.

"Your lien order doesn't pump fresh water," Jin said. He nodded toward Tan. "Open the valve, Tan."

The old docker didn't look at the rifles. His arthritic fingers worked the brass petcock on the lower drum. A stream of clear, cold water—pulled three hours ago from the reverse-osmosis plant and chilled through the tidal turbine’s intake heat exchanger—gushed into a five-liter galvanized pail. The sound of running water in the stifling, airless heat hit the contractors like a physical blow.

Keller’s jaw slackened. He swallowed, his dry throat clicking loudly.

"You’ve been drinking from the fire main," Jin said, looking past Keller toward the two men on the ground. "That water sits in dead-end black iron pipes under forty degrees of ambient heat. It’s full of rust, anaerobic bacteria, and heavy zinc. Drink another pint of it and your kidneys shut down before sundown."

"It's a trick," Keller whispered, though his rifle barrel dipped three inches toward the gravel. "They’re going to poison us, take our gear."

Jin walked straight past him. He didn't look back to see if Keller’s finger was on the trigger. He knelt beside the contractor lying on the gravel, whose calf was swollen to twice its normal size. Jin opened the satchel, pulling out a sterile bottle of saline and a scalpel wrapper.

Thirty years ago, adrift on an unpowered freighter in the Makassar Strait, Jin had watched three deckhands succumb to heat delirium. They had begun by screaming at the sky; within twelve hours, their skin had turned hot and dry, their minds wandering into childhood memories before their hearts simply arrested under the thickened slurry of their own dehydrated blood. He recognized the smell on this boy’s skin: the faint, sweet scent of systemic ketoacidosis.

"Cut the boot laces," Jin told Tan without looking up. "Tan, pour half a liter into a cup. Add two pinches from the paper packet. Sodium and glucose. Slowly. If he gulps it, he’ll aspirate."

The squad leader dragged himself forward, his boots dragging in the dirt. He dropped to one knee beside Jin. Up close, the man wasn't older than thirty-five, his eyes terrified not of the enemy, but of the realization that his life had been factored into a corporate loss spreadsheet as an acceptable rounding error.

"They aren't coming, are they?" the leader whispered.

"The heavy-lift out there has eight thousand tons of concrete ballast in its holds," Jin said quietly, slicing the rotten bandage away from the boy's leg with steady, economical strokes. A line of foul, yellowish fluid drained into the slag; the boy groaned, his body shuddering under a wave of shivering heat. "They are going to drop those hulls into the dredged gut. If you were on that jetty when the channel closed, you were meant to starve until our sortition council agreed to trade our battery banks for your medical evacuation."

The squad leader closed his eyes. A single tear cut a clean gray line through the grime on his cheek. "They gave us forty-eight hours of rations. Said the tugs would pull us off at high water."

"High water was forty minutes ago," Jin said. He took the steel cup from Tan and pressed it to the wounded boy's lips, supporting the back of his neck with one scarred hand. "Drink. Small sips. That’s it."

Keller stood frozen above them, his rifle hanging limp by his side. Behind him, three other contractors dropped their weapons onto the gravel with hollow, plastic clatters, dropping to their knees around the second water drum. One of them buried his face in his wet hands, his shoulders shaking with silent, dry heaves.

"Take your plates off," Jin told the squad leader. "All of you. Strip the Kevlar. You’re cooking your organs. Tan, get the stretchers from the machine shop. We move them into the turbine tunnel where the ventilation is running."

The squad leader unclipped his tactical vest. It fell into the mud with a heavy, dead slap. He reached down, took the cup from Jin’s hand, and held it to his wounded man's mouth himself.

"My name is Vane," the man rasped.

"Jin Wei," Jin replied. "Now help me lift him."

Before they could stand, a sound ripped through the basin—not an explosion, but the gargantuan, groaning screech of four-inch steel cables snapping under catastrophic tension.

Jin snapped his head toward the channel mouth.

A mile out, the corporate heavy-lift had cut its forward davits. The first four-hundred-foot concrete-filled bulk hull tilted sideways, sliding down the angled slipway of the carrier's deck. It struck the water with a sound like a collapsing mountain, throwing a thirty-foot wall of white spray into the rain, before settling directly across the deep-water passage, its rusted spine breaking against the harbor bar.

The channel was shut. And from the gantry tower, Lin’s warning horn began a long, unbroken shriek.

CHAPTER 16

Chapter 16

The displacement wave did not look like water; it looked like a shelf of dark, torn slate sliding across the harbor.

When the scuttled bulk hull settled onto the seabed, four hundred feet of dead steel choked the dredged gut, and the incoming monsoon tide—already forced into a fury by sixty-knot gusts out of the South China Sea—had nowhere left to go. The channel narrowed to a jagged throat. The sea surged upward, piling upon its own back, and came roaring toward the entrance of Drydock 4.

Lin's warning horn died mid-wail atop the crane tower as salt mist choked the air intake, leaving only the brute physical thunder of three hundred thousand tons of displaced seawater slamming against the outer breakwater. Spray leaped fifty feet into the squall, tasting of diesel slick and rotting estuary mud.

"Jin!" Aisyah screamed against the wind. Her soaked tunic was plastered to her ribcage, the fabric tearing at the shoulder where she had snagged it on a cable clamp ten minutes prior. "The outer sill! The miter gates can't take ten meters of head! The pintle pins will shear right off the concrete!"

Jin was already moving, his boots skidding across the grease-filmed limestone apron. His lower spine felt as though a dull chisel had been hammered between his lumbar vertebrae, each heavy stride sending a hot, sickening throb into his hips. "The flat-deck!" he roared back, spitting brackish rain. "The scrap barge at Berth Nine! We put her across the throat!"

Behind them, Keller and the disarmed contractors stood waist-deep in the sudden wash creeping over the lower slipway. Vane, his tactical vest discarded in the mud, grabbed the arm of his shivering comrade and hauled him toward the dry mouth of the machine shop. For a second, Vane looked back at Jin—not with defiance, but with the hollow, animal terror of a man who realized that no contract covered drowning inside another man's cage.

"Get your men inside the turbine house!" Jin bellowed at him without breaking stride. "Up to the crane tracks! Don't touch the floor switches!"

Aisyah was already ten paces ahead of him, her light frame cutting through the sheets of rain toward the rusted silhouette of the *Batam-9*. The barge was an eighty-meter slab of unpainted, pitted iron, moored with three frayed nylon hawsers to the outer bollards. It had spent five years hauling bauxite before the receivers abandoned it; it was empty, high in the water, riding the incoming chop like an enormous hollow tin can. If the surge struck its flank while it was buoyant, it would rip the bollards

clean out of the quayside and act as a battering ram, smashing the miter gates inward and drowning the three refitting hulls resting on the drydock keel blocks below.

"We drop her!" Aisyah shouted, vaulting the gap between the concrete apron and the barge's wet gunwale. Her scarred fingers caught the cold rim of the coaming. She winced, the high-voltage flash burns across her palms tearing open against the raw rust, leaving thin streaks of crimson on the orange iron. "If we don't open the sea chests, the wave will pick her up and toss her into the basin!"

Jin landed on the deck behind her with a sickening jar to his knees. The deck was bucking, tossing side to side as the first low swell of the surge rolled into the slips. Out in the fairway, the sound was deepening—a low, bowel-shaking drone like a freight train running through wet gravel. The scuttled freighter had created a hydraulic ram; the tide was climbing the harbor walls inch by agonizing inch.

"The hydraulic actuators on the scuttle valves are dead," Jin said, dragging the back of his hand across his streaming face. The chemical burn at his collarbone burned like lye in the salt spray. "The lines were cut when they stripped the deck machinery in April. It’s all manual wheel-and-worm."

"Number three and number four compartments," Aisyah said, dropping to her hands and knees to yank up a heavy circular dog-hatch. The stench that boiled out of the dark void was suffocating—stagnant bilge water, decomposing seaweed, and the suffocating tang of trapped rust. "If we flood the stern tanks, her tail will ground against the limestone shelf right in front of the gate apron. She'll act as a breakwater. She'll eat the crest."

"And if she twists?" Jin asked, hauling a heavy iron spanner from the tool rack welded beside the coaming.

"Then she takes the gates with her," she said, her brown eyes meeting his through the pelting rain, wide and utterly cold with focus. "Down. Now."

They dropped through the hatch into the stifling dark.

Inside the double bottom, the heat was ferocious, clinging to their skin like wet wool. The monsoon raged outside, but down here the hull amplified every impact of the rising water against the exterior plates into a series of deafening, metallic clangs that vibrated through the marrow of their bones. The air was thin, tasting of rust dust and old oil.

Jin led the way along the narrow center walkway, his shoulder brushing against the web frames. Every rib of the ship was sweating. At the bulkhead separating tanks three and four, two cast-iron valve wheels, each two feet in diameter, sat locked to their vertical stems.

"Left is open!" Jin barked. He wedged the open jaw of the iron spanner into the spokes of the starboard valve, throwing his full body weight against it.

Nothing moved. The salt air of the strait had welded the bronze stem to the iron gland in a crust of green corrosion.

"Come on, you bastard," Jin hissed through his teeth. His degenerative back gave a vicious jolt, pain radiating down the back of his left thigh until his toes went numb in his boot. He threw himself against the lever again. His knuckles scraped the raw edge of the frame, tearing the skin, but he didn't feel the cut—only the terrible, rhythmic thumping of the outer swell hammering against the steel plates three inches from his skull.

Aisyah threw her shoulder against the spanner beside him. Her small boots skidded on the greasy floor plates. "On three!" she gasped, her voice raw. "One—two—three!"

With a sound like a pistol shot, the rust seal broke. The wheel jerked half an inch, shearing a crust of lime and salt.

Jin didn't wait for his breath. He grabbed the rim with both hands, working the wheel in frantic quarter-turns. Down below their feet, deep in the sea-chest chest manifold, the iron wedge lifted.

The sea did not enter quietly. It burst through the intake pipe with a concussive roar that shook the deck plates beneath their boots. A jet of foul, freezing seawater geysered up through a weeping gasket on the valve bonnet, drenching them both in gray foam. The barge shuddered, a heavy, dead sensation creeping into the motion of the deck as the first hundred tons of the strait rushed into the cavernous empty tanks.

"Port side!" Aisyah yelled, already scrambling over the center pipe to the opposite wheel.

She hauled on the wheel with both hands, but her burned skin betrayed her; she slipped, her knees slamming hard against the diamond-plate steel with a hollow thud that made her gasp in agony.

Jin caught her by the waistband of her trousers, hauling her upright with one arm while his other caught the spokes. His breath was coming in ragged, burning gasps, smelling of old tobacco and acid. "I’ve got the wheel! Clear the ladder! When this tank takes three feet of head, the suction through the air vents will pull the hatch shut!"

"I'm not leaving you down here to drown in the dark, Uncle!" she spat back, her face white with pain, her hands instantly locking onto the rim right beside his own, their torn fingers interlacing on the cold iron.

Together, they hauled. The second valve groaned, fighting them tooth and nail, threads screaming as sand and shell-grit ground through the brass sleeve. Inch by inch, the spindle rose.

The ocean struck the port hull with a blow that threw them both sideways against the bulkhead.

Above them, the sky seemed to tear open. The sound was not wind—it was the great wave cresting over the outer barrier, hitting the barge's high freeboard like an artillery shell. The entire seventy-meter hull rolled twelve degrees to starboard with a sickening, lazy groan. Outside, mooring lines were snapping with the crack of rifle fire.

"She's dragging!" Aisyah screamed, scrambling up the steel rungs toward the square patch of stormy gray daylight.

Jin hauled himself out behind her, his left leg dragging slightly, his boots sloshing with water that was already knee-deep on the lower walkway.

They tumbled out onto the open deck just as the main surge hit.

The wall of dark green water swept clean over the barge's low bow, ripping a metal storage locker off its welds and hurling it across the apron like a cardboard box. But the stern, bloated with four hundred tons of fast-flooding seawater, refused to lift. It dragged hard, its keel grinding into the submerged limestone shelf with a scream of tortured rock and tearing plate that could be felt through the soles of their boots.

The barge swung broadside across the mouth of the drydock, wedging its dead weight directly between the two stone piers just as the crest peaked.

A mountain of foam struck the barge's outer flank. The hull took the blow, groaning along every rivet, buckling inward six inches at the midship frame, but it held. The deadly kinetic hammer that would have shattered the drydock gates shattered against the barge's sacrificial flank instead, spilling into the basin not as a catastrophic ram, but as a harmless, boiling cascade of white water that drained toward the sump pumps.

Aisyah collapsed against the coaming, her chest heaving, rain plastering her hair across her eyes, a wild, breathless laugh tearing out of her throat. "She grounded! She took the hit!"

Jin did not answer. He was standing on the listing deck, his eyes fixed not on the water, but on the torn iron where the barge’s bow had crushed the wooden fender of the eastern pier.

Wedged deep in the splintered timber beneath the smashed concrete lip, revealed for the first time as the storm tide scoured away ten years of accumulated silt and black marine growth, lay a thick, steel-armored bundle—a primary umbilical conduit, stamped with the unmistakable yellow bands of a sovereign military communication cable, cut clean through with the jagged, unmistakable marks of a high-temperature underwater hydraulic shear.

And from the severed, oil-filled core of the cable, a steady, rhythmic pulse of tiny, brilliant green indicator lights was still winking through the murk.

CHAPTER 17

Chapter 17

The monsoon squall had bled out into a breathless, leaden heat that felt heavier than the rain. Inside the vehicle deck of the *Dharma Jaya*—a rusted double-ended ferry moored in Berth 9, stripped of its passenger benches and retrofitted into an emergency nursery—the air was thick with the scent of wet rattan, cooling diesel, and damp laundry hung from overhead cable trays.

Uncle Tan sat cross-legged on a split-bamboo mat, his stiffened knees grinding with the dull, familiar ache of forty years spent on slippery iron decks. His knuckles, swollen at the joints like gnarled mangrove roots, cradled a pair of blunt wire-strippers. Across from him, huddled around two upturned fiberglass fish boxes, seven children were arguing over pieces of buoyant blue insulation foam, their voices thin and sharp against the rhythmic thud of the lower bilge pumps.

"Not with your teeth, Mei," Tan said softly, his voice raspy from a youth spent breathing bilge fumes. He gently nudged a nine-year-old girl's shoulder. "Copper will notch the enamel, and once you swallow salt water, the tooth goes black before you see land again. Use the sheer edge. Steady your wrists against the box."

Mei released the stripped copper wire, her lower lip trembling. She was the daughter of a second engineer who had vanished into an admiralty holding facility three weeks earlier when their container feeder had been seized at the eastern anchorage. Around her, twenty other displaced children sat in small clusters on the deck, assembling miniature boats. There were no plastic hulls or toy motors here. They worked with what the tide and the yard's scrap bins yielded: hand-carved slivers of packing foam, flattened strips of copper salvaged from crushed terminal switches, and fingernail-sized photovoltaic wafers scavenged from shattered navigation buoys.

Tan held up a laminated pictorial wiring card, its edges frayed and gray with grease. There were no equations on the card, only clean black lines showing how the red lead of the silicon wafer met the tiny vibration motor lifted from a dead pager.

"Two suns on the wafer, one drop of pine resin on the stern," Tan murmured, showing eight-year-old Kian how to press the lead into place without cracking the brittle blue crystal.

Kian didn't press down. His small fingers, scarred by oyster shells from his family's days on the southern stilt villages, hovered above the wafer. His chest hitched in a dry, silent spasm—the phantom startle of a child who had spent four consecutive nights listening to patrol skiffs circle their anchorage with searchlights blazing through the ports.

"It won't run," Kian whispered. "The sun is gone."

Tan looked up toward the vehicle deck's open stern ramp. Beyond the safety netting, the sky over the strait was a bruised purple, suffocating and flat. The monsoon clouds were trapping the refinery smog from the western islands, turning the daylight into an oily yellow glare.

"It doesn't need the sun you can see," Tan said, resting a heavy, warm palm between the boy's shoulder blades, feeling the frantic, fluttering pulse beneath the cotton shirt. "It only needs the sky to be awake. Look here."

He tipped the scrap foam boat toward the dull light coming off the bay. The salvaged motor gave a sudden, raspy buzz, vibrating so hard on the fish box that it skittered two inches across the plastic, leaving a faint scratch in the salt crust.

The children gasped. For three seconds, Kian's face lost its taut, hunted hollows. A faint smile flickered at the corner of his mouth.

A crash of shattered stoneware shattered the momentary peace.

Across the ferry's open deck, beyond the hanging canvas tarpaulins that partitioned the nursery from the family berths, a man's voice roared in fury.

"You took the three-quarter valve! Don't lie to me, Basuki! You hid it under your bedding!"

"I took what was allocated to the lower deck pump!" another voice snarled back, raw and venomous. "My sister's baby is coughing up brown phlegm because the bilge in Section Three is six inches deep! Your bunk is dry!"

Tan was on his feet before his knees could fully register the complaint. He didn't rush; sprinting across a wet steel deck only invited broken ribs. He walked with a heavy, rolling sea-stride, his bare feet gripping the diamond plating.

Behind the third canvas partition, two men were grappling over an iron pipe fitting. Basuki, an oiler whose freighter had been abandoned by its owners off Singapore two months prior, had the younger deckhand pinned against a structural stanchion. The younger man's elbow was cocked back, a rusted adjustable wrench gripped in his fist. Surrounding them were a dozen women and elderly mariners, their faces pale, hollowed by weeks of rationed rice and the constant dread of the harbor police clearing the basin.

"Five minutes," Tan said.

He didn't shout. He spoke at the exact pitch of an engine room watchstander reporting a hot bearing. From his belt, he unhooked a circular brass wind-up timer, salvage from a freighter's telegraph station, its glass cracked across the face. He twisted the bezel until the internal spring clicked, a heavy, metallic *clack-clack-clack* that immediately cut through the men's ragged breathing.

He set the brass puck on an overturned steel drum between them.

"First stage," Tan said, placing his broad body directly between the raised wrench and Basuki’s throat. "Both hands off the brass. Palms on the bulkhead. You know the covenant."

"He's hoarding fittings, Uncle," Basuki spat, though his grip loosened. Salt sweat was running into his eyes, stinging them red. "We drown down there while his people sleep on dry wood."

"Palms on the steel," Tan repeated, his tone immutable as an anchor fluke. "Five minutes. Feel the hull. If the pumps stop, the valve doesn't matter, does it? Neither of you has slept since the storm surge broke the outer boom. Put the iron down, Harun."

The younger deckhand hesitated, his jaw working violently, before the wrench slipped from his sweat-slick fingers and clattered against the plating. He pressed his palms against the damp, painted steel of the hull, his forehead resting against the cold bulkhead, shoulders heaving in jagged sobs of pure exhaustion. Basuki cursed under his breath, turned, and did the same ten paces away.

The brass timer ticked with cold, mechanical indifference. Around them, the displaced families slowly let out their breath. A woman stepped forward with a tin mug of lukewarm rainwater and handed it to Tan. He took a sip, then offered it to Harun’s trembling neck.

"The machine shop in Drydock 2 is milling three new threaded sleeves from scrap shafting," Tan told the bulkhead quietly. "They will be ready before the evening tide. You fight over dead scrap because your heads are full of the patrol sirens from three nights ago. Leave the sirens in the strait. You are inside the gate now."

Before Harun could answer, a small tug on Tan’s sarong drew his attention downward.

It was Mei. She was clutching her foam boat, but her wide eyes were fixed on the bilge-cooling trench that ran down the center of the ferry's deck, where runoff water drained into the lower collection sumps.

"Uncle," she whispered, pointing toward the water.

Tan followed her small, grease-stained finger.

The test trench was four inches deep with gray seawater. Several of the children’s finished miniature craft were floating in the still eddy near the drain grating, their tiny motors buzzing weakly as they caught the yellow gloom of the sky.

But Kian’s boat was not drifting with the faint current. It was vibrating violently, pivoting on its foam keel as if caught in a magnetic funnel.

Tan frowned, stepping over the brass timer, which was still clicking down its five-minute cooling period. He knelt beside the trench.

The photocell on Kian’s miniature boat wasn't just catching daylight. Its tiny green diagnostic photodiode was blinking in a sharp, rhythmic cadence—two short bursts, one long, then three rapid pulses.

Dot-dot, dash, dot-dot-dot.

It was identical to the pulse sequence Jin Wei had spotted an hour earlier on the severed military umbilical pinned beneath the grounded barge.

Tan reached out and dipped two fingers into the bilge water. A faint, prickling vibration ran up through his calloused skin—an oscillating high-frequency current bleeding through the harbor basin, grounding itself directly into the ferry’s steel skin. It wasn't the regular thrum of the yard's low-speed diesel generators, nor the smooth whine of the tidal turbines.

It was an interrogation sweep.

A shadow cut across the vehicle deck's stern ramp, blocking out the yellow glare of the sky.

It wasn't a cloud.

Out in the main dredged fairway, half a mile beyond the scuttled barge wedged across the drydock mouth, three low-profile patrol interceptors had cut their engines. They weren't flying the blue flag of the maritime police, nor the red pennant of the port authority. Their hulls were painted an unreflective matte slate, their superstructure devoid of markings save for the bulbous, stabilized radomes of corporate tactical surveillance arrays.

They were drifting in dead silence on the falling tide, their bow-mounted hydrophones submerged, listening to the very pulse currently twitching the tiny scrap of foam between Kian’s feet.

The brass timer on the drum reached zero with a dry, final *ping*.

Across the ferry, the internal sound-powered telephone on the forward bulkhead let out a single, urgent shriek.

CHAPTER 18

Chapter 18

Uncle Tan snatched the handset from the bulkhead cradle before its metallic ring could echo twice off the ferry’s steel ribs.

"Speak," Tan said.

Jin Wei’s voice came through the unpowered diaphragm, hollowed by copper wire and distance, stripped of all timbre except raw urgency. "They aren't boarding. Not yet. Look up."

Tan thrust the receiver back onto its brass fork and stepped out onto the car deck’s starboard apron. The equatorial sky was a bruised, sulfuric ochre, the humidity pressing against the skin like wet fleece. Out in the fairway, the three matte-slate interceptors had dropped their sea anchors, but their crews remained behind sealed polymer visors. They weren't launching boarding skiffs. They were loitering as relay nodes, their bow-mounted hydrophones and passive masts turned skyward.

A low, collective whine—like a hornet’s nest dropped into an iron culvert—descended through the cloud ceiling.

From four hundred feet up, dropping through the haze above the drydock’s towering gantry crane, came eight slender, carbon-composite airframes. They had no rotors; they rode ducted fans that hissed with the venomous, high-pitch scream of overdriven impellers. Beneath each belly hung a twin-jaw pneumatic cutter, designed not to shred flesh, but to sever fiber conduits and crack the quartz prisms of optical transceivers.

"Gantry tower!" Tan bellowed toward the machine shop hatch. "They’re going for the Batam beam!"

High above them, sixty-five meters in the air atop the skeletal arm of the decommissioned crane, Aisyah did not need the warning. She was already tethered to the catwalk’s rusted safety rail by an eight-millimeter climbing harness, her knuckles white around a pair of rubber-sheathed cable grips.

The heat up here was worse than on the deck. The sun-baked iron radiated a suffocating warmth that tasted of scorched primer and gull droppings. Her work shirt clung to her back, soaked through, her chest heaving as she fought the dizzying vertigo that had haunted her ever since an offshore rig blast five years ago left her inner ear permanently damaged. She never spoke of the nausea, not to Jin Wei, not to the arbiters. She simply took short, calculated breaths through her nose, counting the rivets between her boots to keep the horizon from spinning.

Directly in front of her, bolted to a vibration-damped turntable, the optical laser housing was humming. Through its glass aperture, a pencil-thin filament of cyan light pulsed outward, bridging the eight-nautical-mile strait toward the island of Batam.

A red LED on the transceiver’s control box was blinking fitfully.

Packet loss: thirty percent. Atmospheric scatter.

Down in the ferry’s converted chart room, Dr. Lin Zhang jammed both palms against the teak counter to steady her shaking hands. Her migraine had settled behind her left eye like an embedded fishhook, pulsing in lockstep with the flickering diagnostic screen. She reached out with a trembling finger, adjusting the gain on the receiver array.

"Lin, report!" Jin Wei’s boots hammered down the companionway stairs, his heavy frame filling the doorway. The captain’s breath rattled in his chest, bunker-fuel cough rasping like dry leaves across sheet metal.

"The interceptors are bathing the channel in an acoustic baseline sweep to mask the swarm’s descent," Lin said, her voice clipped, breath shallow. "The drones are autonomous. Optical pursuit algorithms. They aren't looking at us. They’re tracking the cyan beam back to the gantry focal point. If those pneumatic jaws snip the emitter head, the Batam clearinghouse loses synchronization. Every grain shipment, every battery ledger swap with the southern islands halts instantly."

"How long until contact?"

"Ninety seconds," Lin whispered. "Maybe eighty. Aisyah can't outrun them down that ladder."

Jin Wei did not waste breath on a curse. He turned toward the sound-powered phone hanging beside the ship's telegraph. He cranked the rotary magnet three vicious turns and pulled the receiver to his ear.

"Chen Rui," he barked into the brass cone. "Tidal turbine bypass manifold. The four-inch bleed valve on the thermal accumulator. Open it wide. Dump the dump line into the crane's dry riser."

From the cavernous engine spaces below the waterline, Chen Rui’s voice answered with monosyllabic fury. "Line’s fouled with salt crust, Captain! Handle’s locked solid!"

"Break the shear pin," Jin Wei ordered. "Do not argue. Use the slugging wrench."

In the damp belly of the hull, six feet below the harbor’s low-tide mark, Chen Rui dropped the phone and grabbed a twelve-pound iron hammer from the shadow board. The humidity down here was ninety-eight percent; condensation wept down the curved steel plates in dirty streams. The twin tidal turbines anchored in the fairway were pumping hundreds of gallons of superheated water through the closed-loop heat exchanger, holding the batteries at operating temperature while dumping excess load into the ballast sumps.

A thick bronze wheel, coated in white, chalky mineral blooms, stood between the primary steam chest and the crane's vertical fire-suppression riser.

Chen Rui wedged the box-end wrench over the squared valve stem and swung the hammer.

CLANG.

The iron vibrated through the bones of his forearms, setting off an electric fire in his chronic tendonitis. He grimaced, taste of copper rising on his tongue, and swung again.

CLANG.

The salt seal fractured with a sound like a rifle shot. Hot bronze groaned. Chen Rui threw his whole body weight against the wrench, dragging the valve open four full turns.

Sixty-five meters above, the sea breeze suddenly died.

Aisyah felt the iron beneath her boots shudder. It was not the wind. It was an internal hydraulic hammering traveling up the crane's hollow vertical legs.

From the north, the swarm dipped below the cloud base. She could see them now with the naked eye: eight black wedges, flying in a tight staggered wedge, their ducted fans whining in unison. The forward drone had its titanium cutters extended, snapping open and shut in a calibration cycle. Fifty yards out. Thirty.

Aisyah refused to drop to the deck. She gripped the transceiver's mounting bracket, stepped in front of the optical path, and pulled her safety line taut. If they cut the housing, they would have to cut through her chest first.

Then the drydock floor erupted.

Ten feet below her catwalk, the crane's forgotten emergency misting nozzles—plumbed decades ago to wash chemical spills from container gantries—screamed to life.

It was not cool sea spray.

Fed by the turbine accumulator's high-pressure discharge, a dense, roaring curtain of superheated steam and vaporized brine blasted skyward through the slotted nozzles. The column of white vapor hit the cooler tropical air and expanded violently, blooming into a towering, sixty-foot thermal wall that swallowed the crane's jib, the transceiver, and Aisyah in a blinding, opaque cloud.

The lead drone hit the thermal curtain at forty miles per hour.

Its forward optical sensors, calibrated for the crisp contrast of the cyan laser against open water, were instantly blinded by the turbulent wash of ninety-degree vapor. The sudden density change and thermal updraft caught the tiny carbon ducted fans, stalling their intake vortexes.

The machine banked violently, its flight computer struggling to compensate for the sudden loss of laminar air. The cutter snapped blindly at empty steam.

A second drone, trailing two yards behind, slammed directly into the lead unit's tail section. The collision was a dull, plastic *snap*. Both airframes tumbled end-over-end through the scalding fog, their gyro-stabilizers whining in panic, before plunging sixty meters straight down into the oily mud of the drydock floor, shattering on the granite blocks.

Inside the mist curtain, Aisyah could not see her own boots. The steam scorched her skin through her denim trousers, and the air was thick with the scent of boiled seaweed and sulfur. But the laser housing was still vibrating beneath her fingers.

She wiped her fogged goggles with a wet sleeve. The red diagnostic light on the optical box flickered once, twice, and then clicked solid green.

The steam was thick enough to blind the drones' wide-angle cameras, but the narrow-beam cyan laser, pulsing at a tight terahertz frequency, bored directly through the vaporous tunnel, burning a clean hole through the fog toward the distant Batam receptor.

Below on the ferry's apron, Tan and Jin Wei stood shoulder-to-shoulder, watching the remaining six drones scatter like frightened sparrows, their autonomous logic breaking under the thermal interference, climbing frantically back toward the yellow cloud cover to re-establish telemetry with the interceptors in the channel.

A ragged cheer rose from the car deck behind them. Kian and the mariner refugees were hanging over the gunwales, pointing up at the billowing white plume that made the old crane look like a volcano rising from the harbor mud.

Jin Wei did not join the cheer.

He lowered his binoculars, his scarred collarbone tightening under his salt-stiff collar.

Out in the dredged fairway, the three matte-slate interceptors were not retreating. Seeing their aerial probe neutralized, their low-profile hulls suddenly surged forward, twin waterjets churning the dirty water into white foam.

They weren't trying to cut the optical line anymore.

Steering hard around the scuttled barge, the three craft were cutting straight for Drydock 4's inner gate, their heavy steel bow-bumpers angled to crush the wooden pontoon barriers that protected the ferry's exposed cooling lines.

And on the lead interceptor's forward deck, two crewmen in charcoal tactical gear were unlimbering a heavy, pneumatic line-throwing cannon, aiming its barbed grapple directly at the ferry's main sea-chest intake.

CHAPTER 19

Chapter 19

"Port monitors! Now!" Jin Wei's voice tore raw against the iron bulkhead.

The pneumatic *thwump* of the interceptor's deck gun sounded across the churned basin like an axe striking wet cedar. A four-pronged steel grapple trailing sixty fathoms of weighted synthetic braid ripped through the low vapor, arcing straight toward the ferry's starboard cooling intake.

Kian didn't drop to the deck. He threw his shoulder into the bronze wheel of the salvaged harbor tug monitor mounted on Berth 8. The valve stem shrieked, caked with hardened salt crust, before yielding with a sudden wet shudder.

Two thousand gallons of silted seawater per minute erupted from the brass nozzle under twelve atmospheres of head pressure.

The heavy, white column of water punched through the air, catching the grapple mid-flight. The hydraulic mass deflected the trailing irons six yards off-axis; the barbed flukes slapped harmlessly against the green-slime apron of the concrete pier and skittered into the dark water below. The jet didn't stop there. Kian cranked the elevation worm-gear down, depressing the nozzle until the solid hydraulic ram slammed directly across the lead skiff's composite foredeck.

The two private security contractors in charcoal flotation vests were blown off their knees. The sheer kinetic tonnage of water swamped the craft's low-slung well deck, depressing its nose until the twin waterjets sucked surface froth and cavitated with a shrill, dry whine.

"Hold them off the pontoon!" Jin Wei coughed, clutching his collarbone where the knot of old scar tissue pulled tight against his neck. The vibration from the monitor's discharge traveled through the iron deck and straight into his lumbar spine, grinding the worn discs until a hot spike of pain radiated down his left calf. "Don't let them foul the raw-water intake! If we lose the heat exchangers, the battery pack cooks in twenty minutes!"

Across the narrow basin, the second interceptor banked hard to evade the churning wash, its waterjet nozzles throwing two tall wings of spray. The pilot didn't panic. These weren't street mercenaries hired off an alley dock; they were licensed civil asset recovery contractors operating under maritime enforcement warrants, disciplined and steady. Recognizing the defensive arc of the shore-side monitor, the second craft backed down its throttles, holding position just outside the monitor's trajectory while the third skiff maneuvered to throw a secondary line over the outer gate's floating booms.

They were probing for an angle, burning through high-grade marine diesel, waiting for the battery banks driving the harbor pumps to drop their charge.

Thirty yards inboard, buried beneath two decks of rusted passenger seating in the ferry's converted purser's office, Lin Zhang heard none of the water cannons.

She heard only the dry, relentless hum of a stripped refrigeration fan and the wet, shallow whistle of her own breath.

A copper-cased drafting stylus—blunt-tipped, completely devoid of ink, an old habit from her first year drafting circuit traces by hand in a windowless Shenzhen basement—rolled between her thumb and forefinger. Her vision was tunneling. The migraine aura had begun ten minutes earlier as a jagged crescent of yellow light in her left eye, and now it was chewing through her peripheral field, turning the steel edges of her desk into pulsing smears of zinc.

On the cathode-ray terminal before her, fed by the cyan laser pulsing down from the crane's optical receiver, the inbound transmission from Batam was clearing.

It was not an administrative ledger. It was the compiled core logic of Aegis-Omni's regional risk-scoring system: sixty thousand lines of unadorned, industrial execution script.

Lin jammed the heel of her palm against her left temple, pressing hard until her eyeball throbbed, trying to mechanically crush the nerve headache back into submission. Her skin was clammy with the sickening, sour grease of third-day adrenaline.

"Come on," she whispered, her voice a cracked reed. "Show me what you call a default."

She did not use automated decompilers. Automated tools smoothed over structural anomalies, interpreting jagged human malice as routine optimization. Instead, she used her blunt stylus to tap rhythmically on the edge of the Bakelite casing, reading the raw procedural flow top to bottom, the way she used to audit power-station load balancing during the summer blackouts.

Five minutes in, her breath caught behind her ribs.

The algorithm had not calculated the creditworthiness of Jin Wei's coastal freighter or the forty-two regional tramp steamers rotting along the outer shoals. It had never audited their manifests, their engine logs, or their actual bills of lading.

Tucked inside the deep recursion of the automated escrow routine lay a synthetic multiplier.

Whenever an independent vessel entered the Singapore or Malacca traffic separation channels, the system pinged the vessel's automatic identification transponder. If the registry flagged the hull as non-syndicated—free of parent-firm commercial debt, operating under municipal or private family ownership—the script triggered a covert secondary transaction.

A ghost liability.

It automatically generated an unnotified micro-charge for "predictive berth reservation insurance" through an offshore holding firm in Labuan. The charge was tiny—less than forty dollars an hour. But it was deliberately billed to a dormant, unmonitored clearance account that the vessel's master had never been assigned the keys to access.

Within fourteen days at sea, the unpaid micro-charges crossed the default threshold.

At that exact millisecond, the logic branch inverted. The synthetic debt was automatically packaged, assigned an astronomical compounding penalty rate of four hundred percent, and transferred via automated clearinghouses to Euro-Asian Maritime Finance.

The ship had not missed a fuel payment. It had not defaulted on a hull mortgage.

The debt was an algorithmic phantom, birthed entirely within the software to manufacture a legal pretext for an admiralty arrest warrant before the ship ever made landfall.

"They didn't go broke," Lin breathed into the hot, dim air of the cabin. Her stomach heaved, a sudden wave of acid rising in her throat. "None of them went broke."

She grabbed a grease pencil from the desk tray, her hand shaking so hard the tip snapped against the glass terminal. Cursing under her breath, she used the splintered stub to circle a sequence of memory addresses directly on the screen.

The ships hadn't fallen to the brutal physics of the sea or the unforgiving arithmetic of global trade. They had been harvested. The system was designed to systematically strip independent mariners of their titles, forcing their hulls into court-mandated receiver auctions where the parent syndicates bought them back for pennies on the ton, re-flagging them under corporate flags of convenience.

Footsteps clattered down the iron companionway. Uncle Tan ducked through the low doorway, his cotton singlet soaked with a mixture of salt spray and gray diesel exhaust. His knuckles were swollen, the joints thick as ginger roots from fifty years of damp bilges, and he held a chipped enamel mug of boiled rainwater laced with sweetened condensed milk.

"Jin Wei has the monitors running on low head to conserve the battery cells," Tan said, his gravelly voice remarkably calm despite the dull thuds echoing from the outer gate. "The skiffs have pulled back fifty yards. They're floating on their sea anchors. They know the tide turns at dusk. When the channel current slacks, our turbines stop spinning, and our batteries run dry."

He set the mug on the corner of the crate beside her, his dark eyes taking in the circled hex strings on the glass.

"Did you find the leak?"

Lin pointed the broken grease pencil at the terminal, her fingers trembling. "There is no leak, Tan. There was never an audit failure. Look here. Look at this execution log from eight months ago. The

Bintang Timur—your nephew's tanker. They said he abandoned his crew because he couldn't cover the canal transit fees."

Tan’s weathered jaw set, the tendons in his neck tightening like dry hemp rope. He didn't speak. He only stared at the phosphor numbers.

"The canal fee was paid in full six days before he arrived," Lin said, the words tumbling out of her in a furious, ragged hiss. "The system routed his clearance funds into an unlinked escrow pocket. Then it generated three false bunkering invoices from an empty terminal in Johor, declared him insolvent, and issued the lien directly to the port marshal. He didn't abandon anyone. They engineered his bankruptcy while he was still three days out in the Natuna Sea."

Tan reached out slowly, his thick, calloused index finger hovering just above the glass, tracing the serial code of the phantom lien. A slow, terrible stillness settled over his broad face—not the wild heat of anger, but the cold, immovable weight of an old anchor finding rock at the bottom of a bay.

"They used a court stamp to steal his life," Tan whispered.

"Not a court stamp," Lin said, wiping sweat and grease from her brow with her forearms, leaving a dark smudge across her temple. "A cryptographic key. An admiralty receiver's private authorization signature. It’s hardcoded right into the forfeiture routine."

She tapped the key on her keyboard, calling up the root certificate embedded in the script's execution header.

"If we broadcast this source tree across the regional mesh—if the crews in Batam, Penang, and the anchorage see the actual transaction IDs—the entire legal fiction collapses. Every single arrest warrant issued in the strait over the last three years becomes an act of statutory piracy."

Before Tan could answer, the ferry’s overhead fluorescent tube flickered and died.

The only light left in the cabin was the sickly green glow of the terminal and the tiny amber pilot light on the wall-mounted battery inverter.

From the companionway above, Jin Wei’s boots hit the steel steps in a hurried, uneven cadence.

"Lin! Tan!" Jin Wei reached the doorway, his chest heaving, his blue work shirt soaked to the skin. "The tactical skiffs aren't waiting for slack tide."

Lin looked up, her vision swimming with yellow floaters. "What are they doing?"

"They just deployed a tethered diving sledge from their support tender," Jin Wei said, his knuckles whitening as he gripped the doorframe for support. "They aren't aiming for the cooling intake anymore. They’re running a hydraulic cutting line directly along the harbor floor, straight for the turbine anchor catenaries. If they sever those power cables, the whole yard goes dark in ninety seconds."

CHAPTER 20

Chapter 20

The vibration traveled up through the ferry's steel keel, a dull, resonant grind that set the tea dregs dancing in Lin's dented mug.

"They're dragging the seabed," Jin Wei barked, his voice raw as iron filings. "Ballast control—now!"

Lin didn't argue. In the belly of the vessel, there was no room for economic models or legal philosophy. Her thumb found the manual release lever beside the flooded cofferdam. The brass handle was cold, slick with condensed salt sweat. She threw her weight against it, her boots skidding on the rusted diamond plating.

A pneumatically sealed valve shrieked open two decks below.

Twelve thousand gallons of seawater, held high in the ferry's starboard trimming tanks, dropped through the bottom scuppers in a violent, cascading purge. The surge struck the shallow harbor mud like an underwater landslide. Through the open companionway, the sound reached them: a muffled, hydraulic *thud* as the wall of displaced water smashed into the channel floor, tumbling the privateers' remote cutting sledge off its tracks and burying its carbide blades in deep silt.

The vibration ceased. The anchor catenary held.

Jin Wei slumped against the companionway bulkhead, his blue work shirt plastered to his ribs. Beneath the salt-stiffened cloth, his breath hitched—a wet, rattling catch that he masked by pressing his forearm hard against his sternum. Before the shipping consortium had revoked his master's ticket, he had spent his shore leaves in a quiet Pontianak garden tending moth orchids, misting their roots with rainwater from an enameled cup. Now, his hands smelled exclusively of stale diesel and bilge lye, the skin across his knuckles split into tiny red fissures that never quite closed.

"They'll clear the intake filters in two hours," Jin Wei wheezed, wiping a streak of engine grease from his cheek. "The tactical skiffs will circle the reef until the tide turns, then they'll drop another rig. We can't sit behind the sea gate. We have three grain lighters and two water barges trapped in the shallows. If we don't move them across the channel before midnight, the privateers will seize the crews under the admiralty lien."

"Who navigates them?" Lin asked, her fingers digging into her temples where a migraine throbbed behind her left eye. She had bitten the inside of her lip raw during the dive scare, and the sharp taste of copper lingered on her tongue. "The port authority has blacklisted every senior master in the basin. The

moment an old captain touches a helm, the harbor grid flags their biometric license and locks the steering thrusters."

"Then no captain takes the helm," a low voice said from the ladderwell.

Uncle Tan hauled himself up into the radio room, moving with the careful, deliberate stiffness of a man whose knees were swollen with fluid. Around his left wrist, he had bound a strip of faded green batik cloth—an old lighterman's trick to compress an inflamed tendon without a splint. In his other hand, he carried a heavy, hexagonal drum made of riveted marine brass, its cylindrical sides scuffed dull by decades of salt spray.

"The charter is clear, Lin," Tan murmured, resting the brass drum on the chart table. "Article Four. When operational command is frozen by legal sabotage, authority reverts to the assembly. We do not pick a hero. We draw the lot."

"Tan, the skiffs are out there," Jin Wei said, straightening up with an involuntary grimace as his lumbar spine ground bone on bone. "A single wrong heading through the south spit and thirty thousand bushels of rice end up under corporate impound."

"The lot does not care about the skiffs," Tan said simply. "And the sea does not care about licenses. Rouse the fifteen."

They convened in the hollowed-out lower hold of the grounded ferry *Pulau Tujuh*. The air was thick with the suffocating humidity of the Malacca Strait, ninety-eight percent relative moisture hanging trapped beneath corrugated iron and peeling red lead primer. The smell was ancient and immediate: bilge oil, wet hemp line, frying shallots from the shelter galley down the passageway, and the sharp, vinegar tang of lead-acid cells venting under load.

Fifteen upturned cable spools had been arranged in a tight, inward-facing circle on the bare deckplates—strict odd parity, as the charter demanded.

No dais. No microphone. Only the dull thrum of the tidal turbines vibrating through the hull, keeping the low-slung work lamps burning with a steady, yellow pulse.

The fifteen seated there were not politicians. They were the human residue of three collapsed regional shipping lines: a boiler-room wiper with chemical burns across his collar; a crane rigger whose spine was permanently curved from forty years of sling work; a cook from an arrested inter-island tramp; three young line-handlers from the Batam wet-docks; two river pilots whose small craft had been seized for unpaid canal dues. They sat with their forearms resting on their knees, shoulders hunched, watching the brass drum in the center of the circle.

Tan stepped forward. He did not deliver a speech. He reached into his pocket, pulled out an iron key, and unlatched the drum’s hinged inspection plate. Inside lay ninety-seven identical wooden tokens

turned from mangrove heartwood, each stamped with an identification notch corresponding to a registered deckhand, engineer, or lighterman currently sheltering in the yard.

"Operational mandate for shipping dispatch," Tan announced, his voice carrying clearly without amplification over the rhythmic slosh of the tide against the outer plates. "The dispatch leader holds sole tactical authority over the southern passage until dawn. Simple majority confirms. If rejected, the drum turns again."

Tan gave the brass crank three full revolutions. The wooden tokens clattered inside like dry seed pods.

He reached in without looking. His calloused fingers emerged holding a single mangrove disc. He squinted at the notched edge, then read the registry number stamped into the grain.

"Eighty-four," Tan said. "Kasim."

A sudden, sharp rustle ran through the circle. Heads turned toward the back row of spools.

A young deckhand sitting near the shadow of a web frame froze, a half-rolled clove cigarette pinched between his fingers.

Kasim was twenty-eight, though the harsh equatorial sun had already etched deep, crow-footed creases around his pale hazel eyes. He was missing the lower half of his left earlobe—torn away six years ago when a synthetic mooring line had parted under tension on a Singapore bunker barge—and his left ear remained half-deaf from the sonic crack of the snap-back. His hands, resting flat against his grease-stained work trousers, were broad and square, the fingernails permanently rimmed with black zinc compound that resisted every brand of pumice soap.

"Me?" Kasim’s voice was dry, cracking slightly on the vowel. He looked around the circle as if expecting someone to point out an obvious clerical error. "Uncle, I’m a deck hand. I grease fairleads and haul wire. I don’t draft passage plans."

"You know the south spit?" Jin Wei asked from the perimeter of the circle, his voice stripped of rank, flat and testing.

"I know it," Kasim muttered, his thumb tracing the frayed cuff of his sleeve. "Ran mud-scows through the mangrove channels during the sand embargo. But that’s manual steering. You’re talking about leading four loaded barges through an automated radar gate."

Across the circle, an older man with the clipped, graying mustache of a former deep-sea second mate leaned forward, his face hardening. "This is madness. Kasim doesn't know the optical mesh protocols. If the port marshal’s patrol launches close within three cables, they’ll run an active vector scan. A deckhand will panic and heave-to. We need an officer who understands admiralty arrest procedure."

"An officer with a certified ticket is a beacon on their scanners," Lin Zhang cut in from the shadow of the ladder, her voice sharp, cutting through the rising murmur. "The moment your signature hits the navigation network, their automated receivers execute the lien. Kasim has no ticket. To their surveillance algorithms, he is invisible—just another piece of ballast shifting in the hold."

"It isn't about paperwork," Kasim said suddenly.

The circle went quiet. Kasim had not stood up, but his posture had changed. The diffidence was gone, replaced by the hard, defensive economy of a man who had survived three sinkings in five years.

"The patrol launches don't watch the bottom," Kasim said, staring directly at the skeptical former mate. "They run on deep-draft bathymetry models sold by the Singapore hydrographic office. Those charts were surveyed four years ago. After the monsoon floods last November, the mud bank behind Pulau Semakau shifted two hundred meters north. If you follow an admiralty passage plan at half-ebb, your tug’s skeg hits the clay and stays there until the tide comes back. You want to run the rice barges tonight? You don't use the channel. You run them five yards off the mangrove roots, through the oyster beds, where the water’s three feet shallower than their patrol craft can draft."

He looked at his own scarred palms, then looked up at Tan.

"I can take them through," Kasim said softly. "But I don't use their harbor radio. I steer by the light of the kerosene torches on the fish stakes. If one of their tactical skiffs tries to box us in, I won't reverse engines. I'll put the barge into the soft mud and let their own wash swamp them."

Tan nodded once, then raised his right hand. "The lot has spoken. Confirm or return to the drum."

The silence in the hold lasted four heartbeats.

Then the crane rigger raised his thick, calloused palm. The wiper followed. The young line-handlers raised theirs without hesitation. Even the graying second mate, after a bitter, swallowing pause, lifted his hand into the dim light.

Twelve of fifteen. Qualified operational majority.

Tan picked up the mangrove token, dipped it into an open tin of red lead paint, and pressed it firmly onto the wooden dispatch board hanging from the ferry’s center stanchion. The scarlet ring gleamed wetly against the gray grain.

"The passage is yours, Kasim," Tan said. "Take the barges."

Kasim swallowed, stood up, and took the laminated channel chart Lin held out to him. His hands were steady now, entirely free of the tremor that had shaken him five minutes earlier.

Before he could reach the ladder, the high gantry optical relay above the drydock gave a sharp, mechanical groan.

The blue line-of-sight laser overhead didn't just flicker—it sheared completely off, its cyan glow snapping into darkness. From the outer pier, a young rigger dropped through the hatchway three steps at a time, his bare feet slapping wet against the steel treads.

"Kasim! Captain!" the boy gasped, clutching the hatch coaming to keep from falling. "The tactical skiffs didn't circle back to the anchorage! They've hooked a towline to an abandoned container hull outside the breakwater—they're pulling it across the channel mouth to choke the reef!"

Kasim didn't look back at Jin Wei. He rolled his chart into a tight cylinder, stepped past the boy, and threw open the weather door into the pelting monsoon rain.

CHAPTER 21

Chapter 21

The squall took the shipyard broadside. Rain hit the galvanized roof of Berth 8 with the dull roar of gravel tipped into an empty hopper, washing away the grease-sheen on the staging planks in foaming gray ribbons.

Kasim didn’t use the gangway. He vaulted the low gunwale of the shallow-draft work skiff, his bare feet slapping the ridged aluminum decking. Behind him came Lin, both arms clamped across a battered, foam-lined cooler of pediatric antivenom and refrigeration-dependent cephalosporins. Her knuckles were bloodless from the grip, her wet spectacles sliding down the bridge of her nose.

"Don't set it on the bare deck," Aisyah hissed from the stern, not looking up. She was already on her knees in bilge water, hauling soaked lengths of jute burlap out of a brine bucket. "The battery hull conducts. If the casing warms those vials by two degrees, the whole batch curdles before dawn."

Kasim caught the cooler by its nylon webbing, wedging it onto two split rubber tires lashed amidships. "Tide’s dropping four inches every ten minutes," he said, his voice flat, stripped of everything but the rhythm of the water. "If the Apex skiffs have jammed the container across the main gut, they think they've bottled the basin. They aren't looking at the stilt-creeks behind the fish traps."

"Not with binoculars, they aren't," Aisyah muttered. Her fingers, raw and peeling at the tips from old electrical flash burns, worked furiously around the rectangular battery bank nestled beneath the thwart. She was lashing blocks of dry, porous clay and wet swamp silt directly to the aluminum heat sinks. "Aegis-Omni’s thermal bird clears the horizon in nine minutes. If that pack radiates more than twenty degrees above the water temperature, we’ll show up on their terminal like a flare in an alley."

Lin dropped onto the thwart beside the cooler, her breathing shallow, rattled by the migraine behind her temples. The air smelled of rotting mangrove tannins, ozone, and the sour chemical bite of heated insulation. "Can we run dead silent?"

"No such thing as dead silent in three feet of water," Kasim said.

He cast off the bowline. The current caught the blunt nose immediately, slewing them out from beneath the shelter of the crane tracks into the churning black gut of the channel.

The mainland lights were already dying behind them, swallowed by the monsoon squall. Ahead lay the eastern lip of Pulau Semakau: a wall of tangled nipa palms and stilt-rooted red mangroves that looked, in the darkness, like an unbroken palisade of iron rebar.

Kasim took the tiller of the low-profile electric drive. He didn't engage the throttle to its stop. He nudged it forward until the propeller blades gave a low, dull hum through the bottom plating—a sound felt in the shins rather than heard. The skiff surged forward, hugging the shelving mudbank where the deeper patrol hulls dared not venture.

To their left, four cables out in the open shipping fairway, the scuttled container ship lay wedged at an angle across the reef channel. Even through the sheets of downpour, the red and green running lights of two Apex tactical skiffs were visible, idling against the rusted hull plates like predatory water beetles, their twin outboards muttering in low, rhythmic growls. They were waiting for anyone attempting to run the deep-water gate.

"Five minutes to overhead transit," Lin whispered, checking the mechanical pocket chronometer tied to her wrist with sailing twine. Her fingers twitched against her oilskin coat, a nervous tic left over from months in windowless logistics basements where the hum of cooling fans had measured out the hours of her life. "Once the sweep starts, it lasts three hundred seconds. If we're under the canopy by then, the foliage scatters the signature."

"If the prop doesn't bind," Aisyah said. She had her palm flat against the motor housing, monitoring its temperature by touch. The skin of her forearm was covered in goosebumps, shivering against the tepid rain. "The silt’s thick here. The cooling intake is drawing mud."

"Then blow it clear with the hand pump," Kasim replied without turning his head.

His eyes were locked on a faint, irregular break in the tree line—a notch where the brackish runoff of the high interior creeks cut a passage through the roots. As a boy, before the petrochemical berths had swallowed the coastline in corrugated steel and high-pressure bunkering pipes, he had set wire crab pots in these cuts with his uncle. Back then, the old man had warned him that the mud had an appetite: lose your way on a falling tide, and the swamp would suck the shoes off your feet and leave your boat perched high on stilt-roots like a crow’s nest.

The skiff slipped beneath the overhanging boughs.

Instantly, the roar of the squall softened, transformed into a continuous, heavy patter against the thick canopy of leaves. The temperature jumped three degrees; the air turned stagnant, thick with the sulfurous stench of anaerobic silt and decaying sea-grapes. The branches scraped against the aluminum gunwales with the screech of fingernails on chalkboard.

"Cut the power," Kasim commanded softly.

Aisyah pulled the mechanical disconnect pin. The hum of the motor died. The skiff slid forward on its own momentum, the hull brushing past thick, gnarled roots that dipped into the black water like spiders' legs.

"Satellite’s rising," Lin said. Her voice was barely a breath. "Bearing north-northwest. It’s sweeping the sector now."

Kasim leaned forward, reaching out with a bamboo setting pole he had pulled from the bilge. He braced the tip against the root of an old mangrove apple, checking their drift. The current here was counter-intuitive, split by the rising mud shoals into a dozen conflicting eddies that wanted to twist the skiff sideways and jam it broadside between two trunks.

Above them, through the gaps in the dripping leaves, the sky was a bruised, slate-colored purple. They couldn't see the satellite—hundreds of miles up in the cold vacuum, its cryogenic lenses mapping every heat differential on the strait's surface down to a fraction of an inch—but they felt it like an invisible weight pressing on the back of their necks.

Every hot wire, every friction point on the propeller shaft, every lungful of thirty-seven-degree air Lin exhaled was a beacon waiting to be indexed by an algorithmic queue in a temperature-controlled server vault in Jurong.

"Motor housing is spiking," Aisyah whispered. Panic tightened the edges of her words. She was feeling the aluminum fins beneath the burlap. "The mud jammed the cooling channel before we killed it. The heat sink is bleeding into the mount."

"Burlap," Kasim said, his teeth clenched as he fought the pole against the suction of the clay bed. "Douse it."

Lin didn't hesitate. She plunged both hands into the dark, foul water over the side, scooping up handfuls of cold river-bottom sludge, slapping it directly onto the top of the casing. The stench was sickening—ancient rot and iron rust—but the wet muck hissed softly, swallowing the escaping heat before it could bloom upward into the gap between the branches.

For forty seconds, no one moved. The only sound was the dripping of rain from Lin's chin onto the lid of the cooler, and the thick, wet sucking sound of the tide draining beneath their keel.

The hull gave a sudden, grinding shudder.

Kasim froze, his weight pressed into the pole. The skiff had stopped.

"We’re aground," Aisyah breathed.

"Not aground," Kasim said. He looked down over the low side. In the gloom, the dark form of a submerged tree trunk—a fallen nipah palm, long drowned and calcified by barnacles—lay wedged across the channel, six inches below the surface. The aluminum bow had ridden straight onto it, the weight of the battery pack pinning them down.

Lin checked the dial on her wrist. "Two minutes left in the transit window. If we thrash, the thermal sensors catch the water disturbance."

"We don't thrash," Kasim said. He laid the pole quietly across the thwarts. "We get out."

Without waiting for an answer, he swung his legs over the side. He sank instantly to his thighs in the thick, viscous mud, the cold muck filling his canvas trousers like lead shot. His feet slid on the slimy curve of the sunken log, searching for purchase among razor-sharp clusters of oyster shells.

Aisyah followed him on the starboard side, slipping into the black water with a sharp intake of breath as the shells tore through the knee of her work trousers.

Together, their shoulders braced against the aluminum bow plates, they pushed.

The mud fought them with terrifying mechanical leverage. It wasn't just friction; it was a vacuum, holding the flat bottom of the skiff like a rubber suction cup. Kasim’s breath tore through his nostrils in ragged, muffled gasps. His bad shoulder—stiffened by years of deck-winch strain—burned as if someone were driving a hot awl through the socket.

Beside him, Aisyah’s face was twisted in the dark, her neck cords standing out, her scarred fingers slipping against the wet metal.

"On three," Kasim hissed. "Lift. Don't push. Lift the nose."

Lin shifted her weight toward the stern, pulling the cooler against her belly to counter the balance, her eyes wide behind her rain-streaked lenses.

"One," Kasim grunted. "Two... heave."

They threw their spines into it. The bow rose an inch, two inches. The bottom scraped over the barnacled wood with a sound like tearing tin. The suction broke with a wet, hollow *thwip*, and the skiff shot forward into the deeper pool beyond the log.

Aisyah scrambled back over the gunwale, coughing up brackish water she had swallowed when her footing slipped. Kasim dragged himself up after her, his shins bleeding freely from shallow oyster cuts that stung with the sharp bite of sea salt.

Lin let out a long, trembling exhalation, tapping the crystal of her watch. "Window closed. The bird is over the Malacca approaches."

Kasim lay on the deck boards for three heartbeats, letting the cold rain wash the mud from his face. Then he sat up, wiping his eyes with the back of a bloody wrist.

"Aisyah. Clear the intake."

She nodded, her teeth chattering so hard she couldn't speak, and reached for the wire clearing rod under the seat.

Before her hand touched the tool, the darkness shattered.

Fifty yards behind them, back where the creek mouth opened into the bay, an engine revved—not the muffled growl of their electric drive, but the sharp, metallic scream of a twin-rotor interceptor skiff throttling up to plan speed. A blue halogen beam tore through the mangrove canopy, slicing between the gnarled branches like a broadsword, illuminating the rising steam of their own breath against the black leaves.

The patrol boat hadn't used the satellite.

It was drifting on a passive acoustic hydrophone, listening for the scrape of aluminum against drowned wood—and it had just found it.

CHAPTER 22

Chapter 22

The halogen blade sheared through the black leaves overhead, turning the drizzle into a curtain of falling needles.

"Down," Kasim rasped.

He didn't reach for a throttle. An engine rev would give their vector away to the hydrophone before the propeller could bite water. Instead, he shoved his calloused palm against the muddy bank, guiding the skiff's nose deeper into the tangle of stilt roots. The sharp, vinegary smell of disturbed mangrove peat rose around them, thick enough to choke on.

Behind them, the twin-rotor interceptor surged into the creek mouth, its heavy hull pushing a bow wave that sloshed violently against the mudflats. The wash rocked the small aluminum skiff, lifting it inches, then dropping it into the silt with a sickening suck.

Aisyah worked on her knees in the bilge, her knuckles bloody from the oyster beds, sliding the wire clearing rod into the waterjet intake. Her fingers, burned raw years ago by switchboard flashovers, lacked sensation at the tips; she had to feel the jammed mangrove twigs through the vibration in her wrists. She twisted the steel wire once, twice, until a knot of fibrous root broke free with a wet pop.

"Clear," she whispered, her voice barely carrying past her cracked lips.

The searchlight swept twenty paces to their port side, incinerating the dark. It pinned a cluster of drowning pneumatophores in stark, blinding silver. A voice boomed over a marine hailer—flat, compressed, stripped of humanity by algorithmic amplification: *Vessel in unchartered shallows, cut your drives and prepare to be boarded under Admiralty salvage writ.*

Kasim didn't move. A drop of blood crawled from his temple, tracking through the river mud crusted along his jawline. He reached into his coat and produced an unlit cigarette—stale, bent nearly in half from three days crushed behind his compass case—and placed the dry paper between his lips, chewing on the bitter tobacco without lighting it. It was an old habit from his early days on the night tugs, something to keep his jaw from clenching until his molars cracked.

"They're drawing five feet," Kasim breathed into Lin's ear. "We draw six inches. Hold the rail."

He dipped a single wooden sculling oar over the stern, feathering the blade so quietly that the dark water parted without a gurgle. He didn't fight the interceptor's wake; he rode it. As the backwash

bounced off the mangrove shelf, it carried them sideways through an archway of drowned roots into the deep dredged drainage flume of Drydock 4.

The searchlight wheeled away, scouring the empty mudbank where they had grounded three minutes before.

Ten minutes later, the aluminum hull bumped against the slime-slick timber fenders of Berth 9.

The Keppel-Batam yard smelled of wet iron, diesel residue, and the sweet, decaying ozone of the massive battery banks working under load. Rain drummed on the corrugated iron overhangs sixty feet above. Uncle Tan stood waiting on the pontoon, his woolen watch-cap pulled down over ears swollen with gout. He didn't ask questions. He merely caught their bowline, threw a turn around an iron cleat with hands that moved like knotted oak branches, and reached down to pull Lin onto the staging planks.

"Jin Wei is inside the plate shop," Tan said, his voice a low rumble under the drumming downpour. "The mortgage receivers just dropped an automated admiralty lien on the harbor master's beacon. They’re giving the fleet six hours to slip cables or be impounded for scrap."

Lin couldn't stop her knees from knocking together. The cold of the Malacca Strait had soaked through her waterproof shell, settling deep into her marrow. Her migraine throbbed behind her left eyeball like a hot nail being tapped with a ball-peen hammer. But under her arm, wrapped in double-waxed canvas and tucked against her ribs, was the air-gapped slate containing the legal architecture they had spent five weeks drafting across three time zones.

"Assemble the delegates," she said, her teeth clicking against the words. "Not the captains. The delegates."

The plate shop was cavernous, lit only by low-voltage orange floodlights strung between overhead crane rails. The floor was a patchwork of rusted steel plates, worn smooth by eighty years of boilerplate transport. One hundred and one men and women—an odd parity drawn by sortition from the sixty-four cargo trampers, feeder barges, and coastal tugs currently riding out the financial freeze in the roads—stood in a loose circle around an iron layout table.

There were no speeches. The mariners were tired. Their faces were gray from weeks of instant noodles and stale rainwater, their clothes stiff with grease and dried brine.

Captain Jin Wei stood by the edge of the layout table, his posture crooked, leaning his weight off his left hip to ease the degenerating discs in his lower spine. He watched Lin approach with eyes rimmed in red. On the table lay an open brass telegraph dial and an unrolled Admiralty chart of the Riau Archipelago, pinned flat with two rusted iron rivets.

Lin dropped the waxed canvas package onto the chart. It hit the wood with a heavy, wet slap.

"The receivers think you’re squatters," Lin began. Her voice was cracked, raw from the salt spray, but in the enclosed steel belly of the plate shop, it carried like a hammer on an anvil. "They think because

your owners folded their corporate shells in Monrovia and Majuro, your hulls are dead metal waiting for the cutting torch. They filed salvage claims under Singapore commercial jurisdiction."

A murmur moved through the circle. An older chief engineer from a bulk carrier spat into the drainage grate. "We have three days of flour left, Doctor. The bunker barge refused our credit cards this morning. They shut off the pipeline at the jetty."

"Because they are treating this anchorage as a private debt-recovery pen," Lin countered, pulling the slate from its wrapping. She keyed the manual rocker switch. A cyan schematic flickered to life, projected upward against the rusted flank of a suspended rudder stock. "This isn't a debt dispute anymore. This is a declared Commons of Refuge under the Law of the Sea."

Jin Wei leaned forward, squinting through the sulfurous glow. "The admiralty courts won't accept mutual aid as a defense against a valid maritime mortgage."

"They won't accept an excuse," Lin said. "They have to accept a sovereign humanitarian refuge. Under traditional sea law, an unflagged vessel in distress has an absolute right to seek shelter without seizure until life-safety is secured. We haven't just pooled our food; we've pooled the operational sovereignty of eighty-two hulls into an indivisible commons trust. The registry isn't tied to a flag state that can be bought by a hedge fund. It's tied to the physical coordination ledger of this shipyard."

She brought her scarred palms flat down on the layout table.

"Every kilowatt coming off the tidal turbines, every liter of fresh water from the reverse-osmosis skid, is logged as an immaterial public benefit under the Geneva sortition protocols. If they send armed private skiffs past the outer breakwater to seize these hulls, they aren't executing a repossession. Under international law, they are boarding an internationally declared humanitarian sanctuary during a systemic supply failure. The moment their private tactical teams cross the tidal sill, their corporate directors become personally liable for maritime piracy under universal jurisdiction."

Silence fell over the plate shop, broken only by the rhythmic *chug-thump* of the bilge pump down in Drydock 4.

A young deckhand, his forearms inked with crude home-needle swallows, shifted his weight. "That's paper, Doctor. Paper doesn't stop an interceptor skiff with twin outboards and twelve men in Kevlar."

"Paper won't," Jin Wei said quietly, his voice cutting through the damp air. He straightened his back, a grim, hard pride surfacing through his exhaustion. "The steel does. Aisyah, are the high-pressure monitors plumbed to the ballast mains?"

Aisyah stepped forward from the shadows, her dripping coveralls leaving a trail of dark circles on the rusted floor plates. "Two thousand five hundred gallons a minute at ten atmospheres. If they come within fifty meters of the dock gates, we don't shoot them. We swamp their cockpits and wash their electronics into the channel. They won't keep a boat upright in that wash."

"And the sortition assembly?" Lin turned to Uncle Tan.

The old man picked up the brass lottery drum from the floor, shaking it once. The ivory balls inside rattled with the dry sound of dice on slate. "One hundred and one members present. Quorum verified by physical mark."

"Then we don't ask for permission," Lin said, keying the final authorization on the slate with a thumb that trembled from cold. "We ratify the refuge charter. Seventy-five percent supermajority required. Raise your hands."

The vote wasn't sudden, nor was it unanimous in a burst of theatrical passion. It was slow, heavy, dragged out of men and women who had spent their entire working lives fearing the blacklists of the shipping syndicates. First Jin Wei's calloused hand went up. Then Aisyah's, her scarred fingers rigid. Then Tan. One by one, grease-stained arms lifted into the orange work-lights—engineers, cooks, second mates, ordinary seamen—until eighty-two hands stood rigid against the damp cavern of the shop.

Eighty-two out of one hundred and one.

"Seventy-five percent exceeded," Tan announced, his breath fogging in the chill. "The Keppel-Batam Commons is in effect."

Lin exhaled, her knees finally giving way. She caught the edge of the layout table, her fingernails digging into the rusted timber.

High above them, mounted on the 65-meter gantry crane tower, the cyan laser transceiver hummed to life. Bypassing the severed undersea cables and the jammed satellite links, the point-to-point beam sliced out across the dark waters of the Malacca Strait, locking onto the receiver tower on the Batam ridge, transmitting the cryptographic seal of the refuge treaty to the public ledger nodes in Geneva and Valparaíso.

Then, the high-voltage floodlights flickered twice and died.

Total, suffocating blackness dropped over the plate shop.

Outside in the harbor, the low, steady thrum of the tidal turbines cut out with a grinding metallic groan, replaced by the sudden, terrifying silence of an intentional grid drop.

Through the salt-encrusted windows facing the channel, Kasim pointed toward the breakwater.

A wall of red running lights—not two skiffs, but an entire salvage flotilla backed by an offshore ocean tug—had just crossed the outer buoy, running dark under complete electronic silence, their hydraulic winches already screaming as they dropped heavy steel dragging chains across the harbor entrance.

CHAPTER 23

Chapter 23

The vertical climb through sixty meters of rusted gantry lattice had drained the last reserve of heat from Jin's thighs. Every lumbar vertebrae ground together like ungreased iron as he hauled himself through the cab's bottom hatch, his shoulder catching the coaming with a dull thud. Rain caught them the instant Lin cleared the sill behind him, slamming the heavy iron hatch downward and dogging the dog-clamps until the rubber gasket hissed against the gale.

Outside, the monsoon struck the glass like a shovelful of wet gravel.

The cab hung suspended between the drowned concrete of Drydock 4 and the black churn of the Malacca Strait. Below them, Keppel-Batam was a sprawling labyrinth of silhouettes. The high-voltage yard floodlights remained dead, killed by the sudden grid drop. Across the dark floor of the plate shop, two amber hand-lanterns bobbed toward the battery bunkers where Rui and Aisyah were fighting to bring the salvaged hybrid tugboat cells online.

Out past the breakwater, the red running lights of the salvage flotilla were already cutting arcs through the whitecaps. The lead ocean tug had dropped its trailing gear; even through the howl of the squall, the scream of its heavy hydraulic drum reached the crane cab as a dull, bone-rattling vibration through the pylon legs. They were dragging steel riser chains across the channel mouth, a blunt mechanical snare to choke the yard's draft before the morning tide.

Lin leaned her forehead against the damp glass of the cab's southern pane. Her breath blossomed against the salt-crusted surface, instantly vanishing in the cabin's draft. She pulled a dented stainless thermos from the inner sling of her oilskin coat, her fingers trembling with the rhythmic twitch of severe nerve fatigue.

"Oolong," she said, her voice dry, stripped of its usual crisp authority. "Cold. Brewed before the dawn watch."

Jin took the cup she poured into the screw-cap lid. The tea was stone-cold, astringent and bitter on the back of his tongue, tasting of copper and old tin. It did nothing for the hollow ache in his ribs, but the ritual of holding something solid kept his thumbs from locking.

"They won't ram the caisson," Jin said, his voice a gravel rasp against the roar of the wind. He pointed a scarred index finger through the wiper arc. "Not in a eight-knot cross-swell. The salvage master wants the tidal turbine mounts. If they foul the subsea cables with those drag chains, the rotor

shafts will twist on their bedplates. Once the copper windings sheer, the whole basin loses base-load power for good."

Lin didn't answer immediately. She pressed the heels of her palms into her eye sockets, trying to crush the visual migraine flickering across her optic nerve—a jagged crown of blinding silver that had haunted her for forty-eight hours. "They aren't just salvors, Jin. Euro-Asian Maritime Finance bought the court-appointed receiver's debt note three hours ago in London. Aegis-Omni holds the secondary lien. This isn't an eviction. It's a calculated foreclosure on our legal refuge window."

Jin let out a short, wet cough, pulling an oil-stained rag from his collar to catch the phlegm. "A lien doesn't pull a four-inch link chain across a channel in a squall, Doctor. Men do. Men getting paid six hundred Singapore dollars a day by an agency in Tanjong Pagar, praying their own company housing doesn't get seized while they're at sea."

He turned away from the glass, sinking back onto the operator’s bench. The worn vinyl padding had split decades ago, spitting yellowed foam through duct tape seams. From his chest pocket, he pulled a small, smooth splinter of polished horn—a net-mending shuttle, barely the length of his thumb, notched at both ends with microscopic grooves worn smooth by nylon twine.

Lin lowered her hands, watching the tiny relic in his scarred grip. "What is that?"

"My mother carved it from a water buffalo rib," Jin murmured, his eyes distant, fixed on the horn rather than the storm. "Hainan, before the land-reclamation concrete covered the mangrove flats. She used to mend drift-nets by the kerosene burner while the tides turned. When the state syndicate consolidated the artisanal fleet into forty-meter trawlers, she gave it to me. Said if a man can weave a knot that holds against a running tide, he never has to beg a harbor master for work."

A harsh, self-deprecating smile touched the corner of his mouth. "Three weeks later, I signed my first contract as third wiper on a chemical tanker. Spent thirty years burning heavy bunker oil, poisoning the very shelf she fished. When the company went into restructuring off Colombo and dumped the crew without pay, I sold my sea chest, my watch, my certifications. Kept only this. A bone stick for catching fish that don't exist anymore."

He set the shuttle on the rusted steel console between them, beside the silent terminal of the cyan laser rig.

Lin looked at the piece of bone, then down at her own pale hands, the skin scrubbed raw around the cuticles where she had picked at them until they bled. A shudder passed through her shoulders—not from the draft leaking through the window frames, but from an older, colder draft.

"I built the ledger engine that flagged your tanker," she said softly.

Jin did not move. He kept his gaze locked on the red running lights moving across the outer basin.

"Five years ago," Lin continued, the words coming out flat, measured, stripped of defense. "At the logistics institute in Tianjin. We were designing the dynamic liquidity scoring for corporate receivers. We called it 'operational pruning.' If a vessel’s voyage margin fell below seven percent against the fuel index, the clearinghouse script automatically canceled the port bunkering credit and froze the crew escrow accounts. It took twelve milliseconds. No human eyes ever looked at the crew manifest. No one asked if the third wiper had enough fresh water to make harbor."

She leaned her back against the cab door, her knees pulling up toward her chest. "Two years later, my sister was running an independent pediatric clinic in the western suburbs. The municipal utility moved to an automated bond auction. Her clinic missed two algorithmic balancing payments during a regional drought. The water main was shut off by a remote telemetry valve on a Tuesday morning while three infants were in incubators. I sat at my terminal forty miles away, watching the load-shedding log tick green. I knew the code. I helped optimize the queue."

She swallowed, the sound loud against the roar of the rain on the cab roof. "I didn't quit out of noble principle, Jin. I quit because I realized I had spent my entire adult life forging the shackles, thinking if I made them precise enough, they wouldn't pinch."

A gust of wind caught the gantry, groaning through the steel box girders. The cab swayed three inches to the leeward side, the cables singing a shrill, harmonic note of strained tension.

On the console, the point-to-point cyan laser transceiver clicked violently. The small motorized gimbal hummed, fighting the violent sway of the tower to keep its optical lens aligned with the distant ridge across the strait in Batam. The green tracking LED sputtered, dropped to amber, then flashed an urgent, rhythmic crimson.

Optical link degraded: 14% line-of-sight clarity.

"Squall mist is scattering the beam," Lin said, instantly back on her feet, the somatic vulnerability vanishing beneath the sharp instincts of a technician under fire. She reached for the optical collimator dial, steadying her trembling wrist against the casing. "If we drop below ten percent, the cryptographic handshake with the offshore trust node will break. Geneva won't receive the ratified registry of the commons before dawn."

Jin stood beside her, his binoculars raised to the rain-lashed glass. The wiper arm thumped back and forth, clearing a half-moon of greasy clarity through the spray.

Below them, past the outer channel buoys, the lead salvage tug swung its stern toward the tidal turbine pens. But through the lenses, Jin saw something that made the muscles in his jaw turn to stone.

The tug wasn't deploying a standard salvage drag. Suspended from its heavy stern A-frame was a black, cylindrical apparatus, thick as a fuel pipe, fitted with four counter-rotating cutting blades and an umbilical bundle thick as an anchor hawser. It was a subsea directional trenching cutter—an industrial tool used to sever and bury pipeline conduits, not salvage hulls.

"They aren't trying to foul the rotors," Jin whispered, his voice cold. "They're cutting the granite moorings. They mean to set the tidal turbines adrift into the shipping lane. If those four-hundred-ton units drift into the separation scheme, international maritime safety law gives the coast guard full jurisdiction to board and clear the entire yard as a navigational hazard."

Lin froze, her fingers on the collimator. "How long until they reach the cable trench?"

"Ten minutes. Once they drop that cutter into the silt, the drag will pull the cables taut."

Then, from the dark shadow of the yard floor directly below their tower, a single, sharp flash of blue-white light pulsed upward through the squall.

It was not an arc from the battery banks. It was a handheld infrared signaling strobe, clicking in rapid, disciplined five-beat bursts from the open doorway of Berth 9—aimed directly at the bridge of the advancing ocean tug.

Someone inside the yard was guiding the cutter to the mooring coordinates.

CHAPTER 24

Chapter 24

The blue-white strobe below pulsed five times, sharp as a needle prick against the oily slick of Berth 9.

Jin did not shout. Shouting was wasted breath in the teeth of a Malacca squall. He slapped the brass intercom horn bolted to the crane cab's bulkhead.

"Berth Nine," he rasped, his voice tearing against the dry ache in his throat. "Doorway. Cut the signal."

Two floors down, in the dripping shadow of the gantry legs, two figures moved. Uncle Tan didn't run—his knees, swollen with fluid that flared whenever the barometric pressure plunged, would not allow it. Instead, he stepped out of the maintenance bay with a lead-weighted mooring line coiled over his forearm. Beside him, Aisyah moved with the flat, economical glide of a diver whose lungs were still adjusting to surface air. Her dive harness dripped sea water over her coveralls, her fingertips raw and peeling from six straight hours in the tidal pens.

Out in the black water, three hundred yards beyond the caisson gate, the salvage tug answered the signal.

Its heavy stern dipped as twin screws bit the incoming current. The subsea trenching cutter, suspended from the aft gantry like an iron carcass, swung into the surge. The hoist winch groaned—a low, mechanical shriek that vibrated through the shipyard's rusted pilings. The four counter-rotating blades were not turning yet, but their weight alone pulled the tug's stern low into the chop. If those teeth reached the channel bottom, sixty feet down in the silt, the armored power umbilical anchoring Node 4 to the seabed would be severed in a single dragging sweep.

"Winch cable at thirty meters," Lin said. Her voice had dropped to a brittle monotone, the flat register she used when her migraine threatened to split her skull behind her left eye. She didn't look at the water. Her hands were clamped onto the optical transceiver's azimuth collar, fighting the violent sway of the tower as a sixty-knot gust hit the crane structure.

The glass lens of the receiver was fogging. Tropical humidity was creeping past the rubber gaskets, blooming into milky halos across the cyan collimator.

"Link clarity down to eight percent," she whispered. Her thumb rubbed obsessively against the knuckle of her forefinger—a nervous habit developed during her postgraduate years in air-gapped server

vaults, feeling for skin breaks to keep herself anchored against panic. "The packet buffer is dumping. If the alignment slips another millimeter, Batam drops offline. The ledger locks."

"Rui!" Jin barked into the brass horn. "The flood pumps!"

Down on the fitting pier, Chen Rui didn't answer with words. He threw his weight against the manual bypass spindle of Berth 8’s high-pressure dewatering monitor. The steel wheel bit into the palms of his hands, inflaming the tendonitis that ran like hot wire from his wrists to his elbows. He braced his hip against the riser pipe and kicked the mechanical release pawl.

A deafening hiss swallowed the roar of the rain.

Two thousand gallons of seawater per minute erupted from the monitor’s brass nozzle, transformed into a wall of pressurized white spray that hammered across the narrow cut toward the tug’s stern. It wasn't artillery; it didn't pierce the steel hull. But the sheer volume of water slammed into the tug’s working deck like a solid wall, swamping the aft deckhands and blinding the wheelhouse windows with sheets of foaming churn. The tug’s stern swung wildly off its bearing, caught between the hydraulic shove of the monitor and the four-knot rip of the falling tide.

Inside Berth 9, the blue-white strobe flickered, stuttered, and died.

Aisyah had closed the distance without a sound. When the silhouette in the doorway turned to bolt toward the scrap piles, she didn't tackle him. She simply jammed a heavy wooden wedge under the steel roller shutter and yanked the emergency pull-chain. The iron curtain fell like a guillotine, sealing the exit. Uncle Tan stepped into the dim light of the auxiliary lanterns, his breathing heavy, his oilskin coat dripping.

The man cornered against the tool cage was not a private security contractor in tactical nylon.

He was an assistant machinist from the dawn shift—a kid barely twenty, his face white under engine grease, holding a pocket-sized industrial alignment lamp. His hands shook so violently the lamp clattered against the corrugated iron siding.

"My sister," the boy choked out, his voice cracking on the syllable. He held up a soaked slip of thermal paper, limp as seaweed. "The maritime clearinghouse in Johor. They flagged her identity registry. Locked her insulin credit at the district depot because I was logged on this dock’s muster sheet. They sent the notice to my handset an hour ago. They said if I gave the cutter the trench line, they’d clear her ledger by midnight."

Tan stared at the kid. The old mariner’s hands, gnarled and stiffened by five decades of salt spray and rusted cable, slowly unwrapped the lead-weighted line from his arm. He didn't raise his voice. He didn't look for a weapon. He took the thermal slip from the boy’s shaking fingers, crumpled it, and shoved it deep into his own pocket.

"You pump grease on Berth Seven," Tan said softly, every word heavy with the fatigue of a man who had seen four flags change over this strait. "The boy who works the grease pump doesn't sell the ground his brothers stand on. Sit on that crate. Keep your mouth shut. When the sun comes up, we convene the three-man panel. Not before."

He locked the cage latch with a mechanical pin, turned his back, and keyed his radio twice.

"Berth Nine secured," Tan reported. "The signal is gone."

Up in the crane cab, the victory lasted less than three seconds.

"The tug is falling back on its secondary tow line," Jin said, his binoculars locked on the foaming wash. "They don't need the ground strobe. They've already got the trench depth on their depth-sounder. The cutter is ten feet off the bottom."

"The laser is dead," Lin said. Her voice was barely a breath.

On the transceiver console, the tracking light went from flickering amber to cold, dead dark. The rain had turned into a solid curtain of vertical water, scattering the cyan beam into useless refraction across the strait. On the monitor, the block-synchronization counter froze. Four thousand mutual transactions from the archipelagic fishing fleets, waiting for ratification by the Swiss node, hung suspended in volatile memory.

"We lost line-of-sight," Lin said, her hands dropping from the collar. The cold realization hollowed her cheeks. "Without the optical bridge, we're an island. In twelve minutes, the automated registry protocols will declare Node 4 unverified. Aegis takes default receivership of the yard under the emergency salvage charter."

Jin lowered his glasses. His back throbbed with a dull, sickening grind where the lower vertebrae rubbed raw. He reached out and tapped the brass frame of the cab's storm compass three times—an unconscious rhythm learned forty years ago on a coal-fired lighter off the Natuna shoals.

"Look east," he said.

Lin didn't move. "Jin, the physics don't care about—"

"Look east, Doctor."

Through the salt-streaked glass, past the outer channel markers where the commercial shipping lane carved its deep highway through the strait, dark silhouettes were emerging from the squall.

They were not tactical patrol vessels. They were too broad, too low in the water, their superstructures caked in the rust of secondary feeder routes and third-tier registry ports. A three-thousand-ton modular container carrier, its deck stacked three-high with weathered red and blue steel boxes. Behind it, a low-slung bulk barge pushed by a twin-screw river tug. Then another. And a fourth.

Nine vessels in loose, staggered line-abreast, cutting directly across the inward-bound lane of the Singapore Strait traffic separation scheme.

"They're off-course," Lin whispered, squinting through the wiper blade’s arc. "They’re running straight into the shallows. Why haven't port control scrambled the harbor launches?"

"Because port control can't see them," Jin said. A thin, grim smile touched the corner of his cracked lips.

On the cab's marine radar repeater, the sea lanes ahead of the yard were blank. Every single one of the approaching vessels had cut its satellite transponder. Their automated identification transmitters were cold. To the automated vessel tracking algorithms in the high-rise tower on the mainland, the nine ships simply did not exist; they were ghost clutter, lost in the heavy sea-clutter returns of the tropical storm.

Then, from the monkey island atop the lead feeder ship's bridge, a needle of brilliant blue light punched through the rain.

It was an optical transceiver, jury-rigged to the radar mast.

A second needle flashed from the tug behind it. Then a third, firing cyan and infrared pulses in a tight, multi-point web across the water. The lead vessel didn't stop in the channel; it swung its blunt bow directly between the advancing salvage tug and the tidal turbine pens, placing sixty thousand tons of displacement and floating steel like an immovable granite wall over the subsea cable trench.

The salvage tug’s siren sounded—a single, desperate blast of reverse propulsion as its captain realized what was bearing down on him through the sheets of monsoon spray. The trenching cutter's hoist cable went slack as the tug threw its engines full astern to keep from being ground into kindling against the feeder’s massive bulbous bow.

Up on the crane gantry, Lin’s console didn't just flicker. It ignited.

The light cascading through the cab wasn't a single beam. It was a mesh. The nine independent freighters, chained together by line-of-sight laser transceivers spaced only four hundred yards apart, had cut straight through the squall’s optical attenuation. What a single six-mile beam across the open strait could not pierce, nine short-hop relays punched through with blinding, luminous clarity.

The tracking LED on the bulkhead flared to an unyielding, steady green.

Incoming synchronization stream: 100% link continuity.

The block counter began to spin, numbers cascading down the screen faster than human eyes could track, locking the mutual registries of ninety-four independent ports into the distributed trust ledger before the salvage tug's master could even reach for his emergency radio.

Jin stepped back from the window, his breath coming slow and ragged in the close heat of the crane cab. He reached down and clicked the yard-wide intercom off.

Out in the strait, three more low whistles sounded through the rain—unregistered, unmonitored, and completely sovereign. The counter-siege was no longer holding the dock.

It held the water.

Chapter 25

The rain hammered the reinforced glass of the gantry cab in rhythmic, deafening sheets, but the steady cyan line held. Out across the churning chop of the strait, the relay of nine merchant hulls remained pinned in place, an ad-hoc breakwater of rusting iron and stubborn mass shielding the subsea trench.

Then, five miles north, the mainland died.

It did not dim. It was not the gradual brownout of a strained transformer bank. In a single, absolute heartbeat, the glittering curtain of high-rise towers, automated container cranes, and coastal refineries along the littoral rim snapped into total blackness.

Inside the gantry cab, the sudden void was so vast it felt like a physical pressure drop. The horizon simply ceased to exist, swallowed whole by the tropical squall.

Jin Wei pressed two fingers against the hollow of his collarbone, where the old chemical scar throbbed against the humid heat. He shifted a dried clove from one side of his jaw to the other—a habit picked up forty years ago shoveling raw bituminous coal in the unventilated holds of river lighters, the sharp, bitter oil the only thing that kept the stomach from turning inside out when the bilge water rose.

"They dropped the mainland feeders," Lin said. Her voice was flat, raspy with exhaustion. The blue terminal glow reflected off the dark circles beneath her eyes, where days of broken sleep had etched deep, gray bruises into the skin. "Not a system fault. They tripped the high-voltage interties at the regional switching station. Deliberate sector isolation."

"They're suffocating the shore," Uncle Tan murmured from the steel hatchway. He stood with both hands resting on the handrail, rubbing camphor oil into the swollen knuckles of his right hand with his thumb. The sharp scent of wintergreen and menthol cut through the cab's heavy stink of damp wool and ozone. "They couldn't cut our optical trunk, so they are starving the villages to make an example."

Across the mudflats and mangrove estuaries flanking the naval channel lay thirty stilt *kampungs*—communities of drift-net fishermen, crab farmers, and repair dockers who lived on the margins of the shipping lanes. The corporate grid had always treated them as an afterthought, charging triple the commercial tariff through prepaid smart meters. Now, with the regional circuit open, their small world had plunged into dark water.

"The nursery aerators," Aisyah said, stepping into the cab. She peeled off her neoprene diving hood, her dark hair plastered to her skull with brine and sweat. Her thumb grazed the white, calloused ridge

on her index finger—an old arc-flash burn from a shore-power junction box that had never healed smooth. "Tanjung Uma has twelve hundred tons of tiger grouper fry in the nursery basins. Without oxygenation pumps, the fingerlings drown in the silt within forty minutes."

"And the clinic at Teluk Sengat," Rui added without looking up from the structural stress monitor. His forearms were wrapped in tight elastic braces to ease the tendonitis flared by forty-eight hours at the manual helm. "Their cold-chain refrigerator runs on the coastal spur. If the insulin spoils, three hundred people are stranded until the monsoon breaks."

Jin looked out into the rain. The consortium’s calculation was bone-chillingly simple and utterly rational from a ledger sheet: by severing the entire coastal periphery, they created a humanitarian crisis on the node's doorstep. Either the independent dockers would abandon their sovereign mesh to salvage their families' livelihoods, or the fishing villages would turn against the shipyard in sheer, desperate panic.

"We have the tidal surge," Jin said. His voice was low, gravelly from bunker vapor. "What is our storage state?"

"The tug battery banks are sitting near full capacity," Rui said, tapping a mechanical indicator dial on the bulkhead. The brass needle trembled just below the red line. "The twin turbines in the deep channel are biting hard into the four-knot ebb. But our step-up transformers weren't built to backfeed the entire southern district. If we tie into the regional trunk, we bleed our own operational margin. If the private security skiffs return, we won't have the current to power the seawater monitors or swing the container drop-blocks."

"We call the panel," Uncle Tan said softly. "We don't make this choice in the dark."

The neighborhood sortition council assembled twelve minutes later on the covered deck of Berth 8, huddled beneath the overhang of an overturned barge to escape the driving rain. Fifteen souls, chosen by the brass lottery drum at dawn: five deckhands, four net-menders, three shore mechanics, two night-shift cooks, and an unlicensed diesel fitter from the reclamation fleet.

There was no rostrum. No microphone. Only the deafening roar of rainwater pouring off the barge's corrugated iron roof into the dock basin.

Aisyah laid the line schematic flat on a wooden cable drum, weighing down the corners with rusted coupling nuts. "The consortium's automated substation on the jetty is locked down from the mainland. We can't access their distribution controls. But the old rural spur—the heavy copper line that supplied the decommissioned cold-storage plant twenty years ago—still ties directly into our transformer bank."

"It's corroded," the diesel fitter said, wiping rain from his chin with a calloused forearm. "The insulation on those mangrove poles has taken twenty monsoons of salt spray. We run full current down that line, we lose a fifth of it to heat and leakage before it even reaches the first village."

"Then we push through the leakage," Uncle Tan said. He looked at the fifteen faces around the drum. "If we hoard the battery banks to keep our searchlights bright, we are just another warlord's bunker sitting in the swamp. If the fish die tonight, the villages starve next month. Then what are we defending?"

The vote took less than two minutes. No speeches. No rhetoric. Fifteen hands lifted into the humid, salty air. Unanimous.

"Aisyah, Rui—take the breaker crew," Jin ordered, his voice cutting through the drumming downpour. "Manual engagement. Keep the fire hoses pressurized on the cooling jackets. If the transformer core begins to whistle, you trip it manually. We don't burn the yard to warm the coast."

They moved with the grim, hurried efficiency of people who had spent their lives around dangerous machinery. On the lower machinery deck beneath Drydock 4, the air was thick with the heat of the massive marine battery modules. Twelve tons of lithium-iron cells, salvaged from the guts of dead hybrid tugs, rested in welded steel cradles, their thick, copper busbars sweating condensation in the swampy humidity.

Aisyah stood before the primary intertie cabinet, an insulated fiberglass rod gripped tightly in her calloused hands. Beside her, Rui checked the manual override levers on the oil-cooled step-up transformer.

"The line impedance is going to kick back like a mule," Rui warned, his hand poised over the mechanical trip latch. "The moment we bridge into the rural spur, the magnetic drag on the tidal turbines is going to double."

"Let it bite," Aisyah said through gritted teeth.

She slammed the heavy fiberglass hook into the overhead disconnect switch and pulled down with her entire body weight.

A crack like a dry timber snapping echoed through the vault. A blinding violet arc spat across the contacts, illuminating the wet concrete walls in stark, violent relief. The smell of scorched air and transformer oil washed over them in a suffocating wave.

Deep beneath the drydock floor, the subsea cable began to hum. It was not a mechanical rattle, but a deep, vibrating resonance that rose through the soles of their boots—a sound felt in the teeth and the marrow of the bone. Out in the black depths of the channel, the massive twin tidal turbines met the staggering electrical load of thirty coastal settlements. The steel mooring chains groaned, tightening like violin strings against the four-knot current as the water fought to spin the loaded blades.

In the gantry cab high above, Jin held his breath.

For five agonizing seconds, the coastline remained an unbroken void of ink and rain.

Then, across the mangrove flats of Teluk Sengat, two miles out, a cluster of yellow sodium lamps flickered, died, and flared back to brilliant, steady life.

A cheer, thin and distant against the roar of the squall, carried across the water.

Half a mile further south, along the stilt platforms of Kampung Pasir Putih, another knot of lights broke through the darkness. Then another. And another. Like a string of pearls catching fire in the storm, the thirty villages ignited along the littoral fringe. Out in the shallow estuaries, the water erupted into white spray as thousands of paddlewheel aerators ground into motion, churning life-giving oxygen into the suffocating nursery ponds.

The cold-chain chillers at the clinic hummed. The harbor beacons along the fishing slips turned green.

Jin leaned his forehead against the damp glass of the cab, the dried clove resting bitter against his tongue, his chest loosening for the first time in eighteen hours.

Then, the collision-warning alarm on the gantry console let out a single, piercing shriek.

Lin's hands flew across the optical terminal. "Jin," she said, her voice dropping into a razor-thin whisper. "Look at the channel mouth."

Jin raised his binoculars into the rain.

Three black-hulled tactical interceptors, running entirely dark with their automated identification systems killed and their radar profiles minimized beneath wave-skimming hydrofoils, had just rounded the southern spit. They weren't heading for the merchant blockade.

They were running at thirty-five knots straight toward the unshielded shore riser where Node 4’s rural power spur entered the mangrove mudflats.

Chapter 26

The hydrofoils carved through the black swells like paired scalpels, leaving twin scars of phosphorescent foam that died against the mangrove roots. Through the rain-slicked lenses of his binoculars, Jin saw the low, matte-carbon geometry of the lead hull: an Apex Marine fast-interception skiff, stripped of running lights, riding high on its automated trim tabs. Behind it came two more, running in tight echelon, their twin supercharged outboards emitting only a muffled, rhythmic thrum that vibrated the salt-crusted glass of the crane cab.

"Three minutes to the mudflat riser," Lin said. Her voice was flat, dried out by thirty straight hours of stale air and the harsh phosphorescence of the optical terminal. She did not look up from the display. With her left hand, she pressed two fingers hard against the bridge of her nose—a habitual reflex whenever the retinal flare of the beam-tracking lasers brought on the stabbing ache behind her right temple. "They aren't pinging the commercial channel. Their forward arrays are locked on the thermal plume from the cooling manifold."

"They know exactly where the bronze busbars meet the mud," Jin rasped. A raw, wet fit of coughing caught him, rattling deep in his sternum, a parting gift from thirty years of inhaling heavy fuel oil mist in the bilge spaces of bulk carriers. He spat a bitter trace of clove into his palm, wiped his mouth on his oilskin sleeve, and hauled back on the crane’s traverse lever. "Chen. Aisyah. Are the manual bypass gates dogged down?"

The sound-powered telephone mounted to the cab bulkhead buzzed—a dry, mechanical chirp powered solely by the speaker's vocal diaphragm, impervious to the signal-dampers the approaching gunboats undoubtedly carried.

"Dogged and pinned," Aisyah’s voice crackled through the brass earpiece, breathless and edged with grit. Down on the tidal pontoon at Berth 9, sixty feet below, water was already lapping over her boots. A stray wire from the afternoon's high-voltage splice had flayed the calluses across her thumb and forefinger, the raw skin now white and puckered from seawater, but her grip on the iron spanner did not slacken. "Pumps two and four are drawing twelve hundred amps off the turbine bank. The lines are shuddering, Captain. If we open the valves wide, the backpressure will shake the deck-plates out of their welds."

"Let them shake," Jin said. "Chen Rui, what’s the head pressure?"

Across the pontoon, Chen Rui knelt in the torrential downpour, his forearms locked tight against the vibration of the four-inch distribution manifold. The tendonitis in his wrists burned like dipped acid, an

old injury from his years lofting frames in the drydocks of Dalian, reawakened by six hours of torquing rusted municipal flanges. "One hundred and forty pounds per square inch," Chen shouted into the brass horn, water cascading off the brim of his hardhat into his collar. "If we trip the main monitor now, we strip the seals on the cooling jacket!"

"Hold until their bows lift," Jin ordered. "They’re running hydrofoils in five fathoms of water. They need their optical track to stay off the sandbars."

Out in the black water of the channel, Commander Marcus Vance stood braced behind the armored windscreen of the lead interceptor, the *Apex Hunter*. His hands, clad in textured neoprene, rested lightly on the fly-by-wire helm. Vance did not hate the dockers or the fishermen whose lights had just flared along the mangrove fringe. He viewed them with the grim, detached pity a civil engineer might feel for squatters building shacks inside a spillway. The global supply chain through the Singapore Strait was an arterial pump moving twenty percent of world trade; it could not tolerate an unmonitored sovereign blind spot powered by pirated subsea turbines. If the local grid took root, the clearinghouses in Zurich and Tokyo would reclassify the entire south passage as contested waters, tripling insurance premiums and stranding grain shipments in the roads.

"Target riser locked," his weapons officer murmured, eyes fixed on the thermal screen. "Forty meters off the port point. Two pneumatic grapnels ready. One high-velocity diamond-wire cutting charge."

"Take the riser clean at the mudline," Vance said, his voice measured, perfectly modulated by years of naval service. "Disable the junction box. No kinetic rounds on the pontoon. We aren't here to give the admiralty court a pile of martyrs. Drop the grid, secure the cable head, let the morning tide flood the trench."

The *Hunter* banked into the river mouth, its foils slicing through the surface chop at thirty-four knots. The bow rose, throwing two great wings of white spray that caught the ambient glare of the distant coastal lights.

High above, in the crane cab, Jin Wei let the breath out of his teeth. Decades at sea had taught him the exact weight of displacement; he knew the feel of a hull fighting the drag of shallow water, the precise instant when speed outran buoyancy.

"Aisyah," Jin whispered into the horn. "Open the river."

Down on the pontoon, Aisyah threw her full weight against the long-handled bronze butterfly valve. Chen Rui lunged beside her, his good shoulder slamming into the cast-iron wheel of the secondary bypass. Metal shrieked on metal. A slug of trapped air hammered through the five-hundred-meter run of salvaged dredge pipe, a sound like a naval gun discharging underground.

From the sunken concrete lip of the drydock sill, four industrial firefighting monitors—reclaimed from an obsolete liquefied gas carrier and fed directly by the roaring surplus of the deep-channel turbines—erupted into the dark.

Ten thousand gallons of seawater per minute hurled upward in a solid, terrifying arc, crashing together sixty feet above the mangrove flats. It was not a spray; it was a localized deluge, an impenetrable mechanical cataract that slammed down into the path of the advancing skiffs. The water did not merely fall—it atomized against the high-velocity discharge from the turbine's cooling loops, creating a blinding, super-dense fog bank laced with boiling brine and thick, churning mist.

Inside the cockpit of the *Apex Hunter*, the thermal imaging array instantly whited out.

"Laser scatter!" the technician shouted, tearing his goggles away as the return beam from the lidar rangefinder bounced off billions of suspended saltwater droplets, blinding the sensor suite in a wash of incandescent green noise. "We lost the bottom profile! Depth sounder is echoing off the spray!"

"Manual steer!" Vance barked, his calm cracking for the first fraction of a second as the physical world reasserted itself over the instruments. He threw his weight against the helm, trying to haul the skiff to starboard, away from the roaring curtain of water.

It was three seconds too late.

The *Hunter* punched into the edge of the water curtain at thirty knots. The sheer kinetic mass of the downpour struck the carbon-fiber deckhouse like gravel dumped from a hopper. The engine air intakes gulped atomized brine, sputtered, and choked as the oxygen sensors panicked. Deprived of lift, the port hydrofoil plowed into the crest of an outgoing tidal rip. The foil caught the submerged crest of a shifting mudbank, twisted along its sheer pins, and snapped with a sharp, sickening crack that shuddered through Vance's boots.

The skiff slewed violently forty-five degrees to port, burying its snout into the soft, unyielding mangrove silt. The two trailing interceptors, their forward thermal screens equally blinded by the wall of churning salt fog, broke formation in wild, desperate maneuvers, their throttles howling as they reversed pitch to avoid t-boning their commander's wallowing stern.

Down on the pontoon, the cold spray rained back down over Aisyah and Chen Rui, soaking them to the marrow. The iron valve wheel was vibrating so hard under Chen's palms that the numbness traveled all the way to his collarbone, but he kept his boots wedged against the riser frame, refusing to yield an inch of pressure.

"First bird is grounded," Lin called down through the horn, her gaze locked on the optical transceiver's real-time silhouette tracking. "The other two have backed off into the deep gutter. They're circling three hundred yards out."

In the crane cab, Jin did not cheer. His hands remained resting on the cold levers, the wind-driven rain leaking through the cab's cracked rubber weatherstripping and dripping steadily onto his knuckles. His left knee, worn flat by forty years of ladder-wells, throbbed with a dull, rhythmic ache that mirrored the thrum of the turbines below.

He leaned forward, wiping a clean circle on the misted windshield with the heel of his hand.

Out in the churn of the channel, just beyond the edge of the roaring water curtain, the second skiff had killed its outboards. It wasn't retreating.

Mounted on its foredeck, a low, pneumatic canister hissed. A dark, spider-like tethered crawler, fitted with magnetic tracked treads and twin articulated grapple arms, dropped into the waist-deep surf of the mudflat. It was below the reach of the fire monitors, crawling along the sea floor, its internal gyro humming as it ground steadily forward toward the unshielded power riser.

Chapter 27

The silt churned black in the shallows where the water monitors could not reach.

Chen Rui tasted old iron and salt. The spray driving off the drydock pontoon carried the stench of decayed mangrove peat and churned bunker residue. Thirty feet out in the gray chop, just beneath the surface scum, a twin track of frothing bubbles crawled steadily toward the submerged tidal power riser.

"Umbilical!" Chen screamed into the wind, the sound torn from his mouth before it could travel ten paces. He hooked his elbow through the safety stanchion to keep from skittering across the algae-greased plating. "The crawler is tracking the casing!"

Aisyah binti Rahman was already moving. She did not waste breath shouting back. Her dive booties found purchase on the rusted diamond-tread of the pontoon deck, her center of gravity low, thighs burning from sixteen hours of salt-water diving. There were no small arms on the pontoon; the yard's defense covenant barred firearms from the berths. What she had was a three-pronged salvage grapnel hooked to a spool of three-quarter-inch galvanized steel cable, its tines pitted and scarred from years of dredging fouled mooring chains out of the fairway.

High above them, sixty-five meters up in the drafty glass perch of the gantry cab, Captain Jin Wei leaned his forehead against the vibrating window. Every shudder of the auxiliary hoist sent a dull, familiar jolt through the lower three vertebrae of his spine—a chronic, grinding ache earned across four decades of standing watch on vibrating engine room deckplates. Through the misted glass, the crawler looked like a flattened iron beetle dragging a thick umbilical of hydraulic line and high-voltage feed through the mud.

Out in the deep gutter of the channel, beyond the thrashing curtain of the fire monitors, the second tactical skiff wallowed with its throttles idling. Vance had stationed his craft right at the drop-off, feeding the tether off a snub-nosed deck drum. His men were not pirates; they were maritime enforcement contractors working off a court-sanctioned admiralty impound order, moving with mechanical, disciplined precision. If that submerged crawler clamped its magnetic jaws onto the yard's main bus conduit, the cutting charge inside its belly would sever Node 4's power supply before the ledger could broadcast past the island chain.

"Line's three yards off the riser collar!" Chen bellowed up toward the cab, his voice cracked from bunker smoke and raw salt air.

Jin’s calloused thumb hovered over the master hoist lever. He did not pull it. Dropping the crane’s salvage block into the shallows blindly would risk crushing their own tidal feed line. "Hold your ground, Chen!" Jin’s voice rattled down through the brass acoustic horn mounted to the pontoon frame. "Wait for the turn!"

At the very summit of the gantry tower, exposed to the full fury of the squall, Dr. Lin Zhang felt neither the height nor the rain. A sharp, rhythmic migraine pounded behind her right eye—the familiar, sickening pressure brought on by forty-eight hours of stare-down with terminal screens and cold coffee. Her fingers, stripped of her oilcloth mittens so she could work the thumbwheels, were numb, white at the nails, and slick with freezing rainwater.

The optical transceiver assembly was shuddering inside its gimbal mount. Clamped to the handrail beside her, the small field diagnostic unit showed an optical carrier attenuation jumping erratically: sixty-four percent, seventy-two percent, eighty-one percent. The monsoon downpour was acting like an endless sheet of frosted glass, each suspended droplet fracturing the cyan laser into useless halos of scattered light.

She did not seek solace in memory. She did not whisper a prayer. Her competence had not been handed down by ancestors; it had been hammered into her through three grueling post-doctoral winters in the unheated basement laboratories of the Shanghai Marine Institute. She knew the physical perversity of salt-pitted brass. She knew that on a salvage mount exposed to tropical humidity, the vernier lead screw suffered four full degrees of dead slack on the clockwise throw before the worm gear finally bit into the elevation teeth.

Take up the lash, she told herself, teeth chattering so hard they ached in her jaw. *Feel the thread.*

She cradled the knurled collar with her palm, bracing her wrist against the transceiver frame. Her thumb dialed the micrometer drum counter-clockwise to clear the salt crust, then rolled it back three millimeters until she felt the hard, mechanical bite of metal against metal.

A tiny green diode on the housing flickered. Attenuation dropped to fifty-one percent. The carrier locked.

"Lin!" Jin’s voice boomed through the acoustic line from the cab below. "The bottom crawler is five feet from the flange! I cannot hold the drop clear of our own conduit!"

Lin did not answer. Dialogue under tension was wasted lung capacity. She leaned into the eyepiece of the optical sight, her cheek resting against the cold, anodized aluminum tube. Through the crosshairs, five miles out across the churning, black-and-silver expanse of the Singapore Strait, the silhouette of the sister transceiver atop the decommissioned grain silo at Batam was an indistinguishable smudge behind the sheets of rain. Beyond it, tracking silently across the low horizon, was an open-access environmental monitoring satellite, its polar orbit passing directly through their narrow transmission window.

They had ninety seconds before the orbital arc dipped below the line of the southern islands.

Down on the pontoon, Aisyah swung the heavy salvage grapnel twice, using the momentum of her shoulders, her boots planted wide on the slick steel. Chen Rui threw his full weight against the friction brake of the manual winch, his forearm tendons bulging against his skin with a vicious, fiery cramp.

"Drop it!" Chen yelled.

Aisyah released the sling. The three-pronged iron head flew ten feet outward, punching through the muddy froth of the shallows. It sank instantly into the mangrove silt.

"Reel!" she gasped, dropping to her knees on the pontoon deck, grabbing the winch handle beside Chen.

Both of them leaned in, their chests heaving in ragged, simultaneous bursts. The bronze pawls clattered furiously—*clack-clack-clack-clack*—as the drum took up the slack. The steel cable came out of the surf dripping gray slime, slicing through the brown foam until the tines snagged something hard and unyielding.

The winch violently kicked back. The steel handle struck Chen across the wrist with a hollow crack that drove the air from his lungs, but he dropped his hip against the spoke, locking it with his ribs.

Out in the mud, thirty feet off the pontoon, the water erupted. The crawler’s rubber-jacketed control umbilical pulled taut as an iron rod, hauled sideways out of the mud by the grapnel's tines. The crawler slewed violently ninety degrees away from the power conduit, its magnetic treads spinning uselessly against the churned silt.

Out in the channel, the winch on the stern of Vance’s skiff screamed as the sudden dead-load stalled its electric motor. The tactical craft’s stern was yanked three feet down into the following swell, seawater sloshing across its low transom.

"Umbilical fouled!" Chen shouted through clenched teeth, his face pressed against the cold winch frame. "Jin! Take the line!"

In the cab, Jin Wei shoved the main hoist lever all the way to the forward stop.

The massive, five-ton cast-iron counterweight block dropped from the gantry’s auxiliary hook. It fell sixty feet through the howling monsoon, striking the mudflat precisely where the taut tether broke the surface. The impact was not an explosion; it was an earth-shaking, hydraulic thud that sent a geyser of black mangrove mud and severed hydraulic fluid thirty feet into the rain.

The severed umbilical whipped through the air like a broken guitar string, splashing dead into the shallows.

Out in the channel, the deck winch on Vance’s skiff sheared its mount with a metallic groan. Vance leaned over his coaming, water pouring from the rim of his helmet, watching the dead telemetry screen on his tactical console go completely flat. He did not curse. His shoulders dropped half an inch. He was

a professional; the material reality of a broken umbilical and a crushed drone was an absolute boundary. He keyed his radio, his voice flat and steady: "Recovery failed. Stand off to five hundred yards. Maintain observation."

Aloft on the catwalk, Lin Zhang did not see the crawler die.

Her entire universe had narrowed to the three-inch dial of the optical receiver and the tiny vernier screw under her bleeding thumb. The cyan laser cut through the thinning fringe of the squall, striking the mirror array of the Batam silo and refracting upward into the low-altitude sky.

On her field terminal, the transmission progress bar flashed from amber to blinding, solid green.

Packet stream verified.

The debt ledger—hundreds of thousands of encrypted usufruct titles, mutual-credit settlements, and maritime mortgage erasures recorded from two dozen port councils across the archipelago—surged into the sky at the speed of light. The multi-hop relay grabbed the passing environmental orbiter, pinging the burst across seven decentralized ground stations from Yokohama to Rotterdam in less than two-fifths of a second.

On Vance’s bridge console, the automated admiralty arrest alerts suddenly vanished, replaced by standard, non-encumbered transit clearings verified by the regional commons node.

Lin stepped back from the transceiver, her chest hitching as the cold air finally caught in her throat. She pulled her trembling hands into the sleeves of her grease-slicked jacket, her vision swimming with blue afterimages.

Then, from the deep channel beyond the breakwater, a sound rolled across the anchorage that froze the marrow in Jin Wei's spine.

It was not the high whine of a mercenary outboard.

It was the deep, thunderous bellow of an automated air horn—five short, continuous blasts signaling immediate, unavoidable danger.

Emerging from the blinding squall at fourteen knots, completely blacked out, its satellite-steered collision-avoidance system frozen by the emergency network reset, a three-hundred-meter automated container ship was plowing dead toward the mouth of the decommissioned drydock, its towering bow wave already surging toward the fragile pontoons.

CHAPTER 28

Chapter 28

The displacement wave hit Drydock 4 like an artillery barrage.

Thousands of tons of displaced seawater, shoved ahead of the three-hundred-meter rogue container ship, slammed into the decommissioned outer caisson. The steel gate shrieked, its massive rivets groaning against concrete footings poured during the British colonial administration. A five-foot wall of dirty brown foam leaped over the coaming, drenching the lower catwalks and washing half a ton of discarded timber into the flooded sluice wells.

Jin Wei caught the rusted handrail with both gloved hands, the shockwave traveling through the steel deck and up his shins into his lower back. His lumbar spine felt like a column of ground glass. He didn't curse. He reached into his salt-stained coat, popped two bitter, dried jasmine tea leaves into his cheek, and chewed—a miserable habit beaten into him forty years ago on tramp freighters hauling raw bauxite through the Karimata Strait, the only thing that killed the taste of sulfur when his lungs began to burn.

"Intake Three!" Chen Rui's voice cracked over the local channel, stripped of its usual calm. "The caisson seal didn't seat! Differential pressure is spiking—we've got five meters of head driving into the pump gallery!"

"Clear the pontoon apron!" Jin bellowed back, his boots already slipping on the green slime of the lower companionway. "Open the equalization ducts! If the head doesn't drop, the surge will peel the bottom plates off Berth Eight!"

He slid down the iron ladder, iron rungs bruising his palms through grease-soaked work gloves. The lower drainage gallery smelled of old diesel sludge, rotting barnacles, and wet limestone. Below him, the dark water of the wet well was spinning into a violent, frothing vortex. The massive bypass sluice—a four-foot bronze gate valve that regulated drydock filling—was wedged half-open.

And pinned directly across its grated mouth was a human body.

Jin froze for half a heartbeat on the bottom rung, sea foam licking the cuffs of his trousers.

The diver was wedged horizontally against the intake trash rack, flattened like a rag doll by thousands of pounds of hydrostatic suction. The yellow fiberglass commercial diving helmet bore the black-stenciled triangle of Apex Marine Tactical, its surface scored by recent scrapes against submerged pilings. The high-pressure umbilical—breathing gas, communications, and hot-water heating hose—was looped tight around a bent angle-iron strut, snarled by the sudden surge.

The diver’s right leg was bent unnaturally beneath the knee, caught between two corroded bronze bars of the gate.

A raspy, ragged scream tore through the open emergency diver frequency on Jin’s shoulder unit.

"Help! Can't breathe—my ribs—God, someone kill the pump! *Kill the pump!*"

"There is no pump, son!" Jin shouted into his lapel mic, dropping into the thigh-deep surge on the flooded gallery floor. The water hit him like ice, soaking his thighs and stabbing into his arthritic knees. "You're caught in the caisson differential! Delta P!"

The diver was Harun. He was barely twenty-two, his face visible through the thick polycarbonate visor of the commercial helmet: eyes white with animal terror, dark skin slick with cold sweat and vomit, a jagged white scar across his left eyebrow where a snapped winch cable had caught him in the Jurong shipyards two years prior. He was no tactical commando; he was a day-labor commercial diver out of Batam, wearing cheap neoprene patched with vulcanized bicycle rubber, hired by the port receiver’s tactical contractor for eighty ringgit an hour to cut fiber lines and clear underwater hull sensors.

"It’s pulling my hip through," Harun sobbed, his voice tinny and breathless through the helmet’s microphone. His diaphragm was being crushed against the trash rack by the sheer weight of the strait pressing to get into the empty chamber. "Mister... please. My kid... I can't breathe..."

"Stop fighting the suction!" Jin reached the edge of the pit, his fingers hooking into the corroded edge of the concrete sluice frame. The pull of the vortex tugged viciously at his rubber boots, trying to drag his legs from under him. "Keep your lungs half-full! Chen! Aisyah! Down here now! Sluice Three!"

Aisyah came down the iron rungs three at a time, her braided hair plastered to her neck by rain, carrying a six-foot length of heavy scaffolding pipe. Her forearms were corded with tension, the old flash burns on her knuckles stark white against her brown skin.

"We can't pull him!" she yelled over the roar of the incoming water. "Delta P is five hundred pounds per square foot across that grate! If we winch him, we'll tear him in half!"

"We don't pull him," Jin snapped, his voice hard, flat, and stripped of everything except physics. "We flood the gallery from the drydock side. Equalize the head."

"If we open the drydock sea-chest, Berth Eight goes under," Chen Rui called down from the upper landing, his voice strained. "The repair skiffs—"

"Berth Eight can float!" Jin roared, pointing toward the seized bronze bypass valve mounted four feet above the waterline on the gallery wall. "Get the cheater pipe on that wheel! Turn it counter-clockwise! Now!"

Aisyah lunged across the slick concrete curb, slamming the hollow scaffolding pipe over the cast-iron spoke of the bypass wheel. The metal shrieked as she threw her entire body weight against it.

Nothing moved. Decades of salt scale and galvanic corrosion held the valve stem in a calcified vise.

Harun’s breathing in the comms went shallow, rapid, whistling. "Chest... cracking... help..."

"Aisyah, off!" Jin shoved himself through the waist-deep current, planting his boots against a rusted steel stanchion. He gripped the pipe alongside her. His bad disc flared—a savage, blinding spike of fire down his left thigh that nearly dropped him into the vortex. He tasted the bitter jasmine leaf, ground it against his molars, and locked his elbows.

"On three!" Jin gasped. "One. Two. *Drive!*"

Both of them threw their mass against the cheater pipe. Jin felt something in his shoulder slip, a hot tear of muscle, but the calcified rust inside the packing gland cracked with the sound of a pistol shot.

The valve stem turned half an inch.

"Again!"

They slammed the pipe down. The bronze wheel spun a quarter turn. Deep inside the concrete wall, a heavy iron clapper swung open with a dull hydraulic thud.

Instantly, a wall of green, aerated water erupted from the equalization conduit on the chamber's dry side. The water level in the wet well rose in a sudden, violent boil, foaming over Jin’s chest, soaking his collar and chilling the old chemical burn on his collarbone.

The differential pressure broke.

The terrible suction holding Harun flat against the trash rack died as the water levels slammed into rough equilibrium.

"Now!" Jin lunged forward, plunging his arms into the oily foam. He grabbed Harun’s harness by the heavy brass D-rings. "Aisyah, haul!"

Aisyah seized the diver’s air umbilical, heaving backward with a guttural grunt. Together, fighting the swirling backwash, they ripped Harun’s pinned leg free from the bronze bars. The bone in his lower leg gave a sickening crunch as it cleared the pinch point, but the limb was intact.

They dragged him up onto the slick concrete apron just as the automated container ship out in the channel sheared through the shallow mudbank outside Berth 7.

The freighter’s bulbous bow struck the hard silt shelf with a low, earth-shaking rumble that vibrated through the floor plates of the shipyard. The massive hull shuddered, slewing sixty degrees, its locked

engines choking out a massive cloud of black unburned fuel oil that drifted over the water like a funeral shroud. The displacement wave subsided, replaced by a filthy, rolling chop.

On the concrete deck of the gallery, Harun lay shivering violently in the bilgewater, his cracked visor fogged with vomit and blood from a ruptured lip.

Aisyah dropped to her knees, working the brass dog-latches on his helmet collar. With a sharp hiss of unsealing O-rings, she lifted the heavy fiberglass dome clear.

Harun stared up at Jin with wild, dilated pupils, his chest heaving as cool, diesel-scented air hit his face. He shrank back against the concrete wall, his hands clawing weakly at his utility belt, expecting handcuffs, zip-ties, or a boot to the ribs.

"Apex... my contractor card is in the pouch," the boy stammered, teeth chattering so hard they clicked. "I didn't sabotage the gate... they just told me to cut the telemetry line... please. Don't dump me out past the boom."

Jin didn't answer right away. He stood over the boy, his own hands trembling with somatic exhaustion, his breath wheezing through lungs scarred by half a century of heavy oil smoke. He pulled a dry, clean cotton grease-rag from his inner pocket and dropped to one knee, wrapping it carefully around Harun’s bleeding forehead.

"Chen," Jin said quietly, his voice dead level. "Bring the canvas stretcher. And two wool blankets from the galley."

Harun blinked, confused, tears cutting clean lines through the salt grime on his cheeks. "You're... you're not locking me up?"

"This is a commons harbor," Jin said, gently easing the boy’s fractured leg straight and stabilizing the knee with his own thick palms. "Under the maritime covenant, sanctuary is unconditional for any soul pulled from the water. You eat what we eat. You mend before you answer a single question."

"I was cutting your cables," the boy whispered, bewildered.

"And you were drowning," Jin replied. "The water doesn't care who signed your paycheck, and neither does this dock."

Before Harun could speak, the handheld radio at Jin’s shoulder hissed with high-frequency static. Lin Zhang’s voice cut through from the gantry tower above, sharp and brittle with immediate panic.

"Captain! The container ship is hard aground on the mud spit, but its hull broke our outer perimeter boom!"

Jin reached for the mic. "Status on Vance's skiffs?"

"They aren't standing off anymore," Lin breathed, the sound of the gale whipping through her microphone. "Three Apex interceptors just cleared the freighter’s stern. They're inside the inner channel, Captain. They’re running full throttle straight for Sluice Three."

CHAPTER 29

Chapter 29

The outboard engines shrieked like circular saws chewing through sheet zinc.

Jin Wei shoved the radio close to his mouth. "Lin, keep the laser locked on the Johor tower. Chen, lift the boy. Move!"

Rain fell in solid vertical ropes, flattening the greasy chop inside the inner slip. Chen Rui hitched the soaked canvas stretcher under Harun’s shoulders, his forearms corded and pale with strain, tendons snapping against his wrist bones with every heave. Aisyah took the diver’s legs. Harun groaned, teeth clicking against his split lip, but the boy had stopped fighting; he clung to the canvas like a child pulled from a well.

Jin turned his back to the gale, pressing his jaw against the wet concrete pillar of Sluice Three. Decades on commercial bilges had taught his teeth what his ears couldn't hear: three hulls, fiberglass-reinforced resin, twin two-hundred-horsepower outboards running wide open, planing over the submerged baffle nets.

"They're not aiming for the main lock," Jin said, spitting diesel-flavored rainwater onto the dock. "They're coming for Berth Nine. The blind spot beneath the gantry tracks."

"They're through the boom gap!" Lin’s voice broke through the speaker, chopped by static and the thrashing of the gale against the crane cab sixty meters up. "Three interceptors. Black hulls. Captain, they aren't deploying boarding ladders. They're carrying cargo cases."

Aisyah dragged Harun behind the safety of the reinforced pump-house doorway. She wiped salt from her lashes, her knuckles scarred white from an old battery flash that had permanently fused two fingernails. "Cargo? They breached an active lock to deliver freight?"

"Evidence," Jin said. The realization hit him not as a deduction, but as a cold weight in the pit of his stomach. "They need a legal trigger for live ammunition. Vance can't authorize lethal clearing on an unarmed maritime collective without an act of piracy."

Out in the black water, three low wedges of matte composite cleared the breakwater. Their running lights were taped over with dull mastic. They didn't hail. They didn't mount water cannon. The lead craft slammed against the rubber bumper of Berth Nine with a dull *thud*, its hull shuddering under the wash of its reversing props.

Four men vaulting the gunwale. No uniforms—heavy black oilskins, composite helmets, low-slung tactical webbing. They moved with the brisk, rhythmic economy of men working against a digital stopwatch. Two dropped to one knee with short-barreled carbines held low across their chests, covering the crane apron.

The third and fourth men hauled a long, olive-drab transit case onto the slippery concrete.

"Berth Nine maintenance bay," Jin whispered into the mic. "Lin, tell me the public feed is live."

"The optical link is trembling in the wind," Lin's voice came back, tight, her breath rattling with the jagged edge of a rising migraine. "Atmospheric scatter is taking half the cyan beam. But the harbor mesh has seventy-two independent receivers locked onto the tower. If I can hold the beam for twenty seconds, every cargo ship anchored in the roadstead sees the raw stream."

"Do not zoom," Jin commanded, keeping his voice dead flat, stripped of anger. "Wide field. Time stamp on the bottom margin. Let the water speak for itself."

On the apron below, the lead contractor barked a single syllable. His partner set down the transit case, punched the heavy latches, and flipped the lid open to the pelting downpour.

Inside, nestled in custom closed-cell foam, lay six Kalashnikov-pattern assault rifles, their steel receivers greased with heavy cosmoline, alongside two military satchel charges wrapped in commercial Malaysian fishing twine.

The contractor didn't check the chambers. He didn't chamber a round. He reached down, grabbed two rifles by their slings, and turned toward the padlocked auxiliary tool shed built into the base of the gantry tower—a shed registered in the port manifest to the shipyard’s local scrap-metal union.

"They're planting them in the workers' locker," Aisyah hissed, her hand gripping the rusted flange of the intake pipe until the skin over her joints went bloodless. "If the admiralty receivers find those inside the perimeter, UNCLOS Article One Hundred applies. Armed brigandage. They get a naval cordon and shoot-on-sight authorization within an hour."

"Stay down," Jin said. His lower back flared, the worn disc between his fourth and fifth vertebrae grinding with every short breath. He reached into his coat and felt the cold, notched edge of a brass pocket-watch case—not his father’s, but an old chronometer he’d bought off a bankrupt Greek second mate in Surabaya thirty years ago. He thumbed the dented rim twice to ground his racing pulse.

The contractor reached the shed door. He drew a battery-powered hydraulic spreader from his hip scabbard, shoved the jaws into the hasp, and squeezed the trigger. The hardened steel padlock sheared with a sharp, rifle-like *crack* that was swallowed instantly by the drumming rain.

He swung the corrugated sheet-metal door wide and reached back for the transit case.

"Lin," Jin said into the mic. "Flood the apron. Now."

Sixty meters above, Dr. Lin Zhang slammed the manual bypass switch for the main gantry lighting bank.

Three dozen four-thousand-watt industrial high-pressure sodium luminaires—rigged to the emergency battery bank salvaged from the hybrid tugs—roared to life in a blinding amber cascade. The entire length of Berth Nine, from the scum-crusted waterline to the crane tracks, was instantly illuminated in harsh, merciless relief. Every puddle became a mirror; every falling raindrop turned into a streak of hammered gold.

The contractor at the shed froze, his face caught square in the beam. His tactical visor was raised against the monsoon fog; his eyes shrank to pinpricks, blinded by the sudden deluge of lumens.

Directly above him, suspended from the underside of the gantry trolley, the shipyard's public maritime-safety camera—a heavy, salt-pitted dome camera installed thirty years ago to monitor hull-plate stress during drydock flooding—pivoted smoothly on its brass worm gear.

A bright red indicator lamp on the camera's aluminum housing blinked twice. Solid.

"Link confirmed," Lin's voice cracked over the channel, trembling with exhausted triumph. "Cyan laser is penetrating the storm. The raw video is mirroring to the Hague Trust maritime registry, the Batam harbor master, and the automated bridge feeds of forty-eight commercial freighters sitting four miles off the breakwater."

On the dock, the two security men covering the apron swung their weapons toward the light tower, then hesitated. Their training was corporate, contractual, calibrated for shadows and legal ambiguity. In the glare of thirty thousand watts, framed against an open tool locker with automatic weapons held in bare hands, there was no ambiguous engagement.

"Drop the crates!" a voice boomed from the crane's public hailing horn. It wasn't Jin's voice; it was the flat, recorded baritone of the harbor's automated safety beacon, repeating the dock's emergency flood protocol in English, Malay, and Mandarin.

The lead contractor cursed, his radio earpiece suddenly buzzing with furious traffic from the command skiff. He looked at the transit case at his boots, then looked up into the glaring eye of the safety camera.

Across the strait, on the bridge of an eighty-thousand-ton liquefied gas carrier anchored in the westbound lane, an automated navigational printer began chattering, spitting out low-resolution frames of the Batam gantry: two men in tactical gear, an open crate of assault weapons, and the clean, unaltered coordinates of Berth Nine stamped in the cryptographic ledger.

"Abort," the contractor muttered, the syllable caught plainly by the directional audio sensor mounted above the shed. "Package is compromised. Back to the boats. Back to the boats!"

They didn't bother locking the transit case. They kicked the rifles across the grease-filmed concrete, grabbed their empty spreader, and sprinted for the gunwales.

Aisyah leaned forward, her chest heaving against the rain-chilled bulkhead. "Captain, the fire monitors—we can pin them against the seawall before their engines catch."

"No," Jin said. His lungs burned with the cold vapor, his cough coming hard and deep, rattling his ribs. "Let them run. We don't need their bodies. We have their serial numbers."

The three skiffs slammed their throttles forward, churning the dark water of Sluice Three into a violent, frothing froth of diesel exhaust and white foam. Within thirty seconds, their hulls had vanished back into the black sheets of the monsoon, fleeing out toward international water where their transponders could hide among the container traffic.

Jin stepped out onto the wet apron. The rain drummed relentlessly on the corrugated iron of the tool shed, washing away the grease the contractors had left on the floorplates. The transit case lay on its side, the cold foam soaking up seawater.

Behind him, Chen Rui stepped into the light, his work boots squelching in the puddles. Harun was wrapped in gray wool inside the dry pump room, sleeping the heavy, dead sleep of hypothermia recovery.

"They'll claim it was a rogue contractor," Chen said, his voice flat with fatigue. "They'll say the weapons were ours and their security team was interdicting them."

"The ledger has the optical burst from before they hit the bumper," Jin replied, kneeling down beside the spilled case. He didn't touch the cold steel. He simply watched the rain pool in the rifle sights. "Every second is signed by five nodes on two shores. You cannot forge an ocean."

The radio at his shoulder crackled again.

It wasn't Lin this time.

The voice was rough, choked with salt and panic, coming over the short-range VHF emergency frequency from the grounded container vessel three hundred yards out on the mud spit.

"Batam Commons... this is the third mate on the *Nordic Sentry*," the voice gasped, competing with the metallic groaning of tortured steel. "The current... the tide turned four knots early. The hull is splitting at hold four. Our master abandoned ship on the launch... we have four hundred tons of bunker fuel over the lower bulkhead, and the plates are tearing."

Jin stood up slowly, feeling every year of his life in the hinge of his knees, and looked out into the howling dark.

CHAPTER 30

Chapter 30

The squall hit the outer breakwater with the concussive weight of wet slate. Through the open doorway of the drydock pump house, Captain Jin Wei watched the rain obliterate the lights of the Singapore roadstead, turning the world’s busiest shipping lane into a void of thrashing gray.

"Batam Commons, respond!" The VHF speaker hissed, choked with carrier hum and the shriek of overstressed metal. "The heel is past twelve degrees. She’s pivoting on the reef! If hold four breaches, the fuel head will drop straight into the bilge!"

Jin pressed the transmit button with a thumb that felt thick and unresponsive from the damp chill. "Third Mate Douglas. Hold your stations. Can you access the ballast manifold?"

"Access it?" Douglas’s voice cracked into a jagged gasp. "The master locked the sea-chest valves open before he dropped the starboard workboat! The lower engine room is already knee-deep in oily wash. He took the logbooks, Captain. He took the paper manifests and the master keys!"

Jin dropped the mic onto the bench. He reached into his coat pocket, finding the dry nub of bitter orange peel he had carried since his apprentice days on the coastal lighters—an old habit to cut the sulfur taste of heavy fuel oil that rose in his throat whenever an engine room flooded. He bit into it, the sharp tang clearing his sinus.

"Chen," Jin said.

Chen Rui didn't look up from the chart table. He was pressing the heel of a flat brass ruler against a sodden schematic of a feeder container ship, smoothing out the swollen paper with rhythmic, desperate strokes. A habit from his university days, when a wrinkled blueprint had cost him his first certification exam. "The *Nordic Sentry* carries forty-two thousand deadweight tons," Chen said, his voice clipped, stripped of inflection. "If the midship snaps on the falling tide, four hundred tons of unrefined bunker oil hits the mangrove line in forty minutes. The tidal turbine draft intakes will choke before dawn."

"Aisyah," Jin turned toward the tool locker.

Aisyah binti Rahman was already hauling two fifty-meter coils of ribbed suction hose across the ribbed deckplates. Her hands, raw and peeling where the high-voltage arc had blistered her skin three days prior, moved with mechanical precision. Under her breath, barely audible beneath the pounding rain on the corrugated roof, she hummed three descending notes of a Bugis fishing song—a rhythmic counter she used during decompression stops to keep her pulse from spiking.

"The work skiff has two hours of battery on the twin outboards," she said, nodding toward the slipway where their flat-bottomed aluminum tender bucked against the surge. "The chop in the channel is two meters. We won't be able to push her off the spit. We can only hook the salvage pump and draw the fuel into our reserve barge before the bottom rips out."

"Then move," Jin said. "Chen, stay on the optical transceiver. If the rain thickens and the laser drops, we lose Johor’s telemetry."

"It’s not just Johor," a new voice came from the shadowed corner behind the rack of battery accumulators.

Dr. Lin Zhang stepped into the pale beam of the workbench lamp. Her face was gray, the skin beneath her eyes shadowed with exhaustion that sleep could no longer touch. Between her thumb and forefinger, she held two dried cloves, grinding them against her molars to stave off the migraine aura creeping across her left eye. She loathed paper—her mother had spent eleven years fighting tax auditors over cardboard boxes of forged municipal receipts in Wuhan—yet her hands held a stack of fresh printouts from the air-gapped terminal.

"Lin," Jin said, his hand already on the door handle. "We have twenty minutes before the hull breaks."

"You don't understand, Jin," Lin said softly. Her voice carried the dead chill of an operating room. "I just pulled the *Nordic Sentry*’s underwriting syndicate from the maritime registry before the optical link degraded."

"We know who owns her," Chen muttered, his ruler scraping the damp paper. "Euro-Asian Maritime Finance."

"No," Lin said. "Euro-Asian sold the debt six weeks ago. The ship is insured through a mutual indemnity pool in Zurich—the Helios Maritime Syndicate. It’s a sovereign-backed risk-retention group. They cover forty percent of all mid-tier dry bulk and feeder container traffic transiting the Malacca Strait."

Aisyah paused, one coil of heavy hose still over her shoulder. "If they have sovereign backing, where are their salvage tugs? There are six commercial harbor tugs moored off Jurong with cold stacks. They refused the third mate's distress call."

Lin laid the printouts on the grease-stained wood.

"Look at the ledger clearing," she said.

Jin leaned over the table, water dripping from the brim of his oilskin cap onto the paper. The figures were not standard ship mortgages. They were nested obligations—layer upon layer of secondary risk instruments, synthetic salvage guarantees, and credit default hedges wrapped around the hulls of three hundred aging cargo vessels across the Pacific basin.

"They aren't late," Lin said, her breath smelling of sharp clove. "They were ordered to stay at anchor."

Jin felt the cold settle beneath his ribs, deeper than the damp draft from the channel. "Explain."

"The syndicate didn't pool risk," Lin said. Her finger traced a line of red-flagged settlements that terminated in shell accounts registered in the Marshall Islands. "They leveraged it. For every dollar of real capital the member fleets deposited into the mutual pool to cover grounding, wreck removal, and environmental spills, Helios wrote thirty-eight dollars of synthetic reinsurance notes and sold them into European pension portfolios."

Chen stopped smoothing the schematic. His ruler froze against the paper. "Thirty-eight to one? That violates every admiralty reserve ratio in international law."

"It’s legal because they classified the Strait of Malacca as an uninsurable transitional corridor under the emergency security protocols," Lin said. "The moment the global clearinghouse froze commercial paper last month, the syndicate went dry. They don't have the cash reserves to pay for a single major bunker spill, let alone a salvaged hull. If the *Nordic Sentry* is pulled off that spit and towed into a drydock, the salvage claim triggers an immediate independent condition survey."

Jin’s jaw tightened. "And the survey reveals the ship was unseaworthy before she weighed anchor."

"Worse," Lin whispered. "The survey proves the indemnity fund is an empty shell. The moment one claim is filed that Helios cannot cover, the whole syndication cross-defaults. Every vessel insured under the pool—over four hundred container ships between Suez and Tokyo—loses its statutory maritime insurance certificate overnight. Under UNCLOS, uncertified commercial vessels cannot legally enter sovereign territorial waters. Port authorities in Singapore, Shanghai, Rotterdam, and Los Angeles would have to issue immediate seizure or exclusion orders."

The room went dead silent, save for the furious rattle of monsoon rain against the iron walls.

"The master didn't abandon ship out of panic," Aisyah said, her voice barely a breath. "He was instructed to let her break."

"If she breaks," Lin nodded, "the loss is classified as an act of God—extreme weather, seasonal monsoon, hydrodynamic anomaly. Under the catastrophic weather exemption clauses, the claims are deferred into a five-year forensic arbitration moratorium. The syndicate doesn't have to post collateral. They survive another quarter. But if we save her—if we pump that oil, patch that plate, and tow her into Drydock Four—the physical evidence sits in our basin. Her logs, her maintenance deferrals, her empty reserve accounts."

The VHF radio on the bench exploded into life again.

"Commons!" Douglas was screaming now over the sound of tearing iron. The screech was horrific—the sound of three-inch structural steel being sheared like wet cardboard over a coral head. "The keel...

the bottom shell just buckled under hold three! Water is pouring across the tank top! We're losing the emergency generator!"

Jin grabbed the handheld radio. His voice dropped into the calm, gravelly register he had used for thirty years through typhoon seas and pirate channels. "Douglas. Cut the generator now. Do not wait for the breaker. If the water hits the busbars, you'll lose the auxiliary pump circuits permanently. Get your crew onto the forecastle head. We are coming with the tender."

He clicked off and looked at Aisyah. "Drop the suction line into the tender's stern well. Grab two pneumatic submersible pumps and the portable diesel air-compressor. Chen, take the helm. You know the reef line better than any of us."

"Captain," Lin said, catching his sleeve. Her fingers were cold, trembling slightly from the pain behind her eyes. "If we bring that ship's records into this dock, we aren't just fighting private tactical skiffs anymore. We are threatening the solvency of the entire global maritime logistics market. They will declare this hub an illicit salvage operation. They will cut the optical lines from the mainland. They will call us wreckers."

Jin looked down at her hand, then reached out and gently uncurled her fingers from his coat.

"Let them call us whatever they want," Jin said, his voice flat and hard as an iron bollard. "There are four hundred tons of bunker oil sitting five feet above a live reef, and five men shivering on a forecastle that is dipping toward the tide. We don't salvage ships for the syndicates, Lin. We salvage them for the water."

He turned toward the rain, pulling his collar high against the howling dark. "Aisyah, Chen. Cast off."

CHAPTER 31

Chapter 31

The tender’s gunwale slammed against the timber fenders of Berth 8 with a splintering thud, lifting on a three-meter monsoon swell that coated the lower gantry in yellowish foam. Rain struck the concrete deck like birdshot. Before the mooring warp had even bitten into the iron cleat, a deckhand dropped from the tender’s thwarts, clutching a bundle wrapped in oilcloth against his chest.

Behind him, Douglas scrambled over the rail, his face gray with salt-scum and exhaustion. "She’s not breathing right," Douglas shouted into the squall, his voice cracking against the roar of the surf. "The cabin flooded two hours out on the reef. She swallowed the bilge froth!"

Uncle Tan met them at the threshold of the machine annex, his heavy canvas coat slick and stiffened with grease. He didn't ask who the child belonged to or why an unregistered deckhand had his family stowed beneath the floorboards of an unclassed feeder boat. At seventy-one, Tan’s body moved with the sluggish, deliberate economy of an old diesel engine; his knuckles, thick and deformed by decades of damp heat and calcified joint pain, took the bundle with a firmness that surprised the shivering father.

"Inside," Tan rasped. "Out of the spray."

Aisyah came up the ladder from the drydock trench two rungs at a time, her boots dripping rust-colored slurry. Her palms were taped where the flash-burns had peeled back raw pink flesh three days earlier, the adhesive gummy and foul from seawater. She took one look at the bundle on the workbench and pulled the oilcloth clear.

The child was a girl, barely a month old, her skin the mottled lavender of a bruised plum. Her ribs snapped upward against her paper-thin chest with a violent, hollow click, sinking so deep beneath her sternum with every inhalation that her belly looked hollowed out by a trowel.

"Tracheal tugging," Aisyah said, the words clipped short as she leaned down, her ear an inch from the infant’s mouth. "Rattling deep in the bronchial branch. She’s choking on her own fluid."

"Concentrator," Tan said, already moving toward the back locker where the clinic supplies salvaged from the Jurong basin were kept under double canvas. He didn't look at the child's father, who had sunk to his knees by the scrap bin, his forehead pressed against the wet steel rim, shivering violently in his sodden coveralls. "Bring the four-liter bottle and the infant harness."

Aisyah threw open the wooden locker, hauling out the olive-drab plastic housing of the portable medical concentrator. She slammed the three-prong plug into the wall receptacle above the lathe bench and threw the toggle.

Nothing.

A dead click from the internal solenoid, followed by the dull, dying whine of an inverter cooling fan spinning down to zero.

"Main bus tripped," Aisyah spat, her voice tight. "The gantry crane’s optical sensor flooded during the last gust. The whole dock ring is isolated."

"The turbine feeder?" Tan asked, peeling back the child’s soaked cotton shirt. His blunt, scarred thumb pressed gently into the baby's heel; the white mark took nearly four seconds to fade back to sick purple. In his youth, running night runs on the unlit timber coasters between Pontianak and the Karimata Strait, he had watched three children die of croup in the foul, humid hold because the kerosene stoves had smoked them blind. The memory wasn't a story he told; it was a physical weight in the pit of his stomach, heavy as pig iron.

"Tidal turbine’s dumping directly into the deep bank," Aisyah said, her mind already tracking the copper runs through the wet floorplates. "If I throw the knife switch to force the tap, the voltage spike will fry the concentrator's motherboard in three milliseconds. We need clean, regulated DC, or the molecular sieve won't cycle."

"The tender," Tan said without looking up. He was tilting the infant’s chin back with two fingers, clearing a thick string of mucous and yellow fuel scum from her tongue with the corner of a clean rag. "The tug pack."

Aisyah was already out the door.

She dropped into the open hatch of the hybrid utility tender moored beneath the crane overhang. The air down here was suffocating—thirty-six degrees, thick with the stench of overheated electrolyte, ozone, and wet wood. In the bilge, sloshing six inches deep beneath the aluminum floor plates, was the sealed marine fuel cell they had pulled from a decommissioned fairway buoy two months ago. It was fed by a low-pressure bottle of boil-off hydrogen, its platinum catalyst stack designed to run continuously in salt fog without maintenance.

Her blistered fingers tore at the quick-disconnect terminal lugs. A sharp hiss of escaping pressure bit her forearm as she cracked the gas line regulator, checking the low-side gauge with a flick of her thumb. Two bars. Enough for three hours if the membrane didn't dry out.

She grabbed a pair of four-gauge jumper leads, clamped the teeth onto the output studs of the stack’s isolated buffer, and ran the heavy neoprene cables up the ladder, dragging them through the muck of the quay and through the annex door.

"Tan! Catch!"

The old man caught the lead with his left hand, wincing as the sudden load wrenched his inflamed wrist. Together, they didn't bother looking for the factory plug. Aisyah flipped the concentrator upside

down on the timber bench, whipped an electrician’s flathead from her breast pocket, and cracked the plastic bottom case open with three brutal twists.

The interior was a tight maze of aluminum canisters filled with synthetic zeolite crystals and a miniature reciprocating piston pump.

"Bypass the onboard rectifier," Tan muttered, his breath coming in ragged whistles through his nostrils. He held the infant tucked in the crook of his right elbow, his body heat shielding her from the draft whistling through the corrugated iron siding. "Wire directly into the twelve-volt rail behind the smoothing capacitor. If you hit the logic board with negative polarity, the whole stack is scrap."

Aisyah peeled back the red insulation with her teeth, spitting copper strands and salt onto the floor. Her hands were shaking—not with fear, but with the cold tremors of sixty hours without real sleep and the sharp, hot throbbing in her burned palms. She touched the copper lead to the terminal lug behind the capacitor.

A tiny spark snapped. The small rotary compressor inside the machine coughed, shuddered against its rubber isolation mounts, and settled into a rhythmic, pneumatic thrum: *ch-ch-ch-ch-ch-ch*.

"Pressure’s climbing," Aisyah said, her eyes fixed on the analog flow indicator on the unit’s face. The steel float ball hovered, sank, then bobbed up to the two-liter mark.

Tan reached into his pocket and produced a clean length of clear silicone tubing he had cut from the reverse-osmosis test bench. He didn't have a neonatal mask. The adult nasal prongs were twice the size of the child's nostrils.

Taking his pocketknife—its blade ground down to a thin, flexible sliver from forty years of whetstone passes—he slit the dual prongs away entirely, leaving a single smooth silicone tube. He wrapped the tip in a scrap of sterile lint-free gauze, binding it with a loop of copper tie-wire so that only a diffuse, soft plume of oxygen could escape, preventing the high-velocity dry gas from tearing the infant’s fragile nasal tissue.

He brought the makeshift diffuser to within a half-inch of the baby’s face.

"Hold the bubbler," Tan commanded softly. "Keep the water level three fingers deep. If the gas dries out her lungs now, the fluid will turn to glue."

Aisyah held the plastic humidifier jar steady between her bandaged palms, feeling the cool, rhythmic vibration of the bubbles breaking through the distilled water. The sound in the shed narrowed until it was only that: the wet, steady ticking of the bubbler and the ragged, shallow gasps of the child.

For sixty seconds, nothing seemed to change. The child’s eyelids remained swollen shut, her chest heaving in that terrible, concave rhythm that signaled the final stages of muscular exhaustion.

Then, slowly, the blue shadow around her lips began to fray.

The dark, slate-gray hue clinging to her earlobes receded, replaced by the faint, mottled pink of returning capillary flow. The violent heave of her ribs slackened, settling into a longer, deeper rhythm. A single, thin wail broke from her throat—not strong, but clear and wet—before she turned her face into Tan’s greasy wool sleeve, her tiny, waxen fingers curling around the cuff of his button.

The father let out a long, shuddering sound that was half cough and half sob, his shoulders slumping against the scrap bin as if his spine had been pulled out through his collar.

"Keep the gas running," Tan said quietly, his voice dropping into the steady register of a man who had seen the sea give back life just often enough not to trust it. "Her temperature is low. We need dry wool and three hot water bottles against her flanks."

Aisyah didn't move. She kept her hands clamped around the humidifier jar, watching the tiny mist of condensation form and vanish on the infant’s upper lip with every breath. Her thumb, raw and throbbing where the tape had slipped, was pressed against the cold copper of the fuel cell lead. She could feel the faint, microscopic pulse of the current flowing through the wire—silent, steady, paid for by the slow, quiet decay of hydrogen across a sheet of carbon cloth.

Then, from the darkness outside the dock gate, a high, piercing warble tore through the rain.

It wasn't the storm.

Aisyah’s head snapped up. On the harbor wall, sixty meters above the boiling surf, the green line-of-sight laser transceiver on the crane tower flickered three times in rapid, frantic succession—the signal for an air-gap override.

The annex door swung inward on its iron hinges, letting in a curtain of horizontal spray.

Jin Wei stood in the threshold, his yellow oilskins dripping black water onto the sill. His hand was on the brass frame of the door, his knuckle white against the wet metal. Behind him, out beyond the concrete breakwater of Berth 7, three long, low silhouettes were cutting through the outer channel, running without navigation lights, their carbon-fiber hulls throwing twin knives of white spray through the dark.

"Jin?" Tan asked, not moving the child an inch from the warm circle of his chest.

"Apex tactical skiffs," Jin said, his voice level, flat, and hollowed out by wind. "They aren't hailing the harbor master. They've crossed the three-mile traffic separation line, and they have recovery rams mounted on their bows."

CHAPTER 32

Chapter 32

The rain did not fall in drops; it came down as an unbroken sheet of grey iron, hammering the corrugated roof of Drydock 4 until speech was impossible below a shout.

Jin Wei did not wipe his face. The seawater and sweat running off his brows tasted of heavy sulfur and burnt oil, stinging the corners of his eyes where the crows' feet had cracked from three days in the salt gale. "They're running forty knots," he said, stepping fully inside the annex and pulling the iron latch shut with a hollow *clunk*. "Triple outboards on each skiff. Kevlar skirts. They aren't trying to board under the cranes. They're angling for Berth 9, where the tidal turbine cables tie off."

In the corner, under the yellow glow of an inspection bulb wrapped in wire mesh, Uncle Tan handed the bundled infant back to the mother. His large, knobby knuckles—swollen like ginger roots from fifty winters in damp bilge spaces—trembled slightly as he straightened his spine. A muffled snap sounded from the small of his back, a familiar, dry pop that had accompanied every shift since the shipyards privatized in the nineties.

"Berth 9 has no seawall," Tan said. His voice was sandpaper against dry wood. "Only the timber pilings we drove last month to cradle the turbine pontoon. If they put their rams into those pilings at speed, the shear pins will snap. The whole array will drop into the mud."

"They don't want the pontoon," Dr. Lin Zhang said from behind the sorting table. She was kneeling on a damp rubber mat, her fingers white-tipped as she cinched zip-ties around an air-gapped optical terminal, wrapping the entire chassis in three layers of tarred sailcloth. Her temples throbbed with a migraine that had settled behind her left eye twelve hours ago, turning every flash of lightning into a white-hot needle driven through her skull. "They want the telemetry loggers. If they physically cut the fiber hub off the crane foot, the maritime registry in Singapore automatically registers an abandonment. The mortgage trustees take possession at dawn."

Aisyah stood by the workbench, her burnt fingertips stinging where the salt-laden mist drifted through the door seals. She picked up the heavy brass signaling key—an old manual relay wired directly to the crane tower's optical mirror. "The fog is too thick for Johor to see us. The cyan beam is scattering sixty percent of its lumens before it hits the outer channel marker."

"Then don't talk to Johor," Jin Wei said. He reached for his hard hat, hanging from a rusty peg beside the muster board, and jammed it over his greasy, thinning hair. "Talk to the roadstead."

Outside, the first engine roar ripped through the squall.

It was a low, snarling whine, the sound of thousand-horsepower marine blocks running open-throttle against the surge. Apex didn't use sirens; they used high-output searchlights that sliced through the driving rain like blue surgical blades. The beams swept across the dark water of the basin, catching the oily crests of four-foot chop before slamming against the rusted flanks of the drydock gate.

Jin threw the iron door back open. The wind caught it, slamming it against the concrete footing with a clang that rattled the grease guns on the wall. He stumbled down the wooden steps, his right knee hitching under the weight of his sea boots. Decades of standing on vibrating deck plates had ground the cartilage to powder, and every step into the tropical gale sent a cold ache shooting straight into his groin.

Chen Rui was already at the foot of the gantry, soaked to the bone, his forearms wrapped in vulcanized rubber sleeves. He had two fire monitors hooked into the auxiliary seawater main, their two-inch brass nozzles pointed toward the narrow throat between Berth 8 and Berth 9.

"Water pressure is only seventy pounds!" Chen screamed over the drumming deluge, his voice cracking. "The low-tide intake is choked with silt from the storm surge! If I open both valves, the head drops to thirty!"

"Don't fire yet!" Jin bellowed, lunging forward and grabbing Chen’s shoulder. The younger man was shivering violently, his teeth clicking together in rapid, involuntary spasms. "You’ll just wash their deckhands down. Apex runs enclosed cockpits. Those rams have six inches of hardened steel behind their rubber bumpers. You hit them with thirty pounds of water, they’ll laugh and shear the risers."

The first skiff broke through the outer curtain of rain three hundred meters out.

It was long, black, and sat terrifyingly low in the water, throwing two massive, foaming wings of white spray that glowed under its own prow lights. Behind it, two more hulls carved parallel furrows through the channel, their blunt, snout-nosed bows angled directly toward the wooden cradles where the community’s power cables entered the dock.

Jin Wei reached into his foul-weather coat and pulled out the small brass telegraph horn—an old, dented mouth-siren he had carried since his first third-mate watch on the bulk carriers. He put it to his lips, his lungs burning with the sharp, acidic reek of bunker dregs that forever haunted the mud flats, and blew three long, flat blasts into the wind.

Silence from the bay. Only the rising scream of the approaching outboards.

Then, fifty meters to the east, behind the black silhouette of an unpowered palm-oil lighter anchored in the shallows, an engine coughed.

It was a wet, heavy, two-stroke chug—an old coastal diesel with an unbaffled exhaust. A tiny yellow bulb blinked to life at its masthead.

Twenty meters beyond that, another engine caught: the high, rattling clatter of an air-cooled agricultural diesel mounted on the deck of an open wooden sampan. Then another. A rusted tugboat, its wheelhouse patched with blue construction tarp, kicked up a great boiling cloud of black soot from its funnel as its screw bit into the current.

"Jin!" Tan's voice cut through the rain from the dock walk above. The old man was leaning over the guardrail, pointing his arm out across the roadstead toward the deep-water anchorage. "Look at the channel!"

Through the streaming rain, the darkness was coming alive with light.

They were not the blinding, cold halogen beams of private security. They were the kerosene lanterns of night-squid jiggers, the dim orange glow of sodium deck floods from anchored cement barges, the flickering LED work-lights of salvage lighters and bunkering sloops that had sat idle for months, trapped under the admiralty liens that choked the strait.

One by one, the hulls slipped their moorings.

They didn't come in formation; they came in an unruly, lumbering mass, drifting across the narrow neck of the channel like an island of timber and rusted iron torn loose from the earth. A seventy-foot flat-bottom ferry, its car deck crowded with drums of freshwater and scrap plate, swung broadside across the lead skiff's approach vector, dropping its heavy Danforth anchor with a scream of chain that echoed off the crane towers.

On the lead Apex skiff, the throttle pitch changed instantly.

The snarling roar dropped to a harsh, stuttering cough as the pilot threw the triple drives into reverse. The black hull dug its stern deep into the chop, a wall of white foam climbing up its transom as it slid sideways, missing the iron flank of a diesel sampan by less than six feet.

The second skiff swerved hard to starboard to avoid the lead boat's wash, its powerful spotlights sweeping across a tangled wall of floating hemp lines, wooden gunwales, and tire fenders.

There was no gap.

A hundred hulls—battered coastal ketches, twin-screw harbor launches, timber longboats loaded with coiled mooring warp, and fifty-year-old steel tugs—had nested themselves into an impassable, floating reef across the entire two-mile entrance to the shipyard basin. They were tied horn-to-cleat with greasy polypropylene hawser, their engines idling in a steady, thrumming chorus that vibrated through the harbor water and through the very soles of Jin's boots.

On the open deck of the ferry, three deckhands in torn yellow ponchos stood by the bitts, holding wooden pike poles tipped with rubber dock bumpers. They didn't shout. They didn't raise weapons. They simply stood with their shoulders hunched against the rain, their weathered faces illuminated by

the blue searchlights of the trapped skiffs, watching the tactical craft bounce helplessly against the churning surface.

The lead Apex boat drifted within ten feet of an old river lighter. Inside the skiff's tinted polycarbonate wheelhouse, Jin could see the silhouette of the contractor pilot, his tactical helmet illuminated by the green glow of his radar screen. The screen was solid red—an unbroken shelf of maritime targets, dense as a coral bank, running all the way from the mud shoals of Berth 11 to the deep-water separation buoy.

The contractor reached up, his gloved hand hovering over the engine toggles. He looked out through the glass, his searchlight beam resting on the open hold of the lighter.

Sitting on a wooden crate inside the hold, sheltered from the downpour by a piece of corrugated plastic, an old woman was calmly gutting small mackerel with a short, rusted bait knife, dropping the cleaned fish into a plastic bucket between her feet. She did not even look up at the searchlight.

The contractor's engines dropped to idle. The high-tension hum of the outboards died into a wet, hollow gurgle.

Jin Wei stood on the edge of the dock, his hand gripping the cold, vibrating iron of the fire monitor. The rain was finally beginning to slacken, thinning to a fine, gray drizzle that drifted across the harbor like smoke.

Behind him, from the annex door, Lin Zhang stepped out onto the catwalk. Her face was pale, the skin around her eyes drawn tight with exhaustion, but her hands were steady as she looked past the sea of masts toward the outer channel.

"Jin," she said, her voice barely carrying over the idling diesels.

He turned his head. "They're boxed. They can't ram without sinking twenty civilian boats under the admiralty cameras. They'll have to back out on their auxiliary drives."

"No," Lin said, pointing toward the eastern spit where the deep-water channel curved around the southern light. "Not them. Look at the radar mast on the separation buoy."

Jin raised his binoculars, wiping the salt smear from the lenses with his wet thumb.

Beyond the civilian flotilla, beyond the stalled Apex skiffs, three massive commercial vessels—ten-thousand-ton heavy-lift ships flying the corporate blue-and-silver ensign of the maritime mortgage syndicate—had altered course from the main Singapore shipping lane. They weren't turning back toward the open sea.

They had cut their transponders, blacked out their navigation bridges, and were dropping their five-ton sea anchors directly into the trench where the shipyard's subsea power link met the international grid.

CHAPTER 33

Chapter 33

The seabed shuddered before the sound arrived.

Through the salt-encrusted steel of the catwalk, Jin felt the vibration travel upward through the drydock pilings, a deep, grinding shudder that rattled the teeth in his jaw. Two miles out in the separation channel, the dark water churned into white foam as the port-side anchor of the *Caspian Venture* struck the submerged shelf. Five tons of forged iron dragged through silt and riprap, its flukes hunting for the thick armored umbilical that carried current from the tidal turbines into the yard.

Lin caught the rail, her knuckles white against the flaking primer. "They're dragging blind," she breathed, her voice raspy from twenty straight hours over glowing monitors. "If those flukes hook the high-voltage jacket, the arc will boil twenty yards of seawater and blow the circuit banks across the whole bay."

"They aren't blind," Jin said.

He turned toward the open hatch of the gantry's bridge deck. Decades of diesel vibration had left his lower back a tight knot of calcified bone, and every step up the grated stairs sent an electric stab through his hip. He didn't rush. Running on an iron ladder over thirty feet of stagnant bilge was how deckhands broke their necks, a lesson he'd learned forty winters ago when he was still an apprentice on coastal coal scows. Back then, before the reclamation companies paved over the green terraces of his home village, his mother had kept three wooden hives behind the vegetable patch. She had taught him to place a bare palm against the cedar boards at dawn; by the frequency of the buzzing alone, she could tell whether the queen was healthy or if the colony was preparing to starve.

He felt that same predatory hum now, not in bees, but in the shuddering radio carrier waves vibrating through the shipyard's emergency bridge.

Inside the glassed-in bridge cab, Uncle Tan sat beside the old marine VHF console. His swollen knuckles were wrapped in damp linen strips against the monsoon humidity, but his hands rested steady on the frequency dials. Flanking him were three young deckhands—two men from the Batam lighter fleet and a woman who had spent five years running fuel barges down the Siak River—their faces slick with sweat, their numbered brass sortition tokens hanging from their necks by grease-darkened cord.

"Channel sixteen is jammed with corporate squawk," Tan said without looking up. "The lead ship is the *Caspian Venture*. Her master is Malek. An old company man. Thirty-two years under corporate charter."

Jin picked up the heavy black bakelite handset. The cord was coiled tight, stiff with age and salt. He didn't key the switch immediately. Through the salt-streaked windscreen, he watched the lead Apex tactical skiff. The patrol boat was pinned twenty yards off Berth 9, entirely hemmed in by three dozen wooden sampans, rusted tugs, and fiberglass runabouts. The contractor pilot remained behind his tinted polycarbonate glass, searchlight trembling, his twin three-hundred-horsepower outboards idling in neutral. He had the speed to cut down two or three skiffs, but doing so under the unblinking gaze of forty civilian bridge cameras meant an open admiralty murder indictment in three different sovereign jurisdictions. The pilot was frozen by his own survival calculus.

Farther out, the three ten-thousand-ton heavy-lift freighters loomed like black cliffs against the dawn light. Their navigation bridges were dark, running running-lights only, pretending to be unguided derelicts to skirt liability while their anchors plowed the seabed floor.

Jin pressed the thumb switch. The microphone click sounded like a dry branch snapping.

"Motor Vessel *Caspian Venture*, this is Keppel-Batam Harbor Refuge. Channel sixteen. Over."

Static washed through the cab’s overhead speaker, a hiss of rain and sea spray. Then a voice broke through—strained, clipped, carrying the thin, mechanical echo of an offshore bridge wing.

"Station calling, identify. You are transmitting on an international distress frequency. Clear the channel."

"Captain Malek," Jin said, his voice dropping into the quiet, rhythmic cadence he had used for forty years across typhoons and blown cylinder heads. "This is Jin Wei. We cleared berths together at Jurong in ninety-eight, when you were second mate on the *Straits Star*. Let the anchor chain rest, Captain. You’re sixty meters off the trench."

Silence hung over the channel. The only sound was the drumming of rain against the glass and the low, hollow rumble of the heavy-lift ship's diesels laboring against their dropped ground tackle.

On the radio, Malek’s breath came through as a ragged hitch. "Jin? You’re on the blacklists, man. Every terminal between Busan and Rotterdam has your name on the lien registry. If I drop anchor inside your coordinates, the syndicate cancels my mortgage indemnity. They’ll seize my vessel at the pilot station."

"They’ll seize her anyway," Jin said evenly. "Look at your charter party. Clause thirty-four. If you damage subsea municipal infrastructure under blacked-out running lights, your third-party liability insurance is voided on the instant of impact. You carry the entire civil judgment on your personal ticket. The syndicate won't pay a single guilder. You know how the paper is cut."

In the corner of the bridge cab, the three deckhands on the sortition watch exchanged glances. The young woman from the Siak barge leaned over the chart table, her finger tracing the red hatched line of the power trench where the depth sounder showed the seabed rising toward the shoals.

"He's stalling," she whispered to Tan. "His starboard winch is still paying out link. You can hear the brake drum squealing across the water."

Uncle Tan raised a hand, gesturing for quiet. His eyes remained fixed on Jin.

Jin did not raise his voice. He kept his grip loose on the handset, letting his thumb ease off the switch just long enough to let Malek hear the absolute absence of panic in the shipyard's control room.

"Malek," Jin said softly. "You have twenty-four crewmen aboard. Eight of them are cadets from the academy in Iloilo whose families haven't seen a remittance transfer in three months because the syndicate froze the clearing accounts. If your anchor flukes cut that trench, the tidal current will ground through your hull plating before the circuit interrupters trip. You won't just black out my dock. You'll cook your own auxiliary switchboards."

"I have orders from maritime receivers!" Malek's voice cracked, the thin veneer of corporate authority fraying into naked terror. "They gave me a legal writ of salvage and clearance! You are harboring unsanctioned hulls!"

"Then look down at the water off your port quarter," Jin replied.

Through his binoculars, Jin saw the master on the *Caspian Venture's* bridge wing raise his own glass.

Below the freighter's massive flared bow, the water was no longer empty. The flotilla of civilian sampans and river lighters was fanning out. They weren't charging. They were drifting into a crescent across the freighter's stern, cutting their engines, dropping small stone killicks into the shallows. Behind them, the lead Apex tactical skiff remained dead in the water.

Then, over the open radio frequency, a new voice cut through the hiss. It was flat, carrying the dry, unaccented tone of a private military contractor who had spent too many years reading tactical operational manuals.

"This is Apex Interceptor One to *Caspian Venture*," the pilot said. His voice was piped through a cockpit throat-mic, mechanical and cold. "Be advised. We have forty-two civilian skiffs directly in our wash. Propeller entanglement hazard is one hundred percent if we apply thrust. We cannot secure your port side. Furthermore, Node Four has illuminated our hull with active safety monitors. If you drop additional ground tackle, you risk fouling our outboards. We are cutting our secondary throttles and holding position."

Lin let out a long, shuddering breath. "The mercenaries are pulling their horns in," she muttered. "They aren't paid enough to get sued for sinking forty fishermen."

"They're paid in corporate scrip that won't clear if the ship gets arrested," Jin murmured back. He keyed the mic once more. "Malek. The sortition council of this harbor has registered your ship under the humanitarian refuge articles of the Law of the Sea. We have water, we have power from the tidal

turbines, and we have an open berth at the south mole. Cut your winch brake. Let the chain go slack. Come in on your bow thrusters and tie up alongside us."

A dead silence settled over the channel, so heavy that the rhythmic slap of small waves against the pilings seemed to fill the room.

For three agonizing seconds, nothing moved.

Then, across the gray surface of the strait, came the sharp, metallic *clank* of a hydraulic windlass locking into its pawl. The boiling foam around the *Caspian Venture's* bow subsided into a gentle swell. The chain went limp, hanging in a long, drooping bight between the hawsepipe and the seafloor, inches clear of the subsea cable.

Uncle Tan closed his eyes, his lips moving in a silent prayer.

Jin lowered the radio handset, his shoulders dropping an inch. The ache in his spine was a dull throb now, manageable, like the familiar weight of wet canvas.

"He's holding," Lin whispered. "He's not dropping the second anchor."

Before Jin could answer, the red beacon atop the gantry tower flashed twice, followed by a dry, rhythmic staccato from the optical transceiver mast.

The young barge woman lunged for the teleprinter terminal on the chart table. The mechanical needles chattered furiously against the roll of paper, driven by the laser pulse from the Johor shore across the open strait.

She ripped the paper from the carriage, her eyes wide as she read the lines.

"Jin," she said, her voice turning completely hollow. "It's not over. Look at the southern horizon."

Jin snatched the binoculars and swung them past the drifting freighters, out toward the open mouth of the Singapore Strait.

Plowing through the morning mist at thirty knots came no commercial tugs or tactical skiffs. Emerging from the deep shipping lane was a gray-hulled naval corvette, its bow wave tossing smaller craft aside like driftwood, its long-range search radar sweeping the Keppel basin with blinding, unceasing pulses of cold white fire.

CHAPTER 34

Chapter 34

The salt spray had dried into a white crust along the brass rim of the bridge binoculars, turning the gray silhouette in the channel into a trembling blur. Jin lowered the glass, his thumb rubbing the stiff, unyielding knot at the base of his spine. Decades of standing on vibrating deckplates had ground the cartilage between his lower vertebrae to dry dust; every swell of the sea sent a dull, electric ache straight up his neck.

"Corvette," Jin said. The word was rough, scraped raw by bunker vapor and thirty hours of stale black tea. "State maritime enforcement. pennant five-zero-two. They aren't mercenaries, Lin. That’s a commissioned naval hull, and they're riding the crest of the incoming tide."

Behind him in the crane cabin, Dr. Lin Zhang did not look up from the glare of the terminal. The skin under her eyes had bruised to a deep, plum-colored exhaustion, and a fresh migraine hammered rhythmically against the inside of her left temple. Her fingers moved in sharp, unhesitating bursts across a keyboard whose letter keys had long since been worn down to bare, yellowed plastic. Beside her, a battered thermos sat half-drained, its surface slick with the inescapable condensation of ninety-degree harbor humidity.

"They're acting on an emergency admiralty writ," she muttered, her voice pitched low and fast. "Euro-Asian Maritime Finance filed an ex parte seizure petition in the high court at dawn. The banks are trying to declare the entire drydock an abandoned hazard before our sortition register clears."

"They're doing twenty-two knots," Aisyah called from the gantry catwalk outside. She slid through the doghouse hatch, carrying a dripping canvas bag of optical cleaning rags. The tips of her fingers were scarred with pale, jagged lines from an old high-voltage flashover, yet she worked the brass latch with practiced gentleness. "The bow wave is already washing over the outer breakwater. If they reach Berth Seven, their boarding party will be on the docks in six minutes."

"They won't board," Lin whispered. She wasn't speaking out of bravado. Her teeth were clenched against the pain behind her eyes, her mind tracking the complex legal knots she had watched her father untangle thirty years ago on the muddy quays of Guangzhou. He had been a low-tier tally clerk, a quiet man who spent his evenings showing her how foreign shell corporations used three nested flags of convenience to make multimillion-dollar freighters legally vanish between ports. *The law is never solid ground, Lin,* he used to tell her, dipping a cheap steel nib into blue ink. *It is only water. You do not fight a wave; you dig a channel and let the water drown the man who made it.*

"Uncle Tan," Jin said into the low-frequency radio mic. "Spin the turbine ballast pumps. Open the steam bypass valves on the auxiliary boilers. If they launch rubber raiding craft, I want a thermal curtain twenty feet off the water. No iron. No projectiles. We give them nothing to shoot back at."

"Understood, Captain," the old engineer's voice crackled through the speaker, accompanied by the deep, rhythmic *thung-clank* of the dock's low-pressure steam manifold warming up. "Pumps are drawing from the tidal tailrace now. Seawater pressure rising."

"Lin," Jin turned, his hand gripping the edge of the steel navigation table to take the weight off his bad hip. "The laser link to Johor is flickering. The morning squall is chewing up the optical beam."

Lin glanced toward the secondary display. Across the eight-mile stretch of gray water separating their decommissioned crane tower from the Malaysian shore, the optical transceiver’s indicator lamp was fluttering between steady amber and a warning violet. The tropical rain, advancing across the channel like a gray curtain hanging from the clouds, was scattering the infrared pulses. Packets were dropping.

"The Hague registry server requires three synchronized consensus signatures," she said, her breathing shallow, perfectly controlled. "Ours. Johor’s. And the merchant convoy holding outside the territorial limit. If the squall cuts the beam before the crypt-hash completes, the asset lock fails. The admiralty court will designate this facility an unregistered private obstruction. The corvette’s commander will have full legal authority to impound every hull tied to our piers."

The ship-to-shore radio receiver crackled, the speaker buzzing with the crisp, clipped baritone of an officer who had spent twenty years running naval intercept patrols.

"Keppel-Batam Basin, this is Indonesian Coast Guard vessel *KRI Haryanto*," the voice boomed, flat and devoid of personal malice. "To the vessel master or acting port authority at Drydock Four. You are harboring three blacklisted commercial bulkers subject to high court arrest orders. Under the Regional Maritime Anti-Piracy Convention, you are instructed to lower all crane gantries, secure all mooring lines, and prepare to receive a judicial boarding party. Acknowledge immediately on this frequency."

Jin stepped to the microphone. "Commander, this is Captain Jin Wei. You are entering a declared humanitarian refuge anchorage governed by the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea. We have over four hundred displaced mariners and shore workers undergoing quarantine and medical relief. Any military boarding creates immediate structural peril to non-combatant lives."

"Captain Jin," the reply returned instantly, measured, rational, and chillingly confident. "We are aware of your claims. However, our orders derive from an executed maritime mortgage lien backed by sovereign bondholders. If your anchorage is uncertified, your refuge status has no legal standing in this admiralty jurisdiction. We will not use destructive force unless fired upon, but we will board and seize the harbor master's office. You have four minutes to clear the southern slipway."

"Four minutes," Aisyah said quietly. Her hand hovered over the hydraulic release for the container drop-blocks—hundreds of tons of rusted pig iron suspended by counterweights that could seal the inner basin with a wall of impassable steel, but would permanently trap their own supply barges inside. "Jin, do I drop the wedges?"

"Hold," Lin commanded.

Her terminal screen had frozen at eighty-one percent.

Outside, the first heavy drops of monsoon rain struck the reinforced glass of the crane cabin with the force of thrown pebbles. Through the salt-streaked pane, Jin saw the *Haryanto* cutting its speed slightly, turning broadside to drop two rigid-hull inflatable skiffs from its stern ramps. The naval craft were crewed by men in dark, fire-retardant coveralls—no heavy machine guns mounted, but carrying pneumatic grapples and non-lethal boarding ladders. They were professionals, methodically doing what they believed was necessary to keep the most congested shipping artery on earth from falling into lawless anarchy.

"The laser beam is down to forty percent transmission," Lin whispered, her fingernails digging into the palm of her hand. "The water vapor is dispersing the pulse."

"Aisyah," Jin barked. "The optical receiver housing. Did you clear the salt crust from the cyan emitter?"

Aisyah froze for half a second. "The secondary hood was sticking—"

She didn't finish the sentence. She kicked the cabin door open, lunging out onto the exposed steel catwalk sixty meters above the boiling gray basin. The squall hit her instantly, plastering her faded work shirt to her ribs, the wind tearing at her braided hair. She threw herself flat against the wet, diamond-plate steel, crawling toward the gantry's forward boom where the optical transceiver perched on its gyroscopic mount.

Jin reached for the safety harness hanging by the door, his teeth set against the blinding jab of pain in his sacrum, but Lin’s voice cut through the howling wind like an iron wedge.

"Don't," Lin said, not looking up. "She knows the mount. Watch the display."

On the monochrome monitor, the line representing the optical link flickered. Through the cabin window, Jin saw Aisyah reach the emitter housing, wrap her legs around the steel rail, and drag the wet sleeve of her jacket across the thick quartz lens, scraping away the dried brine that had baked onto the glass under the morning sun.

The indicator light on Lin’s console surged from violet to steady, piercing emerald.

"Connection clear," Lin said. Her breath hitched. "The Johor sortition assembly just confirmed their seat. One hundred and one delegates. Supermajority reached."

"What about the merchant convoy?" Jin asked, watching the *Haryanto's* lead inflatable bounce across the gray chop three cables out. "Captain Malek?"

"He's in," Lin whispered.

She pressed her thumb against the mechanical enter key, driving it down until the brass contact beneath bottomed out against the frame.

The terminal did not chime. There was no triumphant fanfare. Only the rapid, staccato chattering of the teleprinter beside the chart table as the cryptographic transaction resolved across the air-gapped optical network, bouncing from their crane tower to Johor, and through the neutral maritime fiber line straight into the International Court of Arbitration’s public registry desk in The Hague.

The document was not an appeal. It was a unilateral, irrevocable encumbrance: a perpetual commons trust established under international customary law, funded by the collective sweat-equity of three thousand blacklisted seamen and registered as an indivisible public maritime conservancy. Under maritime admiralty precedent spanning three centuries, the moment an asset enters a sovereign Hague trust, all pending private mortgage liens, bank attachments, and local arrest warrants are stayed instantly by operation of law. Any officer executing a commercial seizure against trust property became personally liable for damages in their individual capacity under civil admiralty jurisdiction.

Down in the basin, the two naval inflatables were thirty yards from Berth Seven when the horn on the *Haryanto's* bridge sounded three long, resonant blasts.

The skiffs slowed instantly, their bows settling into the water as the coxswains pulled their throttles into neutral.

On the bridge of the naval vessel, Jin could see the silhouette of the commanding officer standing outside the wheelhouse wing, a pair of heavy binoculars pressed to his face, a paper printout clutched in his left hand.

The radio crackled. The officer’s voice had changed. The brisk, administrative authority was gone, replaced by the profound, cautious hesitation of a man who had suddenly realized the ground beneath his feet was no longer solid rock, but six miles of judicial open water.

"Keppel Basin Authority," Commander Raden said, his cadence slow, almost reluctant. "We have... received an automated priority notification from the Ministry of Maritime Affairs. The admiralty marshal in Jakarta has suspended our writ. Your facility has just been registered on the International Maritime Organization ledger as a protected public refuge trust."

Jin let out a breath he felt he had been holding for forty-eight hours. The damp air filled his lungs, tasting of diesel soot and clean rain. "We confirm, Commander. The docks are held in common trust. We are bound by international law to offer safe harbor, bunkering, and repair to any vessel in need. Including yours, should you require freshwater or auxiliary power."

A long silence hung on the channel, broken only by the steady drum of rain against the steel hull of the crane.

"We do not require assistance, Captain Jin," the commander replied finally. "We will hold position at the territorial line to observe. But be advised... the syndicates who held those mortgages do not abandon three hundred million dollars of steel because of a Dutch filing."

The *Haryanto's* engines rumbled, the corvette backing slowly into the channel, its inflatables hooking back into the recovery cradles.

In the crane cabin, Lin slumped back against her steel chair, her arms trembling so violently she had to interlock her fingers to keep them still. "It worked," she breathed, her voice barely carrying over the hum of the cooling fans. "The Hague accepted the registration. The whole basin... it's legally untouchable by the banks."

Jin turned toward her, a grim, tired smile touching the corners of his mouth. "You bought us peace, Lin. Real peace."

Before she could answer, the teleprinter on the table clicked once, then twice, its motor whining as it began to advance the paper roll at double speed.

Jin frowned. "Johor again?"

Lin leaned forward, squinting through her headache at the narrow ribbon of paper emerging from the machine. The mechanical pins were not printing text. They were hammering out a jagged, frantic line of raw telemetry—a seismic pressure gradient transmitted from the seabed sensors along the deep Singapore shipping trench.

Aisyah came stumbling back into the cabin, soaking wet, shivering from the squall, her eyes fixed on the paper. "What is that?"

"It’s not Johor," Lin said, her voice turning brittle as she watched the needle spike violently off the scale. "It's the bottom sensor on the high-voltage transmission trench. Someone didn't wait for the court."

Through the floorplates beneath their boots, a deep, shuddering vibration traveled upward through sixty meters of structural steel—not the roar of an engine, but the muffled, subterranean concussion of an explosive charge detonating beneath thirty fathoms of black water.

CHAPTER 35

Chapter 35

The shockwave came not through the air, but through the iron soles of the crane’s gantry legs. Sixty meters above the harbor, the cabin groaned like an ungreased winch. Steel struts vibrated at a frequency that set the water in Lin’s tin mug shivering into concentric rings, before the single overhead flood flickered, browned out, and died.

Down in the basin, the sudden dark was absolute for five agonizing seconds. Then, with a wet, hydraulic clunk from the battery barge moored against Berth 9, the emergency arrays engaged. Dull amber emergency filaments pushed back the monsoon rain, casting long, jaundiced shadows across the flooded caisson.

Jin Wei gripped the window frame until the rust bit into the calluses of his palm. His lower vertebrae felt as though someone had driven an iron spike between the discs, the dull engine-room ache that had followed him for thirty years flaring into white heat. He reached into his shirt pocket with trembling fingers, found three dry, bitter tea leaves, and pressed them beneath his tongue—an old habit from his teenage years shoveling scrap iron on Pearl River scows, suppressing the acid bile of panic without wasting clean water.

"Trench line three," Aisyah said, wiping saltwater from her eyes with a forearm scarred by copper flash-burns. Her breathing was ragged, her chest heaving against her oilskin vest. "The deep conduit to the Batam grid. They didn't breach the lock gates—they blew the subsea umbilical. We’re cut off from mainland power."

"Not from the channel," Lin said. Her voice was thin, but her fingers were already flying across the backup terminal, its screen running on the low-voltage direct-current bus fed by the twin tidal turbines anchored in the strait. The amber display illuminated the deep hollows beneath her eyes. "Turbines are holding five hundred revolutions. The battery bank took the transient shock. We have auxiliary power for sixty hours, provided we don't light the gantry winches."

"They don't want to drown us," Jin muttered, his bunker-cough catching in his throat until he forced it down with a swallow of bitter saliva. "They want us cold. They want the pumps dead."

He raised his binoculars, wiping the salt mist from the objective lenses with the hem of his damp shirt.

Through the squall, three miles out along the edge of the international channel, a vessel was emerging from the driving grey sheet. She was not a naval patrol boat or a private tactical skiff. She was

a hundred-and-ten-meter corporate yacht, her hull painted the matte anthracite of an offshore drilling tender, her superstructure slab-sided and reinforced with enclosed bridge wings. High-frequency communication domes crowded her upper deck like cluster mushrooms, and from her foredeck, two high-pressure boarding booms jutted out over the swell.

The hull bore the clean, sans-serif lettering of the Euro-Asian Maritime Finance Corporation: *The Ardent Trustee*.

"Flagship," Lin whispered, her throat dry. "That's not the receiver's bailiffs. That's corporate executive command."

Within twenty minutes, the ship had swung broadside to the reef barrier, idling her variable-pitch thrusters against the four-knot rip tide. A heavy enclosed launch, ribbed with puncture-resistant polyurethane foam, dropped from her stern davits and came churning across the yellow, silt-churned surface of the harbor, flying the international blue-and-white checkered parley flag from its radar mast.

*

Julian Hauer stepped onto the slippery timber stringer of Berth 8 without the aid of his deckhands.

At fifty-six, the chief operations officer of Euro-Asian Maritime carried the posture of an unyielding structural beam, though his knees made a faint clicking sound as he took the rise of the slipway. He wore an unadorned slate-gray foul-weather coat made of dense, non-reflective wool, devoid of insignia except for a small platinum tie-tack pinning his collar against the wind. His silvered hair was cut ruthlessly close to his scalp, revealing the prominent veins at his temples that throbbed whenever global clearing houses fell out of synchronization. For two decades, Hauer had managed thirty billion dollars in revolving maritime debt. He did not view himself as an extortionist or an imperialist; he viewed himself as the fragile wall separating five hundred million city-dwellers from an empty grain silo and cold power grids. To him, the commons movement was not an ideological revolution—it was systemic entropy, a rust in the gears of the world's logistical engine.

Behind him walked two private security liaisons, their hands tucked visibly outside their slickers, carrying neither sidearms nor riot batons, only heavy, shock-resistant data slates bound by lanyards to their wrists.

Jin descended the final flight of the crane's ladder, his knees trembling from the damp chill, Uncle Tan walking beside him with a heavy bamboo walking stick to brace his arthritic hip.

"Captain Jin," Hauer said. His voice was level, cultured, carrying the dry, clipped cadence of a Zurich boardroom despite the roar of the surf against the breakwater. "I believe you know why I am here."

"You lost a seabed cable, Mr. Hauer," Jin replied, standing his ground on the oil-stained concrete. The monsoon wind whipped between them, carrying the smell of wet soot and decomposing kelp. "Or rather, your contractors lost one. It was very loud. It broke three of our bottom sensors."

Hauer did not flinch. "A severed cable is a municipal infrastructure failure. My surveyors are assessing the seabed. But your occupation of this facility is not an infrastructure failure. It is an unhedged maritime default. I hold four hundred and twelve million dollars in secondary notes against Drydock 4, registered through the Singapore Admiralty Court and backed by the sovereign development fund."

He extended a leather-bound folder encased in clear waterproof vinyl. Jin did not reach for it.

"The Hague Perpetual Asset Trust recognized our collective maritime refuge four hours ago," Uncle Tan said, his voice deep and gravelly, like stones tumbling in a riverbed. "The injunction binds all signatories to the Law of the Sea. You have no jurisdiction within three cables of the slipway."

Hauer sighed, a small puff of white vapor escaping into the tropical drizzle. "The Hague can file trusts until the sea boils, gentlemen. But the Hague does not buy fuel oil. The Hague does not guarantee the reinsurance syndicates at Lloyd's that cover the grain hulls steaming through the Malacca Strait right now. If I declare this basin an uninsurable hazard zone, eighty percent of the merchant traffic bound for your berths will divert to Johor or face immediate seizure of their cargo by their lenders. You will starve on your own slipways, surrounded by cold steel and seawater you cannot drink."

He stepped closer, his cold grey eyes locking onto Jin’s. "Surrender the yard. Evacuate the refugee mariners to the Batam quarantine anchorage. Allow our technical crews to restore the deep feeder cable and place the drydocks under court-appointed trusteeship. If you do, I will personally authorize the release of three container-loads of medical stores and fuel oil for your crews. If you refuse, I will initiate an algorithmic port freeze. Not a single vessel will touch your quays without its credit lines turning to dust before its lines are tied."

Jin looked past Hauer's shoulder, toward the gray expanse of the strait. The salt spray stung the chemical burn beneath his collar.

"You think we are holding this dock by force, Mr. Hauer," Jin said quietly.

"I know you have wired your high-pressure monitors to the basin mains," Hauer said evenly. "I am an engineer by training. I do not confuse non-lethal defense with helplessness. But a fortress that cannot trade is simply a tomb."

"Come with me," Jin said, turning toward the vast, corrugated-iron cavern of Drydock 4's pump-house.

Hauer's security men leaned forward, but Hauer raised a gloved hand. "Why?"

"You came to demand our surrender," Jin said, his voice cutting through the wind. "The man who holds the mortgage should at least see who is spending the interest. Come see who decides."

*

The interior of the machine hall was cold, echoing, and smelled of wet rust and tallow.

There was no stage, no lectern, and no corporate dais. Suspended from the sixty-ton traveling overhead crane were half a dozen low-draw LED work lamps, throwing harsh white circles across the concrete caisson floor. Gathered in concentric rings around a central wooden table were one hundred and one people.

Hauer paused on the threshold, his eyes scanning the gathering.

They were not political cadres. They were deckhands in salt-stained coveralls, Indonesian ballast-tank welders with their hoods pushed back over oily rags, a woman in her sixties wearing the faded nylon jacket of a Singaporean ferry pilot, and three young engine-room apprentices whose hands were stained black with graphite grease. In the center of the ring sat a brass lottery drum—a manual, hand-cranked sortition cage recovered from a passenger liner's recreation deck.

On the table lay a single paper nautical chart of the Singapore Strait, weighted down by brass scrap nuts.

"Order of business," an older woman called out—a retired tugboat captain from Sekupang, her voice carrying across the iron girders. "Item forty-two: Bunkering priority for the *Minerva Star*. Bulk carrier, forty thousand deadweight tons. Her owners went into liquidation three days ago. Her crew hasn't had shore rations in two weeks. Her main generator has two hours of fuel remaining before her refrigeration units fail and sixty tons of poultry rots in the hold."

A young rigger stood up, holding a red copper voting token. "If we give them forty tons from the emergency tank, our reserve drops below thirty percent. If the tidal turbine grid drops out during the neap tide, we lose the desalination plant."

"Her auxiliary pump is cracked," a mechanic from the third row shouted. "I worked her sister ship. If we supply three welders and forty sheets of six-millimeter plate, she can run her own ballast pumps on half-load. She trades us eight pallets of rice and twenty cases of engine filters for the fuel."

"The consortium placed a lien on that rice," Hauer said aloud, his voice involuntary, slicing through the hum of the hall.

Every face in the circle turned toward him. There was no hostility in their eyes, no ideological fury—only the profound, exhausting scrutiny of people measuring finite calories and cubic meters of fresh water against a rising storm.

The tugboat captain looked at him over her wire-rimmed spectacles. "Who is this?"

"Julian Hauer," Jin Wei said, walking to the edge of the circle. "Chief Operations Officer of the mortgage holders. He has arrived to inform us that our credit has been liquidated."

A murmur moved through the ring, but nobody stood. Nobody shouted.

"We are running a sortition council, Mr. Hauer," the woman said calmly, pointing to the brass drum. "One hundred and one members, selected by lot this morning from the basin register. We have seventy-six minutes remaining before the tidal slack. Does your syndicate have an operational proposal for the *Minerva Star*'s poultry, or are you here as an observer?"

Hauer stood frozen, his hand still resting inside his coat pocket where his encrypted satellite uplink hummed against his ribs. For thirty years, decisions of maritime salvage had been resolved in glass-paneled rooms in London and Singapore by calculating debt-service coverage ratios to the third decimal place.

Here, a deckhand with half an index finger missing was balancing the caloric survival of seventy thousand chickens against the electrical draw of a reverse-osmosis water filter, using chalk marks on an iron plate.

Before Hauer could find his voice, the high-frequency speaker mounted to the assembly wall let out a sharp, double chirp.

Lin Zhang rushed from the communications bay, her boots skidding on the damp concrete. In her hand she held a thermal teleprinter strip, the paper still curling from the machine's heater.

"Jin," she said, her voice shaking with an intensity that pulled every eye in the caisson toward her. "The outer anchorage. The *Minerva Star* just cut her automated corporate transponder."

Hauer turned sharply toward her. "That is an international maritime violation. Her insurers will cancel her class certificate within thirty seconds."

"She didn't do it alone," Lin said, handing the ribbon to Jin, her eyes fixed on Hauer. "The *Crested Eagle* and the *Hanjin Horizon* just followed her. Three container vessels, dead-weight total two hundred and ten thousand tons. They've shut down their fleet management uplinks. They've swung their bows toward the drydock channel, and their masters are broadcasting on channel sixteen."

Jin Wei looked down at the paper, then looked up, his jaw set, the pain in his back forgotten in the sudden, surging quiet of the machine hall.

"What are they broadcasting, Lin?"

"They're not asking for your corporate clearance, Mr. Hauer," Lin said, her voice ringing off the rusted iron walls. "They’re asking the assembly for permission to enter the roadstead and discharge their cargo to the commons."

CHAPTER 36

Chapter 36

The rain hit the corrugated roof of Drydock 4 like a volley of lead shot, drumming so hard the iron ribs of the caisson vibrated against Jin Wei's shoulder blades. Outside the caisson gate, across the churned slate water of the roadstead, three hundred thousand tons of steel were drifting toward the shoals without corporate tugs, their deck lights glowing like yellow teeth through the monsoon squall.

"They're coming in blind," Lin Zhang said. Her thumb traced a fresh bruise along her jawline where a swinging optical cable had clipped her two nights prior. Her radio headset gave off a dry, crackling hiss, fouled by lightning five miles south over the Karimun islands. "Singapore traffic control has wiped their transponder slots. On the commercial plot, those three ships do not exist. They are ghost hulls."

Hauer did not move. His knuckles, pale and dry, remained wedged inside his tailored oilskin coat. "The syndicate has already issued a remote emergency override to the fairway escort fleet," he said, his voice flat, scrubbed of malice, carrying only the terrifying calm of an actuary balancing an unavoidable write-off. "Those container vessels are encumbered assets under English admiralty law. If their crews attempt to breach the Batam shoals to discharge bonded freight into an unregistered commons, our private harbor tugs have standing contractual authority to intercept."

"Intercept?" Chen Rui looked up from the grease-stained structural table, his forearms bound in stiff canvas wraps against the ache of swollen tendons. He pushed his spectacles up his nose with the ball of his wrist. "The fairway is eight cables wide at low water, Hauer. You send four thousand horsepower into the flank of a laden feeder ship in this swell, and you'll crack her fuel double-bottom. You'll dump three thousand barrels of heavy oil into the mangrove nurseries before midnight."

"Then her master should have respected the lien," Hauer said softly. "The market cannot absorb the precedent of seized tonnage dissolving into mutual aid."

Through the salt-streaked glass of the watchtower, three sharp crimson flares arced over the outer channel.

Apex Marine's tactical escort cutters were already moving. They were twin-screw, reinforced-steel harbor workhorses, painted dead charcoal, usually hired to fend off sea pirates in the Phillip Channel. Now their bows threw twin walls of white foam as their diesel blocks roared against the rising ebb tide. Behind them lumbered the *Titan Barque*, a ninety-ton bollard-pull salvage tug under corporate charter, its flared ice-strengthened bow surging forward at twelve knots, aiming directly for the steering gear of the *Minerva Star*.

Jin Wei grabbed the copper handle of the assembly horn and pulled. The brass diaphragm bellowed across the flooded basin, a low, guttural shriek that rattled the loose galvanized plates above the machine shop.

"Aisyah!" Jin shouted into the hard-wired copper intercom. "Can the tidal turbines take the load?"

Her voice crackled back, breath ragged, fighting the howl of the salt spray down in the sea-chest chambers. "Submerged cells are at peak torque! The current's giving us four knots clean! If you want the water monitors running at full head, trip the bypass on Berth 8 right now!"

"Trip it!" Jin roared.

At the edge of the decommissioned drydock pier, two retired municipal fire tugs and four salvaged shipyard utility craft—crewed by dockers in orange flotation vests patched with industrial duct tape—pushed out into the chop. They didn't carry steel guns or boarding pikes. Bolted to their bows were heavy industrial monitors salvaged from decommissioned chemical wharves: brass nozzles with three-inch bores, fed directly by the surge of the tidal battery banks.

A thousand yards out, the *Titan Barque* swung hard to port, her blunt snout carving through the swells. Her wheelhouse windows were barred with steel mesh to repel boarding hooks, her searchlights sweeping across the sea toward the lead wooden sampans that were struggling to lay navigational pilot lights for the incoming container giants.

Through the squall, the voice of the *Titan Barque*'s dispatcher boomed over the VHF channel sixteen, relayed by the harbor's high-altitude optical repeater: *All unauthorized small craft in Sector Four, clear the fairway. Maintain safe berth or be subject to hydrodynamic fouling. Clear the fairway.*

"She's not slowing," Lin said, her hand clenching the edge of the radar console. Her knuckles were white, her eyes burning from three days without real rest. "The dispatcher in Singapore is running the throttle sequence via satellite uplink. It's an automated intercept trajectory."

"Look at her deck," Uncle Tan said quietly. He had hobbled up the steep metal stairs from the sortition floor, his swollen knees clicking beneath his stained drill trousers. He was pointing a trembling, grease-blackened finger through the rain. "The wheelhouse isn't empty, Lin. Automation holds the wheel, but the flesh is still standing by the throttles."

On the bridge wings of the *Titan Barque*, three silhouettes in yellow rain gear stood clutching the salt-slick railings. They were not corporate mercenaries or syndicate lawyers. They were Batam mariners—men who had traded shifts at the repair docks, men whose cousins lived in the stilt villages of Pulau Buluh, whose wages were sent home in paper envelopes to buy rice and malaria medication.

Behind them, the massive black bow of the *Minerva Star* plowed through the dark, her deck officers leaning over her high forecastle, hammering a warning on her brass ship's bell—a frantic, hollow clang that was swallowed by the storm.

"They're going to sheer her rudder," Chen Rui muttered, his fingers knotting into the frayed hem of his canvas jacket. "The *Titan* hits her at that angle, the container ship will ground herself on the western reef. Everything in the holds will break."

Jin Wei seized the radio transceiver from the bench. He didn't use the emergency channel. He didn't cite the international convention on salvage or quote the articles of the sortition charter. He switched the selector to the open local working frequency—the channel used by harbor deckhands to trade spare cylinder liners and warn of drifting palm logs.

"Matthias," Jin Wei spoke, his voice dropping an octave, rasping against the bunker fumes that had scarred his throat thirty years ago. "Matthias bin Kasim. I know you're at the winch console on that tug."

A breath of static answered him.

"You took your seamanship papers on the old *Riau Trader* with my brother," Jin said into the microphone. "Your daughter’s school fees were cleared through the clinic account in Berth 7 three months ago when the syndicate froze your payroll card. If you hit that ship, you’re not breaking a contract, Matthias. You’re ramming eighty thousand tons of poultry and grain meant for the basin, while your own village is boiling salted cassava."

On the radar sweep, the green blip of the *Titan Barque* continued to close the gap: four hundred yards, three hundred yards. Her wash was tossing the civilian pilot sampans like dry husks. In the watchtower, Hauer stepped forward, his eyes fixing on the digital readout of the vessel's telemetry on his personal tablet.

"The override has locked the governor," Hauer whispered, almost to himself, the certainty in his posture trembling for the first time. "The company pays their pensions. They won't forfeit their livelihoods."

"A pension is paper, Mr. Hauer," Uncle Tan said softly at his elbow. "You can't boil paper when the straits close."

Down on the lead utility launch, Aisyah’s crew unleashed the high-pressure monitors. Two massive plumes of sea foam leaped sixty yards through the dark, not striking the tug’s crew, but burying the wheelhouse windows in a thundering, blind cataract of green water. The blinding salt deluge shorted out the tug's forward optical cameras, stripping the remote algorithmic pilot in Singapore of its visual lock.

The tactical guidance light on Hauer’s screen flashed yellow, then dead gray. *Sensor telemetry degraded. Reverting to manual helm.*

For three seconds, nothing moved except the fury of the tide. The *Titan Barque*’s steel bow was fifty paces from the towering flank of the *Minerva Star*. A collision was a mathematical certainty.

Then, through the roar of the rain and the scream of the wind, came a sound like an iron mountain tearing itself open.

CLANG-CLANG-CLANG.

It was the manual brake band slipping on a five-ton windlass.

On the forecastle of the *Titan Barque*, two deckhands, their yellow slickers plastered to their backs by the deluge, lunged with heavy sledgehammers. They didn't touch the computer terminals or the encrypted bridge consoles. They struck the brass emergency release dogs on the starboard hawsepipe.

A cascade of rust and sparks shot thirty feet into the night as seven shots of forged-iron anchor chain roared out of the tug's locker.

The anchor struck the seabed twelve fathoms down, biting deep into the hard coral silt. The chain went taut with a hydraulic shriek that echoed off the steel flanks of the drydock. The *Titan Barque*'s bow violently jerked around to face the incoming swell, her stern slewing harmlessly away from the *Minerva Star*'s path, dragging her propellers through churned brown mud.

Behind her, on the second corporate interceptor, the *Apex Prowler*, the running lights suddenly blinked out. A heavy thud reverberated across the water as her crew dropped their port bower anchor directly into the fairway silt, killing their engines in dead silence.

Over the open channel, a single voice broke the squall. It was Matthias, breathing hard, his knuckles audible as he tapped the microphone casing twice.

"Batam control," the deckhand said, his accent thick with the salt of the islands. "Our windlass is fouled. Steering gear unresponsive. We are at anchor in the fairway, maintaining position for the safety of life at sea."

A long pause hung over the water, filled only by the hiss of rain on the dark roadstead.

"Requesting harbor pilot from Berth 7," Matthias added steadily. "Send a line. We are out of fuel."

Hauer stood motionless. The blue glow of his encrypted tablet flickered once, showing sixty-four systemic breach alerts across the Malacca tracking matrix, then the screen went dark as the local tower's laser link dropped beneath the weight of the downpour.

Jin Wei lowered the radio handset. His back throbbed with a dull, grinding fire, but as he stepped out onto the open platform of the watchtower, the smell of the salt spray was clean, cold, and entirely free of engine smoke.

Down in the basin, the massive silhouette of the *Minerva Star* slid past the caisson mouth, her wash rocking the iron gates with a slow, deliberate heave, her bow nudging into the waiting arms of the commons.

Behind Jin Wei, on the sorting floor below, the brass assembly drum began to turn again. But before the first wooden token could fall, a long, low horn blast echoed from the outer deep-water anchorage—

not from the container ships, but from the gray line of industrial tankers anchored on the horizon, their deck lights flickering on, one by one, through the dark.

CHAPTER 37

Chapter 37

The horn blasts did not stop. They rolled across the shallow swell of the Malacca Strait in rolling five-second bellows, deep enough to shudder through the rusted iron plates of the watchtower floor beneath Jin Wei's boots.

One after another, the silhouettes on the outer perimeter—sixteen laden crude carriers, nine bulk freighters wallowing low under Indonesian coal, thirty feeder vessels anchored in the roadstead—lit their deck floods. The blinding white sodium glare cut through the tropical rain, turning the gray horizon into a floating city of cold steel.

Beside him, Lin Zhang leaned her forehead against the salt-streaked glass of the watch station, her breath leaving a brief circle of fog on the pane. Her thumb tapped a silent, rhythmic cadence against her collarbone—a habit she had kept since her student days in Beijing, measuring the erratic racing of her pulse against bone whenever the exhaustion threatened to pull her under.

"It isn't an attack," she whispered, her voice gravelly from two days without sleep.

"No," Jin Wei said. His lower spine burned with an old, jagged heat, the vertebrae grinding together like dry gears every time the wind rocked the gantry. He smelled the sulfur of cheap bunker fuel drifting from the south, mingled with the sweet, vegetative stink of mangrove mud exposed by the falling tide. "They're swinging into the current. Every last one of them."

Down on the pier, the heavy Manila mooring hawsers of the *Minerva Star* creaked under tension as dockhands threw them over the bollards. Aisyah binti Rahman was already at the edge of the caisson, her yellow slicker smeared with grease from the turbine winches. Her fingers, still tender and scarred where a short-circuit arc had bitten the flesh three weeks prior, gripped a battered bullhorn. She was not shouting orders; she was waving lanterns in short, deliberate arcs, guiding the swollen freighter into the silt-dredged pocket.

Across the water, the radio console sputtered. The commercial frequencies—the locked channels rented by Euro-Asian Maritime Finance and guarded by corporate dispatch in London—were silent, deadened by the dropped links. But the open line, the simple copper-wired channel patched through the gantry crane's laser receiver, was hissing with human breath.

"Berth 7, this is *Crest Harmony*," an unfamiliar voice crackled through the speaker, speaking in heavily accented Tagalog-English. "Draft fourteen meters. We have four hundred tons of grain spoilage in hold two because the port clearance lockout refused our customs token. Our master has stepped off

the bridge. Chief mate speaking. We are refusing the Singapore anchorage tug fee. Do you have a pilot who knows the shoals south of Pulau Bukom?"

Before Jin Wei could lift the handset, another voice broke over the carrier wave, flat and hard with Northern Chinese vowels. "Bulk carrier *Donghai Nine*. We have three days of drinking water remaining. The company account in Hong Kong is frozen by admiralty lien. We can't pay the bunker barge. Is your desal line live?"

Lin Zhang’s tablet did not show digital charts or streaming satellite telemetry. It showed only the raw pulse of the mesh: local radio nodes bouncing coordinates from mast to mast, ship to ship, an invisible web stretching fifty miles across the chokepoint. The corporate tracking grid, built to meter every drop of fuel and lease every nautical mile to the highest bidding syndicate, was going blind. It had not been hacked; its mariners had simply turned the bridge consoles toward the wall.

"Jin," Lin said softly, her eyes tracking the flickering amber pulses across the screen. "It's the whole eastern channel. The second mate on the *Aegis Osprey* just threw their satellite decryptor over the side. They’re running on magnetic compass and coastal lights."

Below them, on the gravel apron between the machine shops and Drydock 4, a crowd of mariners had gathered under the tin overhang. Uncle Tan stood among them, his wool sweater soaked through at the shoulders, his arthritic knees stiff as he ladled hot ginger tea from a twenty-liter stockpot into dented tin mugs. He did not speak of treaties or shipping charters. When a soot-streaked oiler from an Apex tug stumbled up the ramp, shivering from the cold squall, the old man simply pressed a steaming cup into the man’s calloused palms and pointed toward the dry warmth of the toolroom.

A door slammed open at the base of the gantry.

Chen Rui came taking the metal stairs three at a time, his forearms bound in tight elastic bandages to brace his swollen tendons against the vibration of the dock cranes. His face was pale, his eyes wide.

"The pilot boats," Chen panted, catching his breath against the iron handrail. "Hauer’s flagship. The *Apex Vanguard*. She just cut her engines half a mile off the western reef."

Jin Wei turned his binoculars toward the deep-water passage. Through the lashing drizzle, the low, predatory profile of the private tactical cruiser was visible, wallowing sideways in the four-knot tidal rip. Her long-range strobe arrays were dark. Her twin diesel turbines, which usually threw a rooster-tail of white foam thirty yards into the air, were gurgling at idle, barely holding her head against the swell.

Aboard the *Apex Vanguard*, Hauer stood on the bridge wing, rain plastering his gray hair against his temples.

He held the satellite terminal to his ear, but all he heard was the flat, synthetic tone of an automated liquidation notice. The Hong Kong branch of Euro-Asian Maritime Finance had initiated a margin call forty minutes ago; the fuel credit cards for his three interceptors had been invalidated mid-channel. The digital bunkering barge that was supposed to meet him at the fairway buoy had already turned its bow

toward Batam, its crew refusing to pump a single liter of marine gas oil without a sovereign settlement that London could no longer guarantee.

Beside him, his young helmsman was watching the depth sounder.

"Current is dragging us toward the shoals, Commander," the boy said, his voice cracking. "We have twenty minutes of auxiliary fuel in the day tank. If we don't start the main engines and run for the commercial berths, we'll ground the rudders on the reef."

"The commercial berths are locked," Hauer said, his voice hollowed of its usual military precision. "The port authority has shut the gates until the admiralty court opens in Geneva on Monday morning. They won't take our lines."

"Then where do we go?"

Hauer looked across the water. Through the mist, the high, orange skeletal towers of the Keppel-Batam yard burned like a cluster of torches against the black jungle shoreline. There were no armed cutters patrolling its entrance. There were only two wooden work-skiffs, driven by longtail outboard motors, circling the incoming freighters with coils of heavy braided line, guiding forty-thousand-ton giants through the narrow channel by the naked eye and thirty years of local mud-knowledge.

He looked down at his desk. His tactical roster, his automated intercept logs, his legal indemnities signed by three ministries of transport—none of them could turn a propeller without fuel. None of them could feed forty hungry deckhands whose wage cards had just evaporated into bank restructuring receivership.

Hauer picked up the VHF radio microphone. He felt the cold zinc of the casing bite into his palm. He did not call the command center in Jurong. He clicked the dial to the open local channel.

"Berth 7," he said, the words dragging out of him like anchor chain across rock. "This is *Apex Vanguard*. We have lost main propulsion due to fuel exhaustion. We have forty-two crew on board. Requesting permission to come alongside the breakwater."

In the watchtower, the room went entirely quiet except for the hiss of rain on the corrugated roof.

Chen Rui looked at Jin Wei, his mouth slightly open. Lin Zhang did not move; she only stared at the small brass telegraph timer mounted beside the radio.

Jin Wei walked over to the console. He remembered his first command, forty years ago—a rust-streaked timber coaster that had lost its rudder in a typhoon off Hainan. The port master at Kaohsiung had left them outside the breakwater for four days because their insurance certificate lacked an underwriter's stamp, while his men ate raw rice and bailed seawater with plastic buckets until their hands bled.

He reached down and keyed the transmitter.

"Apex Vanguard," Jin Wei said, his voice level, gravelly, carrying no triumph, only the heavy, unmistakable weight of the sea. "Cut your auxiliary. Drop your port hook in four fathoms off the south spit to stop your drift. We're sending two longtail boats with a tow line. You will surrender your steering to the harbor watch."

He paused, glancing out at the bay where eighty ships now rode the swell together, their lights reflecting in long, golden ribbons across the dark water.

"And bring your mess tins," Jin Wei added. "Uncle Tan made tea."

The line clicked off.

Lin Zhang let out a long, ragged breath that sounded like a sob, though her face remained set in stone. She turned away from the glass and began shutting down the terminal monitors, one by one. The blue glare died, leaving only the amber glow of the kerosene storm lanterns hung from the gantry beams.

"It's over here," she said quietly.

"No," Jin Wei said, looking down at his sea bag resting against the bulkhead—the old canvas sack he had packed forty-eight hours ago, containing two clean shirts, his coastal master's license, and the wooden sortition token he had drawn in the first assembly. "The channel is open. Now we have to make sure they can never close it again."

He looked through the rain toward the deep slipway where the electric sea-glider sat low in its cradle, its carbon hulls dripping with freshwater runoff, its batteries humming as they drew the last surge of power from the falling tide.

Aisyah appeared at the top of the tower stairs, wiping salt spray from her cheeks with the back of her sleeve. "The glider is trimmed, Captain. Tide turns north in twenty minutes. If we leave now, we catch the dawn window through the Sunda Strait before the naval cordon can reposition."

Jin Wei picked up his bag. The weight was familiar, balanced against the persistent ache in his hip. He looked at Lin Zhang, who had already slung her battered leather satchel over her shoulder.

"Geneva," she said, testing the word as if it belonged to another planet.

"Geneva," Jin Wei agreed, stepping out into the wind.

Down on the pier, as their boots hit the wet timber, the horn of the *Minerva Star* answered the outer anchorage with three short, clean blasts—the ancient mariner's signal for a vessel underway, clear of the shoals, and moving into the open sea. But as the glider's lines were cast off and the hull slid silently into the black current, Jin Wei's eyes caught a solitary red beacon flashing three miles out on the perimeter—not a civilian distress flare, but the tight, pulsing strobe of an approaching high-speed sovereign hydrofoil that carried no maritime identification at all.

CHAPTER 38

Chapter 38

The red strobe on the outer shoals did not blink with the lazy cadence of a channel buoy. It stabbed through the squall in sharp, mechanical pulses—four beats, a split-second fracture of darkness, then four beats again.

Jin Wei gripped the cold composite coaming of the sea-glider's hatch. The vibration of the twin hull beneath his boots was barely a whisper compared to the violent thrum of the diesel freighters he had captained for thirty years; it felt like standing on the back of a diving ray. To his left, nestled against the gunwale, Lin Zhang sat with her knees drawn tight to her ribs, her satchel pressed against her sternum. Her thumbs moved compulsively against the frayed hem of her canvas coat, smoothing the threadbare cotton the way her mother used to level raw millet in the measuring cup before the winter rations were set.

"Hydrofoil," Aisyah said from the helm console. Her voice had the flat, spent calm of a diver who had stayed down ten minutes past the gauge's red line. Her burned fingertips hovered above the magnetic rudder toggles. "Kevlar-sheathed hull. Deep draft when she's idling, but once those foils bite, she'll do forty-five knots through the rip. She isn't signaling Batam harbor control."

Down on Berth 9, forty feet above them, the iron decking clanged. Uncle Tan appeared at the rail, leaning heavily on a scarred teak walking stick he had turned himself from an old hatch cover. The monsoon damp had settled deep into the swelling of his knuckles, twisting his right hand into a claw, but his shoulders were squared against the driving spray. Beside him, Chen Rui was already shouting down into the shadows of the drydock trench, his forearms bound in stiff athletic tape to brace the burning ache in his tendons.

"Hold the release cables!" Chen Rui yelled through cupped hands. "She's cutting across the southern bank to pin the glider in the slipway!"

The approaching vessel cleared the reef point. Even through the rain, her silhouette was unmistakable: a private enforcement interceptor, stripped of national insignia, bearing only the dull matte-gray coat of the receiver syndicates. Her twin searchlights flicked on together, carving two searing cones of white light through the rain that instantly turned the harbor water to boiling milk.

Over the slipway's open hail-speaker, a voice crackled through the static—dry, reedy, stripped of all maritime inflection by a corporate satellite vocoder.

"Vessel departing Berth Nine, you are in breach of maritime lien foreclosure order seven-seven-nine. The Keppel-Batam yard and all associated low-carbon auxiliary craft are under sovereign receivership. Cut your propulsion immediately and make fast your headspring. Any craft entering the channel without registered clearance will be seized under admiralty embargo."

Jin Wei did not reach for a horn. He reached into his pocket, his fingers finding the small, dried clove he had carried since his first deckhand voyage out of Surabaya—shriveled, fragrant, a brittle reminder of soil while salt tried to drown everything. He rubbed it between thumb and forefinger, feeling the sharp ridge of the stem.

"They aren't firing," Lin Zhang whispered. Her eyes were wide, tracking the blinding beams as they swept across the glider’s canopy. "Why aren't they firing?"

"Because an iron lien requires intact collateral to sell at auction," Jin Wei muttered, climbing down into the cockpit well. "And because dead men don't sign over harbor concessions."

Up on the gantry bridge, Uncle Tan didn't answer through the radio. Instead, he pulled three long, brass-weighted chains that hung from the crane’s lower gantry deck.

Far above the berth, the tidal storage array groaned. It was not the sound of weaponry, but of counterweights shifting in their greased steel guides. Two massive ballast wedges—sixteen-ton blocks of poured iron slag recovered from the bottom of Drydock 4—dropped six feet through the vertical guide-chutes on either side of the slipway mouth. They hit the harbor silt with a subterranean thud that shuddered through the sea-glider’s hull, sending a four-foot surge of displaced water boiling out into the fairway.

The incoming hydrofoil’s bow dipped violently as the displacement wave caught her under her forward foils. Her starboard wing grazed the submerged timber of the old breakwater, throwing up a rooster-tail of yellow foam and rotten piling splinters. Her hull dropped off its lift, slamming into the chop with a concussive bang that shook loose her deck lights.

"Berth Nine!" the receiver’s voice barked again, losing its synthetic composure, a ragged human fear bleeding through the speaker. *"You have obstructed an authorized maritime officer! We have a financial injunction backed by the regional admiralty court!"*

Uncle Tan lifted the brass harbor horn from its cradle on the pierhead. He didn't invoke an assembly vote. He didn't cite articles of law. His voice rolled down across the water, hoarse and thick with the tobacco smoke of five decades on the Singapore roads.

"This water isn't listed on your mortgage!" the old man shouted into the storm. "Berth Seven is discharging four thousand tons of rice from the Mekong! Berth Ten is taking on fresh drinking water from the island cisterns! Every vessel in this roadstead has paid its passage in battery hours, drydock shifts, and wheat sacks! The ledger is carved into the slipway stone, boy! You have no debt to collect here, because nobody owes you a single brass coin!"

Out across the anchorage, where eighty blacked-out freighters lay swinging on their chains, the response did not come in words.

The *Minerva Star* hit her deck floods—ten thousand lumens of amber work-light illuminating her towering orange freeboard. Two seconds later, an Indonesian bulk carrier three hundred yards to the north clicked on her cargo cluster lights, bathing the channel in brilliant white. Then a Vietnamese timber freighter. Then a rusty coastal tanker from Kelantan.

Within forty seconds, eighty commercial hulls lit their working decks simultaneously. The sudden, overwhelming glare turned the midnight rain into a shimmering curtain of gold and diamond. The crew of the hydrofoil, perched high on their flybridge behind tinted composite windscreens, were suddenly blinded by three million candlepower of unvarnished maritime labor reflecting off the swells.

The hydrofoil's twin water-jets reversed with a shuddering scream of aerated water. The vessel slewed sideways, her helmsman desperately shielding his eyes as the sheer mass of eighty steel hulls loomed over him in every quadrant—not an armada of war, but an unyielding forest of iron that refused to yield right-of-way to a paper writ.

"Aisyah," Jin Wei said quietly. "Now."

Aisyah shoved the twin throttles forward. The electric glider did not roar; it lunged. The twin carbon-fiber foils bit into the outgoing tide, lifting the main hull four feet above the roiling surface. The craft hissed through the narrow gap between the submerged ballast blocks, throwing sheets of spray to port and starboard that caught the glare of the freighters' floodlights like sheets of hammered brass.

Lin Zhang looked back through the rear canopy.

On the pier, Uncle Tan was already turning away from the railing, his walking stick tapping rhythmically against the iron plates as he headed toward the harbormaster's shanty where thirty cold, wet mariners stood waiting with chalk slates to register their morning offloading times. Chen Rui was by the freshwater manifolds, directing the high-pressure hoses that were feeding three thousand gallons of desalted water into the forward tanks of a grain barge from Samarinda. There were no brokers. No currency desks. No satellite clearinghouse pinging London or Singapore to shave three percent off the sweat of the men heaving the mooring lines. Just the steady, rhythmic clang of iron against iron, the hiss of steam bleeding off the tidal turbine accumulators, and the smell of boiled tea drifting from the mess shack.

The hydrofoil lay dead in the water behind them, her searchlights drowned out by the glare of the working fleet, her commander's frantic radio calls disappearing unanswered into the roar of the monsoon. The market had not fallen to an assault; it had simply ceased to exist the moment the men who turned the winches stopped believing in the paper that claimed to own the wind.

The glider banked hard to the southwest, cutting across the deep trench where the Malacca current ran strongest. The lights of Batam receded into a low, smoldering ribbon of amber, then vanished

entirely beneath the black curve of the open sea.

Lin Zhang opened her satchel. She reached past the encrypted drive to pull out a small, flat brass plate—the sortition badge she had drawn three nights ago in the machine shop. It was blank, save for three notches filed into its top edge by Chen Rui’s file.

"The passage through the Sunda Strait is clear," Aisyah said, her eyes fixed on the passive sonar display. "Twelve hours to open water. But the satellite receiver just caught an optical burst from the high tower before we lost the horizon."

Jin Wei leaned over the console. "Geneva?"

"Not the city," Aisyah said, her voice dropping. "The lake. The cantonal police have deployed floating booms across the harbor mouth at Ouchy. The Swiss sortition delegates are barricaded inside the Palais des Nations, and the clearinghouse syndicates have frozen the food delivery logistics for the entire district. If we arrive without regional standing, we aren't walking into a council."

She looked back at the two of them, the blue light of the depth sounder painting the hollows of her cheekbones.

"We're walking into a siege."

CHAPTER 39

Chapter 39

The sea-glider sheared through the dark swell of the Sunda Strait, her hydrofoils singing a low, dry baritone that vibrated straight through the soles of Captain Jin Wei's boots. His lower vertebrae, worn down by forty years of standing watch above shaking diesel blocks, absorbed every micro-fracture of the chop. Outside the curved acrylic viewport, the black cone of Anak Krakatau rose against the horizon like an unlit furnace, smelling faintly of sulfur and wet pumice.

"Three degrees starboard, Aisyah," Jin murmured, his throat raw from the lingering sting of bunker gas he'd swallowed two days ago in the Batam bilge. "The shelf comes up fast past the light-buoy. If we draw more than two fathoms on the foil, the reef will take our rudder off."

Aisyah binti Rahman didn't look up from the steering yoke. Her knuckles, cross-hatched with faint white scars where high-voltage arcing had cooked the skin down to the dermis three seasons back, adjusted the hydraulic trim by touch alone. Her father had spent forty years tuning marine gearboxes by resting a bone-handled screwdriver against his front teeth to feel the tooth-mesh; she had inherited the same somatic skepticism of dials. "I feel the drag," she said quietly. "The port accumulator is pulling warm. The salt crust on the cooling intake is starving the heat exchanger."

"How long until the cells overheat?" Lin Zhang asked. She was wedged between the navigation bench and the bulkhead, her knees drawn up to support a grease-pencil slate. Her temples pounded with the dull, rhythmic ache of four nights without uninterrupted sleep. A cold sweat soaked the collar of her canvas smock.

"Forty minutes at glide speed," Aisyah replied. "Twenty if we run silent beneath the acoustic picket line."

Lin rubbed her eyes with the heel of her hand, leaving a smudge of graphite across her brow. On the slate lay three hand-written clauses—the maritime codicil of the Asia-Pacific commons, hammered out over thirty-six hours of radio silence between the floating machine shops of Batam and the barge assemblies of the Java Sea.

"Read it again," Jin said, not turning his head from the pitch-black water ahead. "Without the legal jargon. If an engine-room greaser from Samarinda can't understand what he's putting his thumb to, it doesn't go on the wire."

Lin looked down at the slate. "Article Seven: The Open Waterways. No consortium, sovereign admiralty, or corporate registry holds title to the straits, trenches, or migratory shelves of the

archipelagic seas. The right of non-commercial transit belongs to any craft whose draft does not poison the bed and whose manifest carries no instruments of sovereign execution."

"Keep going," Jin coughed, catching the phlegm in a gray cotton handkerchief.

"Article Eight: The Restorative Anchorage. Any vessel under stress of weather, machinery failure, or financial arrest by offshore creditor courts may claim sanctuary in any port governed by sortition. Seizure of cargo carrying grain, fresh water, or pharmaceutical base stocks is declared a structural breach of human trust. The local dock assembly—fifteen mariners chosen by odd lot—shall hold usufruct over the hull until repairs are sound and the crew is fed."

"And the threshold?" Aisyah asked, her voice tight as she felt the glider lurch slightly over an upwelling current.

"Three-quarters," Lin said. "Seventy-six out of the one hundred and one regional ships' delegates must ratify before the optical transmitter clears the horizon. If we fail the supermajority, the document remains a petition. It carries no weight as regional law when the Swiss assembly convenes."

"They'll sign," Jin said.

"You don't know that," Lin countered, her voice fraying at the edges. She had spent her early twenties in the windowless sub-basements of the transport ministry in Beijing, cataloging regulatory drafts that senior bureaucrats tossed into the shredder before noon. The sheer stubborn inertia of entrenched power was something she felt like a physical weight pressing on her sternum. "The barge captains in Surabaya are terrified of the credit freezes. The moment their transponders go dark on the Singapore exchange, their families' rice rations in port are locked out of the automated depots."

"They are already locked out," Jin said, his voice dropping into that flat, gravelly register that came from surviving three separate company bankruptcies at sea. "The private syndicates stopped honoring the sovereign grain vouchers yesterday at noon. If the men on the water don't hold the locks themselves, there won't be rice anyway. They know what the paper is worth. Read the last clause."

Lin swallowed, tasting the bitter dregs of chicory tea. "Article Nine: Non-Enclosure of Ocean Energy. The thermal gradients of the deep trenches and the kinetic pulse of the tidal channels belong to no state, concession, or private utility. Energy drawn from the water must be shared first with the littoral communities whose shores bear the wash, second with the working fleet, and never traded on forward derivative exchanges."

"Simple," Jin grunted. "Even an admiralty lawyer will choke on that."

"Aisyah," Lin said, leaning forward. "Can the laser head on the mast reach the repeater on Mount Rajabasa?"

Aisyah glanced at the gimbal display above the windshield. The amber crosshairs were shuddering violently. "The monsoon squall over the strait is shearing the beam. We're losing eighty percent of the

light to rain scatter. And something else." She reached out and touched the passive acoustic monitor, a phosphor screen that registered underwater pressure waves. A rhythmic, metallic *ping-thrum... ping-thrum* was pulsing through the deep trench to the west.

"Apex patrol skiff?" Jin asked, his shoulders stiffening against the bulkhead.

"Worse," Aisyah said. "A hydrographic surveyor. They aren't shooting. They're mapping the channel floor with low-frequency chirps to locate our acoustic signature. If they bracket our cavitation, they'll cue the maritime police cutter out of Merak to lay a containment boom across the strait mouth."

"We can't dive the foils," Jin said. "The shelf is too shallow."

"Then we cut the drive," Aisyah said.

"If we cut the drive," Lin whispered, "we lose the stabilized platform for the optical transceiver. The beam will drift off the mountain tower, and the sortition session closes in seven minutes."

Jin looked at Lin, then at the small brass sortition plate lying next to her slate—the blank token with three hand-filed notches. He thought of his first command thirty years ago, an unflagged timber barge where he had stood at the wheel with salt sores festering on his wrists, entirely dependent on whether an unseen broker in Hong Kong decided his cargo was worth unloading or abandoning to rot at anchor. The world had not changed because people asked it to; it changed because the people who shoveled the coal or tended the batteries simply laid their tools down together.

"Take the helm, Lin," Jin said.

"What? I don't know the hydrodynamic trim—"

"Hold the wheel dead center," he commanded, already unlatching the heavy water-tight hatch that led to the forward deck well. "Aisyah, keep the battery output pegged at minimum steerage. I’m going onto the bow to clear the gimbal lock by hand."

"The wash will take you over the rail," Aisyah warned, her eyes darting between the sonar sweep and the temperature gauge on the port battery. "The sea is running three meters off the volcanic reef."

"Not if you hold her level," Jin said. He didn't wait for an answer. He pulled the rubber storm hood over his ears, shoved the dog-latches home, and forced the iron hatch outward into the roaring dark.

The cabin filled instantly with the deafening scream of the Sunda swell and the smell of sulfur-heavy spray. The sea-glider pitched sickeningly to port as a wave broke over the forward coaming.

Through the salt-streaked glass, Lin saw Jin's silhouette crawl onto the narrow forward deck, his yellow foul-weather jacket gleaming in the wash of spray. His bad hip hitched with every movement, dragging his left leg behind him across the non-skid plating. He reached the base of the short carbon-fiber mast, hooked his arm through the safety rung, and brought a heavy bronze spanner down against the salt-encrusted gimbal ring.

Once. Twice.

A shower of white salt flakes tore away in the wind. The small cyan emitter at the top of the mast jerked, hummed, and locked onto the high peak of Rajabasa, invisible behind the rain clouds.

Inside the cabin, the terminal chimed—a dry, mechanical tick.

OPTICAL CARRIER SYNCHRONIZED.

"Lin! The packet!" Aisyah shouted over the roar of the water rushing past the hull. "Send it now! The surveyor is turning toward our wake!"

Lin's fingers shook on the keypads. She didn't look at the tactical display. She didn't look at the acoustic sweep closing in from the west. She verified the hash of the three articles, opened the sortition tally buffer, and released the query into the cyan beam.

For forty-five seconds, there was nothing but the heave of the hull, the shudder of the port hydrofoil clawing through the shallow chop, and the dark shape of Captain Jin clinging to the mast against the green water foaming over his boots.

Then, the return carrier pulsed down from the mountain.

One by one, the cryptographic marks of the Asia-Pacific maritime sortition appeared on the liquid-crystal display. They were not corporate endorsements or ministerial stamps; they were the verified signatures of one hundred and one working vessels: the crew assembly of the grain carrier *Bintang Timur*; the engine collective of the ferry *Nusantara IV*; the thirty dockworkers of the Teluk Betung salt co-op; the seventy-four mariners of the Samarinda timber fleet.

VOTES RECORDED: 101.

AFFIRMATIVE: 84.

NEGATIVE: 17.

SUPERMAJORITY ATTAINED (83.1%).

PACIFIC MARITIME COVENANT RATIFIED TO CLASS 0 REPOSITORY.

The hatch slammed open, and Jin fell backward into the cabin, soaked to the skin, coughing violently as brine drained from his collar. Aisyah reached behind her with one hand, hauling him upright by his harness, while her other hand slammed the trim lever forward, dumping the hydrofoils flat to skim silently over the sandbar.

The hydrographic surveyor's acoustic chirp faded behind them, searching empty deep water where they were no longer floating.

Lin stared at the terminal. "It’s locked," she breathed, her voice cracking. "The maritime articles are part of the global draft. Even if they take Batam tomorrow, the ships are bound by their own covenant."

Jin sat on the wet deck plates, his chest heaving, his scarred hands trembling as he wrung seawater from his sleeves. He looked up at the tiny screen.

"That's the sea," he said hoarsely. "Now tell me what came from the land."

Aisyah reached past him to clear the optical buffer. A second transmission, routed through the Batam high tower before the squall closed in, was unspooling in terse, broken lines of text. It had originated six thousand miles away, bounced through three air-gapped alpine relays before reaching the coast.

Lin read the words aloud, her voice sinking into the hum of the cooling pumps.

PALAIS DES NATIONS UNDER ADMINISTRATIVE SEAL.

CANTONAL GENDARMERIE HAS CUT WATER AND DISTRICT HEATING TO SORTITION WING.

LAKE GENEVA BOOMED AT OUCHY AND CHILLON.

EURO-ASIAN CLEARINGHOUSE HAS FILED CONTEMPT LIENS AGAINST ALL 1,001 DELEGATES.

THEY ARE FREEZING THEM OUT BEFORE THE PLENARY CAN OPEN.

Aisyah pulled the throttle back to silent cruise, her face setting into cold, rigid stone. "Can the glider clear the Cape of Good Hope before the ice on the lake hardens?"

"No," Jin said, struggling to his feet and planting his boots wide on the deck. "We don't go around the Cape. We fly the electric transport from Colombo straight into the Mediterranean headwinds. If they think they can freeze a thousand people out of their own history with a municipal valve, they've never tried to keep a cold ship running in winter."

He wiped the salt from his eyes and looked through the glass toward the open ocean, where the storm was waiting.

CHAPTER 40

Chapter 40

The hull of the hydrofoil groaned as Aisyah brought it alongside Berth 8. The Keppel-Batam drydock smelled of wet rust, anaerobic silt, and the bitter sulfur of dying lead-acid backup banks. High overhead, the sixty-meter crane stood against the bruised purple of the pre-dawn squall, its cyan optical transceiver blinking in rhythm like a tired pulse.

Jin dragged himself over the gunwale, his lower back flaring with a white-hot spike that made him catch his breath against the slick iron ladder. Decades of standing watch over thrumming diesel bedplates had ground the cushions between his vertebrae to gristle. Behind him, Lin clutched the waterproof courier satchel against her ribs, her knuckles gray. She kept her jaw locked to stop the trembling; whenever adrenaline receded, the damp heat of the strait made her teeth chatter as though she were standing in freezing spray. She had spent three hours chewing dry cloves from a crushed packet in her pocket, a nervous habit carried over from graduate school to keep the bile down when the screen-flicker triggered her migraines.

Uncle Tan stood at the head of the slipway, flanked by forty mariners, grease-monkeys, and container lashers. The rain had paused, leaving the air so thick with vapor that every breath felt half-drowned. A single low-draw sodium work lamp hung from an exposed conduit, casting long, jaundiced shadows across the pitted concrete.

"The optical feed from Johor dropped five minutes ago," Tan said without preamble. His voice was a rasp, worn thin by six decades of coastal smoke and salt damp that had swollen his knuckles until they resembled knotted driftwood. "The harbor master at Jurong has declared an emergency navigation cordon. Apex security launches are already laying acoustic hydrophones along the fairway to catch electric propeller whine. We have maybe thirty minutes before they drop the steel anti-debris nets across the eastern passage."

"And Geneva?" Lin asked. Her voice was flat, parched.

"The cantonal police have locked the gates," Chen Rui said, stepping out from the shadow of a rusted gantry strut. His forearms were bound in blue athletic tape to brace his inflamed tendons, his work shirt darkened with sweat. "They cut the thermal district pipes to the delegate wing at midnight. The Alpine delegates are sleeping in their wool survival coats. The clearinghouse wants the assembly dead of exposure before the first gavel drops."

Jin wiped grease and rain from his brow. "Then we don’t wait for daylight. Where is the drum?"

Under the Covenant, there were no appointments. No veteran master could declare himself ambassador; no engineer could claim the right by virtue of intellectual sweat. Power was an unexploded mine; to let any hand reach for it willingly was to invite the old rot back into the bilges.

Tan turned and led them toward the center of Berth 8, where a three-legged wooden surveyor's tripod supported a battered brass cylinder. The cylinder had once been the mechanical case of a triple-expansion engine telegraph, salvaged from an ore carrier scrapped twenty years ago in Chittagong. Its polished face had been drilled out, replaced with a hinged wire-mesh hatch secured by a spring-loaded cotter pin.

Inside lay one hundred and one turned hardwood tokens, each the size of a nutmeg, smoothed by the calloused palms of dockers from Surabaya to Belawan. One hundred and one registered mariners of the newly ratified strait commons.

"We need two to take the seat," Tan said softly, his gnarled hand resting on the crank handle. "One deck, one technical. That was the rule agreed upon under the crane yesterday. Two to speak for the southern water, or no one goes."

Jin looked at the drum. In his youth, before the shipyards had automated the slips, his mother had mended hemp trawling nets on the muddy beaches of Hainan, always leaving a deliberate irregularity in the knotting so the sea gods wouldn't think the net was an act of human arrogance. Jin felt that same ancient dread now, prickling along the skin of his neck where an old chemical burn from an engine backfire had left a patch of hairless, white scar tissue.

"Spin it," Jin said.

Tan took the iron handle. The gears inside the telegraph casing clicked with a hollow, rhythmic rattle that echoed off the high corrugated walls of the drydock. The wooden tokens tumbled within the cage, clacking against the perforated brass like dry bones.

Nobody spoke. Around the perimeter, five men holding brass fire nozzles hooked to high-pressure saltwater mains kept their eyes pinned on the black water beyond the sill. If the Apex patrol skiffs came within range, their only defense was the sheer weight of sea-water ballast, enough to swamp an interceptor's cockpit without firing a single lead slug.

Tan stopped the handle. He did not look into the drum. He reached in with two fingers, fished blindly into the mass of polished wood, and drew out a token.

He held it under the dull sodium lamp. Carved into the grain was an anchor crossed with a monkey's fist knot—the seal of the deck watch.

"Number forty-four," Tan read.

Aisyah stepped forward, unfurling the grease-stained ledger from the drydock bench. Her thumb, scarred across the cuticle from a high-voltage battery flash, tracked down the ink-drawn column. She

stopped, her eyes lifting to meet Jin’s.

"Jin Wei," she said, her voice dropping an octave. "Master mariner. Unattached."

Jin closed his eyes. A sudden, deep weariness settled onto his shoulders, heavier than the hydraulic winches he had spent his life rigging. He had wanted nothing more than to take a bunk in the abandoned machine shop, sleep for twenty-four hours, and let the younger engineers patch the turbine seals. Geneva was six thousand miles of frozen rock, concrete corridors, and men who fought with legal liens instead of tow lines. He hated cold air; it made his cracked collarbone ache until his teeth throbbed.

"The drum doesn't bargain," Jin muttered, exhaling a long breath that smelled of stale tobacco and bile. "Draw the engine seat."

Tan turned the crank again. Three full revolutions. The brass gears whined on dry bearings.

The old man reached his hand into the mesh, his fingers searching among the wood. He brought out the second sphere. It was marked with three concentric rings—the sign of the electrical and transmission tenders.

"Number seventy-one," Tan said.

Aisyah ran her finger down the second ledger page. The silence in the drydock grew thick enough to hear the rhythmic drip of condensation falling sixty feet from the gantry beams into the drainage sump.

She didn't look up. "Lin Zhang. Signals and systems architecture."

Lin flinched as though struck across the mouth. She took an involuntary step back, her heel catching against an iron cable ring bolted to the floor. "No. I'm a compiler, Uncle. I run the air-gapped packet switches. I don't... I can't sit in a room with five hundred lawyers. If they put a biometric camera on me, the clearinghouse flag—"

"The Covenant drew your number, daughter," Tan said. His voice was not unkind, but it was as unyielding as the granite blocks lining the drydock floor. "The assembly is not an embassy of the clever. It is a jury of the exhausted. If we send diplomats, they will buy them with port concessions before the third reading. If we send you, they will have to explain to a woman who has worked thirty-six hours without sleep why her people should freeze in the dark."

Lin looked down at her hands. The nails were bitten raw, her skin sallow from weeks beneath flickering low-voltage diodes. She looked at Jin, whose face had settled into the grim, vacant mask of a captain preparing to ride out a typhoon with a fouled propeller.

"We have to cross the Arabian Sea before the monsoons turn," Jin said simply, looking at her. "The electric glider doesn't have cabin heat. Pack your wool."

Before Lin could speak, the warning horn atop the gantry tower gave two sharp, truncated blasts.

Chen Rui dropped his wrench into a bucket. "Apex launch entering the channel. They’re running blacked out, three hundred yards off the beacon. They aren't boarding yet—they’re dropping bottom-moored acoustic gates to bottle the fairway."

"The glider is charged to seventy percent," Aisyah said, already swinging down into the maintenance well where the twin-hulled composite craft rested on its pneumatic transport rollers. "We don't get eighty. We take the tidal outflow now, or we sit in this mud until the receivers come with the admiralty marshals at daybreak."

Tan reached into his canvas smock and pulled out a small, heavy object wrapped in oilcloth. He pressed it into Jin’s thick palm.

It was not an amulet or an heirloom. It was an ordinary three-inch stainless-steel pipe coupling, its threads freshly cut, greasy and cold to the touch.

"If the Swiss heating is cut," the old man said, his knuckles grazing Jin's coat, "tell the people in the hall that the water only flows when the pipe is clear of middle-men. Show them the iron. Remind them what holds a ship off the rocks."

Jin slipped the fitting into his mackinaw pocket. The weight pulled reassuringly against his hip. "Lin. The satchel."

Lin pulled the strap tighter across her chest, securing the air-gapped drive containing the Pacific signatures against her sternum. Her panic hadn't vanished, but the drum had spoken, and in the strange logic of the commons, the burden felt lighter now that it was no longer a choice.

They scrambled down the ladder into the narrow cockpit of the sea-glider. The craft was stripped bare—no bunks, no galley, only two carbon-fiber bucket seats bolted directly over the battery housings and an aluminum control yoke.

Aisyah slammed the canopy shut from the outside. Her face, framed by the spray-pitted polycarbonate, was serious and pale. She tapped the glass twice with her knuckles, then yanked the manual release on the drydock floodgate.

A wall of black, churned sea water rushed under the hull, lifting the glider from its cradles with a violent, shuddering heave. Jin’s fingers found the propulsion toggle. The electric drives spooled up with an ear-splitting, sub-harmonic whine, vibrating straight through his tailbone.

Through the forward glass, the dark mouth of the slipway opened onto the strait. Across the channel, two sweeping halogen searchlights from the tactical patrol boats crisscrossed the black swells, searching for the wake of a vessel that was already dropping from the cranes into the dark.

CHAPTER 41

Chapter 41

The backwash from the slipway surged over the slimy green timbers of Berth 9, foaming around the steel toes of Aisyah’s boots.

She stood on the rusted lip of the drydock, her hands still trembling from the violent torque of the floodgate winch. Twenty paces out into the slick, ink-black water of the channel, the sea-glider was already little more than a low-profile shadow, its twin carbon foils shearing through the surface with a muffled, tearing hiss. There was no rooster-tail wake, no plume of diesel smoke—only two faint bioluminescent ribbons curling off the rudders as the electric drives sucked the low-voltage current from their ballast frames.

Beside her, Uncle Tan did not wave. Waving was for tourists at the ferry terminal. He stood with his shoulders hunched against the steady, lukewarm drizzle of the northeast monsoon, his swollen knuckles buried deep in the pockets of his canvas work coat. His right knee clicked faintly with every shift of his weight, the cartilage worn to gristle after forty years of squatting over steam manifolds.

"They're through the inner shoals," Tan murmured. His voice was a rasp of tobacco and salt-scoured vocal cords. "The current catches them under the beacon. If Jin keeps the foils tucked under four knots, the harbor hydrophones won't hear anything but the chop."

"Apex has two interceptors sitting dead in the water off the reef," Aisyah said. Her chest felt hollow, like an empty ballast tank echoing under a blowtorch. She wiped rain and grease from her eyelashes with the sleeve of her jumper. The rubberized fabric smelled of sulfur and hydraulic oil. "If they paint the glider with millimeter radar—"

"They won't look for fiberglass two inches off the water," Tan said, though his eyes never left the widening gap between the slipway and the fairway buoys. "They're looking for steel hulls with transponders. They’re looking for us."

A sudden, sharp glare split the low-hanging clouds over the western breakwater. A four-million-candlepower halogen beam swept across the mouth of Berth 9, dragging its harsh white cone across the corroded trusses of the gantry crane before slapping against the mud-slicked retaining wall ten feet below their feet.

Aisyah flinched, her hand dropping instinctively to the emergency cutoff key dangling from her belt lanyard. But Tan didn't flinch. He slowly drew a small tin from his pocket, thumbed it open with his calloused palm, and extracted a dried salted plum. He tucked it into the pocket of his cheek, an old habit

from his boiler-tending shifts on the ore carriers, where the sour salt kept a man’s mouth wet when the ambient air was fifty degrees and dry as a furnace flue.

"Kill the slipway floodlights, Aisyah," he ordered softly. "Let the harbor see only scrap iron."

She slammed the main breaker down. The yellow sodium glow that had framed their frantic departure vanished, plunging the berth into the deep, sulfurous indigo of the tropical night.

Behind them, in the cavernous belly of the decommissioned machine shop, boots scraped on wet concrete.

They weren't soldiers, and they weren't revolutionaries from a pamphlet. They were forty-odd men and women: tugboat engineers whose wages had been seized by receiver courts in Singapore, crane riggers with salt-rotted palms, and three generations of Bugis families who lived on the salvage lighters tied four-deep along Berth 11. They stood in the shadows beneath the crane rails, their faces pale in the ambient wash of the distant city lights across the strait.

In the front stood young Hisham, clutching a grease gun like a cudgel, his shirt soaked through with rain. "They're coming into the basin, Uncle," Hisham whispered. "The receiver’s cutter. They got three private patrol skiffs running alongside. They’re sounding their air horns at the outer boom."

Tan didn't answer immediately. He turned his heavy body around, facing the dark interior of the shop. His breath came slow and measured, wheezing slightly at the bottom of each exhalation—the legacy of inhaling powdered asbestos off the bulkheads of scrapped Greek bulkers in the eighties.

"They have paper," Tan said to the assembly. His voice didn't carry the ringing timber of Jin Wei’s quarterdeck baritone, but it settled into the damp iron room like heavy ballast. "They have an admiralty arrest warrant signed by an electronic clerk in a tower forty miles away. They think that paper owns the tidal cables. They think that paper owns the desalination pumps that keep your children’s drinking water sweet."

He looked at Aisyah. For all her brilliant understanding of high-voltage busbars and optical transceivers, she had spent her life hiding inside engine bilges and dive suits. When more than ten people looked at her at once, a red rash crawled up her neck, and she had an involuntary habit of counting the threads on the nearest hex bolt to keep her diaphragm from seizing.

One, two, three, four, she counted on the flange of the winch housing, her teeth set hard.

"Jin and the doctor are on the water," Tan continued, gesturing with his thumb toward the open dark. "They carry the signatures to Europe. But Geneva is ten thousand miles of saltwater, rail, and cold sky. What happens between this tide and the next belongs to Berth 9. Not to the court. Not to the syndicate. To us."

From across the basin, a metallic voice boomed through an amplified marine hailer, distorted by the wet air and the drumming rain:

"Berth Nine, Keppel-Batam facility. You are occupying quarantined private infrastructure under maritime lien. Power distribution from the tidal turbine array is unauthorized and constitutes theft of sovereign assets. Stand down all mooring cables and prepare for inspection by harbor constabulary and authorized maritime receivers."

The voice belonged to Assistant Receiver Lim—a man Tan had known for twenty years, a former shipping clerk who took the syndicate's civil service pension and now carried an encrypted tablet through the docks, locking down ships whose charterers had missed a single interest coupon. Lim was not an assassin. He was an accountant who believed that if the ledgers didn't balance, the ships would stop bringing grain and the lights in the city would go out.

"Aisyah," Tan said without looking back. "The seawater monitors."

She stopped counting threads. The sudden necessity of action burned away the flutter in her throat. "Tidal batteries are at sixty-two percent. The pump manifolds have thirty atmospheres of head pressure."

"Do not aim for their crews," Tan said, his tone flat, unyielding. "Aim for their intakes. Flood their forepeaks. Let the sea weigh them down until their screws bite air."

Aisyah lunged for the manual control stand bolted to the crane's south pillar. Her hands, mapped with small, silvery scars from arc flashes, flew over the brass gate valves. There were no digital consoles here; Jin had stripped the automated actuators two days ago to prevent remote corporate overrides. Everything was raw leverage: cold steel levers, bronze packings, and thick hydraulic hoses braided with stainless wire.

She threw her body weight against the primary lever.

High above them, mounted fifty feet up on the crane's transfer deck, two industrial fire monitors roared to life. They didn't spit a gentleman's stream. Fed directly by the harbor's tidal surges via twin centrifugal pumps, they hurled two solid, four-inch columns of gray harbor water into the darkness.

The roar was deafening, drowning out the whine of the incoming skiffs' outboards. Down in the basin, the nearest tactical skiff—a sleek, Kevlar-hulled vessel belonging to the private security cordon—took the full weight of the jet directly across its bow. The force did not splinter the hull, but it drove the nose down six feet into the swell, swamping the open cockpit with thirty tons of foaming saltwater in five seconds. The skiff's twin four-hundred-horsepower outboards sputtered, choked on their own flooded air intakes, and died with a violent shudder.

The megaphone fell silent, replaced by frantic shouting and the shrill scream of bilge alarms.

A second skiff swung wide, its searchlight dancing wildly across the rain-lashed crane, but Tan stepped forward to the secondary valve. Despite the arthritis that locked his shoulders, he leaned into the wheel, spinning it four turns to the left. A dense curtain of atomized seawater and low-pressure steam, drawn from the cooling jackets of the battery farm, hissed out across the low water. Within

seconds, a blinding, impenetrable bank of white artificial fog blanketed the basin, scattering their searchlights into a useless, milky haze.

The tactical skiffs were blind. Their thermal scopes could see nothing through the churning wall of fifty-degree steam and cold salt mist.

In the sudden tactical lull, Tan turned to the crowd of dockers huddled under the gantry. The plum was gone from his cheek; his face was gray with the physical strain of the valve, but his posture was rigid as an anchor shank.

"Hisham. Take seven men to the tidal conduit locks. Set the physical deadbolts on the manual stops. If they bring an oxy-torch, turn the seawater relief valves into the trench. Aisyah."

She looked up from the pump manifold, her chest heaving, her knuckles white against the iron lever.

Tan pulled a heavy, tarnished brass ring from his neck. Suspended from it was the sortition counter for the shipyard—a simple mechanical clicker, scored with the marks of fifteen harbor stewards, used since the docks had first been abandoned to tally the distribution of clean water and battery hours.

He held it out to her.

"I can keep the pumps turning, girl," the old man said, his eyes softening behind his salt-crusted spectacles. "I know where the pipes rust and which valves stick in the monsoon. But the people need someone who can see the wires that bind this yard to Batam and the rest of the world. Jin Wei is gone. You are the engineer of the Commons now."

Aisyah looked at the ring. The wet brass gleamed under the dull reflection of the mist. She felt the terrifying weight of it—four hundred lives, the fragile tidal grid, the relentless pressure of the courts waiting out in the dark water.

She didn't give a speech. She reached out and took the brass ring, slipping it over her head until the cold metal came to rest against her collarbone, right above the faint scar from her first high-voltage slip.

"Sound the shift bell," she said, her voice small at first, then hardening as she looked toward the fog-choked basin. "Sound fifteen strokes for the stewards. We convene at the drydock sill. If the receivers want these berths, they'll have to haul them up with their own bare hands."

Hisham gripped the bell lanyard. The deep, resonant bronze chime rang out across the water—one, two, three—cutting through the hiss of the steam monitors and rolling out across the Malacca Strait.

Then, from atop the crane tower, eighty feet in the air, a tiny, rapid point of cyan light began to blink through the driving rain.

Aisyah froze, looking up. It wasn't the sweeping halogen of the harbor patrol. It was the free-space optical laser link from the Batam repeater tower, cutting through a brief tear in the monsoon squall.

Three short pulses, one long, then a frantic, uncoordinated staccato of light.

It was the emergency pre-arranged signal from the southern line. Aisyah pulled her pocket receiver from her coat, watching the raw binary translate into mechanical red dots across the small air-gapped display.

The message had not come from the strait. It had been bounced across the Indian Ocean relay from the Mediterranean link:

GENEVA AIRSPACE DECLARED CLOSED BY CANTONAL POLICE. RECEIVERS AT PALMETTO TRUST HAVE FILED EXPEDITED LIQUIDATION. YOU HAVE SIX HOURS BEFORE THE SOVEREIGN EMBARGO FREEZES ALL OFFSHORE ROUTING.

Aisyah looked from the screen out into the black fairway, where Jin Wei's glider was already running the gauntlet of the outer acoustic gates, completely unaware that the sanctuary they were racing toward was already closing its doors.

CHAPTER 42

Chapter 42

The electric sea-glider did not fly so much as skip across the surface tension of the South China Sea, riding its own trapped pocket of pressurized air like a flat stone skimming black ice.

Inside the composite cabin, the noise was not the roar of combustion, but a dry, pneumatic whistle—the shriek of displaced seawater slicing beneath the ventral foils at ninety knots. Every five seconds, an ocean swell slapped the carbon underbelly with the dull, concussive thud of a muffled sledgehammer.

Captain Jin Wei wedged his shoulder into the bulkhead padding, his right hand clamped around a damp structural rib. The engine room vibrations of forty years at sea lived permanently in the cartilage of his lower spine, a dull ache that flared white-hot with every jolt of the glider. Beneath his oilskin jacket, the old chemical burn on his collarbone prickled against the stale nylon lining, irritated by a film of salt-sweat that never dried. He kept his jaw shut tight; biting one’s tongue at ninety knots meant swallowing your own blood while strapped to an experimental battery frame.

Across the narrow aisle, Dr. Lin Zhang sat hunched over a canvas lap-desk, her fingers moving across a matte slate with mechanical twitching speed. Her skin had taken on the greenish cast of unbaked dough, her pupils dilated behind grease-smudged lenses. Three nights of salt-basin siege without sleep had stripped away her clinical composure, leaving only the brittle, hyper-focused tremor of exhaustion. She smelled of scorched wiring and the bitter chicory dust she had been chewing raw to stave off collapse.

"Optical relay just dropped forty percent," Lin muttered, not looking up. Her voice was flat, frayed at the edges. "Atmospheric moisture over the Bay of Bengal is turning the beam to soup. Scattering loss."

"Keep it narrow," Jin Wei said, his throat raw from bunker fumes he hadn't breathed in two days. His thumb found an old brass button in his trouser pocket, rolling the smoothed metal over and over—a nervous habit he had hid from his deckhands for thirty years. "If the Batam laser loses our tail before we clear the Andaman acoustic gates, we’re blind to the western corridors."

Lin didn't answer. She tapped a mechanical copper interlock on her slate, manually adjusting the roof-mounted collimator by micro-increments. Outside, through the blister canopy, the sea was an ink-black void streaked with phosphorescent foam, but through Lin’s air-gapped terminal, the invisible geography of the planet appeared as a skeletal web of light and shadow.

A tiny green diode pulse signaled a clean packet.

"Detroit’s through," she breathed, her shoulders dropping an inch. "Toby routed via the salt-mine thermal tap. Low-bandwidth burst. Three lines."

Jin Wei leaned over, wincing as his lumbar vertebrae protested the motion. On the phosphor screen, the plain text flickered in amber phosphor:

FOUNDRY COLD-DRAWN COILS RATED TO SIX HUNDRED VOLTS. RAILS THROUGH TOLEDO HEAVILY MONITORED BY PRIVATE RAIL POLICE. WE ARE MOVING GRAIN AND COPPER AT MIDNIGHT BY TRACTOR FLOTILLA. HOLD THE LINE IN THE PASS.

"Kids are moving iron in the dark," Jin Wei murmured. A strange, sharp pride cut through his nausea. "No trains. They’re using the old tow-paths."

"They have to," Lin said grimly. "Chicago clearinghouse froze every municipal transit credit five hours ago. Toby says the grain elevators in Michigan are running on local barter chits stamped from scrap tin. If Geneva folds, those chits become kindling."

The glider lurched violently to port as the automated terrain-following sonar detected a half-submerged cargo container bobbing in the shipping lane. The twin contra-rotating electric props wailed, biting thin air before settling back into the brine with a heavy, shuddering splash that soaked the forward windshield in bioluminescent slime.

Before Jin Wei could steady his balance, a second pulse flickered onto the slate. A colder, crisper cadence.

"Turin," Lin whispered, her knuckles whitening against the frame.

The Italian link had bounced across three independent mountain repeaters, riding the catenary wires of abandoned alpine funiculars before dropping to the coastal maritime mesh:

DORA BASIN UNDER ARMED PROVINCIAL CORDON. HYDRAULIC VALVE SEALS SURROUNDED BY CARABINIERI ADVISORS. WE HAVE SHUT OFF THE RIVER GATES FROM BELOW GROUND. NO WATER REACHES THE PRIVATE COOLING ARRAYS UNTIL THE SORTITION DELEGATION LEAVES FOR THE LAKE. BEATRICE IS WALKING THE MONCENISIO TRAIL ON FOOT.

"On foot," Jin Wei rasped. He could see the girl in his mind—the thin-lipped apprentice from the rail yards, carrying the printed ledgers through high snow while private security patrols combed the mountain highways with thermal cameras. "She’ll freeze if the gale catches her on the ridge."

"She knows the paths," Lin said, though her voice lacked conviction. Her eyes twitched toward the glider’s internal reserve indicator. "Jin. Look at the pack."

Jin Wei turned toward the forward console. The bank of salvaged lithium-iron-phosphate cells—plucked from the guts of an impounded Batam tugboat—was glowing dull crimson under the cooling

manifold. Salt crust was already forming around the secondary intake valves, choking the passive heat exchangers.

"Temperature is climbing four degrees every ten miles," Jin said, reading the physical needle gauges. "We're dragging too much spray into the vents."

"If we drop altitude to shed the spray, the surface drag increases fifteen percent," Lin countered, her voice sharpening with real panic. "We run dry six hundred miles east of the Gulf of Aqaba. We don't have the juice to reach the Red Sea corridor, Jin. We'll be dead in the water off Socotra, sitting ducks for the admiralty cutters."

"Then we don't drop altitude," Jin Wei said quietly. "We dump ballast."

"What ballast?" Lin looked wildly around the stripped cabin. There were no passenger seats, no cargo holds, no unnecessary bulkheads—only the high-voltage bus bars, their two survival packs, and the zinc-lined transit trunk containing the physical ratified scrolls of the Malacca Covenant. "Everything on this craft was weighed down to the gram before we cleared the breakwater."

"The auxiliary cooling tank," Jin said. "Forty liters of fresh water."

Lin stared at him. "That's our drinking reserve for the desert leg. If the overland link in Jordan fails and we have to put down—"

"If we don't clear the acoustic line in forty minutes, there is no desert leg," he cut in, his voice dropping into the flat, immovable timber of a master mariner who had grounded three bulk carriers to save thirty lives. "Open the ventral drain valve, Doctor. Let the sea have it."

Lin's breath caught in her throat. She looked at the small plastic jerrycans strapped beneath the central console. Forty liters. In the dry heat of an inland landing, forty liters was the difference between three days of life and a swollen tongue choking a dry throat. But the thermal needle was already edging toward the yellow hash-mark.

She reached down, unpinned the safety wire, and kicked the brass dump lever.

A hollow gurgle vibrated through the floorboards as forty kilograms of fresh, clear water evacuated through the keel, swallowed instantly by the roaring foam. The glider's bows lifted four inches. The pneumatic shriek smoothed into a continuous, high-pitched hum. The thermal needle hesitated, then crawled back three millimeters.

"We gained two knots," Lin said, her chest heaving as she slumped back into her harness.

"Small mercies," Jin muttered.

Then the slate chime rang again—a double-tone, jagged and urgent.

It was not Detroit. It was not Turin.

The signal was stamped with the cryptographic hash of the high-altitude Atacama mesh, beamed across an unmonitored salt-flat laser array and bounced off the hull of an unflagged Japanese bulk carrier crossing the Pacific.

Lin translated the binary burst manually, her pencil scratching furiously onto a scrap of oil-stained paper. When she stopped, the graphite lead snapped against the pad.

"What is it?" Jin Wei asked, his hand dropping from his button. "Did the copper miners hold the switchyard?"

Lin raised her eyes. The smudged lenses could not hide the sudden, paralyzing terror in her face.

"It’s not about the switchyard," she whispered. Her fingers trembling, she held up the scrap of paper.

SANTIAGO EMBASSY JUST ISSUED AN ADMIRALTY RED NOTICE. APEX PRIVATE MARITIME PMC HAS DISPATCHED THREE HYDROFOIL INTERCEPTORS FROM DIEGO GARCIA. THEY ARE NOT WAITING FOR US IN THE RED SEA.

Jin Wei’s head snapped toward the forward blister.

Out across the horizon, beyond the reach of the glider’s low-mounted headlights, the black water of the Indian Ocean lay undisturbed under a starless sky. But through the cabin’s low-frequency acoustic receiver, a new sound was bleeding through the rhythmic thrum of the swells.

Not the wind. Not the sea.

A synchronized, multi-engine whine—twin gas turbines running at maximum sprint, slicing directly across their flight vector from the northwest.

"They aren't trying to board us," Lin said, reading the Doppler frequency spiking on her audio spectrum display. Her voice was barely a breath. "They know the Hague Trust requires physical presentation of the covenants before the midnight assembly in Geneva. If we don't reach the shore..."

"Hold on," Jin Wei snarled, his weathered hands slamming down onto the manual trim toggles, overriding the autopilot.

Beneath them, the glider banked hard into the trough of a fifteen-foot wave, its carbon wing-tips slicing green fire through the dark water as the first searchlight beam from the approaching interceptors slashed across the sky ahead.

CHAPTER 43

Chapter 43

The spray hit the acrylic canopy like gravel fired from a sling.

At six feet above the open swells of the Chagos Trench, ground effect was not flight; it was a brutal, bone-jarring calculation against the curvature of the earth. The composite wing beneath Jin's boots flexed with a sharp *crack*, shuddering through the airframe as the sea-glider skimmed a crest of black foam.

Lin did not look up from the brass-bound slate bolted between their jump seats. Her fingers, stained around the cuticles with bitter gentian violet from treating saltwater ulcers in the Batam bilge, worked across the row of mechanical thumbwheels. A sudden updraft dropped her stomach into her throat, and she swallowed hard against the metallic sourness rising behind her molars.

"Port engine bearing temperature is climbing three points every sixty seconds," she said. Her voice lacked its usual crisp precision, frayed by eighty sleepless hours and the dull ache behind her temples where her spectacles bit into her scalp. "The salt crust is baking onto the stator housing. If you pull us into another trough, the vapor seals will blow."

Jin didn't blink. His jaw was locked tight, his teeth grinding on an old, blunt molar that had split during a drydock cable failure a decade ago and had never been properly crowned. Decades on rolling iron decks had taught him to balance on the balls of his bare feet, letting his knees absorb the sickening vertical jerks of the hull.

"If I climb twenty feet out of the surface cushion, our drag triples," he said, his gravelly voice fighting the slipstream howling past the canopy seams. "We lose our lift-to-drag advantage, the reserve pack bleeds out before the Gulf of Aden, and we become a three-hundred-foot radar target for those skiffs. We stay in the trough."

A mile to their northwest, an arc of cold magnesium light cut through the mist.

It was not a warning beacon. It was a high-intensity marine searchlight, its pencil-thin beam sweeping the surface of the Indian Ocean in tight, predatory diagonals. Behind it, the dual scream of supercharged marine diesels echoed off the water—the distinctive, razor-sharp pitch of Apex Tactical's deep-draft interceptor skiffs.

The private contractor vessels weren't rogue raiders; their AIS transponders were chirping legitimate sovereign enforcement codes, broadcasting the Admiralty Red Notice issued out of Santiago. They were enforcing a lawful maritime lien on behalf of the creditor banks holding paper on the Malacca drydocks.

To the men at those helms, Jin and Lin were not revolutionaries; they were industrial absconders piloting stolen assets across international waters, threatening the collateral underlying half the sovereign bond issues in Southeast Asia.

"Range?" Jin asked.

"Two nautical miles and closing at eighteen knots over our ground speed," Lin said. She reached into her canvas satchel, pulling out a handful of dried bitter melon slices—a childhood remedy her mother had pressed into her hands whenever fever threatened to blur her arithmetic during the humid summer exams in Wuhan. She chewed mechanically, the astringent bite shocking her nervous system back into focus. "They're attempting a flanking pincer. If they bracket our wake, the turbulence alone will trip the sea-glider's attitude gyros. We'll cartwheel into the chop."

"They won't ram," Jin grunted. "They want the cargo intact. They want the physical paper."

He pointed a calloused index finger toward the center console, where a heavy, zinc-lined leather courier pouch lay strapped down with double steel bands. Inside sat the physical, ink-signed deeds of the Four-Continent Usufruct: the parchment covenants signed by the Detroit autoworkers, the Alpine hydro-syndicates, the Atacama lithium cooperatives, and the mariners of the Malacca Strait.

"The ledger isn't just paper, Jin," Lin murmured, her hand drifting over the cold slate display. Her eyes softened with a terrifying vulnerability he had never seen in her during the shipyard sieges. "Look at the synchronization loop."

Across the screen, rendered in amber phosphorescent lines that flickered with every drop in laser signal from the trailing relay buoy, the global balance breathed. It was an intricate web of thermodynamic obligations, an invisible lattice binding human labor to the physical energy of the planet.

To the west, across the darkened continent of Africa, the Alpine reservoirs were feeding power downward into the Mediterranean lines, offsetting a cold snap that had threatened the olive-processing presses in Provence. To the east, the Atacama solar arrays, basking in high-altitude noon, were dumping synthetic ammonia production credits into the trans-Pacific shipping ledger.

Every calorie was accounted for. Every watt had a name, a location, and a human face attached to its release. It was not money; it was the thermodynamic reality of the earth made visible—an accounting system where one could not steal from tomorrow to balance the ledger of today.

"Detroit's forging plants are running on the evening tide from the Bay of Fundy," Lin whispered, her fingers tracing an amber branch that dipped toward the Atlantic margin. "The assembly there held. Even after the federal receivers padlocked the substation gates, the shop floor voted to redirect their secondary battery banks into the municipal cold-storage lockers. They chose the city's insulin over their own tool-lines."

Jin glanced sideways, his eyes catching the faint green reflection of the flight display. "They took the risk because we promised them the Malacca grain ships would clear the blockade."

"And if we don't deliver these signatures to Geneva by dawn," Lin said, the cold truth settling between them like ballast, "the maritime lien attaches. The clearing banks will seize the bulk carriers in Colombo and Durban. The entire circuit collapses under debt default before the assembly ever sits."

A violent jolt tore through the sea-glider's starboard wingtip.

A high-pressure spray curtain erupted five yards off their bow as the lead interceptor fired a water-monitor burst across their course. The sheer kinetic force of twenty tons of displaced seawater crashed against their side-skirt. The glider yawed violently, the horizon spinning forty-five degrees into a sickening blur of foam and black sky.

"Trim!" Lin yelled, her hands bracing against the dashboard as her spectacles were ripped from her ears, clattering into the footwell. "Port pontoon is dragging!"

Jin didn’t reach for the flight controls. Decades of working the rusted winch drums on typhoon-battered bulkheads had taught him that when metal screams under tension, pulling harder only snaps the cable.

Instead, he reached down to the mechanical ballast dump lever—a thick, unpainted iron bar salvaged from an old river barge. He yanked it upward with the full weight of his shoulder, ignoring the sharp, familiar agony that fired down his lumbar spine from his crushed vertebrae.

A cloud of pressurized nitrogen hissed from the glider’s belly. Two hundred gallons of reverse-osmosis freshwater—their drinking reserve for the Red Sea crossing—vented in a roaring white plume straight into the sea-skimmer’s air cushion.

Lightened by nearly a ton in less than three seconds, the glider leapt.

The nose rose six feet, snapping out of the suction of the trough just as the second interceptor surged across their wake. The displacement wave from the tactical skiff passed directly beneath their keel, the turbulent backwash acting not as a tripwire, but as a hydraulic ramp.

The sea-glider soared into the clean, untangled air twenty feet above the swells, its twin ducted fans screaming as they bit into dry wind.

Behind them, the lead interceptor, blinded by the sudden fog of their vented freshwater dump and the boiling wake of its own partner craft, sheered hard to port to avoid a catastrophic collision. The searchlight beam spun wildly into the empty sky, illuminating nothing but low monsoon clouds.

In the sudden, eerie silence of the upper air layer, the glider leveled out, riding the smooth laminar airflow above the spray.

Lin scrambled in the dark, her trembling hands sweeping the deck plates until her skin found the wire frames of her glasses. She shoved them onto her face, blinking through smudged glass at the console.

The amber ledger on the screen was pulsing.

A new, unpredicted knot had formed at the center of the network mesh. The line wasn't coming from Detroit, or the Alps, or the drydocks of Batam.

It was originating from the Gulf of Aden—from the unflagged, mothballed tanker fleet anchored off the coast of Yemen.

"Jin," Lin said, her breath catching in her throat as she read the incoming cryptographic hash. "Look at the frequency. It’s not Apex. It’s not the Admiralty receivers."

Jin stared at the coordinates blooming on the nav-plotter. A single cluster of twelve low-frequency acoustic pings was arrayed across the strait ahead, blocking the mouth of the Red Sea.

"Who is it?" Jin demanded, his hand frozen on the throttle.

Lin pressed her fingers against the glass of the terminal, her heart hammering against her ribs like a trapped bird.

"The tanker crews," she whispered. "The abandoned mariners. They’ve scuttled their anchor chains across the channel. They’re holding the strait—not for the banks, and not for us."

A single transmission flickered onto the screen in raw, unformatted text:

PROVE THE COVENANT HOLDS WATER, OR WE DROP THE BOOM.

CHAPTER 44

Chapter 44

The warning from the tanker fleet didn't fade from the console; it burned there in jagged green phosphors, a tripwire stretched across the mouth of the Red Sea. But the water below was no longer their only border.

Two thousand feet above the swells, the glider's ducted props thrummed with a hollow, laboring whine. The machine was never built for true high-altitude flight. Designed to ride the cushion of compressed air skimming the waves, every yard of elevation cost them dearly in precious battery reserve. The cabin grew bitterly cold, the damp tropical heat of the Malacca Strait bleeding away through the carbon-composite skin into the dry desert updraft of the Horn.

"We can't clear their boom," Jin said, his throat raw from the salt spray that had soaked him during the breach. His left hand locked on the dual pitch-trim wheel, his bad shoulder trembling as the airframe buffeted in the shear winds off the Yemeni cliffs. "If the tankers dropped their heavy salvage lines across the shipping channel, they'll catch our rudders the moment we drop back into ground effect."

Lin didn't look up from her lap. She had tucked a dried, bitter tea leaf beneath her inner cheek, a habit from her university laboratory days to stave off the sickening gray haze of screen-blindness. Her fingers, stained blue at the knuckles from an ink leak in her emergency nav-log, tapped furiously against the cracked edge of the optical coupler.

"Then we don't go down," she said, her voice paper-thin. "We climb."

"The cells won't take it, Lin. We pull forty degrees of pitch, the bus bars overheat before we cross Perim Island."

"Jin. Look up."

Through the salt-scratched acrylic of the canopy, twin pinpricks of high-intensity strobes burned through the twilight haze. They were dropping out of the upper stratosphere, descending from the north at five hundred knots—not tactical skiffs or port authority launches, but two sleek, twin-engine corporate executive jets, stripped of civilian livery, painted the dull, predatory gray of private maritime syndicates.

They weren't trying to shoot. International law over the strait was still an entangled knot of sovereign jurisdictions and maritime corridors, and an air-to-air strike would trigger automated military tracking from three nearby naval bases.

Instead, they were hunting with mass and wake.

The lead jet banked sharply, angling down toward the glider’s ten o’clock. Even at two miles out, the scream of its high-bypass turbofans reached them through the canopy—a heavy, tearing roar that vibrated straight through the glider’s aluminum floor ribs.

"Apex tactical charters out of Dubai," Lin whispered, her breath fogging the corner of her spectacles. She recognized the transponder footprint—or rather, the deliberate absence of one. They were running dark on the commercial ADS-B channels, masquerading as private corporate repositioning flights. "They aren't trying to blast us out of the sky. They’re going to pass fifty yards ahead of our nose."

Jin’s jaw tightened until the tendons stood out like cordage along his neck. He knew the tactic from old harbor tug encounters with oversized container ships: the invisible wall of wake turbulence. A forty-ton business jet cutting across the flight path of a lightweight, composite electric glider would roll them into an inverted spin before Jin could even kick the rudder pedals. At this altitude, recovery was physically impossible; they would hit the dark water of the gulf like a dropped stone.

"Trim down five degrees," Jin grunted. "We dive under."

"No!" Lin lunged across the center console, her forearm brushing the cold throttle quadrant. "If you dive, you bleed the remaining kinetic lift. You’ll stall before you reach the surface, and the tankers have the sea blocked anyway. We hold altitude."

"They're coming around for the cross, Lin! Ten seconds!"

The corporate jet expanded in their forward windscreen, a silver-gray knife cleaving the evening dusk, trailing twin vortices of kerosene heat that shimmered against the red sunset. The sound was an avalanche, pressing down on the glider’s plexiglass until it creaked.

Lin tore the protective rubber guard off the emergency civilian transceiver—an old, maritime VHF unit cross-wired into the glider's optical packet-mesh.

She didn't broadcast on the private tactical frequencies. She didn't appeal to Apex Marine or Euro-Asian Maritime Finance.

Instead, she flipped the selector switch straight to 121.5 megahertz: International Air Distress.

"All stations, all stations," Lin spoke into the collar mic, her voice shedding its tremor, dropping into the clear, measured cadence of open-sea emergency protocol. "This is glider craft *Perak Sanctuary*, maritime humanitarian auxiliary under the Hague Perpetual Asset Trust, currently traversing the Bab-el-Mandeb transit corridor."

"Lin, they aren't listening to distress calls," Jin shouted over the howling slipstream as he fought the controls, the sea-glider vibrating violently as the lead jet’s outer pressure wave brushed their left wingtip. The port motor surged, its thermal sensor flashing an amber warning on the primary panel.

"They aren't," Lin said through clenched teeth, her eyes locked on the amber text scrolling across her secondary display. "But the regional traffic towers are."

She leaned closer to the mesh link, her finger hammering the manual transmit key, broadcasting not just voice, but an automated cryptographic token directly into the public civilian aviation clearinghouses of Sanaa, Djibouti, and Jeddah.

"Broadcasting open-skies non-scheduled humanitarian transit under Article 5 of the Chicago Convention and the Hague Commons Maritime Protocol," she called out, every syllable carved with legal precision. "We are an unpowered and low-energy auxiliary carrying non-combatant civil delegates under international sortition mandate. We are declaring an active emergency flight corridor between coordinates twelve-forty north and thirteen-twenty north. We report imminent, deliberate wake-turbulence interdiction by two unflagged corporate transports maneuvering within civilian separation limits."

In the sky three hundred yards ahead, the lead jet suddenly wobbled.

Its right wing dipped sharply, the silver belly of the craft rolling upward toward the darkening sky.

"What did you do?" Jin panted, his hands fighting the wild updraft created by the jet's passage.

"The Hague Trust doesn't just hold ship titles, Jin," Lin said, the tea leaf bitter against her tongue as she tasted copper from a bitten lip. "The sortition assemblies in Geneva filed an open-access public trust charter three days ago. It binds every civil air-traffic authority that signed the maritime safety pacts. If those private charters cause an incident while we’re broadcasting on open civil distress channels, their parent registry loses its sovereign landing rights in every port from Rotterdam to Singapore before midnight."

The second corporate jet, closing fast from their starboard quarter to finish the boxing maneuver, abruptly pulled its nose up. Its twin jet pipes glowed dull orange in the twilight as its pilots slammed the throttles forward, climbing steeply to break off the interception. On Lin’s monitor, a cascade of regional air-traffic control interrogations lit the screen: Jeddah Control was demanding immediate identification and flight-plan justification from the private aircraft, broadcasting directly across the shared emergency frequency.

To corporate balance sheets, legal liability and sovereign airport impoundments were far deadlier than a lost contract. The risk calculus had flipped in six seconds.

The two jets banked hard toward the northern horizon, their navigation strobes vanishing into the haze over the Saudi desert, leaving behind only the dissipating trails of their exhaust.

Silence rushed back into the glider's cockpit—a cold, thin silence broken only by the steady hum of their twin props and the rhythmic rattle of a loose rivet in the port door frame.

Jin let out a long, ragged breath that rattled in his chest. His fingers slowly unclenched from the yoke, the joints swollen and white from the strain. He reached down with his right hand to massage his lower spine, groaning as the deep ache of the seat's vibration settled back into his bones.

"They'll be waiting at the other end," Jin murmured, his eyes scanning the empty sky ahead. "They won't let us clear the Suez airspace without a fight."

"They won't have the jurisdiction," Lin said softly, leaning her head back against the worn canvas headrest. Her temples throbbed with a migraine that felt like a rusty nail driven behind her left ear. "Once we cross the Sinai, we enter the Mediterranean commons. The sortition delegate flight from Marseille is already airborne to escort us into Swiss airspace under civil neutrality."

She reached out and tapped the glass of the nav-plotter, where the green text from the abandoned tanker fleet below had stopped blinking.

On the sea surface two thousand feet beneath them, the string of rust-streaked, decommissioned tankers was swinging slowly on their massive chains. Through the gathering dark, their deck lamps flickered on one by one—not blinding tactical searchlights, but warm, yellow halogen work lights, illuminating a wide, unobstructed lane right down the center of the Red Sea channel.

They hadn't scuttled their booms to trap the glider. They had drawn their hulls together to form a floating harbor wall, barricading the surface waters against any pursuing tactical skiffs from the southern straits.

Jin watched the lights drift beneath their wings, a constellation of rusted iron and defiant human labor floating on the black water. For the first time in three days, the tight, defensive set of his shoulders eased by an inch.

"They opened the gate," he said quietly.

Lin didn't answer immediately. Her gaze was fixed on the far corner of the primary terminal, where the mesh connection to Geneva was supposed to be idling.

A fresh diagnostic pulse was shivering across the display. The signal wasn't green. It was a sharp, unyielding crimson.

Lin straightened, the fatigue vanishing from her spine in a single, cold jolt.

"Jin," she said, her voice barely a whisper against the hum of the dying batteries. "The delegate register for Geneva. It just dropped three hundred seats."

Jin turned his head, his brow furrowed in the dim cabin light. "What do you mean, dropped? The sortition drum picked them yesterday."

"The Swiss Federal Council didn't ratify the assembly venue," Lin said, reading the encrypted dispatch as it unspooled across the glass. "They've cordoned the Palais des Nations. The cantonal police

just sealed the lakefront."

CHAPTER 45

Chapter 45

The descent out of the alpine cloud base felt less like flight and more like scraping the belly of an iron stove across gravel.

Freezing fog had crusted the leading edges of the sea-glider's composite foils with a three-inch rind of milk-white rime. Every five seconds, the starboard electric prop gave a wet, shuddering hitch, shedding balance as its heating strips drained the last reserve cells.

Captain Jin Wei held the twin yokes with his elbows tucked tight against his ribs. The relentless high-frequency vibration of forty hours in the air had turned his lower lumbar into an agonizing pinch of ground glass, an old ballast-tank injury flaring red-hot in the sudden alpine frost. Through the scratched acrylic windscreen, Switzerland did not look like the postcard sanctuaries of his boyhood atlas. It looked slate-gray, dead, and razor-sharp.

"Altitude three hundred meters," Dr. Lin Zhang said. Her voice was flat, dried out by stale recirculated air, but her knuckles were white where she gripped the edge of the navigation console. She hadn't slept since the Malacca strait; her left eye was bloodshot, twitching to the beat of an untreated sinus migraine. "Lake surface ahead. But it isn't reflecting the shoreline beacons."

"Because it's skimmed," Jin grunted, working the manual pitch lever. The mechanical cables fought him, stiff with thickening grease. "The cold snap out of the Jura. Look at the shallows along Versoix."

Beneath them, Lake Geneva did not roll in deep, sheltering swells. A week of the bitter north *Bise* had locked the Petit-Lac into a sheet of fractured, jagged shelf-ice. Gray plates of pack, crushed together by shore currents, gleamed like broken bottle glass under the heavy ceiling of snow clouds.

"Flaps to full depression," Jin ordered, teeth clutched tight against the shudder of the airframe. "If we catch a pontoon tip on an ice ridge, we flip her. We take the touchdown flat on the reinforced keel. Hold on to the bulkhead."

The glider crossed the shoreline trees at ninety knots.

There was no clean hydrodynamic skim. The keel met the crust of the lake with a sound like a galvanized sheet being torn in half. Violent, concussive deceleration threw Lin against her four-point harness, knocking the breath from her lungs in a harsh gasp. Slabs of slush and gray ice exploded outward, slamming against the fuselage windows in blinding cataracts of gray mud and frozen grit. The port outrigger skipped twice, screeching as carbon fiber abraded against the pack, before the sea-glider

finally slewed forty degrees to port and settled into a frozen furrow, twenty yards short of the timber pilings of the Port des Mouettes.

Silence slammed down on the cockpit.

The twin props hissed as their residual heat melted the rim of ice clinging to the cowlings. Steam curled off the forward battery cowl, smelling faintly of scorched silicone and river silt.

Jin let out a long, ragged exhalation that plumed white inside the unheated cabin. He wiped a smear of cold condensation from his forehead with the back of a calloused thumb. His hands were shaking—not from fear, but from the sudden, jarring drop in ambient temperature. Tropical blood, thinned by thirty years of equatorial salt spray, felt thick as tar in the zero-degree draft creeping through the hatch seals.

"System lock," Lin whispered, her trembling fingers clearing the terminal buffers. "Batteries are at three percent. We don't have enough juice left to spin the bilge pumps."

"We're down," Jin said. "That’s all the juice had to do."

He reached overhead, popped the mechanical latch of the emergency escape hatch, and shoved. The composite door cracked open against a crust of frost, letting in an alpine draft that felt like a bucket of ice water hurled directly into their chests.

Standing on the fractured ice shelf fifteen paces from the sea-glider’s scarred nose were two figures wrapped in heavy, oilcloth-lined coats.

The taller of the two—his broad shoulders rounded slightly against the driving sleet, a wool watch cap pulled down over graying temples—stepped onto the pontoon with the careful, balanced tread of an old machinist who knew precisely how much weight a cracked timber could bear. Marcus Hayes held an unlit wooden match between his teeth, an old habit from his early shop-floor days when smoking was forbidden near the solvent tanks. Beside him, Giulia Bellini’s breath puffed in steady, rhythmic clouds. Her dark eyes were sharp behind frost-flecked spectacles, her woolen scarf tucked tightly into the collar of a salt-bleached Alpine rescue anorak. A noticeable stiffness in her left knee, a legacy of the bitter winter blockades along the northern rail spurs, made her lean slightly on an iron-tipped walking pole.

"You took your time crossing the Rhone valley, Captain," Marcus said. His voice was a low, gravelly rasp that carried effortlessly through the damp chill. He offered a massive, grease-calloused hand down into the hatch well.

Jin gripped it. The warmth of Marcus’s woolen glove struck him with the force of an electric shock. With a single grunt, Marcus levered the captain up onto the slippery composite deck, catching him by the elbow as Jin’s sea-legs momentarily buckled on the glaze of ice.

"The headwind over the Alps was forty knots," Jin rasped, his throat raw from the dry air. He reached back down into the opening to haul up Lin’s canvas kit bag before extending a hand to help her

onto the wing. "And the Swiss radar towers were painting our tail all the way from Chambery."

Giulia caught Lin’s arm, steadying the younger woman as she stumbled on the frozen pontoon. For a fraction of a second, the two women simply looked at one another—the weary, red-eyed cryptographer from the tropical docks of Batam and the veteran legal coordinator who had spent five years running decentralized supply rings across the cantons. Giulia didn't offer a polite smile; she simply unclasped an insulated thermal flask from her belt and pressed it directly into Lin’s stiff fingers.

"Black tea, chicory, and sugar," Giulia said, her cadence crisp and measured. "Drink it before your lips split. The frost here bites bone before you feel the skin tear."

Lin unscrewed the cap with numb thumbs. The steam hit her face like an open kitchen door. "The delegate register," she said between hurried sips, the hot liquid burning her throat in a welcome, agonizing line. "Our link showed three hundred seats dropped while we were over the Mediterranean. What happened to the sortition count?"

Marcus took the wooden match from his mouth, turned it between his calloused fingers, and pointed toward the eastern ridge of the lake.

Half a mile off, through the gray curtain of sleet, the granite facade of the Palais des Nations sat dark against the forested hills of Pregny. No security searchlights swept the grounds, but a neat, unbroken line of blue utility sawhorses and cantonal police vans blocked every access gate along the Avenue de la Paix. Out on the open water beyond the pack ice, a solitary 120-foot cantonal hydrofoil patrol boat idled in the channel, its twin water jets churning a froth of gray slush, its radar mast rotating with mechanical indifference.

"The Federal Council invoked Article 102," Marcus said calmly. "They didn't deploy tear gas or water cannon. They simply classified the global sortition assembly as an unscheduled foreign convention posing a systemic public-health and civil-order liability. The cantonal building inspectors condemned the assembly hall at midnight. Blocked the heating mains, severed the municipal fiber link, and locked the turnstiles."

"On what authority?" Jin demand, his hand instinctively dropping to the empty belt where his deck-knife used to hang. "The sortition drum drew those names under the Hague usufruct covenant. One thousand and one seats, odd parity, verified across four continental meshes."

"On the authority of the municipal fire code," Giulia said, her voice dry as autumn birch bark. "The cantonal administration is rational, Captain. They don't fight revolutions with riot police if they can starve them out with insurance riders and frozen municipal permits. They know the global delegates are arriving in Geneva on expired transit visas. If they freeze the assembly venue for seventy-two hours, the delegates run out of legal lodging, the cantonal hotels are barred from extending credit, and the local courts will deport the entire lottery back to their ports of origin under standard vagrancy statutes."

"We don't have seventy-two hours," Lin said, pulling the canvas satchel tighter to her ribs. "The sovereign mortgage syndicates in Singapore just initiated admiralty foreclosure on thirty-two container hulls. If the Global Assembly doesn't ratify the usufruct sanctuary charters by tomorrow noon, the port receivers will sell those ships for scrap. Three thousand mariners will be turned onto the street without discharge papers."

"Then it's a good thing we never planned to meet in their palace," Marcus said.

He turned toward the shore. Tucked behind the municipal boat slips was a cluster of nineteenth-century timber boat-sheds—cavernous, moss-shingled structures where local fishermen had repaired lake trawlers and dried hemp nets since the days of the old confederacy. Smoke was rising from three tin chimney pipes jutting through the cedar shingles.

A low murmur of voices, thick with a dozen different accents and punctuated by the clinking of tin mess kits, drifted out through the timber seams.

"The Fishermen's Usufruct Union holds the water-rights lease on these sheds until 2048," Marcus said, stepping down from the pontoon onto the packed snow of the slipway. "Paid in advance under old cantonal law that the federal receivers can't touch without unanimous cantonal court consent. We brought three hundred and four delegates in through the freight rail yard at three this morning."

Jin paused on the ice, his gaze sweeping from the grand, darkened silhouette of the Palais up on the hill down to the low, smoking timber roof of the boat-shed.

"And the odd parity?" Jin asked.

Giulia adjusted her spectacles, her mouth curving into the faintest shadow of an iron smile. "Three hundred and five now that you two have stepped ashore. The assembly is quorate."

Before Jin could reply, a sudden, high-pitched air horn cut through the falling snow.

Out in the frozen channel, the cantonal hydrofoil patrol boat surged forward, its reinforced steel prow cracking through the surface shelf-ice with a sharp, rhythmic boom. A bright, halogen searchlight flicked on from the cutter’s bridge, its white beam slicing through the sleet to pin the four of them against the scarred hull of the sea-glider.

Over the patrol craft’s deck speaker, a voice echoed across the frozen water in measured, polite, and unyielding French:

"Civil vessel on the Versoix ice shelf. You are moored within a municipal restricted shipping lane during cantonal curfew. Stand by your vessel. The maritime receiver is coming aboard."

Chapter 46

The halogen beam caught them like deer against salt-crusted timber.

The light was so intense it turned the falling sleet into a curtain of blinding needles, bleaching the blue paint of the sea-glider down to the raw primer. Jin Wei did not flinch, though the glare stabbed into his optic nerves, instantly waking the dull, rhythmic throb behind his temples. Decades under the flickering fluorescent tubes of container engine rooms had left his eyes intolerant of sudden white light; he simply dropped his chin into the salt-stained collar of his oilskin and shifted his weight off his compressed lumbar discs.

Out on the ice shelf, the cantonal hydrofoil's twin diesels rumbled at low idle, a wet, churning vibration that traveled up through the frozen soles of Jin's sea boots. The craft was an armored wedge of aluminum and zinc, its bow sheathed in sacrificial steel to crack the surface rime.

On the foredeck, a figure in a heavy navy-blue storm parka raised a handheld megaphone. His breath curled into the halogen cone, thick as sheep's wool.

"Slipway three is municipal reserve!" the voice called, shorn of electronic resonance by the freezing air. The French was flat, nasal, carrying the dry, unhurried cadence of a civil magistrate whose pension did not depend on bravado. "Curfew commenced at midnight under the cantonal emergency maritime decree. Power down your auxiliary turbines and identify your flag registry."

Beside Jin, Lin Zhang's fingers tightened on the strap of her canvas satchel until the knuckle bones showed white through her skin. Inside the padded nylon envelope against her ribs rested two solid-state ledger cores, still radiating a faint, residual warmth from their forty-hour run across the Mediterranean. If the Swiss maritime bailiffs impounded that satchel under the federal receivership writ, the Malacca drydocks were gone before breakfast. Three thousand seafarers would wake up in Batam to find their berths welded shut and their digital food scrip voided by the clearinghouses.

"Marcus," Lin whispered, her voice barely carrying over the hydrofoil's diesel clatter. "If they board, they'll run the biometric hash against the Singapore admiralty warrants."

"They aren't boarding," Marcus said.

He didn't reach for a weapon. He had none, and wouldn't have drawn one if he did. Instead, he reached into the pocket of his greasy mackinaw and pulled out a rectangular slip of yellow linen paper, folded into four stiff creases. He stepped away from the glider's sponson, his steel-toed work boots crunching deliberately across the crust of frozen slush toward the end of the timber pier.

“Officer Baudin!” Marcus shouted. His voice was gravelly, worn rough by thirty years of Detroit foundry dust and river wind, but it carried an effortless, heavy authority that made the searchlight twitch slightly off Jin’s face.

The man on the hydrofoil lowered the horn. “Who’s that on the slip?”

“Marcus Cole. We met in November at the cantonal flood mediation board.” Marcus didn’t stop until his boots were two inches from the edge of the iced-over stringer. He held the yellow linen sheet out against the glare. “You’re idling forty meters past your territorial sector line, Henri. Under the 1888 Lac Léman Littoral Usufruct Accord, these timber slips belong to the Versoix Net-Menders’ Cooperative. Federal emergency curfews don’t apply to guild waters without a signature from the Grand Council of Geneva. You have that signature on your clipboard tonight?”

A long, agonizing silence hung over the ice, filled only by the rhythmic *chug-slosh* of the hydrofoil’s exhaust.

Jin watched the officer on the deck. He recognized the type: not a private security contractor itching for a bonus, but a tired fifty-year-old municipal harbor master with an arthritic knee and two years left until retirement, stuck running winter patrols because the federal banking commission had put the cantons on high-alert status. Baudin didn't want a riot on the Versoix slips. He wanted a cup of chicory and a warm radiator.

Baudin leaned over the rail, squinting through the falling sleet at the yellow sheet. He knew the paper. Every water cop between Lausanne and Geneva knew the antique linen stock of the local fishing guilds—legal landmines left behind by nineteenth-century socialist weavers that modern corporate lawyers spent millions trying to invalidate and always failed.

“The harbor master’s office is locked down until six, Marcus,” Baudin called back, his tone shifting from bureaucratic threat to weary irritation. “The private bailiffs from Zurich arrived on the night train. They’ve got five squads of private port marshals at the commercial docks. If that pontoon craft moves an inch into the federal channel, I have to impound it.”

“It’s not moving,” Marcus said. “The batteries are dead anyway. We’re securing the lines to the guild bollards and going inside to dry our socks.”

Baudin spat over the side into the black water churning around his props. “Two hours until dawn, Marcus. At seven, the commercial receivers file the universal foreclosure order at the Palais. After that, guild paper won’t buy you a loaf of rye.”

The hydrofoil’s engines revved with a heavy, throaty growl. The helm came hard over, the steel prow carving a wide arc through the broken surface slush, and the white cone of the searchlight swung away, sweeping across the dark, undulating surface of the lake toward the distant amber streetlamps of the quayside.

The darkness collapsed back over them, cold and suffocating.

“Come on,” Giulia muttered, her hand gripping Lin’s elbow. “The wind is turning north. The lake effect will freeze the rudder linkages if we stay on the ice.”

Marcus grabbed the glider’s bow painter, looping the thick braided nylon around an iron cleat embedded in the mossy oak pilings. With a practiced heave, he threw open the low cedar sliding door of the nearest boat-shed.

A wave of heat rolled out into the sub-zero night.

It wasn't the sterile, conditioned heat of an office tower; it was thick, living air that smelled of wet loden wool, curing pine tar, woodsmoke from three drum stoves, and the sharp, mineral tang of unwashed human sweat.

Jin Wei stepped over the raised wooden threshold, his knees trembling slightly as the sudden warmth hit his frozen joints.

The cavernous interior of the shed stretched fifty yards into the gloom, lit only by suspended storm lanterns and the orange glow of the iron stoves. Suspended from the massive timber rafters overhead were four antique wooden lake skiffs, their varnished ribs glowing like the skeletons of great fish. Beneath them, seated shoulder-to-shoulder on rough-cut pine benches and inverted crates, were hundreds of people.

They were dockers from Rotterdam with split lips and salt-rimed coats; rail engineers from the Ruhr with oil ground permanently beneath their fingernails; high-altitude line-workers from the Valais wearing wool balaclavas pushed up over their foreheads; and mariners in stiff blue dungarees who had managed to slip off the container ships before the Singapore bailiffs seized the gangways.

No one was cheering. No one was waving banners. They were chewing hard tack, scraping frost from their spectacle lenses, and checking mechanical pocket watches by lantern light.

At the far end of the shed, standing over a carpenter’s workbench cleared of wood-shavings, stood a woman in an oil-darkened leather flight jacket. Her skin was the deep, burnished bronze of the high Karoo, her hair cropped close to the scalp, and her right forearm bore the pale, puckered track of an arc-welder’s flash burn.

Nia Ndlovu looked up as the sliding door thudded shut.

For five long seconds, the room fell dead silent. The only sound was the crackle of pine knots in the woodstove and the dry, hacking cough that Jin Wei couldn't hold back.

Nia crossed the sawdust-strewn floor, her stride unhurried, grounded by the heavy steel caps of her boots. When she reached Jin, she didn't offer a polite European handshake. She laid both palms flat against his upper arms, her calloused fingers digging into the wet wool of his pea coat with the fierce, anchoring grip of someone who had pulled men out of flooded mine shafts.

“You brought the strait,” she said quietly. Her voice was deep, textured like crushed shale.

Jin swallowed the metallic taste of his cough. “We lost three feeder tugs at the Horsburgh light. The mortgage receivers ran wire nets across the channel.” He reached back, gently taking Lin’s satchel and laying it on the nearest bench. “But the ledger roots are whole. Thirty-two hulls verified by their crews.”

Nia nodded slowly, her dark eyes reflecting the lantern flame. She looked past Jin to Marcus, then to Giulia.

Four people. Four continents.

Marcus, who had kept the cold-forges of the Detroit rail loop running through two federal bankruptcies without firing a single round. Giulia, who had held the Alpine penstocks against the energy trusts using nothing but mechanical weir locks and cantonal water statutes. Jin Wei, whose battered bulkheads had turned the Malacca traffic lane into an open commons. And Nia, who had unified twelve thousand miles of sub-Saharan solar corridors across four closed borders by moving high-voltage inverters on the backs of mules.

They did not speak of victory. They had seen too many assembly organizers disappear into federal holding cells to believe in easy dawns.

“The sortition parity,” Giulia said, pulling off her wool gloves to reveal fingers stiff with frost. “What is the count?”

Nia gestured toward the long benches. “Three hundred and one selected delegates arrived before the cantonal police blocked the rail head. With the four of us standing together on this floor, we are three hundred and five.”

The odd parity. The Class Zero invariant, preserved across ten thousand miles of winter sea and cordoned track.

Lin stepped to the carpenter’s bench, unzipping her canvas satchel. She did not plug the cores into any network; there was no internet here, no cellular signal penetrating the zinc-lined roof panels. She pulled out a small, wind-up micro-projector—a mechanical device built by the Valais precision co-ops, driven by a brass clockwork spring.

She set it down on an overturned spruce barrel. The brass gear buzzed, a tiny shutter clicked open, and a sharp beam of amber light cast a map across the rough pine wall.

It was not a map of nations. It was a map of physical lifelines: the high-voltage catenaries of the Alps, the freight arteries of the Midwest, the Malacca shipping channels, the Sahelian solar routes—all converging like drawn veins upon a single, low gray building on the hill above them.

The Palais des Nations.

“Seven o'clock,” Lin said, her voice steady now, stripped of fatigue. “The Euro-Asian Maritime Finance syndicate and the Zurich clearinghouses have convened an extraordinary closed session in the council chamber. They intend to pass the Global Foreclosure Protocol under emergency receivership rules. If they sign it, the private bailiffs have statutory authority to cut power to every node that hasn't cleared commercial debt by noon.”

Marcus walked over to the wall, his heavy hand resting on the pine timber just beside the illuminated outline of the Palais.

“The gates are locked,” Marcus said. “The Swiss federal police have placed concrete anti-ram blocks at the Pregny gate, and the private marshals have welded the turnstiles.”

Giulia stepped forward, adjusting her spectacles. From inside her wool tunic, she withdrew a folded sheet of vellum, yellowed and fragile along the margins, covered in faded blue draftsman’s ink.

“The gates are locked,” Giulia agreed, her voice flat and resolute. “The surface belongs to their bailiffs. But the Palais was built in 1930 over the old drainage system of the Ariana park estate. The lake overflow conduit runs from the timber slipway directly beneath our feet, straight up the hill into the central utility plenum under the Assembly floor.”

Jin Wei looked down at the floorboards beneath his boots, hearing the subterranean rush of lake water pushing through the ancient stone culverts below.

“The conduit is sixty centimeters wide,” Jin said, his seafarer’s eye immediately measuring the volume. “And the current is fighting the lake ice.”

Nia unbuttoned her flight coat, revealing her work harness and a coil of braided retrieval rope slung over her shoulder.

“We didn't cross four oceans to look at the front door,” she said.

The clockwork projector clicked, its brass spring winding down to its final, stubborn revolution. Outside, across the frozen surface of Lake Léman, the first gray light of dawn was beginning to bleed through the falling snow, and from the direction of the city, the low, mechanical rumble of the bailiffs’ diesel convoys began to shake the earth.

Chapter 47

The slipway timbers shuddered under the slap of gray lake swell, each wave throwing an icy slurry through the gaps in the floor.

Jin Wei pressed his palm against the rough pine wall, feeling the low, rhythmic grind of heavy diesels crawling up the Pregny incline a half-mile inland. Above them, the bailiffs were locking the perimeter. Below them, thirty inches of black culvert channeled the winter runoff of the Ariana estate directly into the churning belly of Lake Léman.

A three-beat knock rattled the boathouse's lakeside hatch—two short taps, a drag of wet leather across pine, then a hard third strike.

Marcus reached the hatch first, his shoulder blocking the seam as he drew the oak deadbolt. Cold air poured across their boots, thick with the smell of lake weeds and kerosene.

A man tumbled through the opening, caught by Marcus's forearm before his knees struck the planking. He was barrel-chested, his ribcage broadened by a lifetime of thin air at four thousand meters, wearing an oil-stained llama-wool poncho over a salt-encrusted work parka. Frost clung to the coarse stubble along his jaw, and his lips were split from the dry, biting gale of the altiplano. Around his neck hung a woven cord of dyed alpaca fibers, knotted at tight, measured intervals—the water-turn tallies of the Cotahuasi canyon.

"Carlos," Giulia breathed, pulling a coarse wool blanket from the tool bench and throwing it across his shoulders.

Carlos Quispe did not take the blanket. He caught Giulia's wrist with fingers that felt like cold iron, his breathing shallow, rattling with the wet rasp of a man who had dropped from nine thousand feet of altitude directly into the humid winter slop of the lowlands.

"The perimeter road is closed," Carlos said, his voice scraped raw, accented in the rhythmic Quechua cadence of the southern sierra. "Swiss marshals have parked two municipal snowplows across the rail spur at Sécheron. I came over the water from the French shore in an open skiff with two net-menders from Saint-Gingolph. The outboard fouled on lake ice two hundred meters out. We rowed with ash planks."

He reached inside the grease-stiffened canvas of his coat and pulled out a flat, rectangular bundle bound in vulcanized rubber and sealed with red electrical tape. His thumbs were purple beneath the

nails, split open by cold and stained with graphite lubricant from the high-altitude sluice gates he had spent three months defending against the mining syndicates.

“The Andean water-trust ratifications,” Carlos said, laying the bundle on the pine trestle table between the lantern and Giulia’s blue-inked survey map. “Seventy-two irrigation assemblies from the dry puna down to the coast. They did not sign for an ideology, Jin. They signed because your Malacca desalinator blueprints kept the nursery pumps turning when the mining company shut off the valley grid.”

Jin Wei nodded once, his throat tightening. He coughed, a dry, racking heave that shook his bad spine, smelling the faint trace of dried muña and woodsmoke trapped in Carlos’s wet wool. It was the same smell he had known on the bulk carriers off Callao thirty years ago, when mountain boys came down to shovel bunker slag in the hold.

“That makes five,” Nia said quietly from the shadows by the slipway winch.

She stepped toward the lantern light, the braided retrieval rope coiled across her chest like a bandolier. Her dark skin was pale with exhaustion, the skin around her eyes mapped with fine salt crystals from two sleepless nights of tracking logistics lines across the Sahara-to-Rhône power links. She laid her own contribution beside Carlos’s packet: an aluminum data cassette, its casing scored by sandstorms, housing the hand-carved soapstone seals of forty-one Sahelian solar farming cooperatives.

Beside it lay Marcus’s heavy ring-bound ledger—eight hundred pages of tool-and-die allocations signed by the machine-shop stewards of the Great Lakes basin, stamped in dark purple indelible ink on recycled kraft paper.

Giulia smoothed her vellum map flat, placing her family’s century-old alpine water-concession tallies alongside them.

And from his own coat, Jin Wei withdrew the brass-cornered logbook of the *Batam Star*, signed by two hundred and forty merchant captains, pump-tenders, and tugboat pilots across the Malacca Strait.

Five delegations. The living muscle, water, copper, and sun of five fractured continents, sitting on a greasy workbench in an unheated Geneva boathouse while three hundred private bailiffs secured the hill above them.

Lin Zhang pulled a brass-cased balance scale from her rucksack, setting it on the center of the table. Her temples throbbed with a migraine that had blurred her peripheral vision since Munich, but her hands were entirely steady. From an insulated thermos, she uncapped a small pot of dark, viscous oak-gall ink, mixed with cold-pressed linseed oil and lampblack.

“This is not an agreement between governments,” Lin said, her voice dropping into the quiet cadence she used when calibrating high-pressure steam turbines. “The legal charter of the Hague Trust recognizes no national sovereignty over the thermodynamic baseline. If we sign this, we are binding our

bioregions to an unalterable Class Zero usufruct pool. No single continent can cut its surplus to hoard against winter without triggering the automated isolation of its own credit relays."

Carlos looked down at the paper Giulia was unrolling. It was not vellum, nor was it corporate bond. It was a single, three-foot-long strip of heavy rag linen, milled in a cooperatively owned textile shed in the Jura mountains, woven from hemp and flax that had never touched a commercial loom.

"Explain the friction clause," Carlos demanded, his dark eyes fixed on Marcus. "In the sierra, when the frost comes early, we cannot guarantee the copper tonnage for your electric motors if our children are freezing in the schoolhouses."

Marcus leaned forward, his massive hands resting flat on the table, the old burn scars on his knuckles white against the dark timber.

"You don't guarantee tonnage," Marcus said, his voice low and gravelly. "The Charter doesn't trade in futures. It trades in actual, verified kinetic work. If the frost locks your penstocks, your draw on our winter turbine inventory scales down to emergency life-support levels, and our automated machine shops switch from commercial shafts to manual-treadle heat pumps for your valleys. You don't owe us a single gram of copper until your water runs free again. We absorb the deficit on our side through deferred factory hours."

Carlos studied the Detroit machinist's face. He saw the same exhaustion he had seen in the mirror that morning in the fisherman's hut at Saint-Gingolph: the hollow cheeks of a man who had spent his life bargaining with machines that took everything and gave back nothing.

"And the sortition?" Carlos asked. "Who breaks the deadlock when the rain fails everywhere at once?"

"One hundred and one names," Giulia answered, pointing her draftsman's rule at the third paragraph of the Charter. "Drawn at random from the registered maintenance stewards across all five basins every three solstices. Odd numbers only. No lawyers, no ministers, no professional delegates. If they cannot reach three-quarters agreement within forty-eight hours, the default condition is the immediate, equal rationing of all base-load energy to hospital grids and water treatment plants. The luxury circuits stay dark until the consensus is signed."

Carlos stood silent for ten seconds. The only sound in the boathouse was the lap of the black lake water beneath their feet and the distant, muffled clatter of an air compressor being started on the grounds of the Palais.

He reached into his pocket, pulled out a small pocketknife with a worn horn handle, and cut the braided tally cord from his neck. He laid the knotted alpaca fibers across the top margin of the linen sheet.

"The Andes are in," Carlos said.

One by one, they stepped to the table.

There was no ceremony, no speech, no flash of cameras. Lin Zhang dipped an iron quill into the gall ink and signed for the maritime networks of the eastern straits, her handwriting small, cramped, and fiercely precise. Marcus signed below her with a carpenter's flat-lead pencil, pressing so hard the lead grooved the hemp fibers. Nia pressed the carved soapstone seal of the Gao solar array into a pool of red wax, leaving the raised outline of an acacia root. Carlos Quispe rolled his right thumb in the lampblack ink and pressed the whorl of his skin directly beside the knotted alpaca cord. Giulia signed last, using the faded steel drafting pen her father had carried down from the Gotthard tunnels.

Five marks. The Master Charter of Open Networked Earth.

As Giulia lifted the pen, a violent shudder ran through the boathouse walls.

Above them, on the stone terrace of the Ariana park, a heavy steel plate dropped with a deafening *clang*.

Jin Wei's head snapped toward the ceiling. Through a crack in the slipway floorboards, the conduit's outflow suddenly surged, lake water churning white as a back-draft of pressurized warm air blew out from the mountain culvert, carrying the sharp, synthetic smell of ozone and commercial floor wax.

"They've powered up the main HVAC chillers in the Assembly building," Lin said, her voice tightening as she checked the mechanical pocket watch pinned to her lapel. "Six forty-five. The syndicate delegates are taking their seats in the council chamber. The emergency receivership vote is scheduled for seven sharp."

Marcus snatched the dry linen Charter from the table, rolled it tightly into an oiled canvas cylinder, and lashed it to the chest harness beneath his work coat.

"The drainage culvert," Marcus said, turning toward the dark opening in the slipway floor. "How long is the crawl?"

"Four hundred meters uphill against the overflow," Giulia said, pulling a pair of heavy rubberized miners' waders from a wooden peg. "The gradient is ten percent until you reach the foundations of the 1930 wing. If they open the storm bypass from the roof drains, the water level rises to fifty centimeters within forty seconds."

Nia swung her legs over the timber edge, dropping waist-deep into the freezing black torrent of the culvert mouth. The cold hit her with a physical blow, driving the air from her lungs in a sharp gasp.

"Then we don't take forty seconds," she said through chattering teeth.

Carlos Quispe adjusted his poncho, stepped off the ledge into the black, rushing water beside her, and gripped the stone arch of the drain. His lips parted in a grim, silent grin that showed teeth yellowed by coca leaves.

“Lead on, mariner,” the mountain man said to Jin Wei. “The water here is warmer than Lake Titicaca.”

Jin Wei lowered himself into the conduit, the freezing lake current tearing at his knees, his bad spine burning like a red-hot iron rod. Ahead of them, the culvert curved into absolute, suffocating darkness, carrying the distant, hollow echo of three hundred wingtips pacing the marble floors above.

CHAPTER 48

Chapter 48

The glacial runoff tore at Jin Wei's thighs like liquid glass.

His boots found no purchase on the rounded river cobbles lining the culvert floor. Every three paces, his lower lumbar vertebrae ground together with the sick, dull scrape of ungreased gears, sending hot needles of pain shooting down his left calf. In the pitch blackness beneath the Ariana gardens, he didn't navigate by sight; he kept his left shoulder pinned to the mossy limestone arch, counting the cold mortar joints under his fingertips in clusters of four—an old habit from his youth, gauging the bulkheads of unlit ballast tanks during midnight pump failures.

Behind him, Lin's breath was a thin, whistling gasp. The freezing water was up to her sternum now, soaking the woolen lining of her windbreaker until it dragged on her like a diver's lead belt. Whenever her footing slipped, her fingers dug convulsively into the coarse weave of Carlos Quispe's poncho. To keep the suffocating dark from closing her throat, she muttered a sequence of prime offsets under her breath—the identical rhythm her sister had hummed years ago while stringing loom shuttles in the damp backrooms of Guangzhou.

"Incline is sharpening," Giulia's voice echoed off the low ceiling, flat and deadened by the rushing water. "Ten meters to the sump trap. Watch your heads. The 1930 stonework gives way to low-clearance iron ribs."

The ceiling dipped abruptly. Jin Wei bent double, the lake overflow lapping against his chin, tasting of mountain silt, dead weed, and the synthetic chemical bitter of lawn runoff. His temple scraped against a jagged encrustation of rust.

Then the current slackened.

They stepped up out of the black trough onto an inclined silt shelf where the culvert met the subterranean foundation blocks of the Palais des Nations. Above them, through the heavy slots of a cast-iron inspection hatch, poured a shaft of searing, amber brilliance and the dry, roaring draft of the building's primary air-handling units.

The heat hit them like an open furnace door. Steam rose instantly from their saturated clothes, smelling of bog-rot and sodden wool.

Giulia dropped her kit bag on the slime-slick concrete. Her hands, red and swollen from the freezing swim, fumbled with a dog-leg brass spanner she had tucked into her belt. She jammed the tool into the recessed dog-latch of the ventilation plenum, throwing her entire weight against the lever. The corroded

bronze nut groaned, spat a flake of dried white grease, and gave way with a sharp *clack* that vibrated straight through her wrist bones.

Marcus helped her shoulder the plate aside.

Through the opening, the sound of the world above crashed down upon them: not the sterile hum of an international bureau, but the roiling, multi-throated rumble of three thousand people packed into a pressure cooker. Microphones crackled through ceiling horns. The rhythmic, frantic tapping of mechanical keyboards in the press gallery sounded like a thousand beetles rattling inside dry gourds.

Jin Wei hauled himself through the opening first, his bad hip catching on the iron lip with an agonizing jerk that drew a muffled hiss through his teeth.

They stood in the low-ceilinged mechanical undercroft immediately beneath the presidential rostrum of the Assembly Hall. Massive galvanized ductwork branched out overhead like the exposed ribcage of an iron leviathan. Every four seconds, a low-frequency shudder rattled the steel decking under their soles—the synchronized HVAC chillers working overtime to pump chilled alpine air into the crowded auditorium above.

Marcus untied the oiled canvas roll from his chest harness. The outer layer was coated in gray culvert muck, but when he peeled back the tarred flap, the dry linen Charter within was bone-white, its wax seals intact, cold to the touch.

“Security perimeter,” Lin whispered, wiping a streak of muddy condensate from her glasses with a trembling thumb. She pointed toward the far end of the pipe-run, where an industrial flight of perforated steel stairs led up to a pair of heavy, sound-dampened mahogany doors.

Stationed at the foot of the stairs stood three men in dark, unadorned service suits, their lapels marked only by the silver-and-blue enamel shield of the United Nations security corps. None carried visible sidearms—firearms had been barred from the plenary floor since the 1947 convention—but their belts hung heavy with hardened composite batons, radio transceivers, and pneumatic restraint zip-cuffs.

The tallest of them, an officer with close-cropped silver hair and the weathered, watchful squint of an alpine border guard, turned at the sound of wet boots squeaking against the steel treadplate.

His hand fell instantly to the clasp of his service radio.

“Halt,” the officer said in clipped, unhurried French, his eyes sweeping across the six dripping figures, taking in the frayed hemp rope around Carlos’s waist, the mud drying into gray crusts on Jin Wei’s cheeks, and the linen cylinder gripped in Marcus’s scarred hands. “This sector is sealed under Cantonal Security Order 4-B. Turn around and step back down into the inspection well.”

He didn’t shout. His voice was steady, heavy with the institutional weight of a man whose entire family had guarded federal frontiers for three generations. He wasn’t a corporate mercenary; he was a civil servant who believed, with terrifying sincerity, that the thin line of red tape beneath his polished

shoes was the only thing preventing Europe from sliding back into the bloodbaths of the twentieth century.

“We are not intruders, Inspector,” Lin said, her voice dry as dead reeds, stepping past Jin Wei so the light caught the steel sortition token pinned to her collar. “We are the registered delegates of the Maritime Commons and the Southern Andean Watershed. Your plenary board received our post-quantum key registration fourteen hours ago.”

The silver-haired officer did not move his hand from his radio. “The registration list was frozen at midnight by administrative decree of the receivership syndicate. The sovereign floor is closed to non-accredited factions.”

“Look at your registry screen,” Jin Wei rasped, stepping forward with his uneven, dragging gait. Every word tore at his raw throat, scraping against the cough he had carried since his first winter in the shipbreaking yards of Chittagong. “Not the syndicate’s private feed. Look at the public ledger buffer on your cantonal interface. The Hague Perpetual Trust recognized the parity of this assembly forty minutes ago. If you physically block sortition delegates from taking their seats on the floor, your own cantonal charter strips your immunity before sundown.”

The officer’s jaw tightened. For three long seconds, the only sound was the deep, rhythmic hum of the air scrubbers and the steady *drip-drip-drip* of lake water pooling at Jin Wei’s boots.

The officer’s eyes flicked to Marcus’s hands—to the lead seal of the High Court pressed into the green beeswax hanging from the Charter’s edge. He knew the seal. Every border inspector from Basel to Chiasso knew that specific, archaic lion-stamp.

Slowly, his thumb lifted off the radio’s transmit paddle. He did not step aside, but his shoulders settled two centimeters lower, the rigid line of his spine softening under the crushing weight of an impossible legal choice.

“If you open those doors,” the officer murmured, his eyes fixed on Jin Wei’s hollow, fever-bright gaze, “the receivership syndicate will declare a total debt-settlement freeze across every port from Rotterdam to Genoa within five minutes. You will break the shipping lines. You will empty the grocery shelves in thirty-two nations by Friday morning.”

“The shelves are already empty for the people who harvest the grain, Inspector,” Carlos said softly, his voice cutting through the mechanical drone like a stone dropped into a dry cistern.

Marcus didn't wait for permission. He stepped past the guard, his heavy shoulder brushing the man’s woolen sleeve, and drove the flat of both palms against the panic bars of the mahogany service doors.

The doors swung inward with a heavy, oiled glide.

The roar of the Palais des Nations hit them like a physical wave.

A wall of white television lights, blinding and furnace-hot, washed over them. Above the floor, the immense, sepia-toned murals of José María Sert stretched toward the vaulted ceiling—titanic gold-and-bronze figures of giants forging chains, breaking titans, and dragging cannons across shattered fields of stone.

Below the murals, three hundred national delegations sat arrayed in semi-circular tiered mahogany benches, their faces bathed in the glow of desk monitors, simultaneous translation earpieces dangling from their collars like thin black nooses.

At the central podium, the presiding director of the Euro-Asian Financial Consortium froze mid-sentence, his ivory gavel poised four inches above the green baize sounding board.

The entire vast room—four thousand journalists, diplomats, corporate receivers, and sovereign ministers—fell into an abrupt, dead silence so profound that the wet *shlap* of Jin Wei's mud-caked deck shoes echoed against the distant travertine walls like pistol shots.

Jin Wei did not look at the cameras. He did not look at the gilded ceiling. He kept his chin down, his hand clamped over the ache in his lumbar spine, and began the long march down the central aisle toward the empty rostrum.

Behind him, Marcus drew the Charter from its canvas sheath, the thick, unbleached linen catching the glare of the world's spotlights.

At the high rostrum, the director's fingers closed around the handle of his gavel, his knuckles turning white as he reached for the emergency microphone cutoff switch beneath the desk.

EPILOGUE

Epilogue

The director's thumb bore down on the red rubber toggle beneath the mahogany trim. The circuit broke with a dry, spring-loaded snap, killing the podium's ribbon microphones and cutting the floor feed to the interpreter booths.

The silence that followed was not an absence of sound, but an increase in atmospheric weight. Four thousand men and women in the tiered amphitheater leaned forward, wool coats rustling against velvet-backed chairs, paper dossiers slithering like dry leaves across the green baize desks.

Jin Wei did not stop. His right deck shoe, crusted with dried salt-spray from the South China Sea, dragged slightly against the plush blue carpet. Every vertebra in his lower lumbar spine felt packed with ground glass, the dull ache radiating downward into his left heel—a legacy of thirty winters spent standing watch on vibrating steel deckplates. He reached the lower tier of the rostrum, climbed the two low steps without touching the brass handrail, and hauled the canvas satchel onto the polished surface.

The presiding director, a man named Vane whose gray hair was sheared with military precision, did not shout. His tailored cuffs were damp at the wrists. His knuckles remained white around the handle of the ivory gavel, not with theatrical rage, but with the specific, suffocating terror of an actuary who has calculated the exact hour the seawall collapses.

"Captain Jin," Vane said, his voice stripped of amplification, carrying across the front three rows on the raw acoustic curve of the Sert vault. "If you lodge an unregistered multilateral instrument from this floor, you invalidate the secondary mortgage paper on four hundred thousand hulls before noon. You will freeze the credit guarantees of every central clearinghouse from Tokyo to Frankfurt. The grain transfers for the Maghreb cannot clear without those underwriters. You think you are liberating a shipping lane. You are starving seventy million people who have never seen the ocean."

Jin Wei did not reach for the dead podium microphone. He reached into his coat pocket and withdrew a small, battered brass pocket mirror—the kind his late wife had kept in her sewing tin in Haiphong, its silver backing flaking away in jagged crescents. He angled the glass toward the eastern skylight high above the Sert murals.

A pulse of invisible cyan light, transmitted from a handheld optical transceiver Lin Zhang had clamped to the banister of the public gallery, struck the mirror's surface. It bounced directly into the optical pickup of the independent press pool's master camera perched on the press balcony. The signal bypassed the chamber's patched switchboard entirely, modulating along the line of sight through the dust motes in the warm Swiss air.

“The grain is already rotting in the holds at Port Dickson, Director,” Jin Wei said. His voice was raspy, thick with the chronic cough of an old boiler tender who had swallowed too much heavy-fuel exhaust. “Your underwriters arrested the rudders three weeks ago because the bunkerage debt was denominated in paper that dissolved. The sailors are drinking condensate water from the air conditioners. They are not waiting for your clearinghouse.”

Marcus laid the unbleached linen Charter across the desk. The document bore no ornate corporate seal. Along its margins ran eighty-four hundred thumbprints in waterproof blue docking ink—the ink used by chief mates to certify fuel ballast—alongside the dry-stamp notary seals of thirty-one independent port magistrates who had spent the last seventy-two hours breaking admiralty locks with blowtorches.

Vane looked down at the cloth. His jaw worked once, a tiny muscle twitching beneath the earlobe. He knew the doctrine of maritime necessity under the ancient laws of salvage. If an abandoned derelict poses an immediate hazard to navigation, any master who puts a line aboard holds possessory lien against all prior claimants. The consortium had declared the entire fleet technically abandoned to claim the insurance write-downs; they had simply forgotten that abandoned ships still had living flesh inside them.

Lin Zhang sat three tiers back in the diplomatic gallery, her knuckles pressed hard against her temples to suppress the pulsing throb behind her left eye. On her lap, an air-gapped terminal—its gray polymer shell scarred by battery acid—did not display numbers or network maps. It showed a single, mechanical indicator: the status of the deep-channel tidal turbines ten thousand miles behind them in the Riau Archipelago.

The reading was green. The evening tide in the western Pacific had turned into the dawn flood through the Phillips Channel.

Ten thousand miles to the east, the sun was cutting through the morning haze of the Malacca Straits like a dull copper blade.

At Berth 9 of the decommissioned Keppel yard on Batam, the air was ninety-eight percent humidity and smelled of dead barnacles, brine, and the bitter tang of wet mangrove roots. Uncle Tan stood on the lower catwalk of the crane gantry, a chipped enamel mug of bitter black coffee cradled in his swollen, arthritic fingers. The dampness always found his left knee first, stiffening the joint until every step down the ladder sounded like a dry branch snapping. He didn't use his cane today. He leaned his forearm against the salt-pocked steel railing and watched the water.

In the channel, the gray, predatory hulls of Apex Marine’s fast-interceptor skiffs were no longer maneuvering.

They sat dead in the water, three miles off the Batam reef, riding the long, oily swell of the morning tide. Their twin outboards were silent, the engine cowlings open, dark with the grease of dismantled fuel filters. Their corporate fuel cards had been rejected by the offshore bunker barge at midnight when the

syndicate's master accounts frozen in Geneva failed to authorize the encrypted vouchers. The private security guards, stripped of their tactical vests in the suffocating thirty-four-degree dawn heat, sat on the forward gunwales with their boots dangling over the water, smoking clove cigarettes and trading tins of sweetened condensed milk with a passing Indonesian fishing prahu.

Nobody had fired a flare. Nobody had swung a cutlass or leveled an assault rifle. The mercenaries had simply run out of sweet water and refined diesel, their supply umbilical severed by three clerks in Rotterdam who had closed their ledgers and walked out to join the municipal dock strike.

Down on the drydock apron, Aisyah binti Rahman was winding high-voltage shore cables onto a wooden spool. Her forearms were streaked with zinc paste and her fingertips bore the yellow, calloused scars of three days spent rewiring the gantry transformers. Her hair, tucked under a sweat-stained bandana, clung to the nape of her neck. When the low rumble of a ship's horn rolled across the water, she stopped, her boots slipping an inch in the red tidal silt that coated the slipway.

She looked out past the reef.

Through the narrow throat of the Singapore Strait, where four hundred container carriers had sat anchored in a paralyzed, debt-arrested line for twenty-six days, the lead vessel was moving.

It was the *Mindanao Star*, an eleven-thousand-box leviathan with red rust bleeding down her hawseholes like dried tears. Her bulbous bow tore through the flat, mirror-bright water, throwing up a rolling white bow-wave that sent the driftwood and sea-foam tumbling toward the mangroves. Behind her came an ancient geared bulk carrier flying the flag of Tuvalu, its deck stacked high with rough-sawn timber; behind that, an orange chemical tanker, its hull low in the water, its crew lined up along the port rail waving grease-rags and orange life vests.

They were not transmitting automated clearing codes to the shore radars. They were not queueing for toll slots.

Aboard each bridge, the engine telegraphs stood at *Full Ahead Sea Speed*. In the wheelhouses, the old brass compass repeaters hummed quietly, their headings set by the open-channel radio coordinates that Uncle Tan's apprentices had been broadcasting across the maritime emergency frequencies since four in the morning: the surveyed bathymetric contours of a channel cleared of corporate acoustic tags, kept open by the sheer, uncoordinated momentum of mariners who had decided to go home.

On the Batam catwalk, Uncle Tan took a slow sip of his lukewarm coffee. The bitterness coat his tongue, grounding him against the dizzying scale of the horizon. He set the mug on the flat top of an electrical junction box, lifted the brass hammer of the manual dock telegraph, and struck the iron bell once.

The clear, brassy tone carried over the water, cutting through the low thrum of the diesel exhausts.

From the bridge wing of the *Mindanao Star*, two miles out, a mate pulled the lanyard of the ship's air horn in answer—three long, earth-shaking blasts that rattled the corrugated iron roofs of the fishing

villages along the shore, scaring a cloud of white egrets from the mangrove canopy into the pale morning sky.

Ten thousand miles away, in the cool, tomb-like air of the Palais des Nations, the echo of that horn was invisible, but its weight was absolute.

Jin Wei took his hands off the linen charter. He turned his back on the director’s raised gavel, on the rows of frozen ministers, on the four thousand television lenses staring down like empty glass eyes. He walked down the center aisle toward the open service doors where Marcus and Carlos stood waiting.

As his deck shoes crossed the threshold into the stone corridor, Lin Zhang caught up to him, her fingers closing tightly around his rough woolen sleeve. Her face was pale, the skin around her eyes dark with exhaustion, but she held up the small phosphor terminal.

On the screen, an encrypted packet from the cantonal police registry in Bern had just replaced the maritime data.

“The Consortium has filed for emergency asset sequestration,” she whispered, her breath coming fast and shallow in the cold draft from the lake. “Not in Singapore. Here. They’re locking the cantonal airspace within forty minutes. They’ve dispatched the federal marshals to seal the rail line between Geneva and Basel.”

Jin Wei did not break his stride. He pulled the collar of his windbreaker up around his scarred throat, feeling the chill of the Swiss autumn bite deep into his old lungs.

“Then we don’t take the train,” he said.